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Evaluation of the impact of the MARAC networking model

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Summary

The purpose of the study is to evaluate the impact of the MARAC model on victims of domestic violence, professionals, and support networks in Estonia. MARAC (*Multi-Agency Risk Assessment Conference*) is a network-based case management model that aims to identify victims at high risk of domestic violence and prevent severe consequences of violence. The study focuses on two main questions: what is the impact of MARAC on the professionals, volunteers, and victims contributing to the network, and how can MARAC be made more effective? In addition, the study includes the feedback to the e-course on domestic violence. The study is based on an analysis of MARAC monitoring data, surveys of MARAC core groups and volunteers, and interviews with members of MARAC core groups, victims, and volunteers.

Composition of MARAC core groups

At the time of the study's completion (summer 2023), there were 18 MARAC core groups in Estonia, which included 137 specialists. Each county has a MARAC core group, and two core groups operate in Tartu County and Harju County. The core groups are composed of representatives of the Social Insurance Board (SIB), the Police and Border Guard Board (PBGB), and the Prosecutor's Office in each region. In most regions, the Women's Support Centre (WSC) is also represented (missing in only two). A representative of the local government (LG) is in almost half of the core groups. In other core groups, local government representatives are involved on a case-by-case basis. The above-mentioned five agencies (SIB, PBGB, prosecutor's office, WSC, and LG) are all necessary for the operation of the MARAC network, and their representation in the core groups is urgently needed to provide effective support.

Recommendation: the composition of the agencies of the core group members (PBGB, SIB, prosecutor's office, WSC, and LG) is suitable, and for the networks to function, the representation of these agencies must continue to be ensured.

Some members of the core groups feel the need to involve additional specialists in the work of the core groups. In particular, they cite the need for specialists in the field of health care. It is not unequivocally clear in which role and on what basis health specialists should be included in the core groups. A health professional is not needed in all cases, and expectations for their role vary from consulting core group members to providing appropriate medical services.

Recommendation: Consider what the possibilities are and in what role to involve specialists in the field of health in MARAC and give instructions to the core groups to involve additional specialists.

Some core groups have too many members, especially in larger regions, which makes it difficult for victims to participate in meetings. It also makes it difficult to follow the principle of data protection, according to which the victim's information should only be accessible to the minimum necessary number of people.

Recommendation: keep the number of members of the core group (especially in meetings) to a minimum, avoiding, if possible, the representation of one agency by several people.

A situation where a member of the core group is simultaneously a representative of the agency in MARAC and a direct supporter or service provider for the victim poses a role conflict and discomfort for the victim and makes them feel insecure, as does the situation where the victim has had some kind of negative contact with a member of the core group before MARAC.

Recommendation: Add clear guidelines to the MARAC manual on how the core group and its members should handle a situation where a core group member is in a role conflict situation at a MARAC meeting.

Most members of MARAC core groups have participated in the work of the group for three years or more. New professionals know less about the roles and responsibilities of core group members, the work organization of MARAC, and how and which victims are referred to MARAC. Core group members with shorter seniority rate their role clarity lower, and also, fewer of them have used self-care account options.

Recommendation: to make it easier for new MARAC core members to settle in, we recommend directing them to the DV e-course, preparing short and specific instructions for them that explain the roles, responsibilities, and tasks of the core group members, and additionally acquaint the new member with how the regional MARAC works and what the possibilities are to get help and support for self-care.

The role of local governments in MARAC core groups and meetings is not always clear, causing problems for representatives of LG as well as representatives of other agencies. Different perceptions and experiences can be caused by other core group members overestimating LG's resources or LG officials having a limited understanding of their role and possibilities in supporting victims.

Recommendation: the core group works effectively if the roles of the parties are clear and they work cooperatively. Therefore, we recommend describing in more detail the possibilities and role of local governments in supporting victims and explaining it more precisely to all parties.

How MARAC core groups work

The members of the core group value the clarity of their role and the work organization of MARAC in general. The members of the core groups mostly feel that the cooperation in MARAC works well and that the introduction of the MARAC model improved the opportunities to help victims and cooperation with other agencies involved in the prevention of domestic violence. MARAC improved the exchange of information between agencies, which in turn helps to better coordinate services. About a third of core group members feel that MARAC changed the way they work. Long-term MARAC members notice the change in working methods the most.

Recommendation: MARAC is a relevant and necessary collaborative framework for bringing together professionals dealing with high-risk domestic violence cases, and we recommend continuing the development of MARAC.

MARAC meetings

The main form of cooperation of the MARAC core group is the MARAC meeting, which takes place regularly, usually once a month. Special meetings are called, taking into account the necessity and availability of resources. The majority of core group members consider the frequency of meetings to be appropriate. MARAC meetings follow certain rules, and their mandatory elements are mostly fulfilled. The organization of the meetings and the use of time are efficient and are set as an example for other roundtables.

Recommendation: To continue to conduct MARAC meetings with the current time management rules and structure.

In Estonia, the duty of the chair of MARAC is exclusively performed by a representative of PBGB; the coordinator is usually a representative of SIB, and the secretary is, again, mostly a representative of PBGB. However, the role of the chair of MARAC causes a bit of confusion because it has developed into a technical rather than a substantive role.

Recommendation: clarify the role of the MARAC leader and further clarify the content of this role and the basis for its appointment to the members of the core groups.

Victim profiling and risk assessment in MARAC

High-risk domestic violence is a problem that primarily affects women. In MARAC cases, the victims are predominantly women (95.8%) aged 35-50 (42.6%), with minor children in their household (72.3%). However, monitoring data show that the profile of victims varies, and high-risk domestic violence also includes younger and older people without minor children and male victims.

MARAC cases are selected by risk assessment, which uses the DASH risk assessment method. The members of the core groups consider risk assessment to be mostly necessary and relevant. In the monitoring data, the average initial DASH score is 14.9 points. In Estonia, MARAC also includes cases where the initial DASH score is below the high-risk threshold (14 points).

The DASH questionnaire is not suitable for all target groups of high-risk incidents of violence and underestimates the risk of older partners or parent-child or male victims.

Recommendation: to create risk assessment instruments suitable for target groups in order to assess risks in a standardized and objective manner in target groups to whom the DASH questionnaire does not fully apply.

Risks are assessed mainly by SIB Victim Support and WSC representatives, less often by PBGB representatives. Core group members representing other agencies often direct the risk assessment to the SIB. The practice of completing the DASH risk assessment questionnaire varies based on the evaluators' preferences and official guidelines - some fill out the DASH questionnaire on their own, using the information they received in a free-form conversation with the victim; others again are of the opinion that when filling in the questionnaire, they should ask the victims to provide the answer for each particular question.

Recommendation: since the methodology of filling out the DASH form depends on the person filling it in, we recommend considering whether it is necessary to define the ways of filling out the DASH more precisely and to harmonize practices.

The MARAC guidelines specify that at the closure of the case, the victim's risk level must be reassessed; however, approximately half of MARAC core group members do not know how often it is actually done. The interviewed victims had no idea if any assessment had been performed. In monitoring MARAC, the information regarding the risk assessment performed upon closure of a case is also found to be patchy. Thus, risk assessment does not take place on completion of MARAC on a regular basis, and therefore, it is very difficult to monitor and evaluate MARAC's impact, as well as to obtain assurance that risks have indeed been mitigated.

Recommendation: Perform a risk assessment and compile mandatory documentation of results at the closure of the case.

Work and administrative burden and data protection

According to core group members, MARAC increases the overall workload by approximately 60%, especially for PBGB and SIB representatives who fulfill multiple roles. The procedure related to the confidentiality agreement is sometimes left partially unfulfilled in the activities of the MARAC meetings. Confidentiality is considered necessary and important by the core group members, but they want adjustments to the procedure that would reduce the work and administrative burden.

Recommendation: Consider revising the protocol associated with the confidentiality agreement to streamline processes while ensuring compliance with data protection requirements.

Verbatim enforcement of the confidentiality agreement prevents the effective sharing of information from core group members to other officers. This sharing of information is necessary in the event that colleagues within the agency need the information to perform their duties, for example, organizing the provision of services to victims and dealing with police work cases.

Recommendation: Adjust the text of the confidentiality agreement and create a regulatory-compliant solution for core group members to forward information shared at meetings to other employees of their organization who need it to perform their duties.

Drafting a security plan in MARAC creates conflicting opinions and differences in its formalization. Although the creation and execution of a security plan are considered important in all core groups, some MARAC core groups do not formalize the security plan as a separate document, and in some, the security plan is not distinguished from the minutes of the meeting. MARAC's guidelines have not clearly defined the obligation to prepare a security plan as a separate document, but according to the principles of case management, MARAC's development team sees the need for it. Compiling various documents brings an administrative burden to Victim Support workers, so it is important to define the requirements of the security plan more clearly and to find ways to reduce the administrative burden.

Recommendation: to clearly outline the purpose of the security plan, the principles, and requirements of formalization to the core groups and explain their need. At the same time, consider ways to reduce the administrative burden of documentation for Victim Support workers.

Volunteers

As of summer 2023, there were 64 MARAC volunteers on the SIB roster, 32 of whom had MARAC casework experience. The recruitment and training of volunteers are managed by the SIB volunteer coordinator, and involvement in MARAC cases is done in cooperation between the volunteer coordinator and the regional Victim Support worker. Therefore, Victim Support workers must have a good understanding of the principles of volunteer involvement and their role. Volunteers and members of core groups generally conceptualize the volunteer role as described in the MARAC guidance material. The involvement of volunteers in MARAC cases varies from region to region and is done on a case-by-case basis, where the volunteer's role and tasks depend on the context and the case. In practice, the main role of volunteers has become the provision of psychosocial support, but its scope and clarity need to be specified. It also needs to be specified whether the volunteer is a victim's representative in the network, a case-based specialist, or a volunteer psychosocial support service provider of SIB Victim Support.

Recommendation: to increase and simplify the involvement of volunteers, gather examples of positive practices of volunteer involvement for Victim Support workers, which clearly state the tasks of the volunteers and what the volunteers need to perform these tasks.

Communication and cooperation between the volunteer and the victim requires suitability, which may depend on factors such as age, mother tongue, gender, etc. Finding volunteers with suitable profiles for all MARAC cases can be difficult; for example, there is a lack of native Russian-speaking volunteers or suitable volunteers for male victims.

Recommendation: increase the diversity of volunteers so that it is possible to find a volunteer with a suitable profile for specific cases.

Volunteers communicate with the victim mainly by telephone or in face-to-face meetings. The current means of communication provided to volunteers, the push-button telephone, causes inconvenience and limits effective communication with the victim. Volunteers have attempted to solve this problem by using personal mobile phones and multiple SIM cards.

Recommendation: find out what the possibilities are to make the means of communication by phone more convenient for volunteers and introduce them to different possibilities.

Interviewed volunteers pointed out the need for more modern communication channels, such as social media and other virtual channels, for which there is currently no system and secure options.

Recommendation: develop a system for volunteers to communicate with victims through virtual communication channels as an alternative to phone calls.

Increasing victim safety

The data suggest a decrease in police intervention following MARAC - the number of police calls decreases on average before MARAC involvement and after completion of MARAC. On average, the impact of MARAC on increasing victim safety was rated high by core group members and volunteers, but there is a wide variability in the assessments. On a 10-point scale, the members of the core groups rated the increase in the victim's safety with an average of 7.8 and the volunteers with an average of 7.6. The variation in estimates is due to the fact that cases are different, and the increase in security is difficult to estimate because it depends on many factors.

Core groups perceive that MARAC has several advantages compared to the situation where MARAC is not available. In summary, the members of the core groups value the following as the advantages of MARAC: extensive support for the victim; concentration of information for the victim in one source (there is no need to contact different agencies separately); core members have comprehensive information about the case; faster coordination of victim services and support; trauma-informed communication with the victim. However, some interviewed victims did not perceive that they were exposed to these benefits. The main benefits that victims highlighted were specific services and support measures (for example, psychologists/therapy for the victim or child, being added to the 112 emergency response list), as well as specific advice and answers to questions they received from MARAC-affiliated specialists (such as family mediation with child protection, assistance from a prosecutor in the proceedings, etc.).

Core group members perceive shortcomings in the efficacy of MARAC, citing insufficient resources for victim assistance and highlighting delays and legal impediments within the processes. At times, core members doubt the effectiveness of MARAC and feel that they are doing the same things in MARAC that they would do outside of MARAC. Sometimes, members of the core groups sense that the opportunities to help victims through MARAC have been exhausted, especially in cases where the victim has addiction problems, there is mutual violence between the victim and the perpetrator, or other complex circumstances. At times, members of the core groups doubted whether the case referred to MARAC was still high risk, and there was also doubt whether the victim was telling the truth. Some of the victims interviewed felt that they were not believed or understood by the MARAC core group. The above shows that the core groups have difficulties in solving complex cases and sometimes have re-victimization attitudes; therefore, the MARAC core groups need more support and training.

Recommendation: to ensure that the new members of the MARAC core groups pass the (basic) e-course on DV and to find out whether the members of the MARAC core groups still need more specific training (e.g., networking, supporting a victim with addiction disorders, etc.). Collaborate with core groups to pinpoint the primary areas of concern and identify situations where core group members believe that MARAC's capabilities are insufficient in assisting victims with specific needs. With the support of the MARAC development team and/or within the agency, to provide support and opportunities for specialists to improve their knowledge and skills as well as to develop suitable solution ideas.

Victim perception of the MARAC process

Victims' understanding of MARAC is superficial, and sometimes, they are unclear about the benefits that MARAC brought to them, as they do not have a clear understanding of MARAC's functioning, objectives, capabilities, and role. There was also uncertainty among the interviewed victims as to whether and when their case was closed at MARAC.

Recommendation: Clarify to the victim the purpose and functions of MARAC, highlighting the victim's involvement in MARAC meetings, their opportunity to participate, and their role within the meeting. Also, explain the process of closing the victim's case within MARAC. Victims mainly communicate with and are satisfied with the Victim Support worker, who is a core group member of MARAC. Experiences and exposure to other core group members mostly take place at MARAC meetings and vary, including both positive and negative examples. Some of the victims felt that they received a lot of support, advice, and encouragement from the members of the core group. Others, on the other hand, felt that the specialist was passive, did not believe the victim, and did not provide any guidance or counselling. In the core groups of MARAC, opinions and practices on involving victims in meetings differ based on personal preferences and previous experiences.

Recommendation: identify good practices for involving victims in MARAC meetings and create common principles for deciding whether to involve victims in MARAC meetings. In addition, develop guidelines for resolving situations arising from the involvement of victims.

E-course on domestic violence

Professionals dealing with domestic violence now have access to an e-course designed to enhance awareness. The course delves into the nature of domestic violence, introduces assistance principles, and provides guidelines for responding swiftly and decisively in urgent situations. As of the end of September 2023, 114 people had completed the course. Twenty-three of them filled out the course feedback form. Most evaluated the course positively, praising the clear content, easy-to-follow structure, versatility, and practicality. Technical obstacles in the online environment, the volume and lack of clarity of the course, the time it takes to complete it, and problems with language use and spelling in the course materials appeared as problems.

Recommendation: Identify and address technical issues, differentiating between those associated with the online platform and potential problems arising from the participant's device. In the case of the latter, to point out possible solutions to the learners to avoid technical obstacles. We also recommend considering the possibility of clearly indicating the approximate time required for the course, both in the study guide and, if possible, indicating the average time required for this module at the beginning of the curriculum modules. Problems with spelling and language use in the course materials also need to be resolved.

Terminology

The wording of the terminology and definitions of roles and processes related to MARAC varies between documents. Also, the use of terms and their meanings differ among members

of core groups. This can cause misunderstandings for new members as well as for officials outside MARAC exposed to the process.

Recommendation: Harmonize the terminology used in the MARAC guidance materials.

Introduction

Domestic violence is a serious social problem that has a profound impact on victims and society at large. In 2022, according to the Ministry of Justice,¹ 3,244 domestic violence crimes were registered, and the number of domestic violence-related homicides and murders and their attempts was 7. Estonia acknowledges the gravity of domestic violence and has implemented various measures to enhance the protection of victims and prevent the occurrence of new cases. In 2014, Estonia ratified the Council of Europe Convention on preventing and combating violence against women and domestic violence (Istanbul Convention). This commitment mandates member states to offer support and services and foster a societal attitude that unequivocally rejects any justification or acceptance of violence against women and domestic violence. The Ministry of the Interior and the Social Insurance Board launched the European Social Fund-funded project "Identifying families at risk, including families suffering from domestic violence, and solving their problems using the network method" to deal with domestic violence. Within the framework of the project, the suitability of the MARAC model dealing with the high risk of domestic violence in Estonia was developed and tested.

MARAC (Multi-Agency Risk Assessment Conference) is a network-based case management model designed to identify adult victims at high risk of domestic violence² to reduce domestic violence and its severe consequences by ensuring the protection of victims through networking that includes several agencies and specialists. The MARAC model was tested and implemented in stages in Estonia since 2016 and was widely adopted throughout Estonia in 2019. However, the functioning of the MARAC model and its impact on victims and the work practices of specialists in the field have not been studied in Estonia so far, but in order to further develop the model, it is necessary to identify the current bottlenecks and positive practices.

The purpose of the study is to assess the impact of the implementation of the MARAC networking model on the relevant target groups, which are victims, specialists, and Victim Support networks. The impact on the victim is expressed both in the process and in its outcome, i.e., how the victim felt during and after MARAC and how successfully their case was ultimately resolved. Focusing on specialists and the MARAC network, we focus on the impact on the work process, i.e., how effectively networking works and how it affects each specialist. The study focuses on three main questions:

1. What impact has the implementation of MARAC's networking model (including MARAC volunteers) had on the victim, specialists, and Victim Support networks?
2. What would increase the effectiveness of MARAC's networking in helping victims in the future?

¹ Ministry of Justice. Crime in Estonia 2022.

<https://www.kriminaalpoliitika.ee/kuritegevus2022/perevagivald-ja-ahistamine/>

² MARAC is intended for victims of legal age, but also accepts victims under the age of 18 if they are victims of high-risk domestic violence by a partner or ex-partner.

3. What is the feedback on the e-learning course on domestic violence created by the Social Insurance Board? What are the recommendations to increase its effectiveness?

The study is based on the analysis of both quantitative and qualitative data. As quantitative data, we use MARAC monitoring data, supplemented with data on police calls and initiation of criminal proceedings, as well as data from MARAC network core groups and volunteer surveys. We collected qualitative data through interviews with members of the core groups of the MARAC network, victims, and volunteers.

The first chapter of the study report provides a statistical overview of MARAC implementation based on monitoring data. In the second chapter, based on surveys and interviews, we reveal the impact of implementing the MARAC networking model on core group specialists and Victim Support volunteers. In the third chapter, we focus on the cognitive impact of MARAC from the perspective of core group members and victims. The fourth chapter deals with feedback on the course from those who completed the e-course on domestic violence. In the last chapter, we provide an overview of the most important results of the study and the resulting recommendations. We present the research methodology in the annex to the report.

1 Statistical overview of MARAC implementation

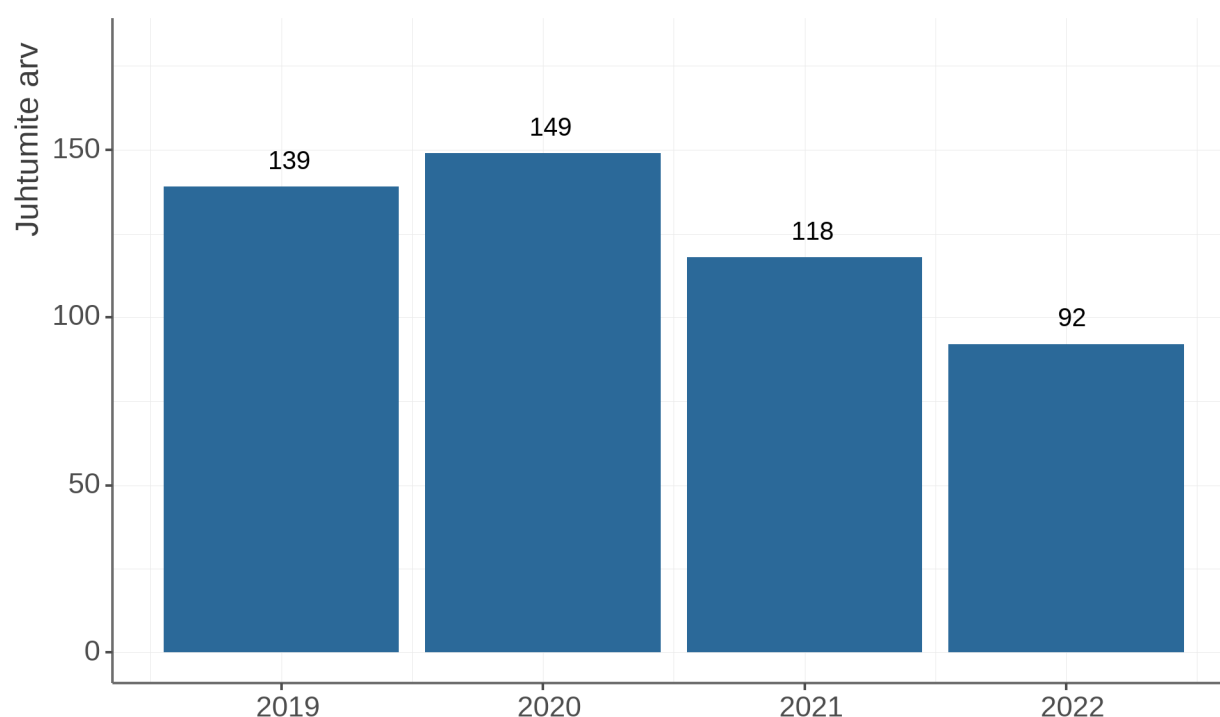
1.1 Number and regional distribution of MARAC cases

In the following, we provide an overview of the monitoring data collected by the SIB, which includes information about MARAC cases.

The database includes cases whose start date falls in the period 2019-2022 (498 cases in total). The number of cases has decreased somewhat in recent years - if there were 149 cases in 2020, by 2022, it had decreased by 57 cases, or 38.3%.

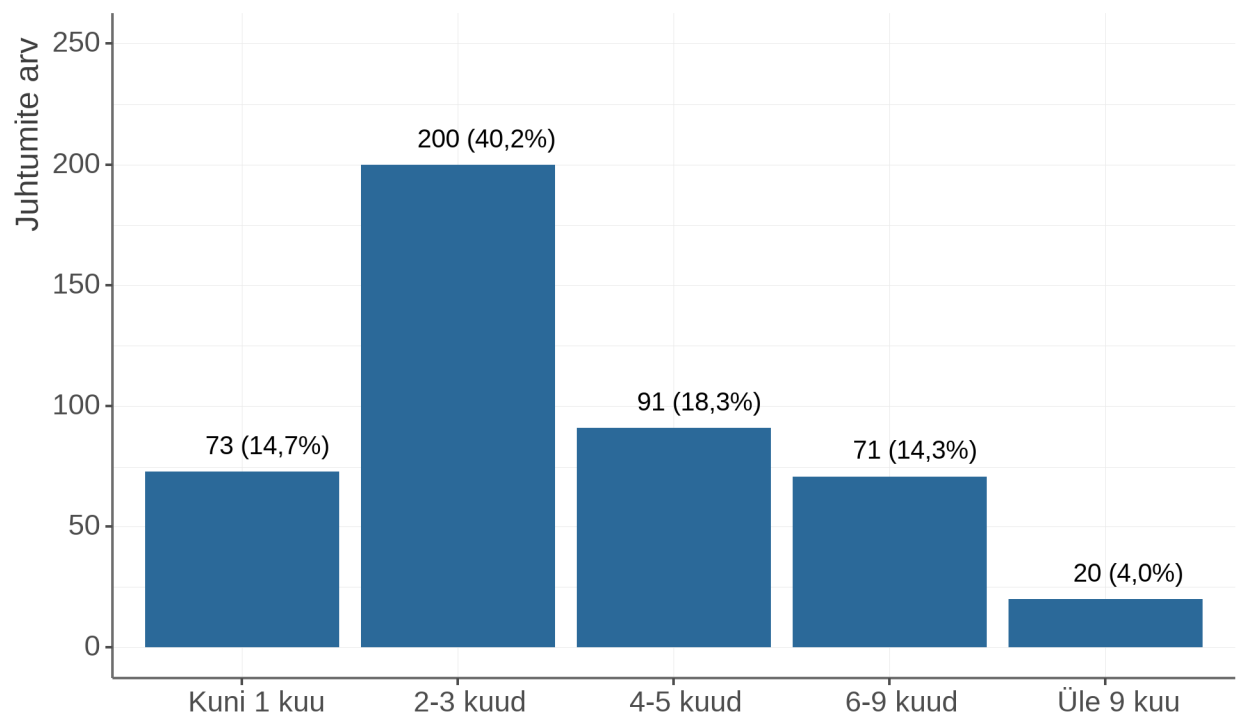
As a rule, during this period, the victim is referred to the MARAC model once; in 10 cases, the person has been referred to MARAC repeatedly because the risks have increased again.

Figure 1. Number of MARAC cases by year, 2019-2022



The duration of most (54.8%) cases is less than three months, and 4% of cases have a duration of more than nine months.

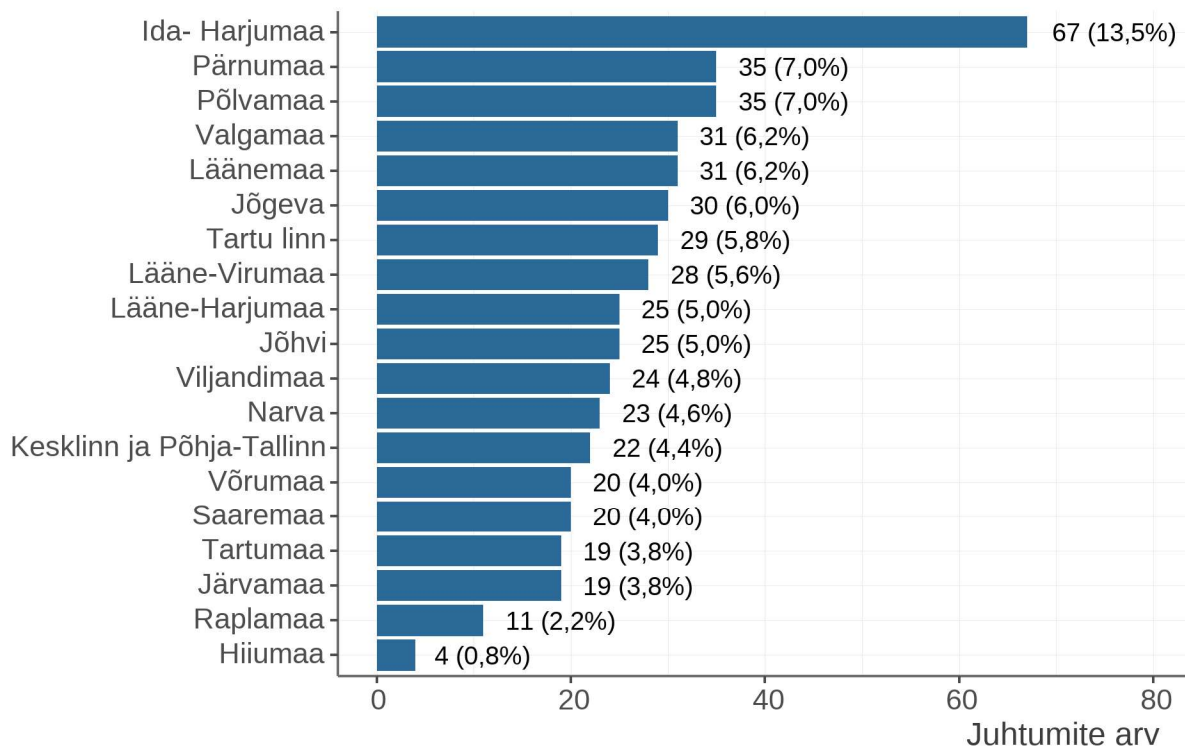
Figure 2. Duration of MARAC cases



Regions are mostly marked as counties in the monitoring data, and some regions are also distinguished in more detail. Thus, in the case of Harju County, Western Harju County and Eastern Harju County have been considered separately. Eastern Harju County also includes the eastern settlements of Tallinn, the city centre, and North Tallinn, forming a separate region (this division was used until 2021). In Ida-Viru County, Narva and Jõhvi are accounted for separately. In Tartu County, the city of Tartu and the rest of the County are accounted for separately.

The region with the highest absolute number of cases is Eastern Harju County (67 cases). Hiiu County has the fewest cases (4 cases). Rapla County also stands out from the others with a smaller number of cases.

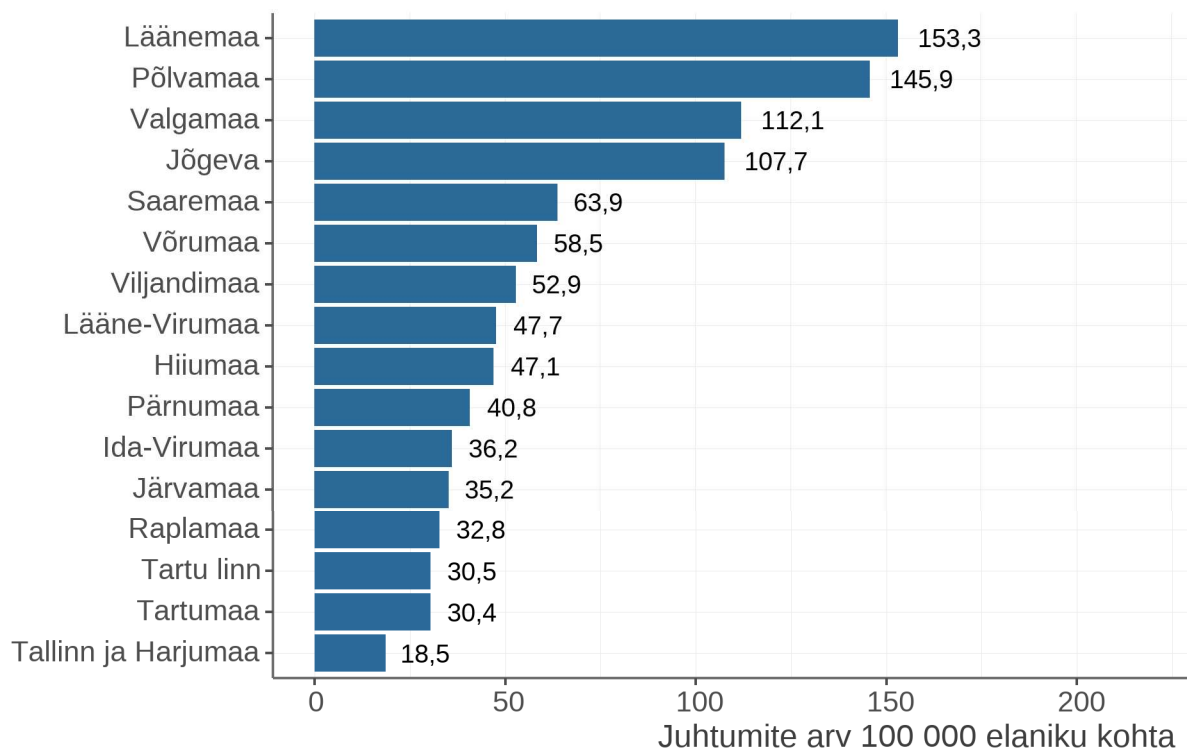
Figure 3. Number of MARAC cases by region and percentage of total cases



However, the absolute number of cases probably also reflects the population of the region (e.g., Hiiu County, with the lowest number of cases, is also the county with the lowest population in Estonia). Therefore, it is reasonable to relate the number of cases to the population of the region. Since population statistics are not available for all regions (e.g., Eastern Harju County), the regions are grouped together below.

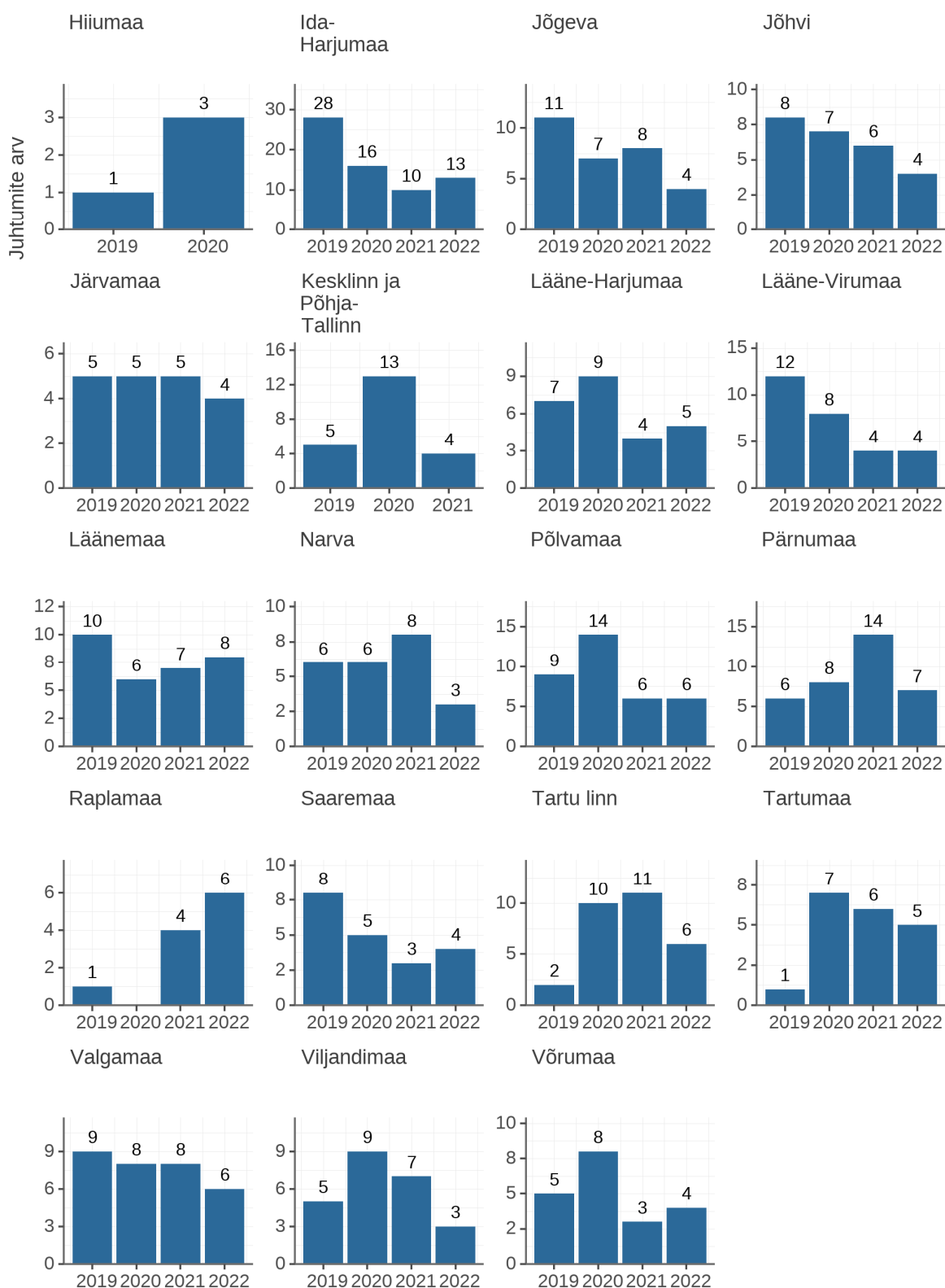
The following figure shows the number of cases per 100,000 inhabitants. Lääne County emerges with the largest proportion of cases. Followed by Põlva County and Valga County, which are also in the top five of the absolute number of cases. The proportion of cases in the population is smaller in Tallinn, Harju County, and Tartu County.

Figure 4. Number of MARAC cases per 100,000 population by county



It is difficult to identify regional trends, as the number of cases per year is quite small in most regions. Therefore, it is not clear whether these may be random fluctuations or systematic trends. At the same time, there are regions where there were no cases in some years: Valga County in 2020, Hiiu County in 2021 and 2022, and in the city centre and North Tallinn in 2022.

Figure 5. Annual number of MARAC cases by region, 2019-2022



All in all, the number of MARAC cases in Estonia as a whole decreased by 57 cases, or 38.3%, when comparing 2020 and 2022. On average, there were 8 cases per core group in 2020 and 5 in 2022. There is no uniform trend in the dynamics of the number of cases by region, as the number of cases in one core group is very small. The addition or omission of one case already affects the development of the trend. Therefore, although there seems to be a clear trend of decreasing MARAC cases in Estonia as a whole, it is not clearly identifiable in regional networks. MARAC cases are rare phenomena that affected 0.2-0.02% of the region's population in the four years under review. No clear correlation emerges that an area with a higher population would have more or fewer cases of MARAC than an area with a lower population.

1.2 Victim profile

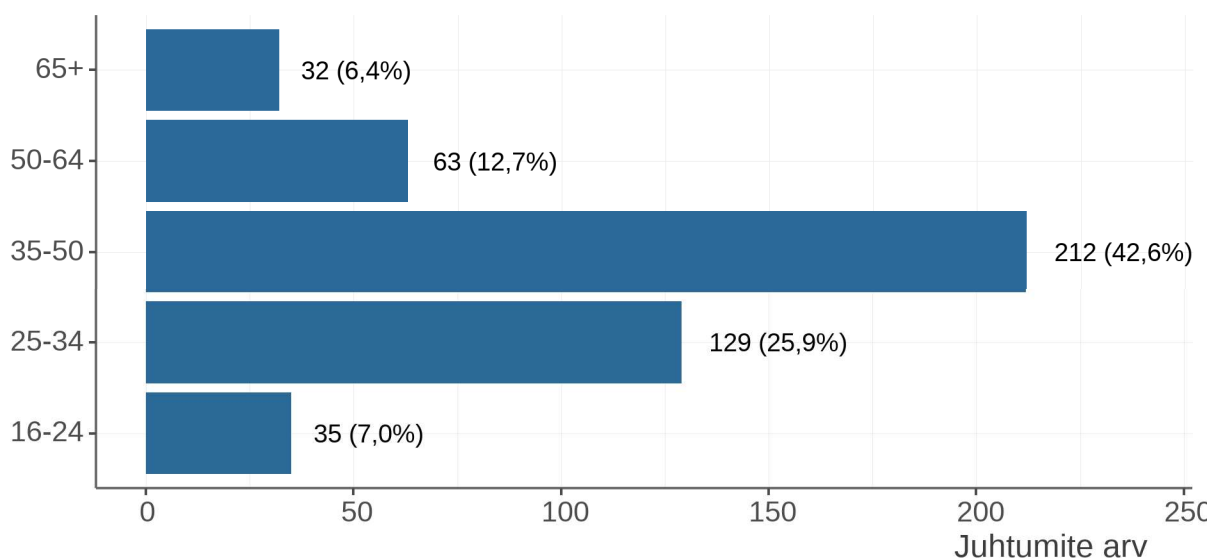
1.2.1 Gender distribution

The gender of the victim is female in 95.8% of cases. In most cases, the gender of the perpetrator of violence is not indicated (for cases that occurred before 2022, information about the gender of the perpetrator is completely missing). In only 40 cases, the gender of the perpetrator is indicated, of which 37 (92.5%), i.e., in the vast majority of cases, the perpetrator is a man. Although the gender of the perpetrator has not been systematically recorded in the monitoring database, it is known that the perpetrator is usually the current or former partner of the victim. Given that there have been no LGBTQ victims, it can be concluded that the perpetrators are predominantly men.

1.2.2 Age distribution

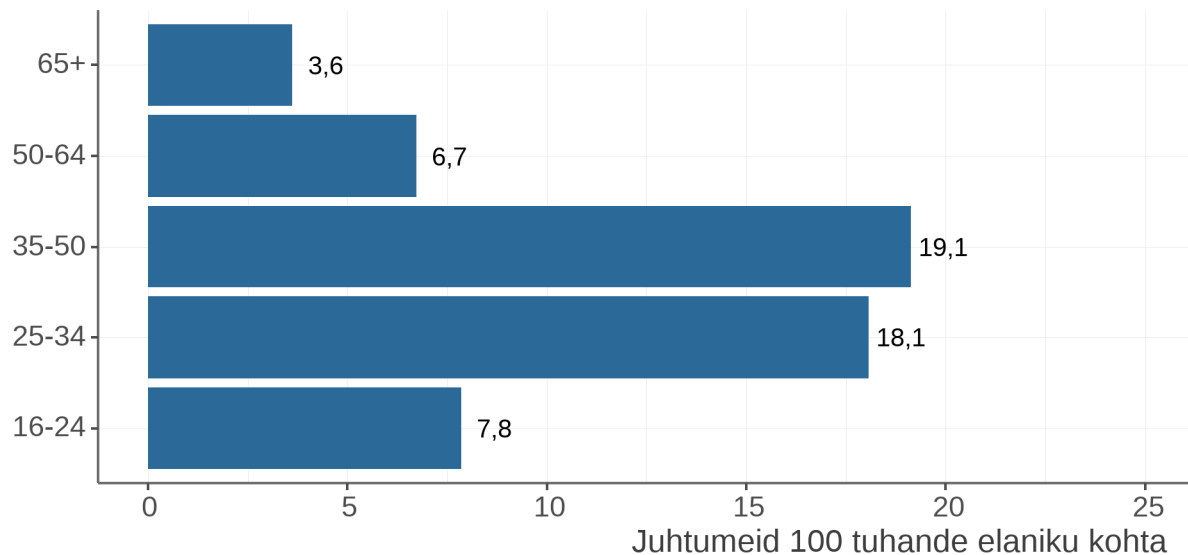
Information about the age of the victim is missing from the database in 5.4% of cases. Among the cases where age information is available, the most frequent age group is 35-50 (42.6% of all cases recorded in the monitoring data).

Figure 6. Number of MARAC cases by age group of the victim



As a percentage of the population, the number of cases is highest in the 25-34 and 35-50 age groups (see figure below). If the absolute numbers are 65 years and older and 16-24 years old,³ the number of cases with victims is similar; the number of cases with victims in the 65+ age group is significantly lower as a proportion of the population of the corresponding age. At this point, however, it is not known whether high-risk domestic violence occurs less often among this age group, whether they seek help less often, or are less likely to be seen by specialists dealing with DV.

Figure 7. Number of MARAC cases per 100,000 population by age group

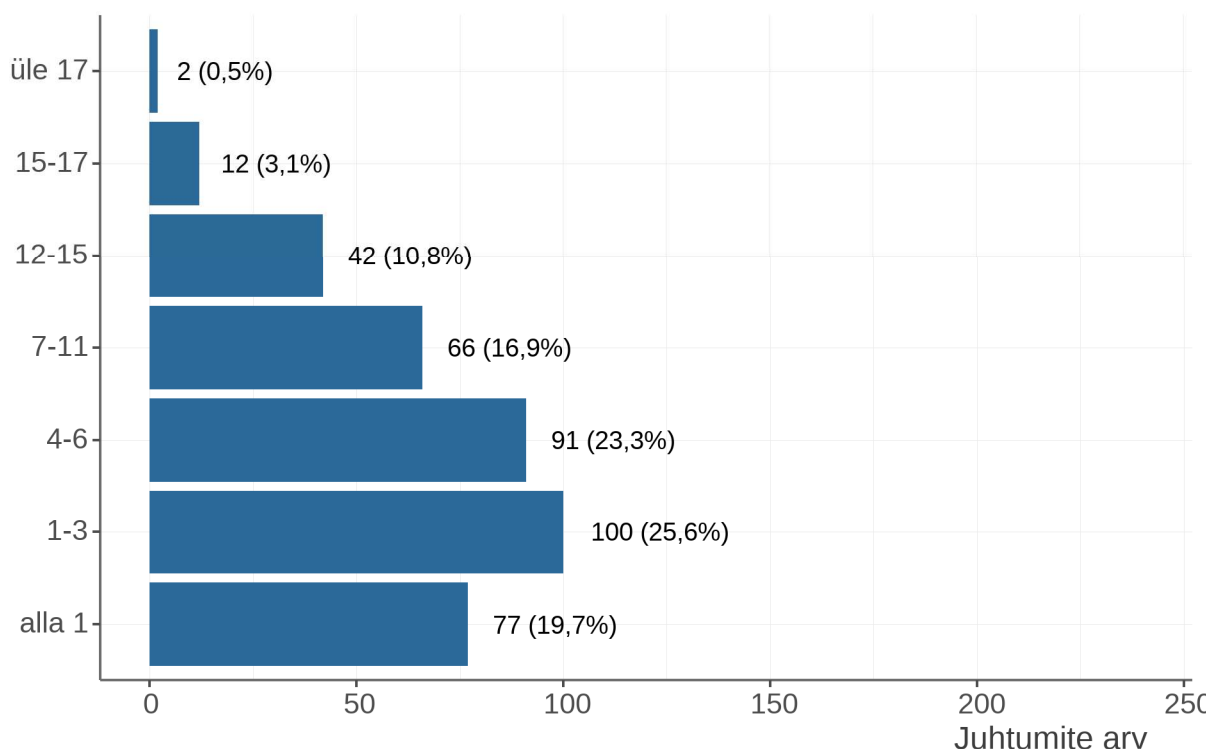


1.2.3 The number of minor children in the family

In 72.3% of all cases, there were minor children in the victim's family (up to two children in 71.7% of cases, 3-4 children in 18.7% of cases, and five or more children in 3.6% of cases).

³ MARAC is intended for victims of legal age, but also accepts victims under the age of 18 if they are victims of high-risk domestic violence by a partner or ex-partner.

Figure 8. Number of MARAC cases by age of victim's youngest child



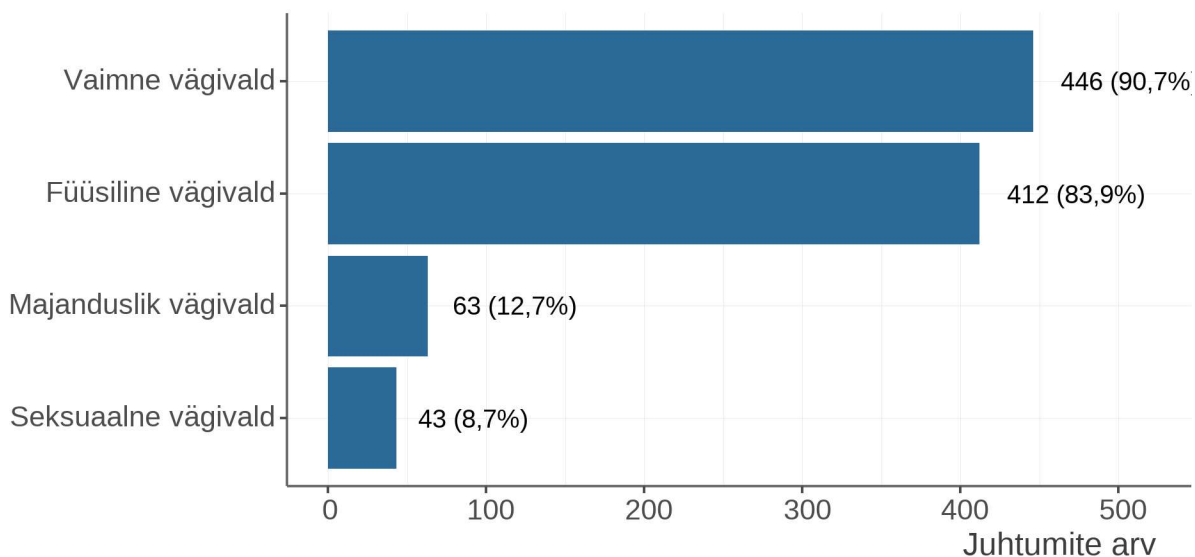
The most frequent case of domestic violence considered by MARAC is one where the victim is a woman (95.8%) aged 35-50 (42.6%) and whose household includes minor children (72.3%). However, there are also situations where the MARAC victim is significantly younger or older, without minor children, or male. Therefore, MARAC's networking must be suitable for victims with different characteristics. The findings from the data analysis further validate that high-risk domestic violence predominantly affects women. This underscores the significance of implementing policies geared toward preventing violence against women on a broader scale.

1.3 Characterization of MARAC cases

1.3.1 The main type of violence

According to the monitoring data, the most common type of violence is psychological violence (90.7%), but very often, physical violence is also mentioned (83.9%). Identified sexual and economic violence occurs significantly less in the dataset, 8.7% and 12.7%, respectively. All types of violence began to be registered in the database in 2022; before that, only the main type of violence was recorded. There were 12 incidents involving all types of violence.

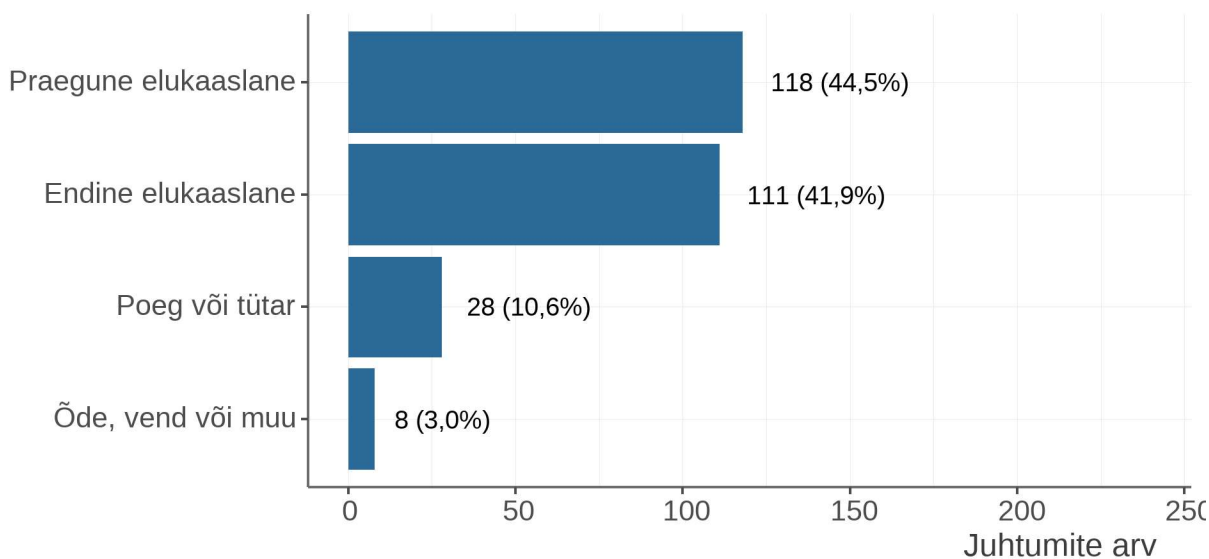
Figure 9. Frequency of types of violence in MARAC cases



1.3.2 Relationship with the perpetrator

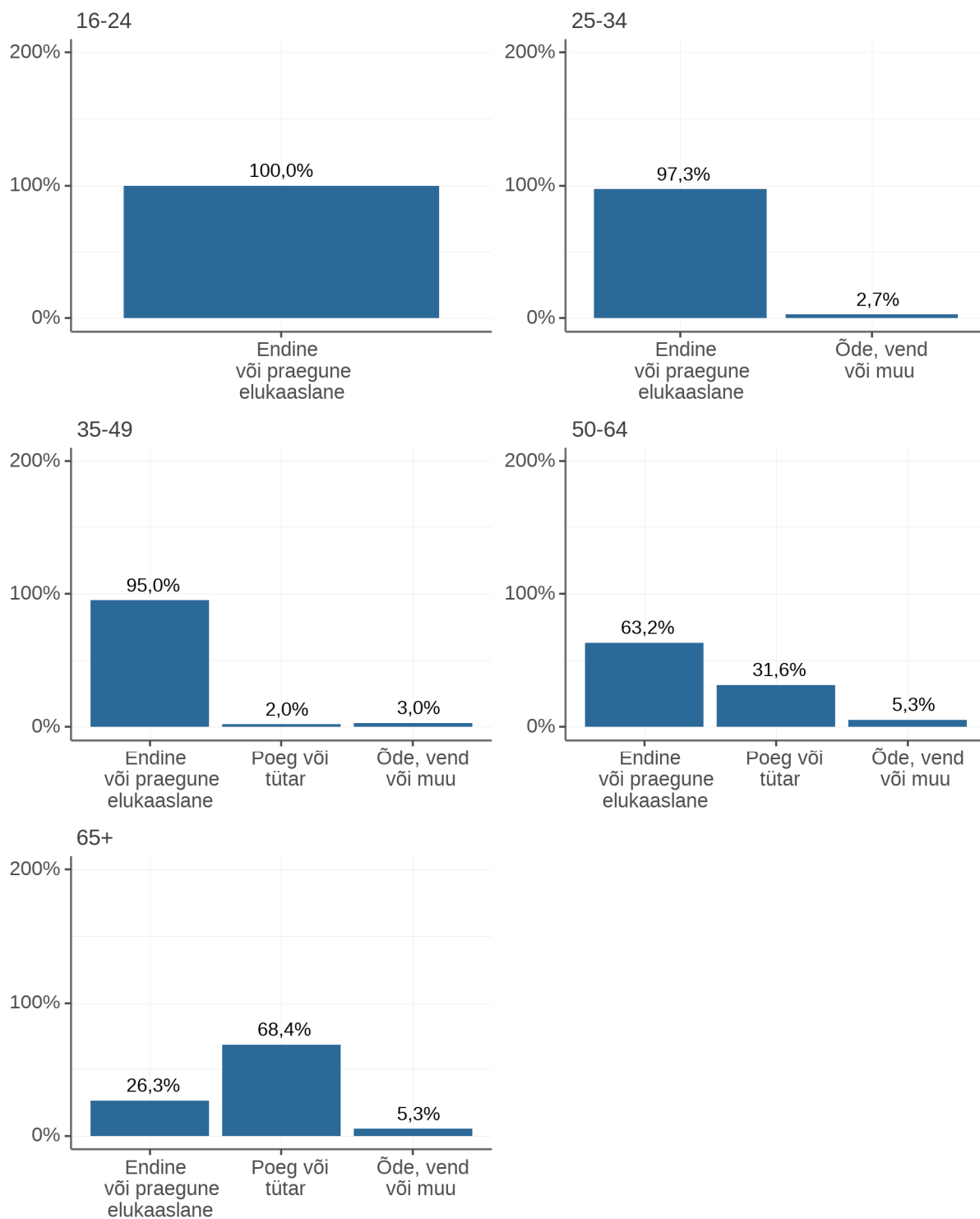
In most cases, the perpetrator of violence is the victim's former or current life partner (86.4% in total). The son or daughter is the perpetrator in 10.6 percent of cases; other connections and relationships with the perpetrator are less common.

Figure 10. The relationship between the perpetrator of violence and the victim



The relationship between the perpetrator and the victim varies by age group. For victims under 50 years of age, with only a few exceptions, the perpetrator of violence is a former or current partner. In the age group 50-64, the perpetrator is a son or daughter in nearly one-third of the cases, and in those aged 65 and over in more than two-thirds of the cases.

Figure 11. The relationship between the perpetrator of violence and the victim by age group of the victim

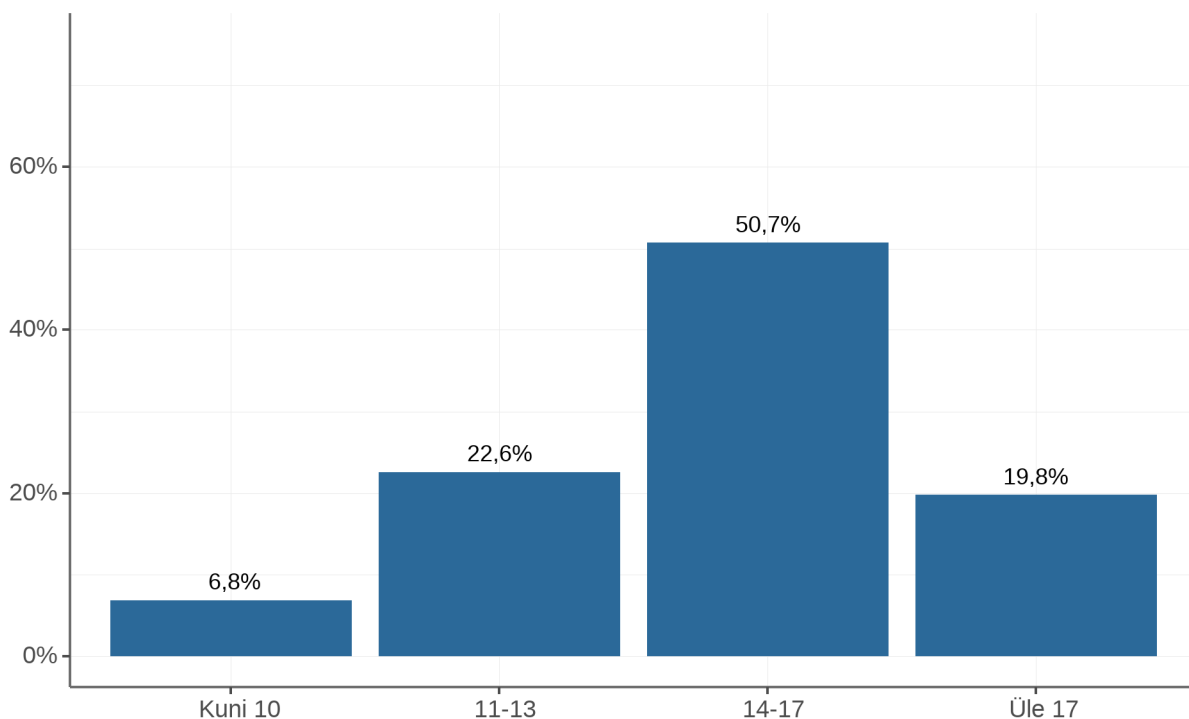


1.3.3 DASH score

The mean DASH baseline score was 14.9.

The DASH baseline score was missing in 29 cases (5.8% of all cases in the dataset). From the information found in the text fields of the database, it appeared that the baseline score could be missing, for example, because the risk assessment could not be carried out for various reasons. The final score is missing in 374 cases (75.1%) and present in 124 cases. Annually, the percentage of cases without a final score varies between 61.1-89.1%. The number of cases with a missing final score is highest in 2022, which may be because the cases are recent. However, this is not the only reason, as the percentage of cases without a final score is very high, even in previous years.

Figure 12. The DASH baseline score distribution (% of cases with baseline score reported in the baseline dataset)



The average DASH baseline score has increased over the period under review, from 14.9 in 2019 to 16 by 2022. Looking at the distribution of DASH baseline scores, the proportion of cases with an initial score below 14 has decreased over the period, and the proportion of cases with a baseline score of 14 and above has increased.

Figure 13. DASH mean baseline score by years

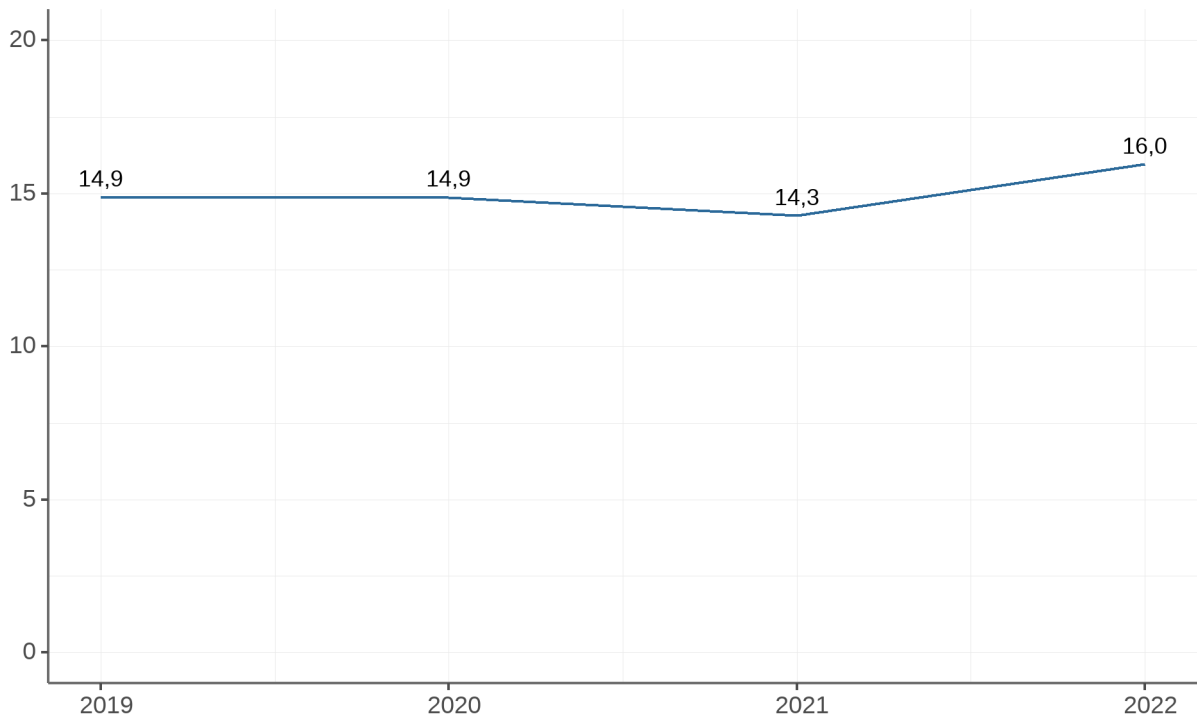
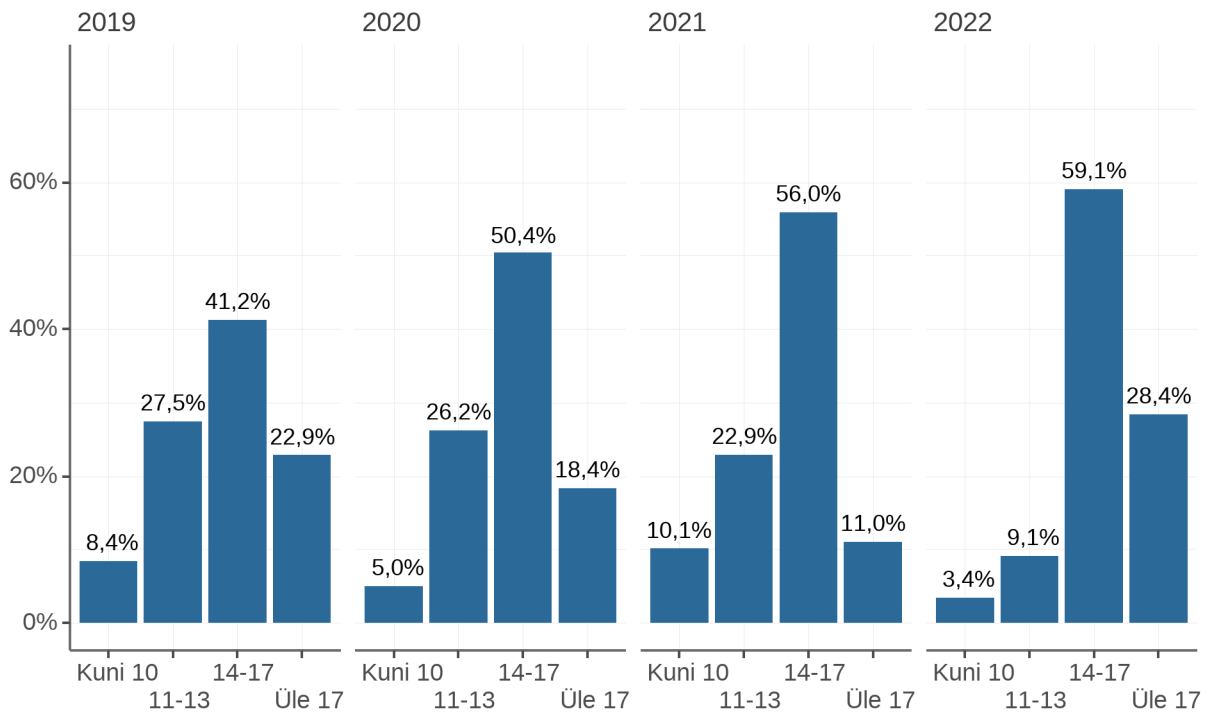


Figure 14. Distribution of DASH baseline score by year (% of cases where baseline score is reported in the baseline dataset)

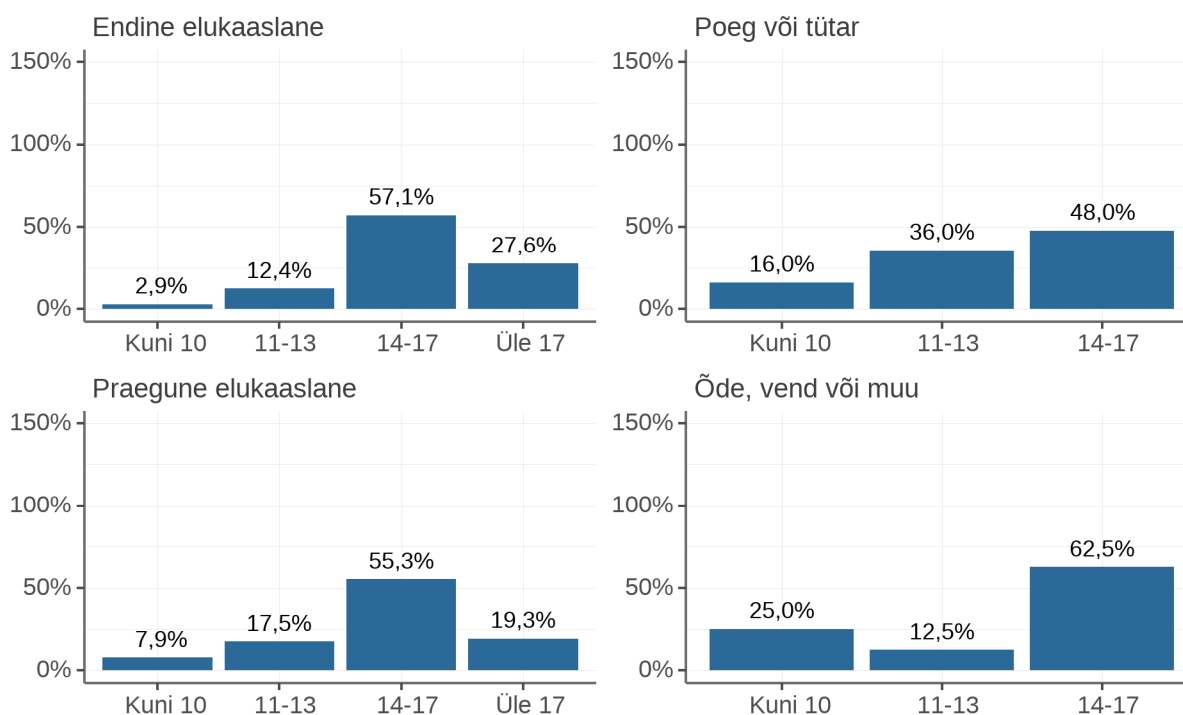


The mean final DASH score was 6.8. In cases where both the baseline and final scores were indicated, the average decrease was -7.5 points or 47.3%.

There were 74 cases where the baseline score was 14 points or more, and the final score was less than 14 points or 60.2% of the cases in which both the baseline and final scores were indicated (123 cases). There were 4 cases where the final score did not decrease compared to the baseline score. There were 3 cases where both the baseline and final scores were 14 or higher.

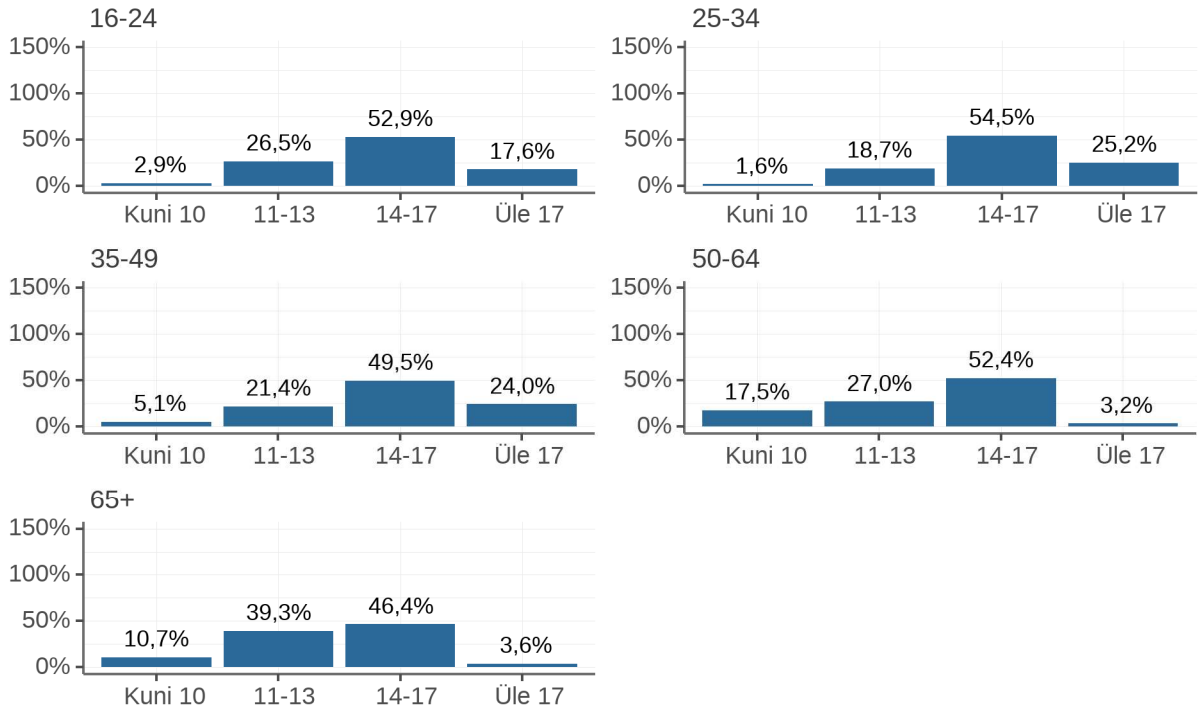
On average, the DASH baseline score is slightly higher for cases where the perpetrator is a former or current partner (15.4) compared to cases where the perpetrator is a son/daughter, sister/brother, or someone else. Cases with a baseline score higher than 17 only occur if the perpetrator is a former or current partner.

Figure 15. Distribution of DASH baseline scores by victim-perpetrator relationship



By age group, it can be observed that the frequency of lower baseline scores (up to 10 points) is higher among those aged 50 and older (see figure below). Among those aged 65 years and older, the prevalence of baseline DASH scores below 14 points is significantly higher (50%) than in other age groups.

Figure 16. Distribution of baseline DASH scores by victim age group



Overall, in MARAC cases, the perpetrator of violence is predominantly the victim's current or former partner. The older the victim, the more likely the perpetrator is the victim's child. The baseline score of the average risk assessment (DASH) for MARAC cases is 14.9, and 70.6% of MARAC cases have an initial score higher than the threshold, i.e., 14 points (taking into account only the cases in which initial score information is indicated in the dataset). In situations where the perpetrator is the victim's son or daughter, the baseline score is higher than the threshold in only 48% of cases, and if the victim is older than 65, then in 50% of cases.

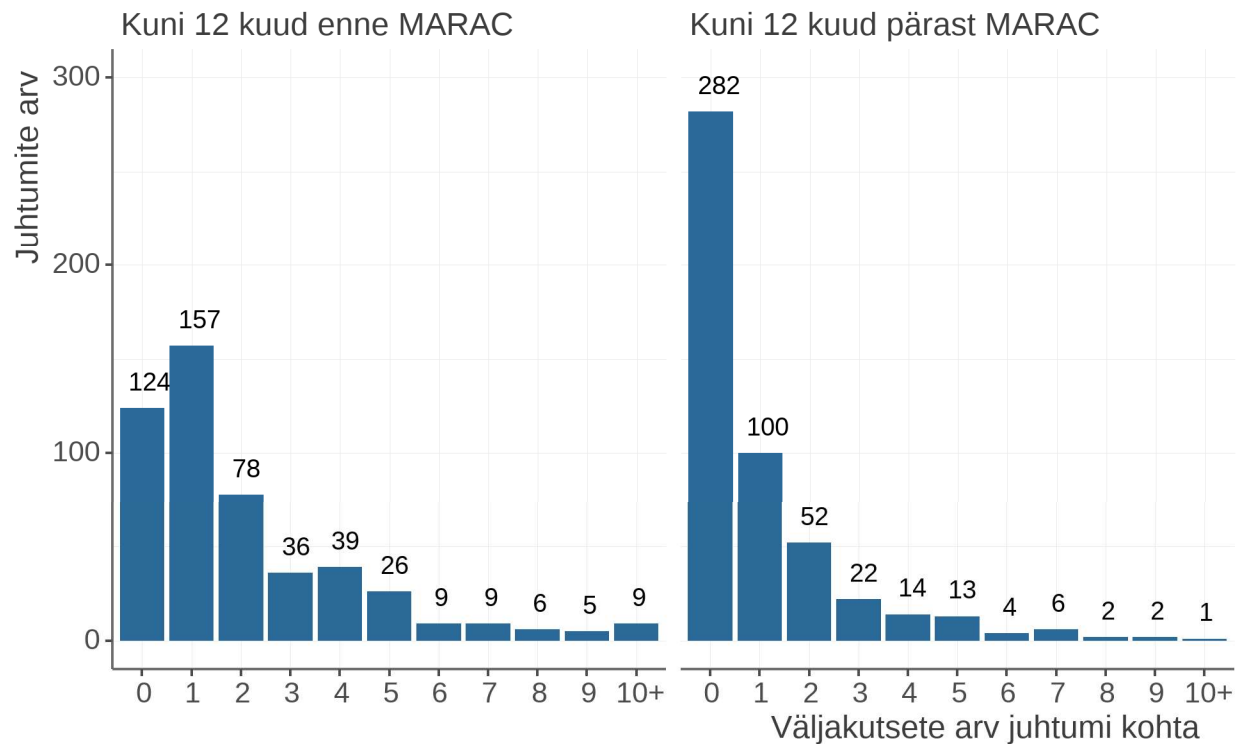
1.4 Use of police measures and criminal proceedings

1.4.1 Police calls

According to data from the Police and Border Guard Board, there were an average of 2 calls per incident up to 12 months before MARAC intervened.

Six months after the intervention, there was an average of 0.7 or 65.3% fewer calls. In the 12 months after the intervention, there was an average of 1 or 51.9% fewer calls than before the MARAC intervention.

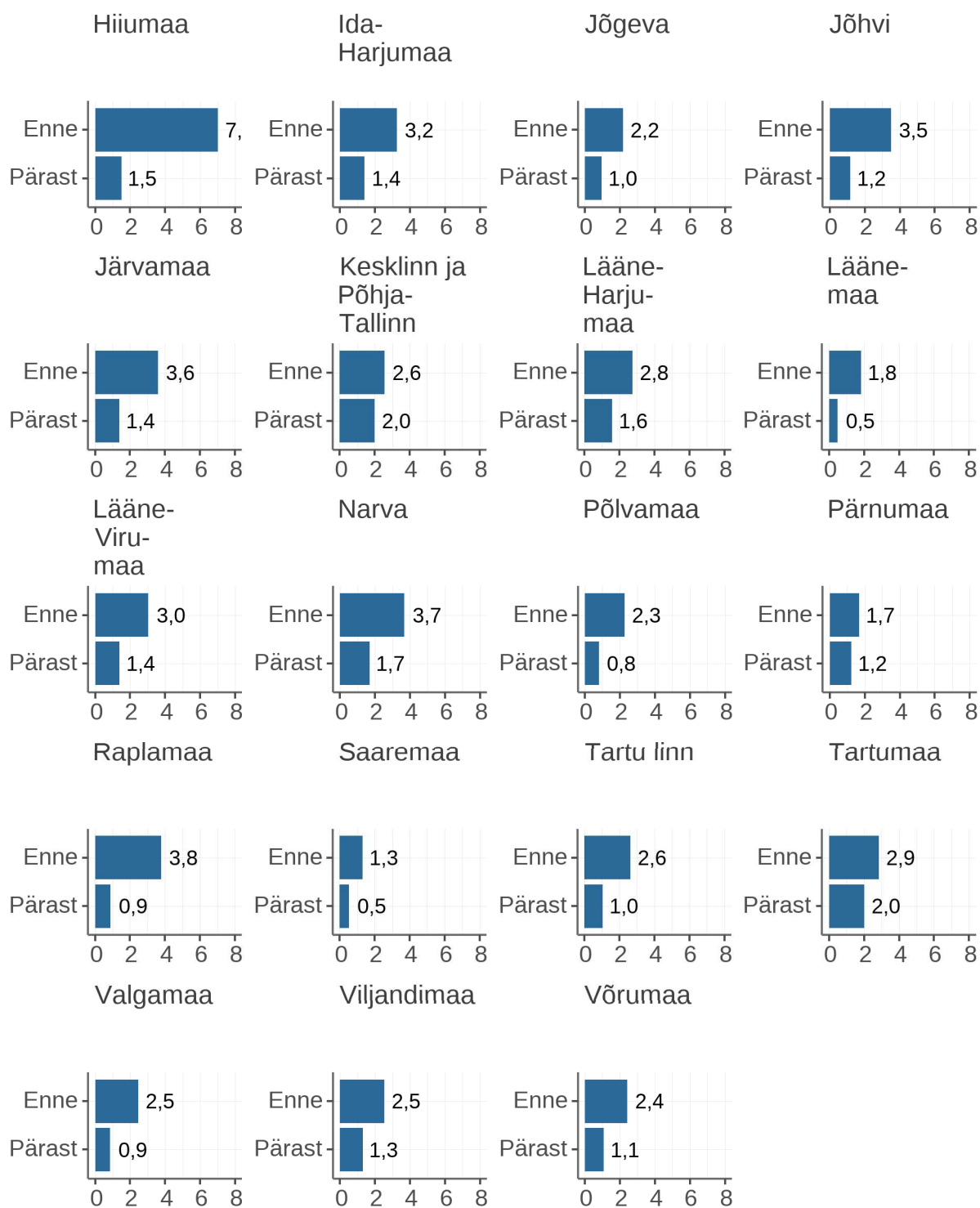
Figure 17. Number of police calls before and after MARAC



The number of cases where there was at least one police call in the 12 months before the MARAC intervention and the total number of calls did not decrease in the 12 months after the MARAC intervention was 83, or 22.2% of all cases with a police call in the year before MARAC. Among the cases where there were calls before MARAC, but no reduction in calls occurred after the start of MARAC, there was a preponderance of cases where the number of calls before MARAC was also small (only one call in two-thirds of cases).

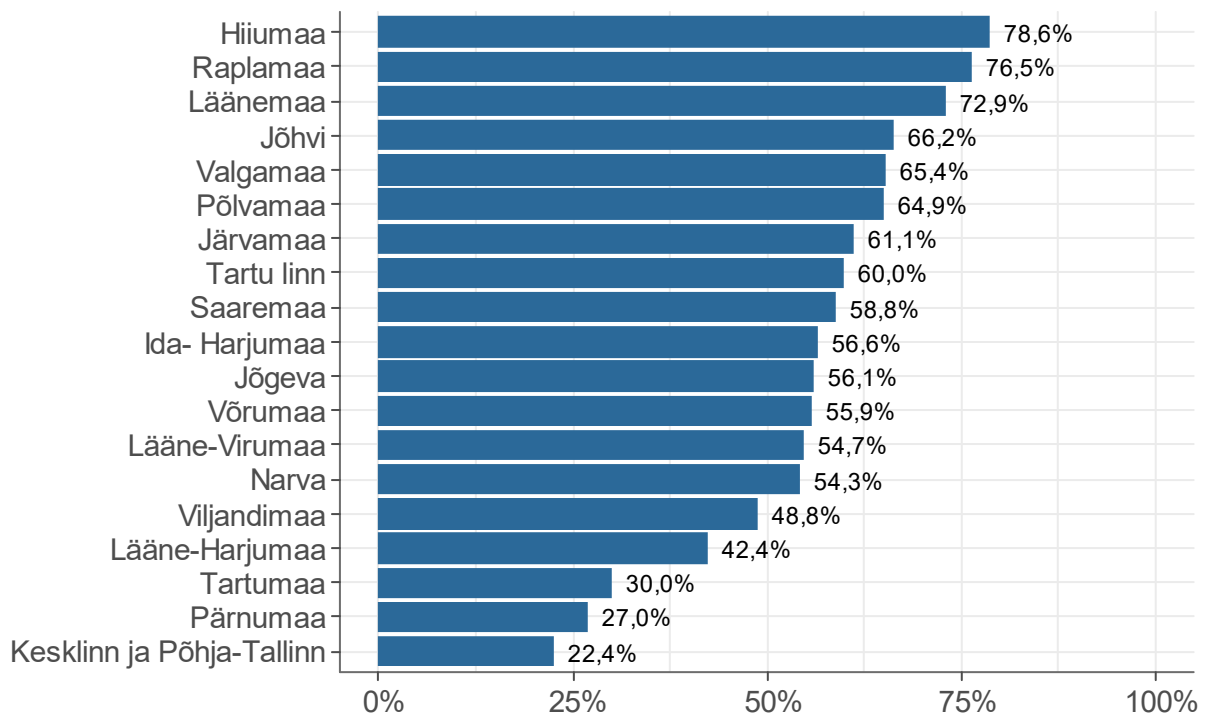
Significant differences in the number of calls to the police can be observed by area when comparing the number of calls in the 12 months before and in the 12 months after the MARAC intervention. In most areas, the number of calls in the 12 months after MARAC is at least half less than before.

Figure 18. Number of police calls by region before and after MARAC (cases of police calls before MARAC)



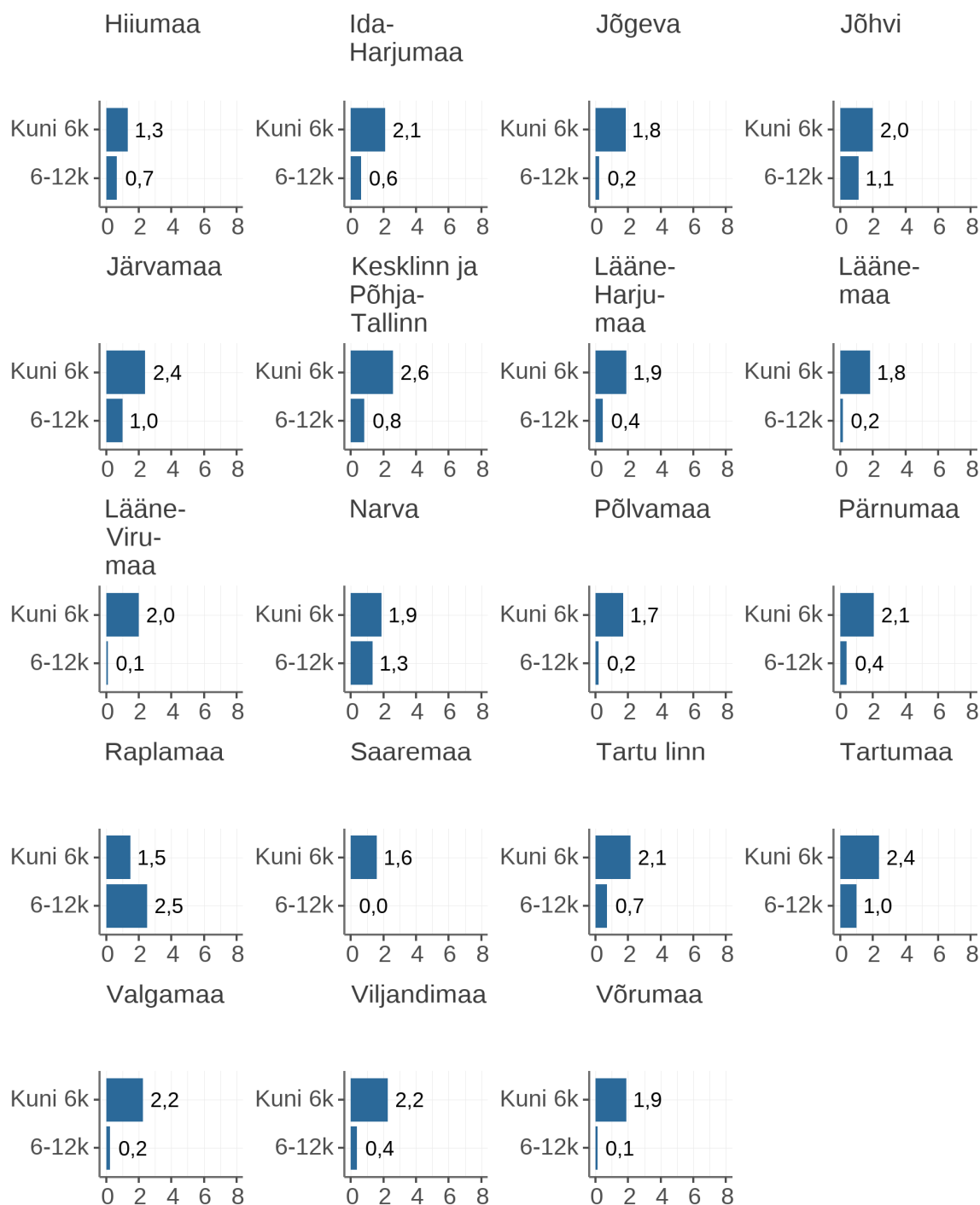
Percentage-wise, the number of calls decreased the most in Hiiu County (but from a relatively high level). The decrease was the smallest in the centre of Tallinn and North Tallinn.

Figure 19. Percentage reduction in police calls in the 12 months after MARAC (incidents with police calls before MARAC)



Quite large differences can also be observed when comparing the number of calls up to 6 months and 6-12 months after the end of MARAC. In most counties, the number of calls after the end of MARAC decreases (the only exception is Rapla County); in many counties, the decrease is considerable.

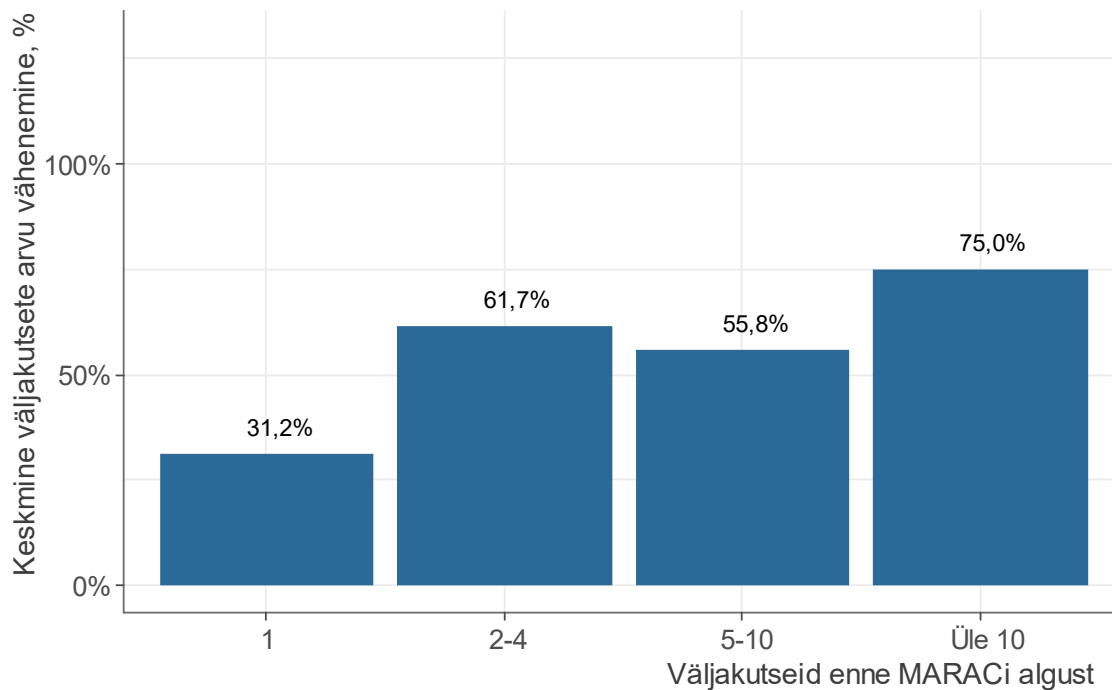
Figure 20. Number of police calls up to 6 months and 6-12 months after MARAC by region (cases with police calls up to 12 months before MARAC)



The percentage reduction in the number of calls was greater for cases with more than one call prior to the start of MARAC (see the following figure). For cases with one call before MARAC, the average number of calls after MARAC was 31.2% lower. However, when

comparing cases with 2-4 calls before MARAC and those with 5-10 calls, there is no pattern that a higher number of calls before MARAC is associated with a greater decline in calls after MARAC. However, the largest drop in calls can be seen in cases where there were more than ten calls prior to MARAC.

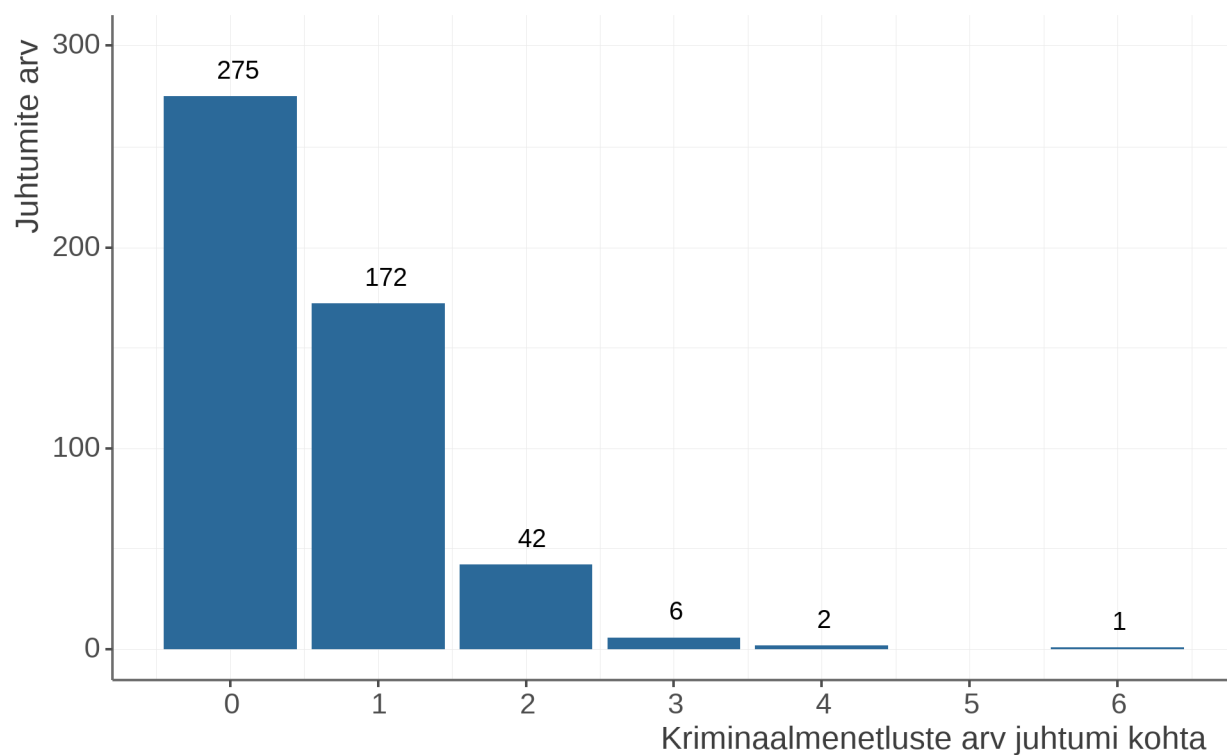
Figure 21. Reduction in the number of calls by a number of pre-MARAC calls, %



1.4.2 Initiation of criminal proceedings

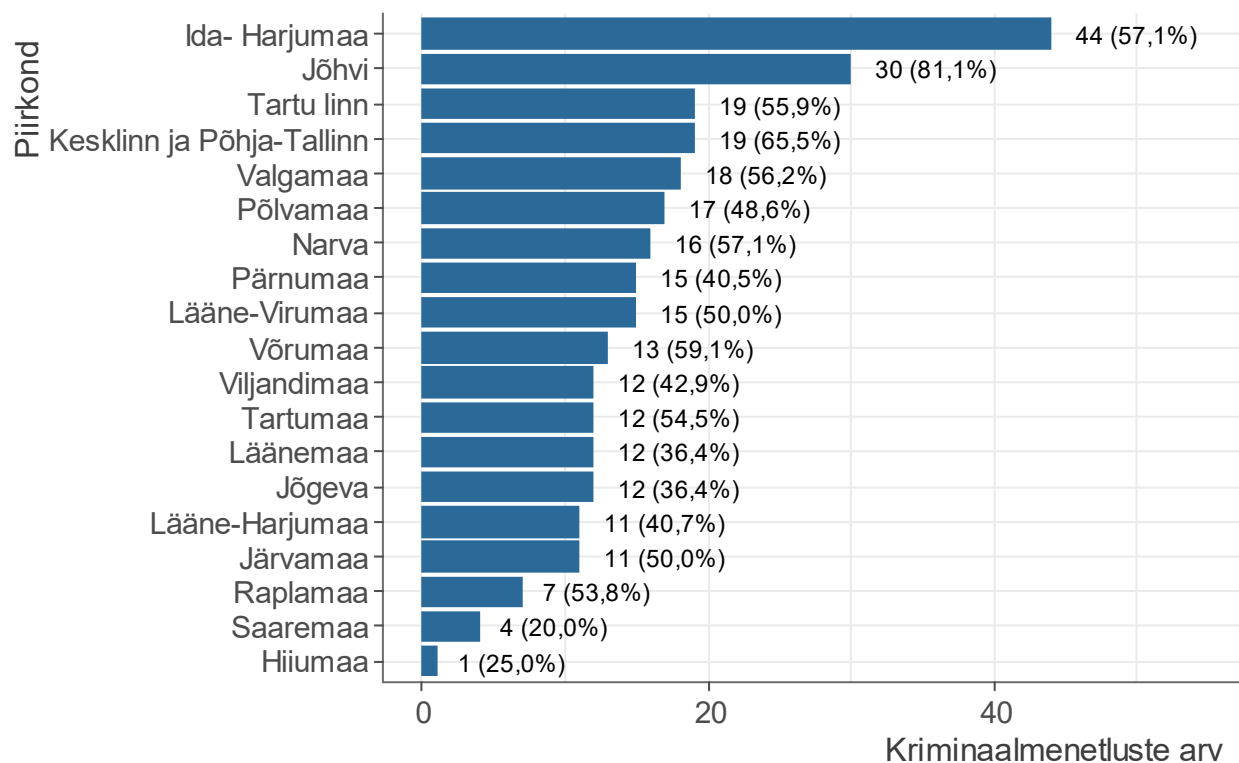
Criminal proceedings were initiated in a total of 223 cases (44.8% of all cases). There was mostly one criminal proceeding per case, but there were quite a large number (51 cases) of cases in which more than one criminal proceeding had been initiated (mostly two, but in one case also 6).

Figure 22. Number of criminal proceedings per MARAC case



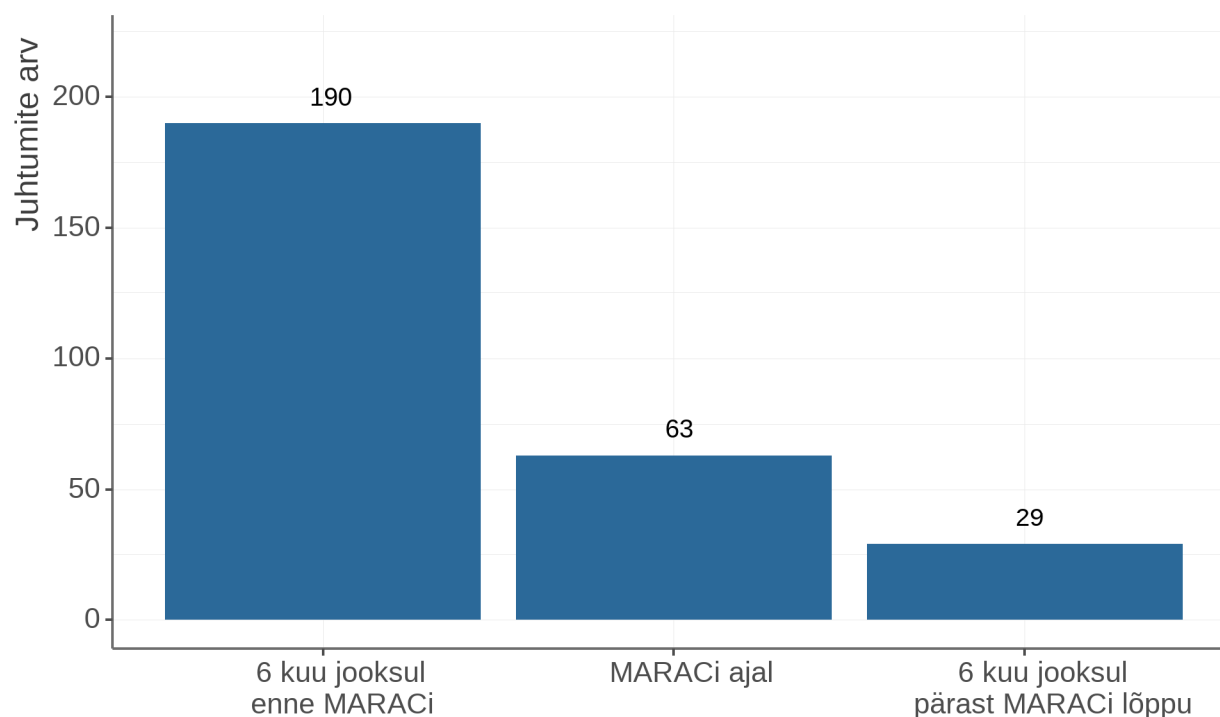
By region, the most criminal proceedings were initiated in Eastern Harju County and Jõhvi, the least in Hiiu County.

Figure 23. The number of criminal proceedings by region and the proportion of cases in which criminal proceedings were initiated



In 190 cases, criminal proceedings were initiated within six months before the MARAC intervention, in 63 cases during the MARAC intervention, and in 29 cases within six months after the end of the MARAC intervention.

Figure 24. Number of criminal proceedings before and after MARAC and during MARAC



1.4.3 Restraining order

A restraining order can be applied to prevent the violation of the victim's rights. A restraining order is set by the court, and it prohibits one person from approaching another person or their frequent location for up to three years. Beyond limiting physical proximity, the court may impose additional restrictions, determining the specific conditions under which the offender is allowed to communicate with the individual through means such as telephone, social media, or other channels. A restraining order can be set in both criminal and civil proceedings.

In criminal proceedings, a restraining order can be set either for the duration of the initiated criminal proceedings or, in the case of a conviction, for up to three years after the end of the criminal proceedings (so-called long-term restraining order). From 07.05.2020, the prosecutor can also establish a temporary restraining order, but the court must confirm its admissibility later (the corresponding application must be submitted to the court within two working days).

The legal basis for the application of the restraining order is § 1055 (1) of the Law of Obligations Act. If the unlawful infliction of harm is continuous or if unlawful infliction of harm is threatened, the victim or the person who was threatened may demand that the perpetrator discontinue the harm-causing behavior or stop threatening. In case of bodily injury, damage to health, violation of privacy, or other violation of personal rights, it may be requested, among other things, to prohibit the person causing the damage from approaching

another person (restraining order), to regulate the use of housing or communication, or to apply other similar remedies.

Information on requesting a restraining order is available in the SIB monitoring database in 222 cases (44.6% of all cases). A restraining order was requested for 59 victims (26.6% of those for whom this information is available). A restraining order was applied in 36 cases (61% of the cases in which a restraining order was requested). In most cases, information about the procedure in which the restraining order was applied is not indicated in the monitoring database. In those cases where it was indicated, the type of restraining order was mostly a restraining order through criminal proceedings (13 cases); in 1 case, the type was a shelter. According to the Prosecutor's Office database, a temporary restraining order was requested in 31 cases. The request was granted in 25 cases and partially granted in 4 cases. Of the requests for a temporary restraining order, ten were partially or fully granted within six months before the start of MARAC, 12 during MARAC, and five within six months after MARAC.

According to the Prosecutor's Office database, a long-term restraining order (a restraining order that is imposed on a convicted person and remains in effect after the end of the criminal proceedings) was requested in 33 cases, and all of the requests were granted. Of the requests for a long-term restraining order, four requests were granted within six months before the start of MARAC, 12 requests were granted during MARAC, and 13 requests were granted within six months after MARAC.

Overall, 81.5% of MARAC cases involve calls to the police (before or after MARAC), and criminal proceedings were initiated before or after MARAC in 44.8% of cases. There are 13.7% of cases where neither occurs. The distribution of police calls before and after the MARAC intervention shows that the number of police calls decreases on average, which may indicate that there is less police intervention as a result of MARAC. There are some regions where MARAC cases were initiated in cases with an average higher number of police calls compared to other regions (Hiiu County, Eastern Harju County, Jõhvi, Narva, Järva County, Rapla County). Criminal proceedings are more than twice as likely before MARAC as during or after MARAC.

2 The impact of implementing the MARAC networking model on professionals and Victim Support networks

2.1 Introduction

First, we will give an overview of MARAC cores, or core groups, and then of MARAC volunteers.

We begin the overview of the core groups with the number of members and their distribution among MARAC's contributing agencies. We then describe the work organization of the MARAC core groups, starting with the roles and tasks of the members in MARAC and the mapping of the missing specialists. Based on the MARAC system, we describe victim risk assessment and MARAC referral, MARAC meetings, and activities after the closure of MARAC cases. We look at the meetings as regulated elements of the MARAC network from several angles: the frequency and adequacy of the meetings, compliance with the mandatory parts of the meetings, assessment of the effectiveness and content of the meetings (including discussion of the victim's social problems and the perceived need for measures aimed at the perpetrator). Separately, we discuss core members' satisfaction with MARAC's work organization, MARAC's impact on members' work methods, and the impact of recent crises. Finally, we look at MARAC members' assessments of the support and opportunities for support they need to operate in a self-sustaining way within MARAC.

Finally, we describe the number, workload, role, work processes, and perceived need for support of MARAC volunteers.

2.2 MARAC core groups and numbers of core group members

MARAC is a network-based case management model. Estonia is divided into 18 MARAC regions, each of which has its own network or core group. MARAC core groups consist of members representing various agencies (hereinafter also referred to as MARAC core group members) and specialists involved on a case-by-case basis. The core group decides the composition and number of members independently. Regardless of the region, the members of the core groups are representatives of the Social Insurance Board (SIB), the Police and Border Guard Board (PBGB), and the Prosecutor's Office. Most of the core group members are also members from the Women's Support Centre (WSC) and from the local government (LG) in more than half of the regions. MARAC was created specifically to coordinate the actions of these parties in high-risk domestic violence (IPV) cases. The effectiveness of MARAC largely depends on the participation of agencies because each agency has valuable information about the victim's situation, which can influence the solutions agreed upon to solve the case (Kerti, 2017).

The number of MARAC core group members ranges (see Table 1) from 5 people in Hiiu County to 15 people in the Eastern Harju region. Thus, the number of core group members differs threefold in the smallest and the largest core group. By agency, the largest number of MARAC members work in PBGB, followed by SIB.

Table1. Members of MARAC core groups by agencies and regions

Region	Agencies						Total
	Local gover nmen ts	Other	WSC	PBGB	Prosecutor's office	Social Insur ance Board	
Haapsalu	1		1	2	1	1	6
Hiiumaa	1			2	1	1	5
Ida-Harju	2		1	4	2	6	15
Jõgeva	1	1	1	2	1	1	7
Jõhvi			1	3	3	3	10
Lääne-Harju			1	3	1	4	9
Narva			1	3	1	3	8
Paide		1		4	1	2	8
Pärnu	1	2	1	1	1	2	8
Põlva			1	3	3	2	9
Rakvere	1			3	1	2	7
Rapla			1	2	1	2	6
Saaremaa	2	1	1	1	1	1	7
Tartu	1		2	3	1	2	9
Tartu County	2		2	4	2	2	12
Valga			1	4	1	1	7
Viljandi	2	1	1	2	2	1	9
Võru	1	3	2	3	1	1	11
Total	15	9	18	49	25	37	153

Source: List of SIB MARAC core group members, author's adaptations, and calculations.

There is no LG representative in the core group of 7 regions. There is no LG representative, as the core group covers several LGs, and depending on the victim's place of residence, the LG representative participates in the work of the core group on a case-by-case basis. The

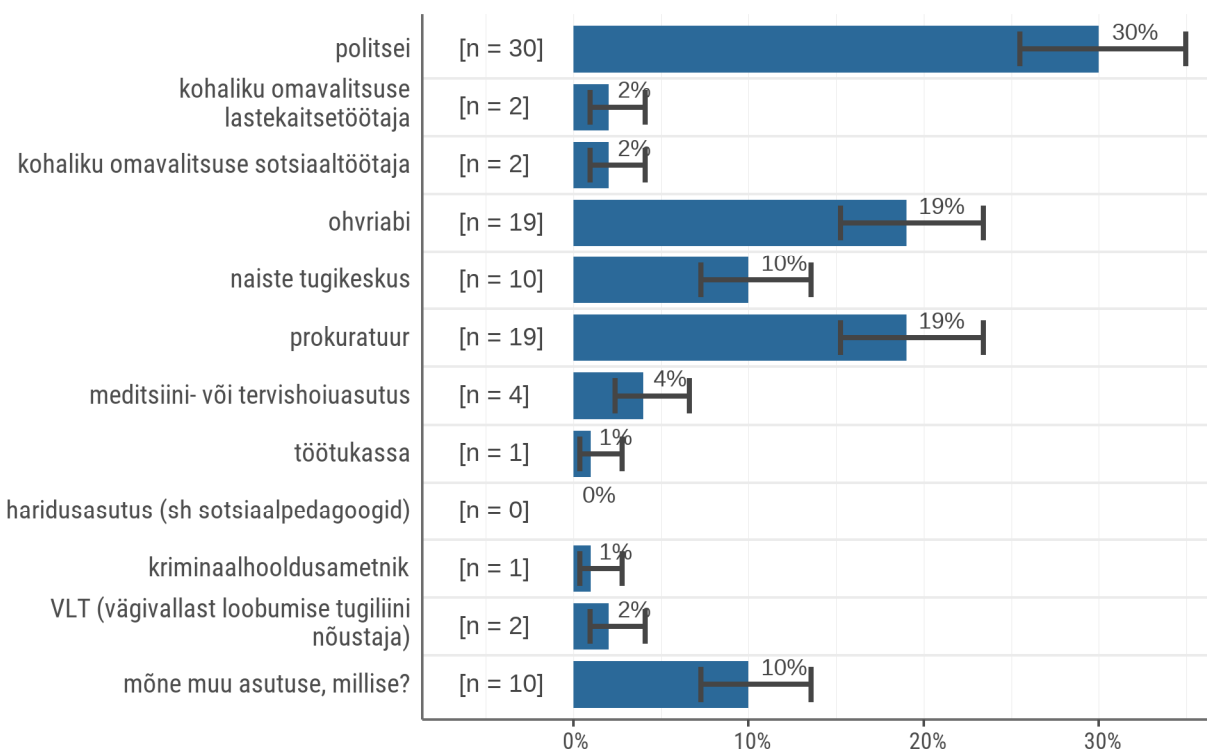
core groups of Hiiu County, Saare County, and Tartu MARAC mainly focus on one local authority, which is why a representative of the local authority is included as a member. At the same time, some core groups covering several LGs also have LG representatives among their members. Therefore, there is no uniform practice for involving LG representatives in the core groups of different regions.

In 7 regions, additional members have been added to the five agencies normally represented in a MARAC core group (SIB, PBGB, WSC, LG, prosecutor's office). These additional members represent the following agencies:

- Education and Youth Board
- Prison
- Estonian Forensic Science Institute
- Estonian Unemployment Fund
- Hospital

In the survey of the core group members, the respondents themselves determined the agency they represent. The survey reflected the agencies and the numbers of respondents, as shown in Figure 25. The Social Insurance Board, local government, and Rajaleidja were named under other agencies.

Figure 25. Distribution of core group members by agency represented in MARAC (% of core group members)

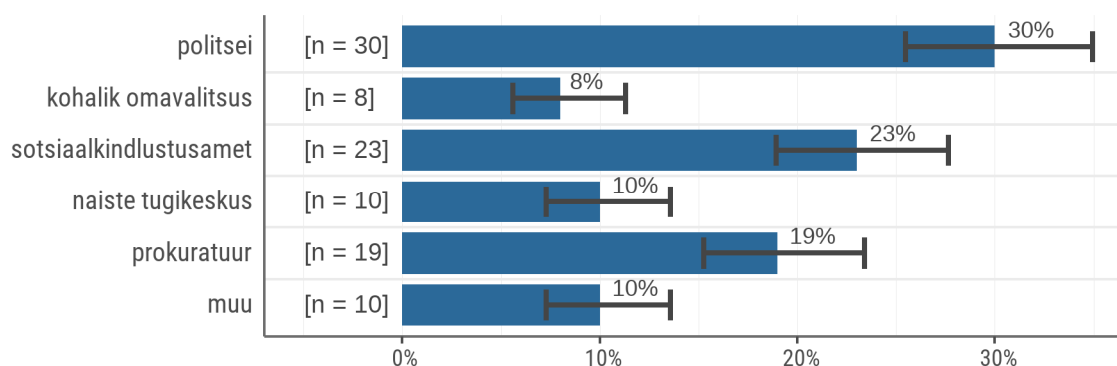


Source: A survey of MARAC core group members.

Note: In this figure and hereafter, n represents the number of survey respondents on which the value presented in the figure is based. The range at the end of the bars shows the upper and lower confidence limits of the estimate with a 95% confidence interval. The confidence interval shows the uncertainty of the mean value found from the survey when extended to the statistical population with a chosen probability.

In the following analysis, we grouped the agencies into the following categories as background characteristics (see Fig 26): police, SIB, Centre of Women's Support Services, local government, prosecutor's office, and others. Other includes all those responses left over from the five main agencies.

Figure 26. Distribution of core group members according to aggregated distribution of agencies represented in MARAC (% of core group members)



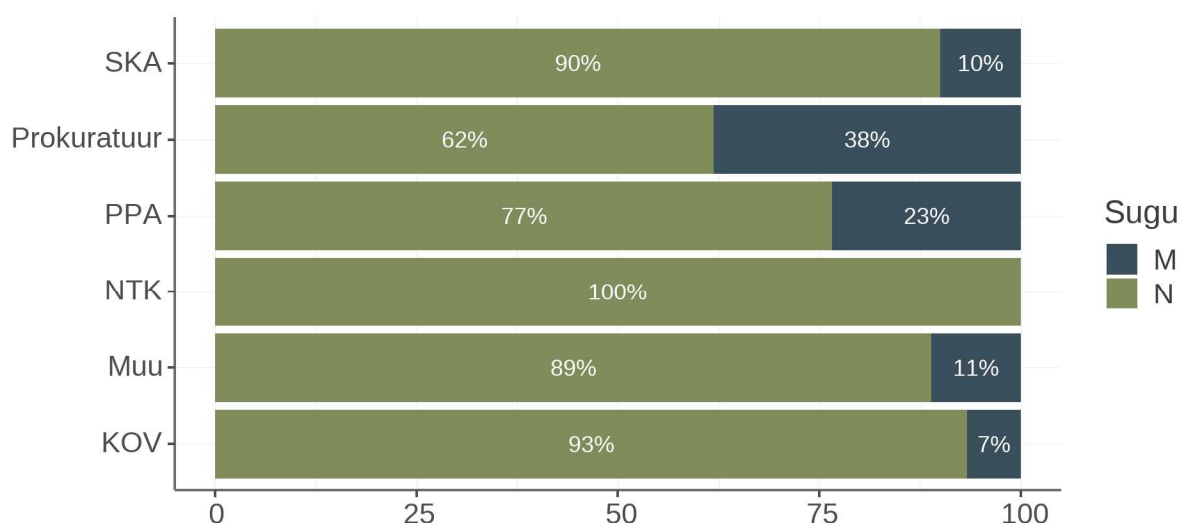
Source: Survey of MARAC core group members, author's calculations.

The total number of core group members is 153. Since several people belong to different core groups at the same time, the number of people active in MARAC networks is less than the number of members. The core groups include 137 people, including 13 people who belong to more than one core group. Of the people operating in several MARAC core groups, most belong to two core groups, but three belong to core groups in three different regions. Of the people operating in several core groups at the same time, five belong to the Tartu and Tartu County core groups at the same time, and the rest operate in the core groups of different regions. According to agencies, the list of MARAC members in several regions includes:

- 5 of the people working at SIB,
- 3 of the representatives of the prosecutor's office,
- 3 of the representatives of WSG and
- 2 of the representatives of PBGB.

82.5% of MARAC core group members are women, and 17.5% are men. The gender balance differs between agencies (see Fig 27). The proportion of men is higher among the members of the prosecutor's office, and there are no men among the representatives of women's support centres.

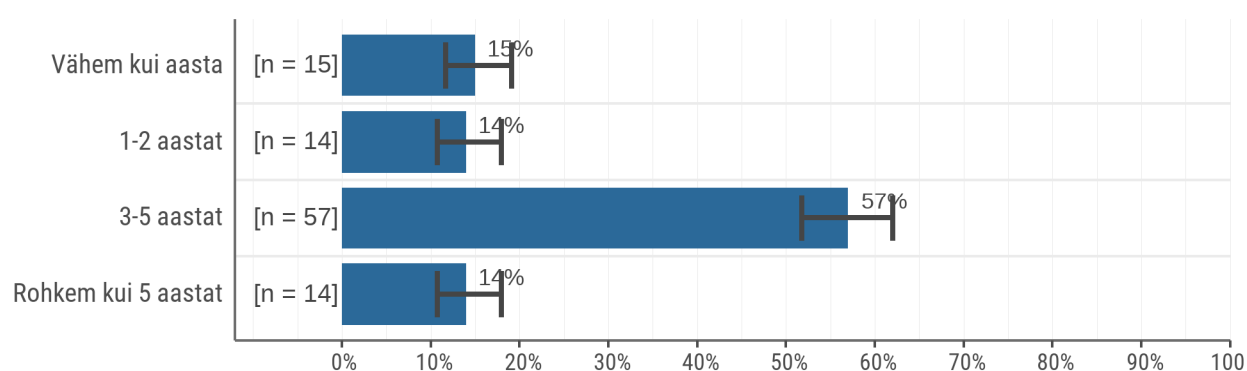
Figure 27. Gender distribution of core group members by agency



Source: List of members of MARAC core groups of SIB, author's adaptations and calculations.

MARAC core group members have, on average, quite a lot of experience in MARAC work (see Fig 28). The largest part (nearly 70%) has participated in MARAC for three years or more. Some labor turnover among agency staff is natural, and it also leads to changes in officers at MARAC. At MARAC, nearly 15% have short-term experience, i.e., less than one year. Long-term work at MARAC means that a person has developed an understanding of MARAC's operating principles and practices. If people who have been active in MARAC for a long time have experience since the launch of MARAC and a comparison with the period before using MARAC, the evaluations of members who have been active in MARAC for a shorter time indicate how new members of the MARAC network can be involved on an ongoing basis.

Figure 28. Distribution of core group members by years of activity in MARAC (% of core group members)

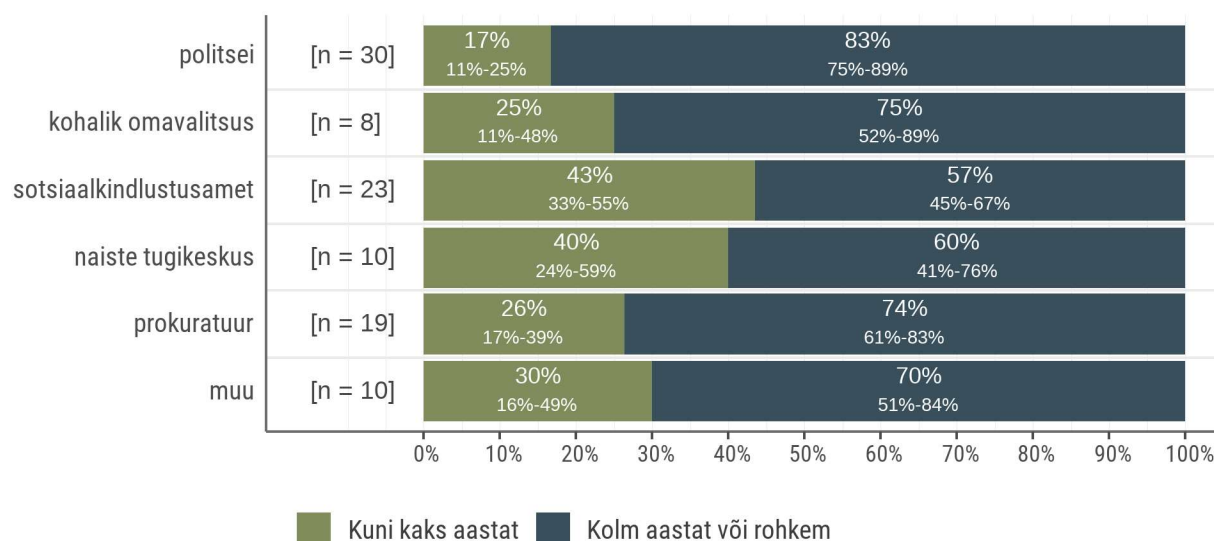


Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

The permanence of MARAC membership varies from agency to agency. Among MARAC members, there are more people with longer experience from PBGB than from SIB. From

other agencies, there are people with both shorter and longer experience in MARAC, but the number of respondents is too small to estimate the average time of operation in these agencies (see confidence limits of estimates). Differences in the distribution of years of activity in MARAC probably reflect the turnover of the agency's workforce, and the connection with MARAC cannot be directly drawn. Since new people regularly join MARAC, it is necessary to take into account that it takes time for them to familiarize themselves with MARAC, the process, and the core group, and solutions should be created for new members to speed up the introduction.

Figure 29. Distribution of members of the core group by years of operation



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

2.3 MARAC work organization

2.3.1 Roles of core group members

The MARAC network acts as a platform for sharing information and coordinating measures to ensure the safety of the victim of DV. Core group members represent their agency in the network within the framework of the support and resources it offers. In essence, MARAC is a cross-institutional work organization measure for faster and more effective channeling of aid to victims and coordination of measures between agencies. The operational framework set by MARAC entails the regular convening of meetings.

MARAC's activities are coordinated by an SIB Victim Support worker; according to the list of core group members provided by the client at the time of the survey, there was one coordinator in almost all core groups. According to the list, there was one core group with no coordinator and one with two coordinators. However, some core groups have several members from SIB (see Table 1), but the others are, in this case, either from the child welfare department or with some other additional function. According to the MARAC guidelines, in addition to the MARAC coordinator, there are two other defined roles in the meetings:

Chairperson and secretary of the MARAC meeting. Both roles are primarily confined to meetings, while the role of the MARAC coordinator is broader and includes tasks outside of meetings.

Among the core group members of MARAC, the roles of coordinator, chair of the meeting, and secretary are shared (see Table 2). According to the agencies, these roles are mainly carried out by SIB and PBGB representatives:

- The role of MARAC coordinator is held only by SIB representatives. In one core group of the MARAC region, there is no MARAC coordinator on the list (Võru), and in one, there are two (Eastern Harju County) who can replace each other if necessary.
- The role of chairpersons of MARAC meetings is held by PBGB representatives, and in the two largest core groups (Harju County), more than one person is assigned to perform this role.
- From the list of core group members, it is the representative of the PBGB who is most often assigned the position of MARAC secretary, but in several cases, this position is also assigned to the representative of the SIB, and there are some regions where the representative of the LG or the prosecutor's office has been assigned the task of the secretary.

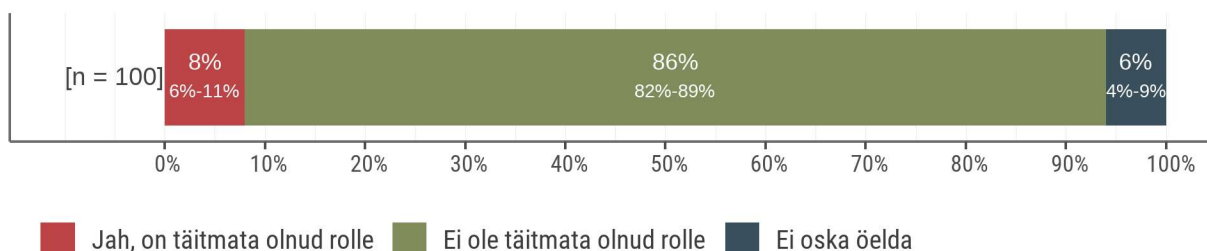
Table2. Number of members in MARAC roles by agency

Role	Agencies				Total
	Local governments	PBGB	Prosecutor's office	Social Insurance Board	
Head of MARAC		21			21
MARAC Coordinator				18	18
Secretary	1	12	1	2	16
Total	1	33	1	20	55

Source: List of members of MARAC core groups of SIB, author's adaptations and calculations.

Based on the survey, mandatory roles at MARAC meetings are usually fulfilled (see Fig 30). A few MARAC members from Eastern and Western Harju County, Tartu, Jõhvi, Narva, and Viljandi pointed out some situations where one or the other role was not fulfilled at the meeting. However, there was no core group where all core group members would have jointly responded that some mandatory role of the meeting was not fulfilled. Thus, it is rather a matter of random and isolated situations, and there is no systematic problem with the fulfillment of mandatory roles in meetings.

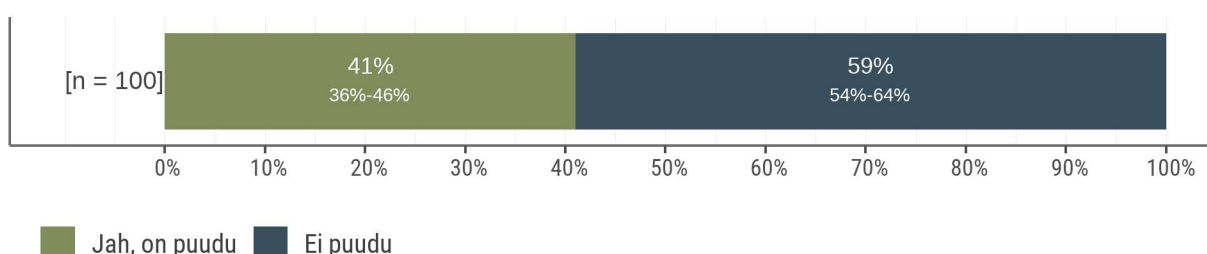
Figure 30. Distribution of members of the core groups according to who thinks that during the last 12 months of the MARAC of the region, some mandatory role (chairperson, coordinator, secretary) has not been fulfilled in the meetings (% of members of the core groups)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Unlike the fulfilment of obligatory roles, which poses no issue, nearly half of MARAC members believe that there is a deficiency in specialised personnel within MARAC, hindering the provision of optimal assistance to victims. (see Figure 31). People from the fields of health, law, and child protection were highlighted as lacking specialists, but the unemployment fund and SIB were also named as external observers who would help bring in new perspectives.

Figure 31. Distribution of members of the core groups, according to those who think that there is a necessary specialist missing in MARAC in the region and those who do not think so (% of members of the core groups)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

78% of those pointing out the lack of specialists specified that there was a lack of professionals from the health care sector (family physicians, mental health nurses, psychiatrists, and psychologists, but they also mentioned the lack of social workers in county hospitals).

Some of the respondents felt that a specialist from the health field should be included in MARAC on a case-by-case basis rather than as a member. In some core groups, representatives from the healthcare sector are also involved on a case-by-case basis. The scarcity of health specialists in the particular region or in Estonia overall was identified as a notable hindrance to engaging these professionals. Consequently, it becomes challenging to find individuals willing to participate in MARAC. In the list of MARAC members, there was a

representative from the local hospital in the core groups of Pärnu, Võru, and Viljandi. Although the list of members of the core groups of Võru and Viljandi includes a representative from the healthcare sector, at least one member noted the additional need for a psychiatrist or psychologist in these core groups as well.

The additional need for a specialist in the field of health was also highlighted in the interviews, where this need was justified in several ways. On the one hand, the core group members' lack of knowledge in the field of health was felt. Since the members do not know how to assess and refer victims to health services, the possibilities for comprehensive support to the victim remain limited.

"The one I miss is a psychologist; there is none, and it is nowhere to be found. ... He would see many hidden things that we might not see. We self-proclaimed psychologists somehow try to see, right? But if there was a real psychologist in the group, it would definitely be even better from the victim's point of view. But, yes, there is a problem with psychologists all over Estonia anyway, and we don't have such opportunities."

—(Prosecutor)

Conversely, there is a requirement for input from medical or psychological service providers to assist the victim in comprehending the situation and devising more effective plans for subsequent measures.

"...when a person goes to a psychologist, the psychologist does not reveal what they talked about, which is understandable. But this information would be useful for us; without this knowledge, it would be difficult for us to help this person. Maybe if they participated, because they don't have to reveal what the conversation was about, but just the part that should be thought through."

—(local government official)

At the same time, it was pointed out in the interviews that the services in the field of health are not services that bring the immediate out of danger in the sense of MARAC. This creates confusion regarding the role a health specialist would play in the core group's activities. In this case, the task of the health specialist would only be to support the rest of the core group members with information. Nevertheless, as the involvement of an excessive number of specialists in a single case is perceived as a challenge within core group operations, it is unclear whether a health specialist should be included as a core group member.

"... the question is what their intervention possibilities are. When we think about it, yes, they are there in the core group; they share, and they are more like information sharers. So that they are also in the same information field, and we get this information. In this view, it is like good, it is important. But right now, I can't exactly point out what the specific activities are, which maybe can be obtained through health care, a family doctor, and all. Certain activities can be planned, but I don't know. Psychologists, let's say, such a restorative activity, so to speak. But if there is an active situation, you need to offer help immediately. In that sense, it's like..."

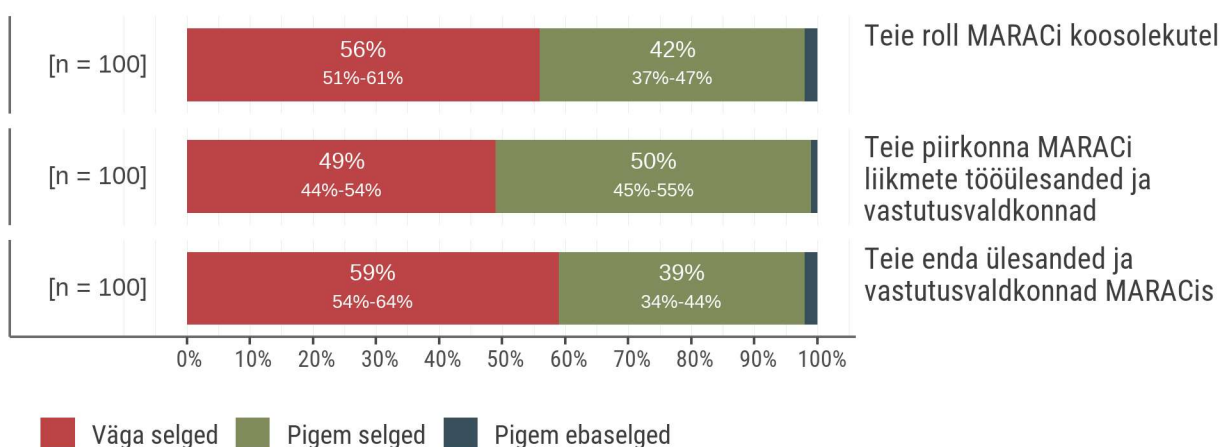
—(Official of the SIB)

Apart from specialists in the field of health, in the core group survey, some pointed out the need to involve specialists in the field of law. Among them, the need for a lawyer, a judge, including a civil judge, or a probation officer was mentioned. Among the members of the Paide and Võru core groups, there is already a probation officer, and in the Pärnu core group, there is an expert from the Institute of Forensic Science Institute (see Table 1). The core group members' interviews did not indicate the need for such an additional member. One of the victims noted the additional need for legal services that would help the victim carry out the legal actions started in the active phase of MARAC until its completion. As MARAC assists the victim in navigating immediate danger and may initiate discussions regarding child custody and access rights, the responsibility falls on the victim to pursue such legal actions following the closure of the MARAC case. According to one interviewed victim, they may not have enough knowledge and skills to do so, and therefore, they saw the need for the so-called continued legal support by MARAC.

In addition, individual respondents pointed out the need for the inclusion of a representative of the unemployment fund (currently present in the core group of Võru), a representative of all local governments, a representative of child protection, and an external observer from SIB as additional necessary specialists.

MARAC core group members feel that their own role, both in the meetings and in MARAC in general, is clear (see Figure 32). Individual members of the core groups (less than 5%) rated the role as unclear. Thus, in general, tasks, responsibilities, and everyone's role are relatively well established in MARAC.

Figure 32. Distribution of core group members according to how clear the role is in MARAC meetings, distribution of tasks and responsibilities in MARAC in general, and the members themselves (% of core group members)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

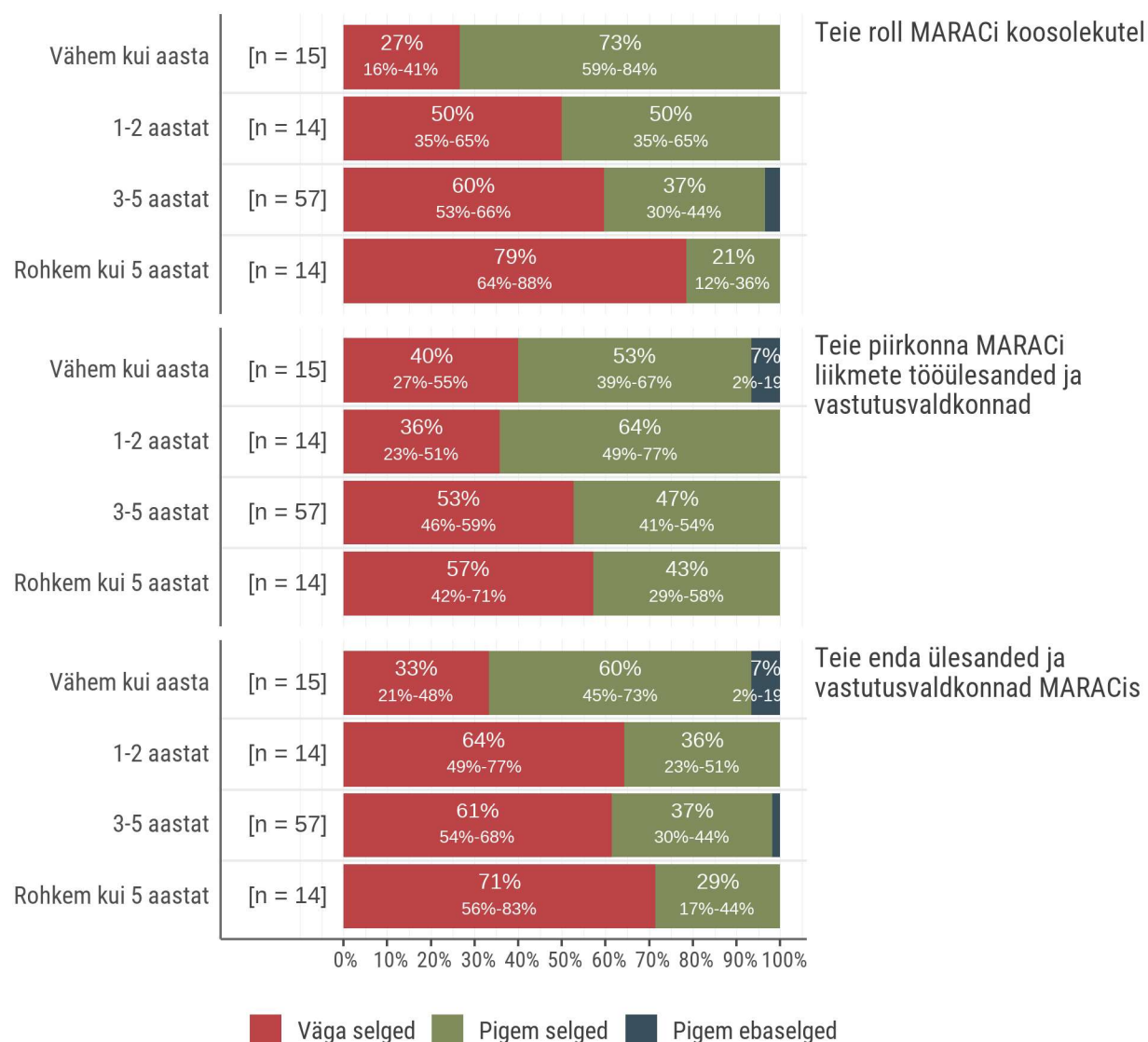
It appears that individuals who have been involved in MARAC for an extended period and have dealt with numerous cases tend to have a clearer understanding of both their individual roles and the allocation of tasks and responsibilities within MARAC as a whole. (see Figure 33). The core group interviews revealed that it can be difficult for a very novice person from

outside the field to understand how MARAC works, what role someone plays in MARAC, and what the person's own role is. The understanding of the roles of the parties will fall into place, and the distribution of tasks and responsibilities will become clear during the work, but new members need additional help to facilitate the onboarding. Understanding MARAC's work organization and processes, as well as the topic of domestic violence, are key prerequisites for participating in the MARAC network (London et al., 2021; Steel et al., 2011)

"As a new person, I was given an introduction tour, of course. But now, the thing is that through each meeting, I have continuously received new information for myself. I think in the first two or three meetings, I had nothing to say, I couldn't say anything, or well, I didn't know where my place was. Now I already understand more, I know how to prepare myself better, and [name of SIB Victim Support worker] communication has become closer. But with other parties again, the thing is that I have no contact with them outside of MARAC. I don't know them..."

—(Member of the core group that has been active for less than a year)

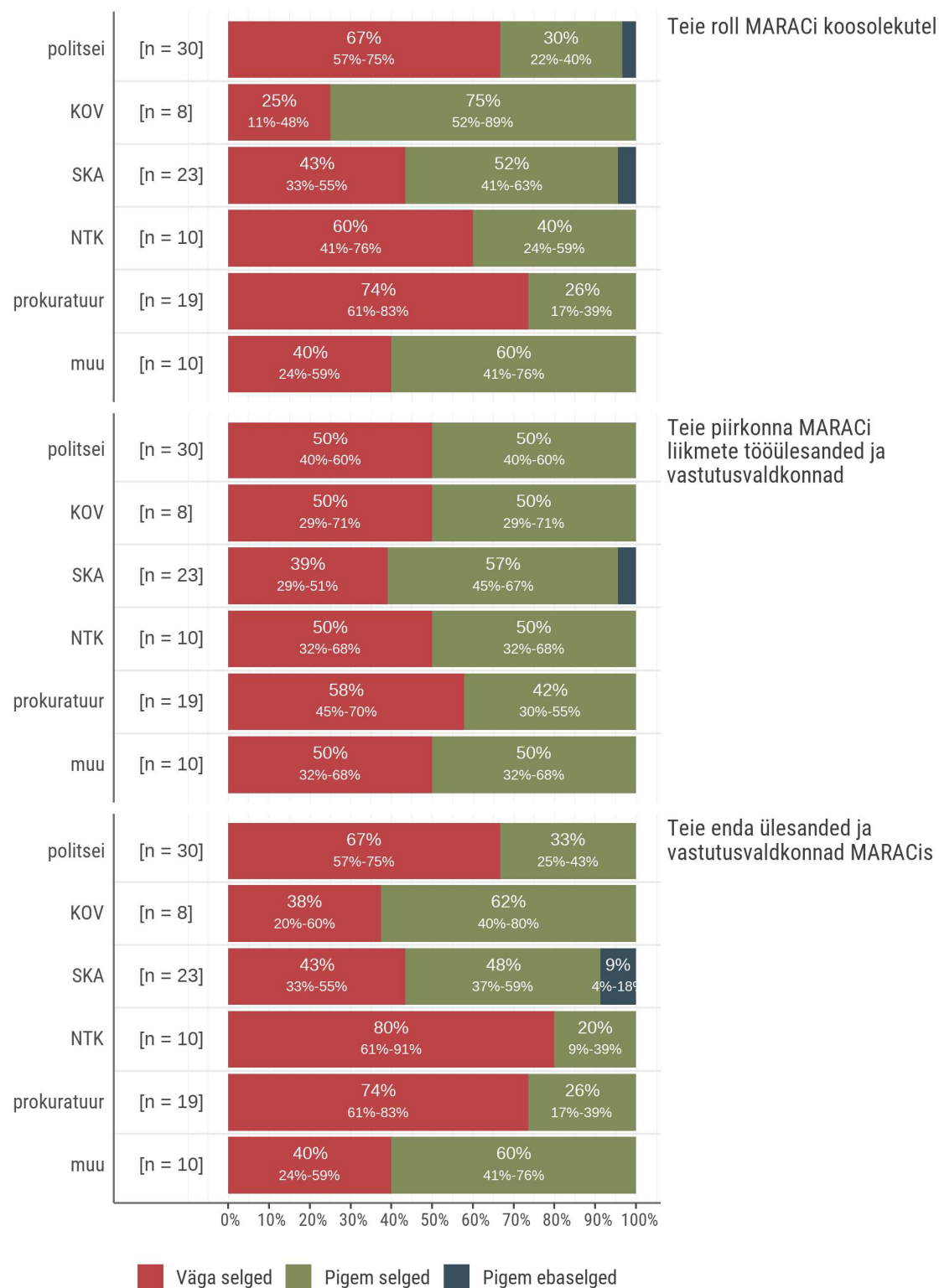
Figure 33. Role clarity in the core group members by length of time in MARAC (% of core group members with corresponding length of time)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Core members' assessments of role clarity differ slightly between agencies (see Fig 34). The role of some individual PBGB and SIB officials is rather unclear. Among the representatives of local governments and other agencies, there is a slightly smaller proportion of those who say that their own role at MARAC meetings is very clear to them, and a larger proportion say that it is rather clear. However, in general, role clarity is highly valued in all agencies. Because of the wide confidence intervals in the estimates, it is not feasible to make quantitative conclusions regarding which agencies have better or worse role clarity among their representatives.

Figure 34. Role clarity in MARAC by agency (% of core group members of the respective agency)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Regarding the clarity of MARAC's roles, the following trends emerged, the content of which we will discuss below in the same order:

1. Ambiguity in roles is greater for local government officials and officials of other agencies in relation to the role of local governments compared to other agencies.
2. The content of the role of the head of MARAC has become chairing of meetings, and it is not clear why this role should be carried out by PBGB instead of SIB, which coordinates all activities of MARAC.
3. There have been situations of role conflict, where the conflict is between the role of a representative of the agency at the MARAC meeting and the role of a representative of the victim or a direct provider of services to the victim.
4. Since all agencies are in the role of helping the victim in MARAC, and communication with the victim is not always coordinated between different agencies, confusion arises as to who the victim's contact in MARAC is in a particular case.
5. The meetings involve a substantial number of core group members, and it is uncertain whether all these agencies are necessary for every meeting and in what capacity.

Both the interviews and the comments of the free-form answers to the survey reveal that, in terms of agencies, the representatives of local governments themselves are the most dissatisfied with the clarity of MARAC's role (or role performance), and representatives of other agencies also have the greatest dissatisfaction with local governments. Some representatives of local governments feel that unrealistic expectations are placed on them at MARAC meetings.

"The purpose of the round table meeting cannot be to interrogate the local government and assign tasks to the local government."

—(local government official) (feedback survey of SIB data used by SIB)

"Their [role] is kind of to think along. And maybe sometimes to explain why, if the expectations of MARAC members for children's specialists are a bit beyond their power, then an explanation would be needed."

—(local government official)

Simultaneously, numerous representatives from other agencies express criticism towards local governments within the core groups, alleging that the representatives are uncooperative and neglect their responsibilities.

"...actually, there is no desire to do it at the local government level. They say it's none of our business, or it shines through that look at what the victim is like, they don't cooperate. The local government should have many more opportunities on the basis of services, how to help and support, connect people with various social services."

—(representative of the WSC)

"...the smaller, the more peripheral the local government is, the more difficult it is to handle things with them."

—(Prosecutor)

In a situation where it is felt that local governments are not fulfilling their tasks, others get the feeling that they are, among other things, fulfilling the tasks of local governments.

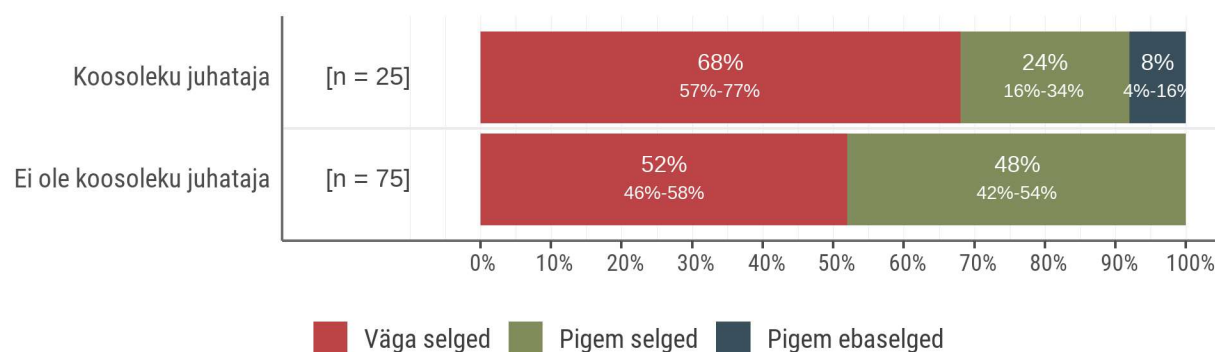
"Sometimes we just take on some tasks. We had one such case where the local government did not see any problems... We took on the task with the regional police officer and got it done."

—(Representative of the SIB)

Despite the accusations directed at local governments, quite a few core group members stated in the survey that MARAC improved the exchange of information and the coordination of work with the local governments. Also, many local governments are satisfied with MARAC and domestic violence roundtables (see feedback survey of local governments on SIB services, data held by SIB). In summary, there are MARAC core groups where there are problems with the role of local governments, and the roots of the problem can be both in the fact that other parties do not understand the capabilities and services of local governments and in the limited understanding or limited opportunities of local government officials to provide adequate support to victims. Since the problem was pointed out both by representatives of local governments and representatives of other agencies in MARAC, it is necessary to pay attention to it because an important basis for the operation of MARAC is trust between the members of the network and lack thereof can prevent the quick coordination of services for the victim (Kerti, 2017).

In terms of the roles assigned during MARAC meetings, there is ambiguity associated with the role of the meeting chairperson. Although the majority of those in the role of the chairperson of the meeting rated role clarity in meetings highly, there were also some who rated the role as unclear (see Figure 35).

Figure 35. Distribution of core group members according to their role clarity at MARAC meetings - by the role of the chairperson of the meeting (% of core group members in the respective role)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Since the substantive coordination of MARAC is the responsibility of the SIB and the role of the chairperson of MARAC is only technical chairing of the meeting, it is not always

understandable why the role of the chairperson of the meeting is held by the PBGB. One person acting as the chair of the meeting described the confusion as follows:

"I guess the way I see it, I think that the meeting could be chaired by a Victim Support worker. I'm not saying I have anything against it, and it doesn't hurt me, make my life harder, or increase my workload significantly. But just maybe, initially, when I came in, it was difficult for me to understand these roles. The money comes from the Social Insurance Board, and the minutes go to the Social Insurance Board through Victim Support ... Today, I'm probably used to it, and it doesn't cause me any hard feelings, but at first, it was just difficult for me to understand."

—(an official of the PBGB)

In order for everyone to understand why the role of chairperson of the meeting is assigned to the PBGB, it could be more clearly formulated in the MARAC guidance material and also explained to the MARAC members. While the instructional material of MARAC does not explicitly designate a police officer as the chairperson of the meetings and emphasises that the role can be rotated, in Estonia, it is typically the police who assume this role. This is also confirmed by the list of MARAC core group members (see Table 1).

In addition to the aforementioned observations about MARAC's tasks and division of responsibilities, the interviews revealed that there have been situations where a MARAC member has assumed dual roles: a representative of the agency in the MARAC network and a direct provider of services to the victim or a representative of the victim in some context. According to MARAC's guidance material, meetings do not usually require a case specialist to attend, as the MARAC core group does not require such detailed information about the case. It is more important that the meeting be attended by a person who has the authority to share their agency's resources to solve the case. However, it can be seen from the interviews that in a certain case, when the representative of the agency is also a direct service provider to the person, it may be difficult for them to put themselves into another role. For example, there has been a situation where the prosecutor has to obtain as much information as possible from the victim for the criminal proceedings, and for this, it is necessary to ask the victim clarifying questions; on the other hand, the prosecutor has to consider the victim's trauma and create a safe atmosphere for the victim at the MARAC meeting. Also, one victim's interview revealed a situation where a person with whom the victim had had a negative contact before MARAC when the officer was in the role of providing support to the victim attended the MARAC meeting.

"In our case, there is a representative of the prosecutor's office, and we only have one prosecutor here on site. In certain cases, perhaps this creates such a conflict of interest or so. If the person for whom the prosecutor has to stand in court and support her... there will be some kind of controversy. Maybe not even in a legal sense, but in a kind of an emotional level. Maybe this is something that needs to be thought about."

—(an official of the PBGB)

At the same time, due to the small size of Estonia and the distribution of MARAC regions, it is not possible to find replacement members for the representatives of all agencies. As a counterbalance to the role conflict established in this way, on the other hand, it was felt that

there is a need to involve people dealing with specific cases on a case-by-case basis in MARAC in order to ensure sufficient flow of information between all parties.

"... I would also like it if, for example, the investigator who specifically investigates participates himself in MARAC and gives an overview."

—(Prosecutor)

Although the role clarity of MARAC core group members was generally rated relatively high by all MARAC members and representatives of all agencies offer support to the victim within the competence and services of their own agency, there is (partly) duplication of services and overlap of roles from the victim's point of view. The task of all parties is to help the victim already before MARAC, including within the main activities of the agency. In the interviews, it was pointed out that this large number of people and agencies that help the victim causes confusion in terms of who should specifically be the provider of support and the contact for the victim on a certain topic.

"What we often come across is that maybe four or five people deal with one person, one case, a case of a person in need of help. Various specialists. And sometimes, I have the feeling that if we add MARAC to it, it will actually cause a huge confusion in a person. So, who organizes what, or who do I need to contact? If MARAC is the only place they finally end up, then that's great; that's where we can start. But in the case of those people who have already been handled by different people, different networks, then at some point, the confusion arises as in what are we trying to achieve here today."

—(an official of the PBGB)

"That maybe even I myself, like ... I don't know, I would maybe try to create a little more clarity in terms of their role, that sometimes it seems to me that the Victim Support worker has too much, well, they have different topics and that they can't or shouldn't to be in the role of a psychological counsellor or supporter. But if the victim has a psychologist or the victim has a support person, right, in addition to all the other agencies that are also dealing with the victim. That sometimes it is really not clear to me why am I here, right..."

—(a volunteer)

The blurring of roles from the victim's point of view is thus related to MARAC's position among other measures of DV, the assistance of people, and the overlapping of services.

It was pointed out in the survey and interviews that additional specialists would be needed in the MARAC core groups, but at the same time, it was pointed out in several interviews that the number of people participating in MARAC meetings is too large.

"But I'm saying that my question is, are all the people that are there at the table, I don't know how many of them there are, eight, nine, ten? Do the people who aren't involved all have to be there? Well, I don't; I don't know if a person is not in a shelter, and it is not even assumed that they go to a shelter. Does the WSC manager have to be there? Do two people from SIB have to be there? For example, well, there is

probably one right now, but before that, there used to be two. I think it has grown very big."

—(local government official)

A large number of people is problematic for several reasons. On the one hand, it is an excessive load on the resource; it would surely be possible to reach the same result with a smaller number of people. On the other hand, more people learn about a person's case, i.e., sensitive data, than is necessary. It was also noted that it is difficult for the victim to participate in meetings, explain, and re-introduce their situation in front of such a large group of people because it is scary.

"...there are actually so many people. So for the victim, it is a bit scary to be there, and they don't know who they all are, what they have to do with their case in the first place."

—(representative of the WSC)

In summary, the members of the core group value the clarity of their own role in the meetings and in MARAC in general, and the role clarity of all parties quite highly. However, there are several aspects where there is room for improvement in the clarity of roles, tasks, and responsibilities:

- Better clarification of the role and opportunities of local governments;
- An illustrative description of the functioning of MARAC and the roles of the parties for people who have just joined MARAC;
- creation of clear instructions for the role conflict of representing the agency and representing the victim;
- more precisely, defining and agreeing on the division of work of those who provide support to the victim;
- Reducing the number of core group members at MARAC meetings to the minimum necessary while involving relevant case-specific specialists;
- case-by-case development of a system and guidelines for the inclusion of specialists from the healthcare sector in a MARAC core group;
- Clarification of the basic principles for the selection of chairpersons for MARAC meetings.

2.3.2 MARAC risk assessment and referral to MARAC

MARAC is designed to prevent the consequences of high-risk incidents of violence, and high risk is defined in the MARAC guidelines as follows: "A high level of risk refers to the danger that killing or murder, attempted killing or murder, violence committed using dangerous objects, violence causing severe health damage requiring urgent medical attention, repeated violence causing health damage, severe and continuous coercion and control, rape, stalking, deprivation of liberty, enslavement and torture may take place." The guidelines note that victims cannot be grouped by risk, as risk may change, increase, or decrease. Assessing the magnitude of the risk and deciding what risk is sufficient to direct MARAC and what is not is a difficult task. In essence, any violence can be considered high risk.

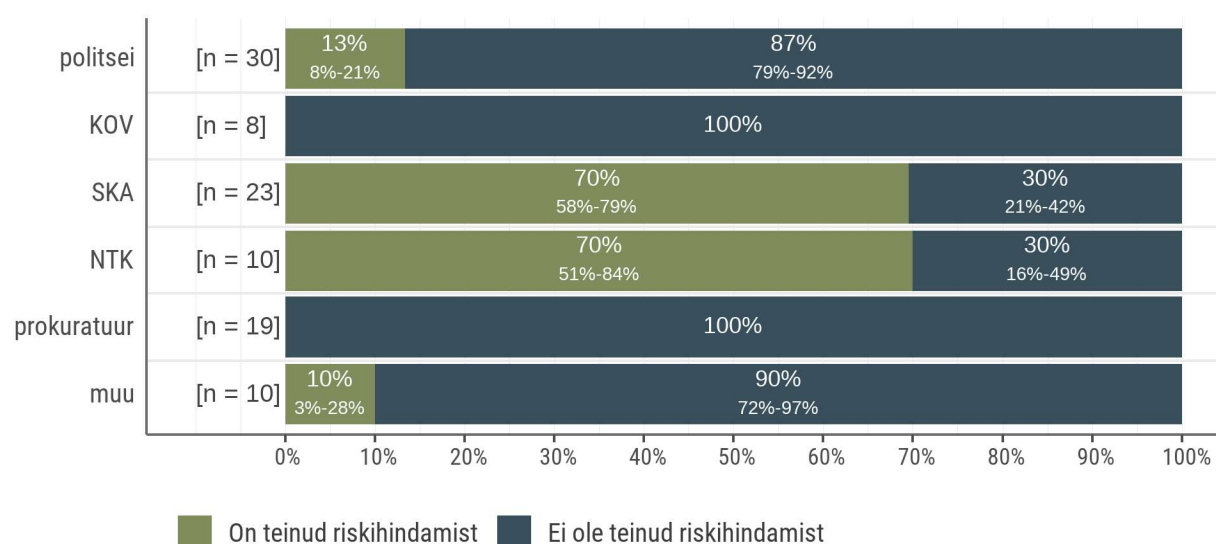
"Well, for me, violence as such is always high risk. Doesn't it basically come from the legislation? If in the Republic of Estonia, according to the Penal Code, any violence starting with the feeling of pain is punishable as a criminal offense, then according to my logic violence without any DASH risk assessment should actually be eligible for MARAC."

—(Prosecutor)

In order to delineate MARAC's activities and provide a more objective basis for risk, the DASH risk assessment methodology is used. Before referral to MARAC, the victim is assessed for risk based on the DASH questionnaire.

Although risk assessments can be carried out by representatives of various agencies, the practice has developed in such a way that risk assessments are mainly carried out by WSC Victim Support staff and WSC representatives. Several members of the core group of other agencies, when the need for a risk assessment arises, refer it to the SIB. Among the local government representatives interviewed, there were none who had carried out risk assessments. Among the representatives of the police and other agencies, only a few of the respondents have made risk assessments (see Figure 36).

Figure 36. Distribution of core group members according to whether they have carried out a risk assessment and referred a victim of domestic violence to MARAC in the last 12 months



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

The police are seen as the most logical place to implement DASH in cases where the police officer first comes into contact with the victim. And in some places, police officers have also filled out DASH forms.

"We make the most of these DASHes. When a case comes to the table, we cannot say that we have nothing to do or that we push it to someone else's yard because we are

the first channel to whom this matter comes. But, of course, this is a wider problem, not a MARAC problem, that we are the first channel to whom this matter comes."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

Although the police, in some cases, carry out a DASH risk assessment, there are also examples where the assessment is referred to the SIB. Sometimes, police officers feel that the physical environment (e.g., in the victim's home) where they come into contact with the victim is not the most suitable for carrying out DASH risk assessment and, therefore, feel that the role of the police is more to obtain consent from the victim and direct them to contact Victim Support.

"We try to do it in such a way that the police don't do it. In the past, I have done it myself a couple of times, but to be honest, I don't have that one and a half, two hours. If we assume that the follow-up checks are not carried out in the police station, but we go to the apartments, it is a bit unethical and uncomfortable, like when I start asking such unpleasant, difficult questions. I'm not in my own territory, and I find it a bit difficult to do. In this sense, maybe they don't say anything. That's why we try to refer them to Victim Support, and we try to get consent."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

In addition, police officers fill out a risk assessment instrument in their own system, so when filling out the DASH, the police officer performs two separate but partially overlapping assessments.

"Somehow, in the police, this DASH assessment has not gained much momentum because we are still dragging along the issue here that we are doing this risk assessment mitigation page, which is mandatory for every DV case. I think regional police officers perceive that they have to complete this one risk assessment. It's like DASH is no longer our line of work, part of our work. But I see that we have these databases here, where it is written in the solution field that a DASH assessment has been done, but these are extremely isolated cases."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

The results of the survey show that a significantly smaller proportion of police officers than SIB or WSC representatives perform DASH risk assessment (see Figure 36). Therefore, it seems more common for a police officer to refer a potential victim of a MARAC case to the SIB for discussion, adjudication, and risk assessment.

The representatives of the prosecutor's office clearly see that the DASH assessment is within the competence of Victim Support and also direct the assessment there if necessary. At the same time, it was noted that usually, when the matter reaches the prosecutor's office, it is already in MARAC's field of view.

"... sometimes some cases are such that we had very, very serious criminal proceedings where there were victims, and we ourselves turned to Victim Support to say, listen, we have such and such a victim, we need to do DASH. If the Victim Support doesn't have

contacts and they don't know, then we give recommendations, tell them to contact the victim, discuss and evaluate."

—(Prosecutor)

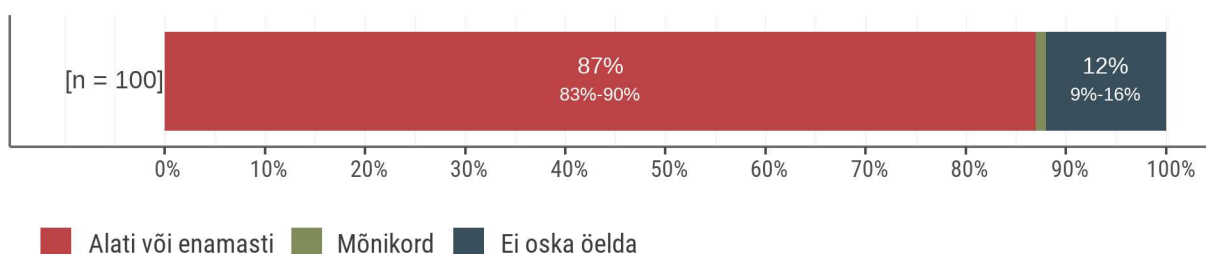
However, the interviewee, who had worked at MARAC for a short time, was not even aware that he could also do risk assessments because there was a system in place in the region, according to which SIB does the risk assessments.

"Currently, the type of victim support we have here is such a dark place at the moment, and I have not even spoken to [SIB VS employee's name]. I have not talked to them. About whether I also have the opportunity to bring a case to the table if I see that something could be suitable."

—(Core member active in MARAC for less than a year)

Before referral to MARAC, the victim is usually subjected to a risk assessment (see Fig 37). Some individual members of MARAC could not judge whether a risk assessment would be carried out or not.

Figure 37. Breakdown of MARAC core group members by how often in the last 12 months a victim has had a risk assessment done at MARAC in their area before being referred to MARAC (% of core group members)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Although risk assessments are routinely performed, the criterion for referring to the MARAC is interpreted more loosely than the baseline 14-point DASH score determined by the guidelines. If the baseline DASH score is above 14, the case was previously referred to MARAC on the condition that the person agrees to have their case heard in MARAC. From April 2023, the new Victim Support Act will allow victims of domestic violence to be supported through MARAC, regardless of the victim's consent.

The DASH risk assessment questionnaire is not independently suitable for assessing the risk of domestic violence in several target groups, as it was developed to assess violence against women of childbearing age by a (former) partner. The DASH is not the most appropriate for assessing other victims, such as victims of violence between adult children and parents, between elderly partners, or against men. Many of the questions on the DASH cause discomfort to both raters and victims in the case of victims from these target groups, and the original DASH score underestimates the severity of such violence because some questions are simply not relevant (e.g., for an elderly victim, asking if the victim is pregnant).

Despite the fact that the DASH questionnaire is not the most suitable instrument for all target groups, the members of the core group believe that an evaluation instrument is needed. The evaluation instrument is a good working tool for the background of decision-making; it provides an objective basis for decision-making and for summarizing an overview of the case. For this reason, but also because risk assessment is currently a mandatory part of MARAC, core members see that the instrument should be adapted to Estonian conditions and target groups.

The practice of filling out the DASH questionnaire depends on the person doing the risk assessment and is sometimes seen as a problem.

"Well, it can be said at this point that the part of making DASH is actually quite subjective anyway. There are those questions, but a lot depends on how you ask them."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

Some interviewers prefer to complete the DASH Risk Assessment Questionnaire without the victim present. They ask the victim for necessary information in advance and fill out the questionnaire themselves.

"The DASH form, after all, we can't fill it in the presence of the victim. I have to gather information, and it's actually completely understandable that I can't get this information all at once. This may require several consultations. I will receive additional information, and then I will be able to complete this DASH once and for all."

—(representative of the WSC)

"... I talk to people about these same topics, in their language that these people understand, as they understand, I explain; then there is also another thing here. You don't have to approach it uniformly, and these are topics that need to be discussed and talked about."

—(local government representative)

However, others consider that the answers to the questionnaire must be clearly asked of the victim and filled in according to their answers.

"We proceed from the way our work methodology currently prescribes ... however, we still have to get the answers to our questionnaire from the person. And they, usually, are district police officers, they say, we understand that this is uncomfortable for you, and now it can get a little uncomfortable, right? But we also have to discuss these issues. ... we try to do it in such a way that we get the answer to the question, and we discuss it a little bit, and then we go on to the next topic block. It is not about the physical form filling. ... we try to do it humanely, after all."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

Thus, there is no uniform practice for filling out the DASH form. At the same time, it must be taken into account that in the case of any kind of risk assessment and filling out questionnaires, apart from the content, the method of carrying out the assessment and filling

out the questionnaire is equally important. The creator of DASH states in the manual (Richards, 2009) that the victim must be asked all the questions in the questionnaire but in a way that takes into account the vulnerable state of the victim. At the same time, it is important that conducting a risk assessment is not just a matter of a "checkbox exercise" but that the victim's situation must be made thoroughly clear. He also points out that DASH risk assessments should be carried out by specialists who have undergone the necessary preparation and training, which also indicates how important a role the method of risk assessment plays.

When cases of violence are referred to MARAC, the DASH form is almost always filled out, but it is not the only basis on which a decision is made to accept a case as a MARAC case. Based on the interviews, it seems to be a common practice that in order to refer a case to MARAC, core group members discuss the severity of the violent case and the added value arising from MARAC, whether the cooperation of several parties is necessary or whether the case can be solved in a smaller circle. If a benefit is seen arising from MARAC, cases with an initial score below the threshold are also included in MARAC. An initial score lower than the threshold may result from the fact that the DASH questionnaire is not suitable for all target groups, but it may also result from the victim's insecurity and the desire to downplay the situation. In the DASH risk assessment, the possibility of escalation and the specialist's assessment is added to the filling of the questionnaire, which is why those cases where the initial score obtained when filling out the DASH questionnaire is lower than the threshold can be included in MARAC because some questions did not apply to the victim's situation. At the same time, several specialists expressed the opinion that their work would be simplified by developing a risk assessment questionnaire or questionnaires suitable for the target group.

There were interviewees who indicated that there had been no victims with an initial score below 14 points in their MARAC core, and the inclusion of such cases in the MARAC has not been discussed. By comparing this information with surveillance data, it can be assumed that such MARAC members are not familiar with all cases, as all regions have included victims with lower baseline DASH scores among MARAC cases. However, there is an increase in the mean DASH baseline score in the 2022 follow-up data, which may indicate that fewer victims with a baseline score below the threshold are admitted to MARAC cases than previously.

In addition to the above, consideration has been given to taking advantage of the process established with MARAC to include lower-risk cases in MARAC in the absence of high-risk cases.

"With the assessment, there are currently no such big cases to take to MARAC, but we just discussed that maybe we will take some such cases that have not received such a high score, that have received lower scores. I would really take them next if they themselves agree to have their cases heard at MARAC. ... If possible, we could also help and contribute and maybe do something, so why not take those cases with a lower score there as well, if there are currently none with a higher score."

—(local government representative)

The format of deliberations and the circle of people that decide to refer a case with an initial score below the DASH threshold to the MARAC meeting for discussion may vary. When a referral to MARAC is discussed, in some cases, a discussion is held between a few core members (usually the referring member who completed the risk assessment form and the SIB Victim Support worker) before the MARAC meeting; other cases are discussed at the MARAC meeting with all core group members participating.

"... whether it would be helpful, it will be discussed together, in advance, not exactly at the MARAC meeting, but at such an extraordinary one, or simply between specialists. Then a joint assessment is given that either we take it, we watch it a few times, right, or we don't. It has been this way, and then again, no, this is not a case of MARAC."

—(representative of the WSC)

"... here we have tried to proceed from the fact that if this risk, or that, that so-called quota does not come together, and there really is no life-threatening, life-threatening risk, we will simply discuss it with the core group. But we don't take it into active work, so to speak. When I've done that risk assessment, the last time I did it, it came in at nine. Yes, and fourteen is the threshold. Then, together in the core group, we discussed what someone's feeling is and what information someone has about it. Maybe someone will get some additional information from there, and maybe there is still a high risk. But we found that it was not, and then we didn't take it."

—(Representative of the SIB)

In both cases, a MARAC case is considered if the joint action of the MARAC network is seen to benefit the resolution of the case.

"... first of all, there is a discussion, we discuss among ourselves why this case should go [to MARAC], whether it is possible to solve it outside of MARAC, so to speak, what are the bottlenecks and why it can't just be solved outside of MARAC. If it really needs the participation of core group members, so to speak, and some other things, then yes, this case will be raised to MARAC."

—(Representative of the SIB)

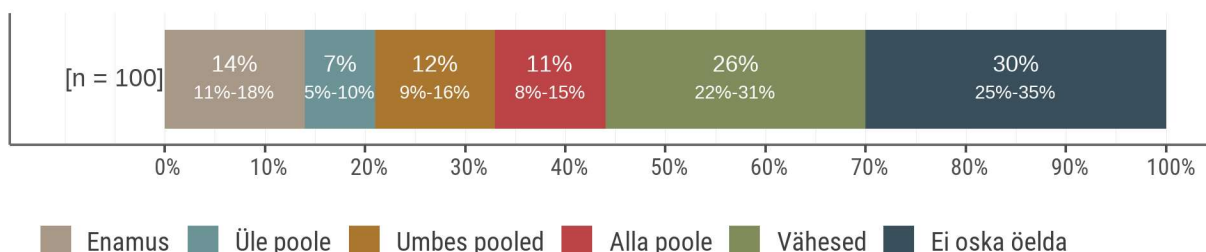
"The DASH assessment actually selects who has this high-risk danger. But if indeed this high risk does not materialize ... we have potential cases immediately on the agenda, and then we have to discuss those potential cases. Quite often, we have come to the conclusion that there is actually no high risk. There is no such danger to life, and there is no danger to children. A case of domestic violence, yes, but it is still not a MARAC case."

—(representative of the WSC)

Since the number of high-risk domestic violence cases and victims is unknown, it is difficult to estimate how many of the victims reach MARAC and how many do not. The members of the core group estimated the rate of the victims ending up in MARAC based on their opinion, and their estimates differ quite a lot (see Figure 38). Almost a third of the core group members could not estimate the proportion of victims who make it to MARAC; a quarter

think that few do, and only a fifth of the core group members believe that more than half of the victims make it to MARAC.

Figure 38. The proportion of core group members by what proportion of high-risk adult* victims of domestic violence they believe will end up in MARAC in their area (% of core group members)



Source: A survey of MARAC core group members.

*Note: MARAC is intended for victims of legal age but also accepts victims under the age of 18 if they are victims of high-risk domestic violence by a partner or ex-partner.'

In the survey, individuals who think that a significant portion of high-risk domestic violence victims are referred to MARAC pointed to the effective efforts of specialists (frequent information exchange, clear explanations, heightened awareness, and a functional referral system) as a contributing factor. People's awareness and bolder interventions were mentioned less.

The main reason why many victims of high-risk domestic violence still do not end up in MARAC, according to the members of the core group interviewed, is that domestic violence continues to be hidden, victims do not tell anyone about it, and even if the victim has come to the attention of professionals, they often do not dare or do not want to accept help. According to some specialists, this problem of not daring/being reluctant to accept help occurs more in smaller places where everyone knows everyone.

Thus, the number of MARAC cases is partially shaped by risk assessment, but even more important than risk assessment is the ability of specialists to help and support victims so that they can find the desire and courage to seek help and change their lives in cooperation with MARAC. The victim's willingness to cooperate with MARAC and to leave the situation of domestic violence can be hindered by the trauma of domestic violence, the effects of which can manifest in many different ways. Robinson and Tregidga (2005) have summarized psychological factors, such as the loss of self-esteem and identity of the victim of domestic violence, self-blame, loss of perception of reality, depression, fear of the perpetrator's revenge, fear for the life and health of loved ones, etc. Economic dependence on the perpetrator is also an important obstacle. Therefore, victims of domestic violence need support and understanding in order to be ready to make changes to get out of the situation of domestic violence.

From the interviews conducted in this study, it is evident that all involved parties make efforts to secure the consent of victims of domestic violence (DV) for referral to MARAC or

for assistance in general. Frequently, victims need persistent persuasion and detailed explanations about the available help and how it can be accessed. Despite these efforts, there are instances where individuals may remain fearful and unwilling to agree. Convincing and guiding the victims to seek help was mentioned by the representatives of all agencies.

"... many people don't want their personal lives to be in the hands of a committee. Incidents of domestic violence are so painful anyway. Now, these people are already broken, and they don't want their case to be discussed by some kind of group again. There are still people who say a categorical no. And nothing can be done there."

—(local government representative)

"... what is the painful point for us is that if the victim does not want to cooperate, right, so to bring them to MARAC and then to see if it is possible with joint forces to somehow, in a good way, pressure the victim to cooperate. But there are all sorts of reasons why the victim does not want to cooperate. After all, there is a limit to how much we can pressurize them."

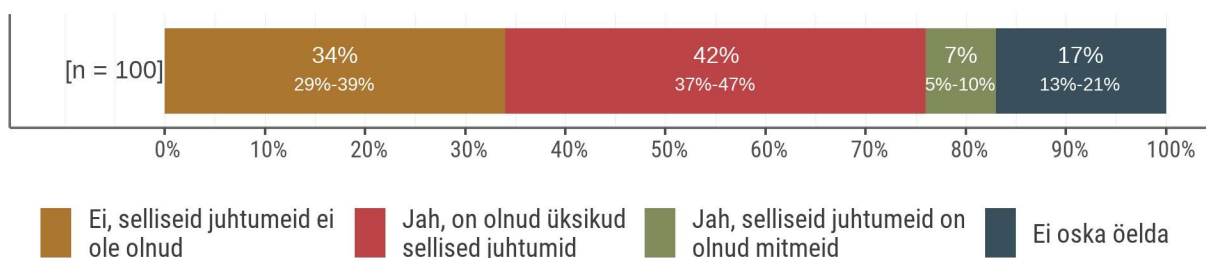
—(Prosecutor)

"We tell them that this information doesn't go anywhere from MARAC, but it does. Once the police come, it will anyway, and we also have police reports in our paper that there are so many cases of domestic violence this weekend and maybe some descriptions, too, without names, of course. But [the name of the place] is a really small place, so here you know where the police car went and maybe who was taken away."

—(local government representative)

The efficient functioning of MARAC prevents the allocation of resources to address cases involving low-risk victims. Approximately half of the core group members believed that there were instances within their MARAC area where they perceived cases as not meeting the criteria for high-risk domestic violence. (see Figure 39).

Figure 39. The proportion of core group members who believe there have been incidents in their area's MARAC that they believe were not a high risk of domestic violence* (% of core group members)



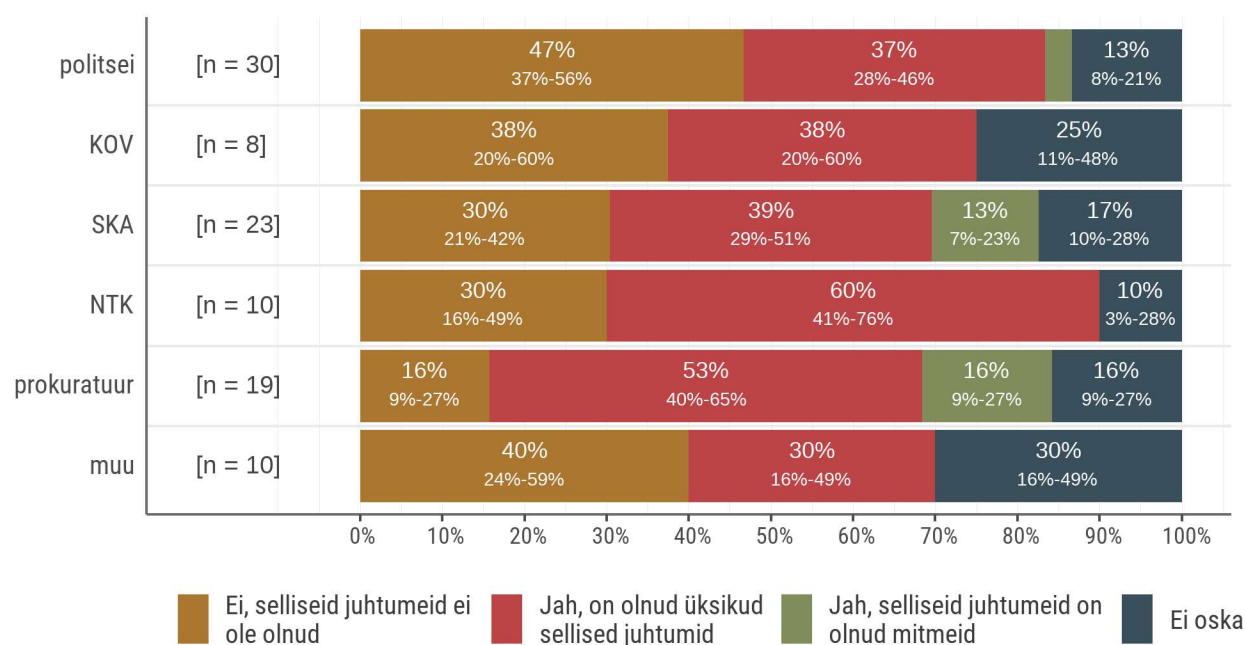
Source: A survey of MARAC core group members.

*Note: the risk threshold was not defined in the survey question; the respondents filled it in according to their own assessment.

The core group members' assessments of whether there have been cases in MARAC that were not cases of a high risk of DV do not depend on the region of the core group or the agency of the specialist. By region, in all core groups (except Valga County), there are some members who found that there have been cases in MARAC that, in their opinion, were not cases of high risk of domestic violence. According to some members of the core groups of Lääne-Viru County, Narva, Pärnu, and Saare County, there have been several such cases.

Among the representatives of all agencies, there are those who believe that there have been cases in MARAC in their area that were not of high risk (see Figure 40). The specialists who believe that there have been many such cases in their area are only among the representatives of the police, SIB, and the prosecutor's office.

Figure 40. The proportion of core group members according to whether they believe there have been cases in MARAC in their area that they did not consider to be at high risk of domestic violence - by the agency (% of core group members of the respective agency)



Source: A survey of MARAC core group members.

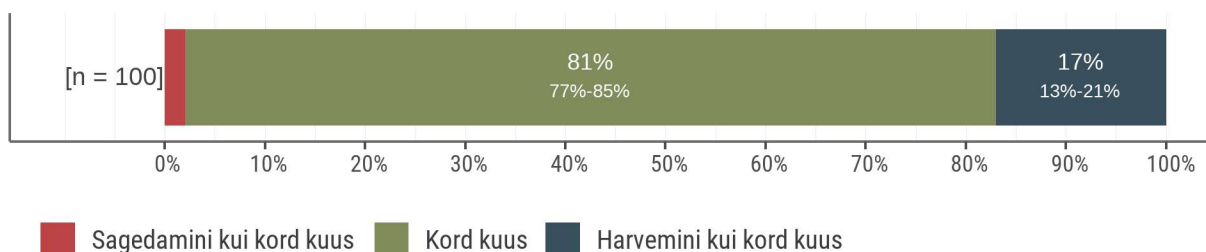
In summary, DASH risk assessment for referring victims to MARAC is standard practice, and risk assessments are mainly carried out by SIB, WSC, and police representatives. The DASH questionnaire is used in practice to assess the risks of a wider range of victims, but the DASH is not suitable for all target groups, and therefore, it is necessary to consider the possibilities of creating new assessment instruments that allow for standardized and objective measurement of risk also among those target groups to whom the DASH does not currently fully apply. Since victims with an initial score lower than the DASH threshold are also admitted to MARAC in Estonia, the increasing benefit from MARAC is considered every time to resolve the situation. The round of discussions and the format for making such decisions varies from region to region. Although the new law on victim support does not require the

consent of the victim to take the victim's case to MARAC, several specialists feel that convincing and guiding victims to seek and receive help is more difficult than risk assessment. Various core group members and agencies contribute to convincing the victim to participate in MARAC.

2.3.3 Frequency and adequacy of MARAC meetings

The central working form of the MARAC network is meetings, which take place at an agreed regularity. Special meetings are arranged when necessary, and regular meetings are occasionally canceled during the summer months or in the absence of cases. The usual frequency of meetings is once a month or once every two months (see Fig 41). Meetings taking place less often than once a month were mentioned in Haapsalu MARAC, but also in Järva County, Lääne-Viru County, Rapla County, Saare County, and Võru County by some respondents.

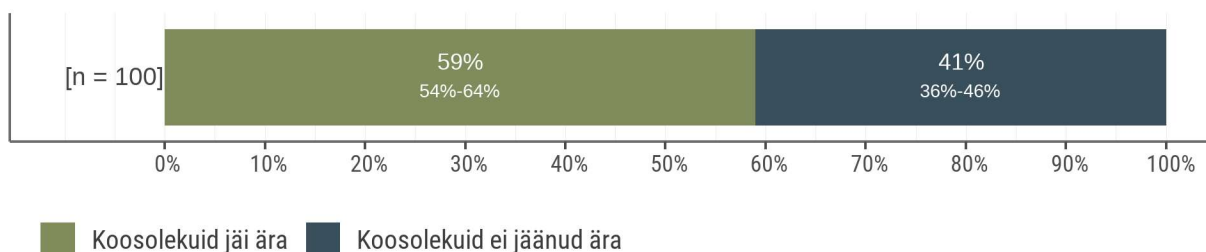
Figure 41. Proportion of core group members by frequency of regional MARAC meetings in the last 12 months (% of core group members)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

It is a common practice to forego a regular MARAC meeting during the summer months or in instances where there are no active cases. (see Figure 42). On average, 60% of respondents indicated that in the summer of 2022, the MARAC meeting was not held in their region for some months.

Figure 42. The proportion of core group members, according to whether they think a MARAC meeting did not take place in the region in the summer of 2022

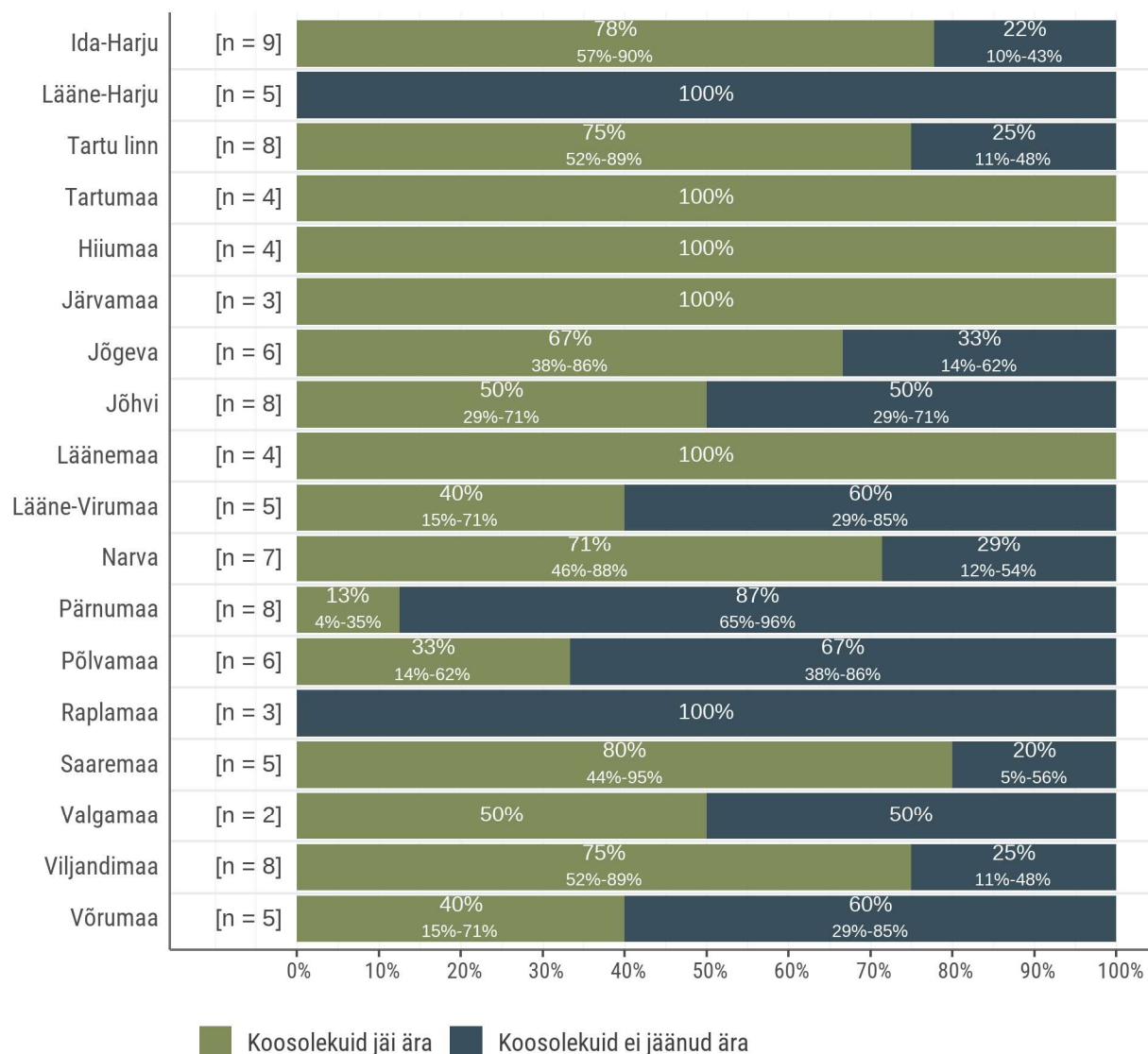


Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Missing meetings in the summer of 2022 for all or at least some MARAC members was common in almost all regions (see Figure 43). Only the members of the core group of Lääne-

Harju municipality and Rapla County did not mention that the meeting was canceled some months in the summer of 2022.

Figure 43. Percentage of core group respondents who, according to their estimation, did not have a MARAC meeting in some months of the previous summer, in their region



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

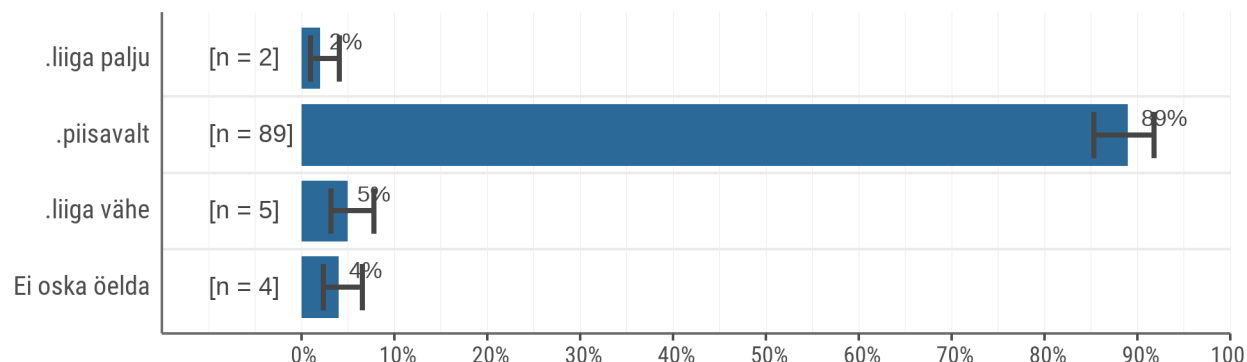
Some MARAC core groups include scheduled break-in meetings during the summer.

"At the moment, we have agreed on a monthly meeting, except for July. Was it August? I have to check, and there was a one-month-long break... If we don't have a case, we have an agreement between us that if we don't have cases and there are no potential cases, we cancel the meeting by joint decision ... If there is even something little to discuss or, for example, a statistical overview, to give kind of half-year reviews or five-month reviews, in any case, even without a case, we will do it."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

Overall, core group members express contentment with the frequency of meetings and believe that the current number of meetings is sufficient (see Figure 44.)

Figure 44. Distribution of core group members by assessment of the adequacy of MARAC meetings in the region (% of core group members)

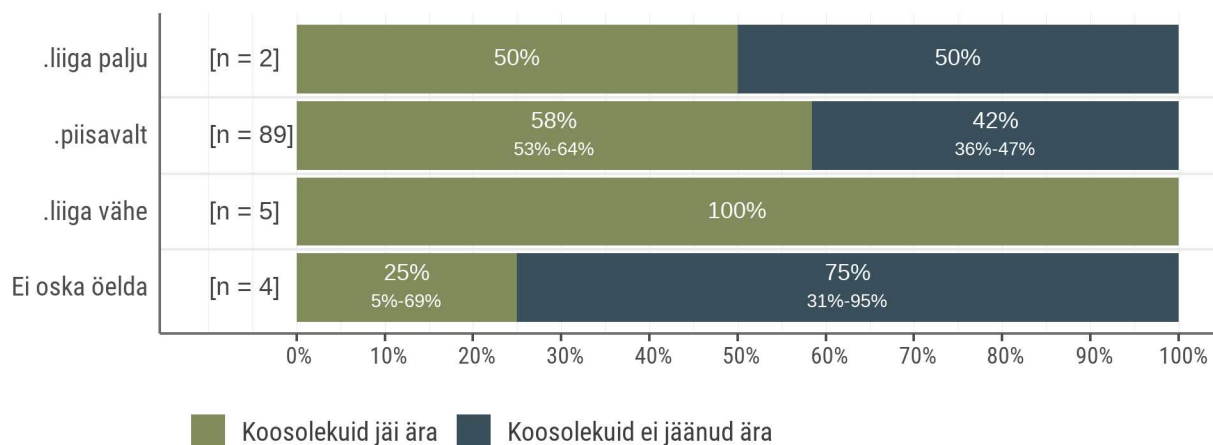


Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Members of the 14 regional core groups collectively felt that the frequency of meetings was sufficient. Some members of the Ida-Harju region, Tartu County, and Hiiu County core groups cited too few meetings, and there are too many meetings, according to some members of the Hiiu County core group and Jõhvi core group. In no core group did all members agree that there were too many or too few meetings. Thus, there are some core groups with members who feel that there could be somewhat more or fewer meetings, but no clear conclusion can be drawn from the regional division. Those suggesting an adjustment in the number of meetings argue that the frequency should be based on the caseload.

All those according to whom there are too few meetings were from core groups where meetings had been canceled (see Figure 45). However, canceling meetings is not uniquely related to people's perception that there are too few meetings. Even in those core groups where meetings have been canceled in the past, there are members who think there are enough or too many meetings.

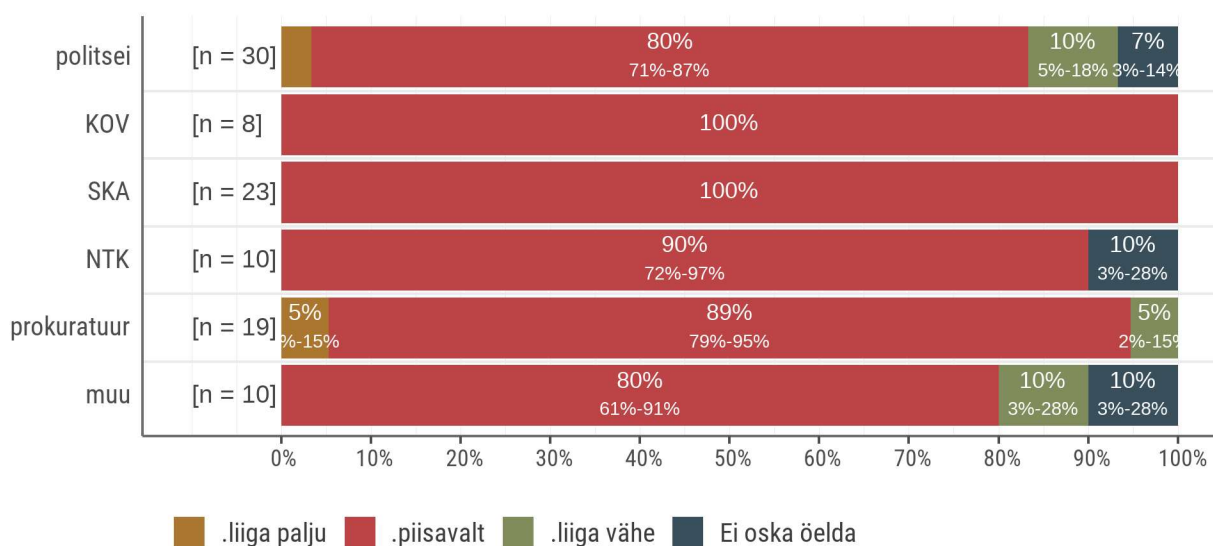
Figure 45. Distribution of MARAC meeting adequacy ratings by whether or not meetings were canceled



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

In terms of agencies, all members of the SIB, local government, and WSC core groups answered that there are enough meetings. Among the members of the core groups of the PBGB and the prosecutor's office, some answered that there are too many meetings, while some also answered that there are too few. Therefore, according to the agencies, there is no clear pattern according to which the number or frequency of meetings would need to be revised.

Figure 46. The proportion of core group members who feel there are too few or too many MARAC meetings in their area - by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

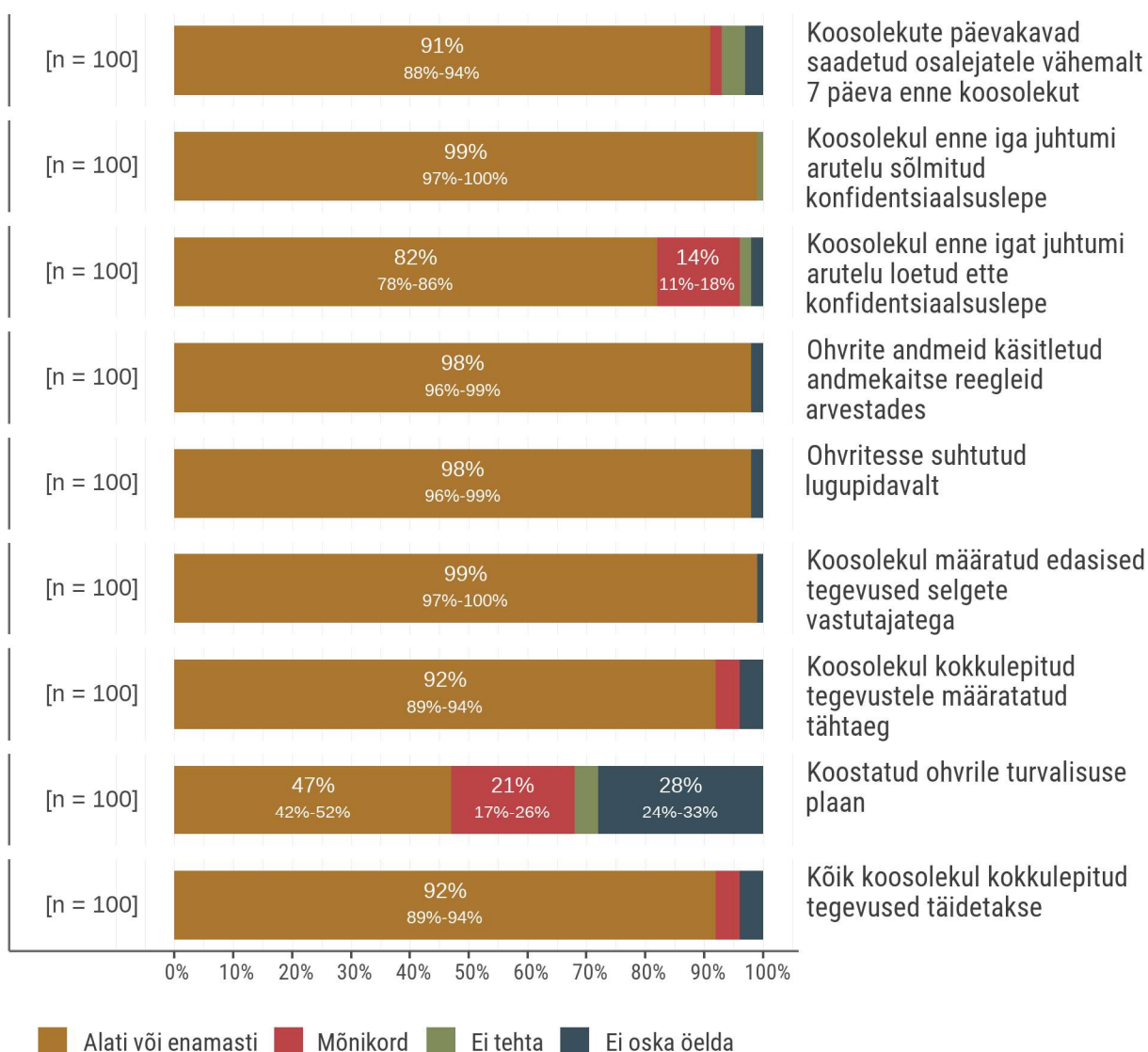
Overall, most members of the core group are satisfied with the frequency and number of meetings, but in some cases, more or fewer meetings are desired. Since we are dealing with individual respondents, it is about some specific cases, which does not provide a basis for reviewing the frequency of meetings.

2.3.4 Mandatory parts of MARAC at the meetings

The MARAC manual outlines some elements that should exist or be performed at every meeting. In the survey, members of the core group rated how often these elements are performed in their core group (see Fig 47):

- Before the meeting and at the beginning of the meetings:
 - Sending agendas of the meetings at least seven days before the meeting.
 - Signing a confidentiality agreement before discussing each case.
 - Reading the confidentiality agreement before discussing each case.
- During meetings:
 - Treatment of victims' data according to data protection rules.
 - Treating victims with respect.
- As a result of the meetings:
 - At the meetings, further actions are determined with clearly assigned responsibilities.
 - A deadline has been set for the activities agreed at the meeting.
 - A security plan has been drawn up for the victim.
 - The security plan is regularly updated.
 - All activities agreed at the meeting are carried out.

Figure 47. In the last 12 months, how often has the MARAC been in your area...? (% of core group members)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

From the activities related to the meetings, based on the survey, it can be seen that the requirement to prepare a security plan is less often fulfilled than other elements, and the confidentiality agreement is not always read out before the discussion of each case. Signing a confidentiality agreement, handling the victims' data, providing assistance to the victims, and determining future activities are points that some of the members of the core groups are unable to express an opinion about, but in practice, they are almost always done.

Of the pre-meeting elements, there are a few situations where the agenda was not sent to the participants seven days before the meeting in accordance with the instructions. Individual core group members have also noted that a confidentiality agreement has not been signed before each case, and there are even more situations where the confidentiality agreement

has not been read aloud. The formality and time consumption of signing and reading the confidentiality agreement each time were brought up in various interviews, and the practical benefits were also pointed out when the core group decided to adjust the procedure a little.

"... in the beginning, it was quite pointless that with our confidentiality agreement every time... We read it once; we didn't know what was written there, but what happens if we read it again? Then we changed it; we don't read it every time; we just sign it. Now, the question is whether we should sign this confidentiality agreement again every time. I don't think so; I have done it once already. I am a member of MARAC. Why? One thing is whether we need to record on paper who attended this particular MARAC core group meeting with a signature again. I sort of cannot see the point in that; I mean, we have a secretary who takes the minutes. The secretary wrote down the names of the participants, and then my signature there in the minutes indicated that I was present. So who's to say that no, I didn't really participate. Such formalities seem a bit redundant.

—(Prosecutor)

Confidentiality, more generally, was seen as important, and several interviewees indicated that they understood why the confidentiality agreement had to be signed and read aloud. However, this is a point where we could consider the reduction of red tape. The survey suggested the following as a possible solution:

- conclusion of one confidentiality agreement per meeting;
- conclusion of one confidentiality agreement per case;
- conclusion of an annual confidentiality agreement;
- reading the confidentiality agreement only when there are new people in the meeting.

In addition, in the interviews, the formality and legal complexity of the wording of the confidentiality agreement were pointed out. Since the confidentiality agreement should be comprehensible to the victim, the wording of the confidentiality agreement should be revised so that it is easier for an ordinary person to understand.

"The victim is important here, and this confidentiality is explained to them so that they understand it. Perhaps the wording of confidentiality is too formal and too legalistic. We approach the victim, and we basically say in plain language that what you say here stays between the walls here, period. That's what it means, right? But if you read half a page of this text, it's actually one that people generally ... like a contract that you read and don't actually read. You can read, but you can't understand it; maybe this thing should be made easier."

—(Prosecutor)

Regionally, it appeared that some members in Hiiu County, Rapla County, Saare County, and Võru County mentioned not sending agendas in the survey. In the survey, some core group members from Pärnu County and Saare County mentioned not signing or reading the confidentiality agreement.

All members of the core groups consider that the data is handled in accordance with data protection rules, but the interviews revealed that there are still obstacles in this process. Namely, a confidentiality agreement is signed for the storage of data, but the core group member must pass on the information learned at the meeting to the employees of their agency (e.g., the head of the social department must inform the social worker in order to organize the provision of services, the head of the police district must inform the regional police officer). If we strictly follow the confidentiality agreement, the information disclosed at the meetings cannot be used in this way. In order for MARAC not to be limited to discussions between specialists and for the agreed solutions to be implemented quickly and effectively, it is important to communicate information to the officials who arrange for the victim to receive services and help (Robinson & Tregidga, 2005).

"... as a manager, anyway, you have to, even though you have signed a confidentiality agreement, and now you have to tell the district police officer to go there, do things like that, and take it into account. Now it has been agreed that we have to go to the women's support centre, and we have this situation with the children, so that now when you go, you have to take them into account. The manager just has to pass on this information. Especially if we have some critical cases or cases where escalation is expected, then it is important that we, as general first responders, have as broad a background as possible and a picture of it. It would be unprofessional for me to tell my local police officer, I'm sorry, I can't tell you about it. It would prevent us from doing our work on a professional level."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

As a more important element, the preparation of the security plan, which is not formalized as a separate document in several MARACs, causes conflicting opinions. The description of the MARAC instruction does not give a clear recommendation on how the security plan should be formalized, i.e., whether it should be a separate document or not. Essentially, the security plan is understood as the activities agreed on at the meetings, which in some cases are recorded only in the minutes of the meetings, but in other cases, both in the minutes and in a separate document. Since the distribution of the protocol and the preparation of the security plan are the responsibilities of the MARAC coordinator or the SIB Victim Support worker in Estonia, they also decide how to prepare the security plan. The SIB Victim Support staff justify not preparing the security plan as a separate document due to the duplication of work and information that accompanies the preparation of protocols and the security plan but also with data protection, which comes with sharing the same information with members of the core group in different documents.

"... these things are written down in the minutes, including the one who does it [the agreed action]. And with the security plan, there is also the question of where to store it. For the client, every person in need of help cannot keep it with them every time precisely because they have nowhere to keep it safe. So many times, it is also the same employee of the local government, which also puts them in charge. ... We actually have these things in the minutes, and we've agreed among ourselves to whom we're going to send the minutes. We have also had times when we very correctly sent all these encrypted protocols. But the members of the network also think that not all this is

needed. ... It's also like saving a resource. Let's say that if there are, on average, eight to ten network members in MARAC, there are also considerably larger networks. If each protocol is encrypted and sent separately, it is a huge burden for this one person, this coordinator. ... sometimes it's necessary, and of course, but then again, when there have been periods where I've had eight cases in one MARAC, it's overwhelming."

—(Representative of the SIB)

"...I'm in two different core groups; I haven't come across a different approach yet. So I have a feeling that maybe this is the one place where the red tape can be reduced, and so because I have to say that the other members didn't even know the word "security plan" either. They said that we take the minutes, we agree on activities, and I will do these activities and report."

—(Representative of the SIB)

Agreements are made in meetings, and core group members feel that they do not need the security plan in a separate document to refer to their own actions. The security plan is not shared with the victim as it would not be safe to keep it with the victim. Because, in part, the members of the core groups do not distinguish between the minutes of the meetings and the security plan, there is no core group where all the members say that the security plan is not made. In a situation where the core group does not prepare a security plan in a separate document, the activities of the security plan are still essentially noted in the minutes. Individual members of some core groups noted the lack of a security plan in the core groups of Ida-Harju region, Tartu County, Valga County, and Võru County.

In addition to the bureaucracy associated with the above-mentioned activities, the Victim Support worker's role as MARAC coordinator is accompanied by the task of entering and transmitting data. All the parts add up to a situation where Victim Support workers feel a significant bureaucratic burden from MARAC. The increase in administrative burden associated with MARAC is a well-known issue (Robinson, 2004), which has also been addressed in other countries where the MARAC model is utilized. There is a recognized need to allocate additional resources to address administrative tasks and to reorganize workflows in a manner that prevents an overwhelming burden from falling on one individual.

In Estonia, core groups have tried to find a solution to the problem by making small changes in administrative tasks. Although all core groups consider compliance with both the security plan and confidentiality requirements to be very important, the increase in bureaucratic workload has raised concerns for the core groups. Therefore, some core groups have made organizational adjustments within the existing system, which core group members themselves believe will ensure more optimal functioning. However, these adaptations may not be fully consistent with MARAC and case management principles. Therefore, the procedure of concluding and reading the confidentiality agreement, sending and sharing minutes, and preparing the security plan should be reviewed, and various options for reducing the bureaucratic burden for the core groups should be considered while still fulfilling the goals of the security plan and the confidentiality agreement. There might be a necessity to provide additional clarification to the core groups regarding the purposes and format of the aforementioned documents.

"things go quite organically with us, so if we feel that something is not necessary, we don't do it. Because we, for example, according to my information, but I'm not quite sure, we don't make a security plan... in the same way that we look at the fact that people have all participated before, we don't reread the confidentiality agreement."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

In summary, based on the input of the members of the core groups, the arrangements for signing the confidentiality agreement, reading it aloud, and preparing and dispersing the security plan and minutes should be revised and optimized. While examining the structure of document creation and distribution to reduce administrative load, it is essential to distinctly outline the purpose, intended users, and purpose of use for each document. Additionally, ensuring the security of personal data processing and adhering to the principle of data minimisation is crucial. Since the current MARAC manual is not uniform in terms of the preparation and sharing of security plans and protocols and describes the processes in detail, the arrangement should be clearly and unambiguously reflected in the MARAC guidelines.

2.3.5 Effectiveness and content of meetings

Core group members describe the organization and time management of meetings as effective and cite MARAC's organization as an example for other roundtables. Established and adhered-to rules for holding the meetings to ensure efficient use of time. Institutional representatives undertake preparatory tasks for the meetings and, in accordance with the agenda, gather information about the developments within their institution to be shared during the meeting. Usually, 20-30 minutes are planned for discussing one case at the meeting, and the participants try to stick to it.

However, keeping case discussions within the time limit is sometimes a challenge, for example, when (1) it is a new or complex case, (2) the meeting is attended by case specialists who are not as familiar with MARAC, or (3) the victim herself attends the meeting. Discussion time may also be longer due to core group members who are not very familiar with the process of MARAC meetings or in cases where representatives of different agencies have different expectations of each other.

"depends on who participates in the meeting within the case. It just depends on the people who understand and who don't understand... just maybe they don't understand what is expected of them and what is wanted from them, and if it gets a bit more agitated.... It doesn't happen often, but sometimes it does. Local governments are the biggest bottleneck, and perhaps they have different expectations of each other."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

It helps to stick to the meeting's time limit if cases that require a longer time are moved to the end of the agenda.

The moving of a case from one meeting to another ensures that the case is under active attention at MARAC and that it does not disappear or die down on its own. The case is considered closed in MARAC by a clear decision of the meeting. In the interviews of the core

group members, individual examples of cases were brought up, which were transferred from one meeting to another without the MARAC network being able to bring about a significant change. In such situations, core group members have felt that joint discussions in MARAC do not add value to solving the case, and MARAC's possibilities have been exhausted. Examples of such cases were cases of people with alcohol addiction or alcohol abuse and situations where the victim is in a state where they are not ready to accept help to resolve the situation.

"where there is alcohol consumption on both sides. Both refuse treatment... This is not a MARAC case, but the local government should intervene because the police, Victim Support, and the local government have their own separate round tables where they discuss these cases. But simply in MARAC, we discuss that there is such a case, someone, for example, says, Victim Support or the police, that alcohol is consumed there."

—(representative of the WSC)

"... lets him in herself, if the victim herself works against MARAC. How can MARAC help? We can't help - we can monitor, the police can do checks, home visits. But if the mother still lets her son in, it doesn't really make sense. In such a case, the social department should intervene here... there have actually been such cases."

—(representative of the WSC)

In situations where the case remains high risk, but the core team feels that the options to solve the cases have been exhausted, the core teams should be assisted. At this point, the development of new measures and solutions, as well as the development of the knowledge of core group members to solve complex cases, should be considered. The identification of effective measures within the MARAC network may be affected when the victim simultaneously acts as a perpetrator of violence. This situation makes it difficult to find relief measures through MARAC because the main task of MARAC is to reduce the threat to the health and life of the victim, but at the same time, such a case requires finding solutions from several different angles.

"if a person is herself a suspect and is the perpetrator of the act. After all, MARAC deals with the victim. We have also had such cases when a person is both a suspect and a victim. Then MARAC just needs a bit of time to find out where the line is."

—(representative of the WSC)

Numerous experts emphasised that each MARAC case is unique, demanding a tailored solution specific to that particular situation. Consequently, the extended resolution time for certain cases is not an inefficient allocation of MARAC time but rather a necessary duration to identify an appropriate solution. However, some members of the core groups pointed out that in their experience, there have been cases that, in their opinion, should not have reached MARAC and could have been resolved without MARAC. Such situations may be because the MARAC risk assessment did not screen out high risk. However, the members of the core groups did not point out these examples as deficiencies in the risk assessment. Since the risk assessment and the referral to MARAC were generally well evaluated and no major deficiencies were seen in the selection of MARAC cases, it is possible in these examples that the core member had incomplete information about the circumstances of the case or there are prejudices and

attitudes where the victim is not believed. For example, there was an assessment that, at times, the MARAC process could be used by victims to gain an advantage in civil litigation.

"It seems to me that a few times, a few times, it has been like this that, for example, when the victim is currently in the process of dividing property or dividing the child in the civil court, it may happen that the victim manipulates. In fact, there is a big house or a fancy car behind it. Why is it so blown up that it has reached MARAC, but in reality, maybe there is no reason to be there."

—(Prosecutor)

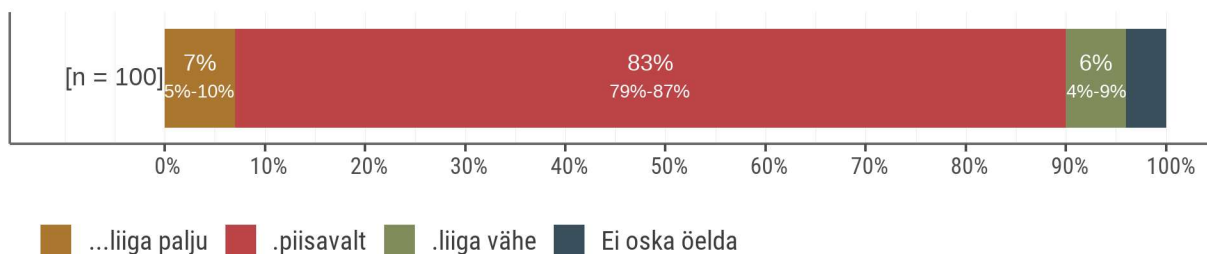
As the victim is only directed to MARAC following a risk assessment, the second prosecutor highlighted that in cases involving a civil dispute and concurrent domestic violence, where the situation lacks criminal proof, MARAC serves as the avenue through which assistance can be provided.

"in civil cases where there is no criminal case, there are really unpleasant divorces, separation of children, where they talk about violence. Where this risk assessment questionnaire seems to give such a result that it could be discussed in MARAC, right? ... if it is already known in advance that the criminal proceedings will lead nowhere, certain evidence is missing. Then the question remains that we do not conduct criminal proceedings, but the victim, at least who claims to be a victim, and at least that is the general picture, needs help. Well, the MARAC cooperation network should help them to move forward in life."

—(Prosecutor)

In general, MARAC should not deal with people's social problems but focus on bringing people out of acute risk. At the same time, a person is a whole with acute risk and social problems. Social problems cannot be completely ignored when trying to mitigate the threat to health or life. In general, the members of the core groups think that the MARAC meetings deal with solving other social problems of the victim sufficiently (see Figure 48).

Figure 48. The distribution of core group members according to the assessment of dealing with solving other social problems of the victim at MARAC meetings

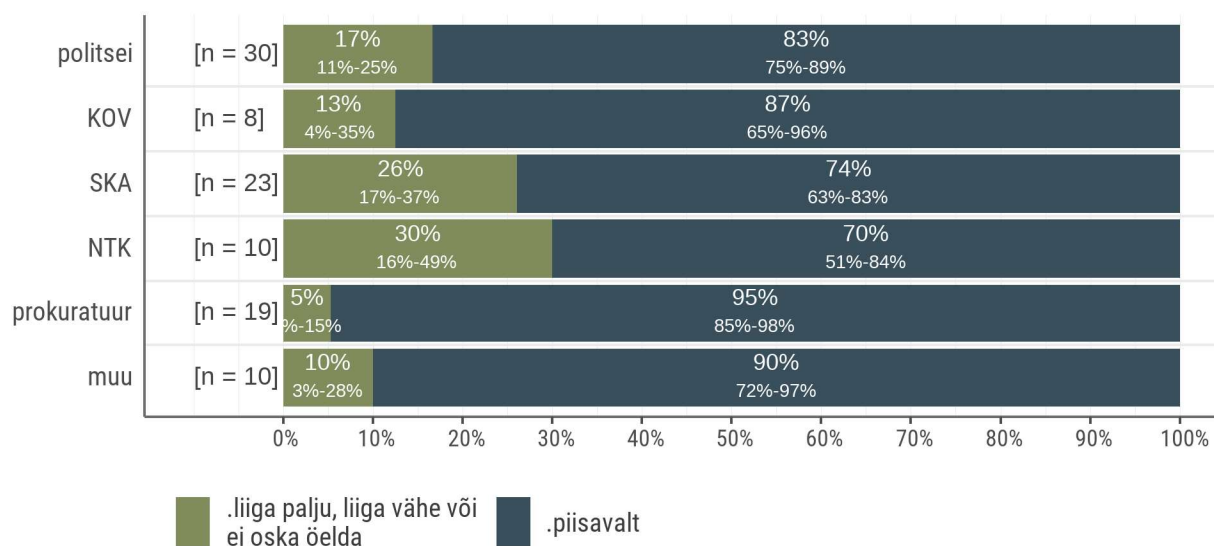


Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

There are no core groups where all members feel that social issues are being addressed too little or too much. Five core groups have members who believe that social problems are being addressed too little, and six core groups have members who believe that social issues

are being addressed too much. At the same time, there are two core groups: those who think that social problems are dealt with too little and those who think that too much is being done. From all agencies, there are core group members who think that social problems are being dealt with either too little or too much, or they do not know how to evaluate it. Statistically, only the representatives of the prosecutor's office significantly differ from the representatives of the SIB and WSP, among whom there are more of those who think that social problems are dealt with sufficiently (see figure 49).

Figure 49. The proportion of core group members who consider that MARAC meetings address the victim's other social problems sufficiently or not - by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

In summary, the time management of meetings is efficient. Adhering to the meeting times will be affected if a person who does not know the MARAC meeting rules, including a victim or a case specialist, attends the meeting. A central issue in the substantive effectiveness of meetings is the selection of cases to be discussed at meetings. Even in the cases included in MARAC, it is not possible to distinguish well in the meetings the discussion of social issues of the victim from the discussion of security measures. There is no consensus among the core group members regarding increasing or decreasing the discussion of the victim's social issues at the meetings. The MARAC referral process is generally considered appropriate, but there are still situations where a core group member feels that a case referred to MARAC is not a really high risk. Also, in the case of complex cases, core group members sometimes feel that MARAC's opportunities to help victims have been exhausted and that the network's cooperation does not provide added value in solving the case.

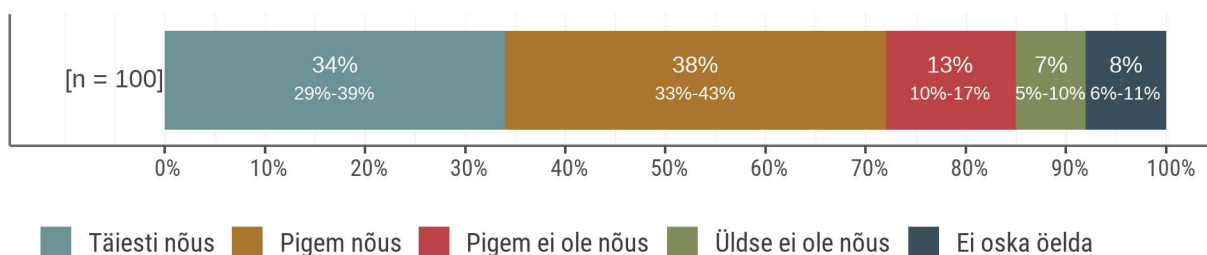
2.3.6 Measures directed at the perpetrator

In every case of violence, in addition to the victim, there is a perpetrator of violence. MARAC's activities are focused on assisting the victim, but the effectiveness of the support and the development of the victim's situation in domestic violence depend very much on what

happens to the perpetrator of violence and to break the cycles of domestic violence, it is important to do additional work with the perpetrators (Kerti, 2017).

More than half of MARAC core members believe that MARAC should support the perpetrator in giving up violence at the same time as helping the victim (see Figure 50). Since MARAC acts as a network within the resources and services of the institutions, this result means that essentially, the members of the network should discuss the topic of the perpetrator of violence, and appropriate measures to help the perpetrator should be developed in sufficient volume in the institutions that are members of the network.

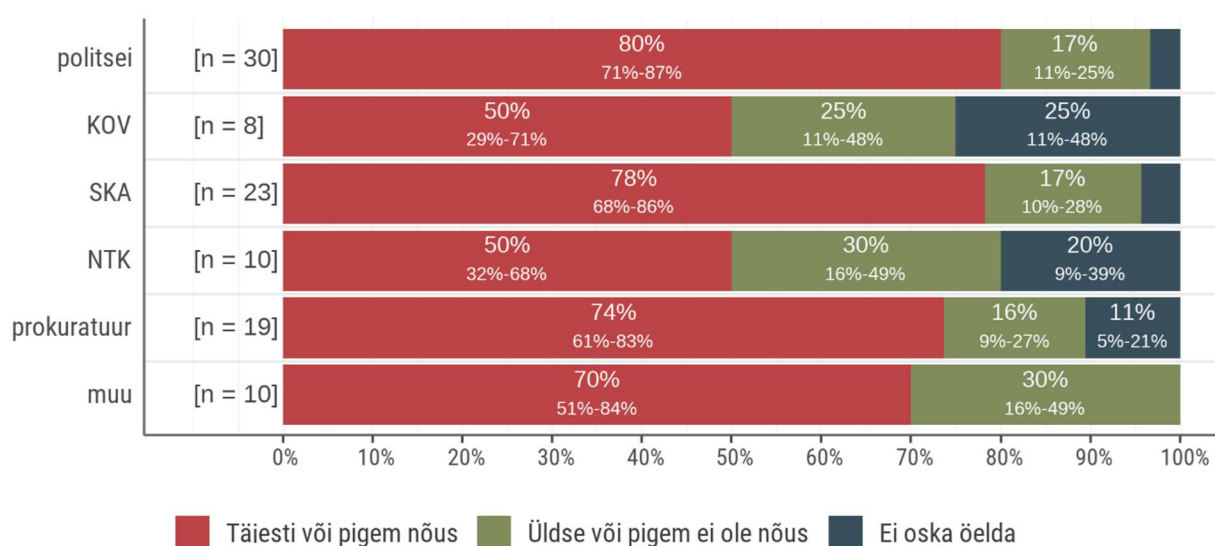
Figure 50. Distribution of core group members according to whether MARAC teams should support the perpetrator to desist from violence



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

The majority of the representatives of the agencies operating in MARAC believe that the perpetrator should be supported in giving up violence. Among the representatives of the police, SIB, and the prosecutor's office, there are more people who agree that the MARAC teams should support the perpetrator in giving up violence (see Figure 51).

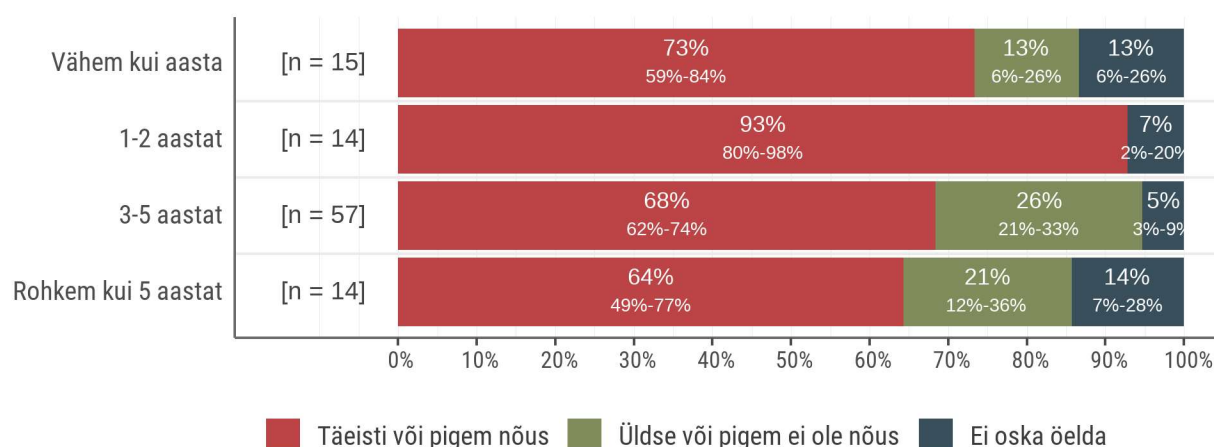
Figure 51. Breakdown of core group members by whether MARAC teams should support the perpetrator to desist from violence - by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Among those who have been active in MARAC for a longer time, there is a slightly smaller proportion of those who think that supporting the perpetrator in giving up violence could be the task of MARAC (see Figure 52). A higher proportion of those who have been active in MARAC for 1-2 years than those who have been active for 3-5 years agree that the perpetrator should be supported in giving up violence.

Figure 52. Breakdown of core group members according to whether MARAC teams should support the perpetrator to desist from violence by length of time in MARAC



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

One interviewee pointed out that there is a counselling service for giving up violence, but the lack is still felt.

Local government: "We have also had abusers who have agreed to go to counselling, so not only victims but also abusers. We have also had these cases." Questioner: "Who does the work to get this consent from the abuser?" Local government: "I think that Victim Support is probably the main worker, but maybe also the police."

—(local government representative)

At the same time, the core members of MARAC also do not have good solutions on how to better reach the perpetrator, although they agree that work should be done on this.

"I just think that we should figure out what to do with these perpetrators. Okay, we have a helpline in Estonia for those wanting to give up violence. But what is the benefit of it? I am, I am very critical of it."

—(Prosecutor)

"But we cannot completely dismiss this perpetrator. We can only give suggestions, what the next move should be, what needs to be done next. We don't have any more chances because the law doesn't allow us to deal with the other side anymore."

—(Representative of the SIB)

However, at least one member of the MARAC core group highlighted that the sanctions imposed on the perpetrator are currently effective in certain instances.

"Generally, many of these perpetrators have received their punishment, and then they don't dare anymore. That's because a lot of the sentences are suspended prison terms, and if that abuser knows, they're very smart actually, if they know that whatever I'm going to do now, the next step is prison. Then they stop. Intimidation - just like they intimidate their victims. It turns out Ehk "In summary, a considerable portion of MARAC members believe that dealing with the perpetrator should be part of MARAC proceedings, but almost one-fifth of MARAC core group members hold a differing view. Those in the core group who express uncertainty about dealing with the perpetrator indicate a lack of clear strategies to effectively engage with them."

—(local government representative)

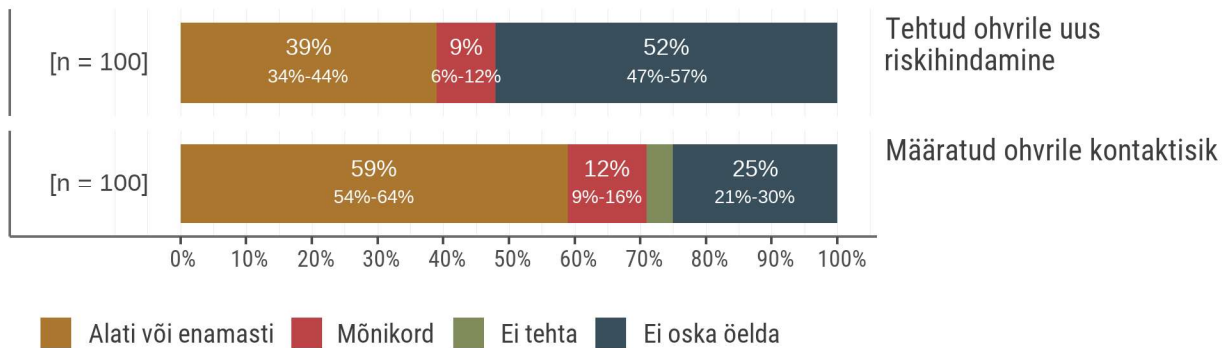
In summary, a considerable portion of MARAC members believe that dealing with the perpetrator should be part of MARAC proceedings, but almost one-fifth of MARAC core group members hold a differing view. Those in the core group who express uncertainty about dealing with the perpetrator indicate a lack of clear strategies to engage with them effectively.

Closure of a MARAC case and follow-up activities

As per MARAC guidelines, a case can be concluded when the security plan is fulfilled and the risk level falls below the 14-point threshold in the risk assessment. Upon closing the MARAC case, a designated contact person should be assigned to the victim. This contact person would be available for the victim to reach out to if needed, or they may initiate contact later to assess the situation. According to MARAC instructions, it is recommended to call the victim after six months and ask for feedback about their coping and the impact of MARAC.

Almost half of the MARAC core group members do not know whether a risk assessment was done to close MARAC, and about a third do not know or think that a contact person will not be appointed when the case is closed (see Figure 53). The results of the MARAC closure risk assessment are also very patchy as monitoring data. It follows that MARAC closure risk assessments are not carried out regularly.

Figure 53. In the last 12 months, how often was the closure of a case at MARAC in your area?



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

In no region does every member of a MARAC core group unanimously agree on whether a risk assessment should or should not be conducted at the conclusion of a case. In each core group, there are individuals with varying opinions on this matter.

The MARAC guidelines recommend that the follow-up call be conducted by a specialist who has not previously dealt with the client's case, as some clients may be uncomfortable admitting that the violence against them continued even after the intervention of a specialist. Interviews with specialists from the core group revealed that after the end of the MARAC case, the SIB Victim Support worker still maintains contact with the victim. Hence, other core group members may not have precise information about the appointment of a contact person and may be unaware of who contacts the victim and when.

"I can simply call a person or invite them to my place. Well, we don't because it's like a re-victimization for me that we call six months later and say that we'll call again. Although you have to ask, you just talk to the person, and if something comes out, you write it down. If everything is fine, then everything is fine. Just trust your gut feeling, according to your own intuition."

—(Representative of the SIB)

"if there hasn't been an active story, then yes, so we'll get in touch after some time in half a year, again in a year, to see how you're doing and just ask for feedback. However, at the same time, it is again that you don't have to follow the guidelines so strictly, yes, as the method requires."

—(Representative of the SIB)

Although core group members other than SIB representatives are not directly designated as contact persons under MARAC, they may have contact with the victim depending on their work. The police have preventive domestic violence home visits outside of MARAC, which are carried out in higher-risk cases.

"... unless he is in the TOP of this DV, we don't really deal with it. At TOP, we have a thing, and sometimes, we do preventive home visits precisely in the sense of specifying

whether there are still risks or not. This is the kind of thing we've had this year... DV top means that statistically we take out and see where the risk is high, there is more repetition."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

The prosecutor remains in contact with the victim if the criminal proceedings continue longer than the MARAC case.

"Since our most difficult cases end up in court, as a rule, I am very often the support person who maintains contact with the victim. We have a case of rape and beating, three years have already passed since this matter, but I still communicate with the victim from time to time. The victim has some questions, then they immediately call me, specify and ask something. Sometimes, we are really together with these victims for a very long time. It gives them some reassurance that we have someone if they have a question, that we have someone they can turn to. Even though we no longer had this particular victim in MARAC, but the trial had just started, we constantly communicated with them on this topic, we constantly met them, prepared them, and then all the time we were constantly in contact, doesn't matter that it was no longer in MARAC."

—(Prosecutor)

The WSC representative notes that the victims themselves have the opportunity to contact various core group members and service providers who have worked on their cases through MARAC.

"There are no direct follow-up activities with the victim, and it is rather that they have a contact, in fact, several contacts, with whom they can communicate if necessary and know that they can always turn to them if there is anything. Because these pieces of advice on how to protect yourself, stand up for yourself and establish yourself, they are so constant because it takes practice."

—(representative of the WSC)

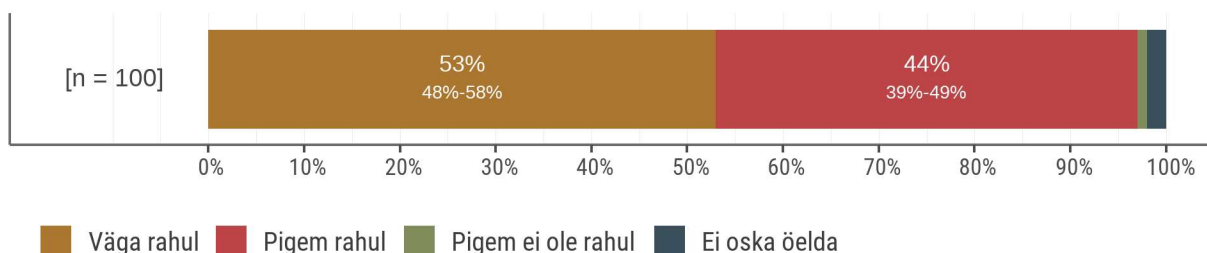
In summary, risk assessment for MARAC case closure and assigning a specific contact to core group members is less common or less known than risk assessment for MARAC referral. In addition to the specifically designated contact person, other MARAC core group members are in contact with the victim according to the specifics of the case. Core group members are flexible about regular post-MARAC inspections.

2.4 Satisfaction with MARAC work organization and changes in work organization

2.4.1 Satisfaction with work organization

Most people are very satisfied or rather satisfied with the work organization of MARAC in the region (see Fig 54).

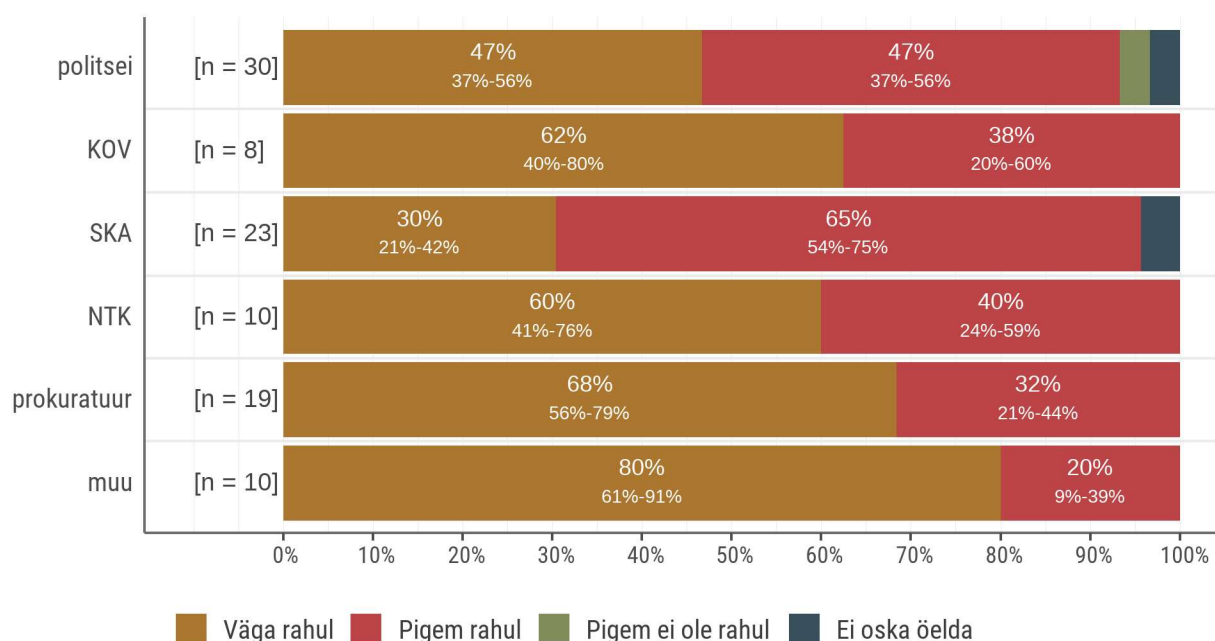
Figure 54. Distribution of members of the core group according to satisfaction with the work organization of MARAC in the region



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Dissatisfaction with the MARAC work organization was expressed only by a few police representatives (see Fig 55), who acted as the chairman of the meeting. This indicates the need to rethink and clarify the role of the leader and the choice of its executor in MARAC core groups (see also the chapter on the roles of core group members).

Figure 55. Distribution of members of the core group according to their satisfaction with the work organization of MARAC in their region - by agency



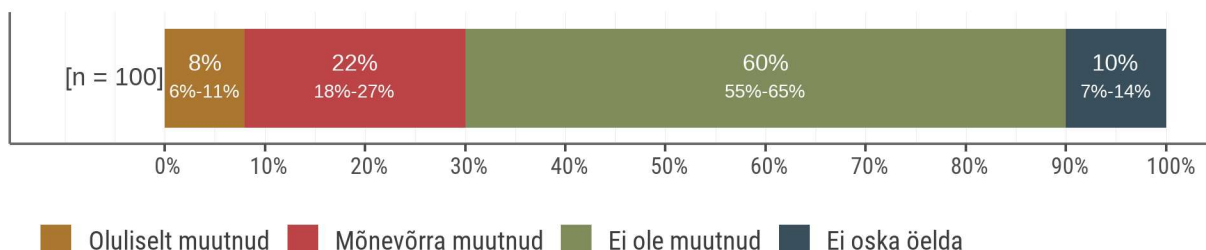
Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

2.4.2 Impact on work methods, workload, and opportunities to provide support to the victim

The majority, or nearly 60% of the members of the core group, think that the work in MARAC has not changed the working methods of dealing with domestic violence, and a smaller part, or nearly 30%, think that it has changed significantly or somewhat (see figure 56). Such a

result shows that the previous working practices of the people operating in MARAC and the reference points for describing the change are different.

Figure 56. Distribution of core group members according to the extent to which the work in MARAC has changed the working methods of dealing with the issue of domestic violence



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

There is no core group where all members say that their working methods have changed because of MARAC. None of the members of the Tartu County, Lääne County, and Põlva County core group thought that MARAC changed the working methods of dealing with domestic violence. In other core groups besides Tartu County, Lääne County, and Põlva County, at least one of the members thinks that the working methods have changed. Since DV roundtables were already active before MARAC and continue to operate in parallel, several members of the core groups pointed out in the interviews that MARAC did not change the working methods and that MARAC is only a separate platform for discussions of selected cases.

"Even without MARAC, we had a very well-functioning cooperation network. We had domestic violence roundtables, so how to say, for me personally, MARAC was not such a magic wand that now everything changed, and everything became better. ... certainly MARAC was very good in those places, I think, in regions where there was no good cooperation network in Estonia. ... in essence, it functioned as an analogous network even before that ... then it was rather case-based this cooperation network."

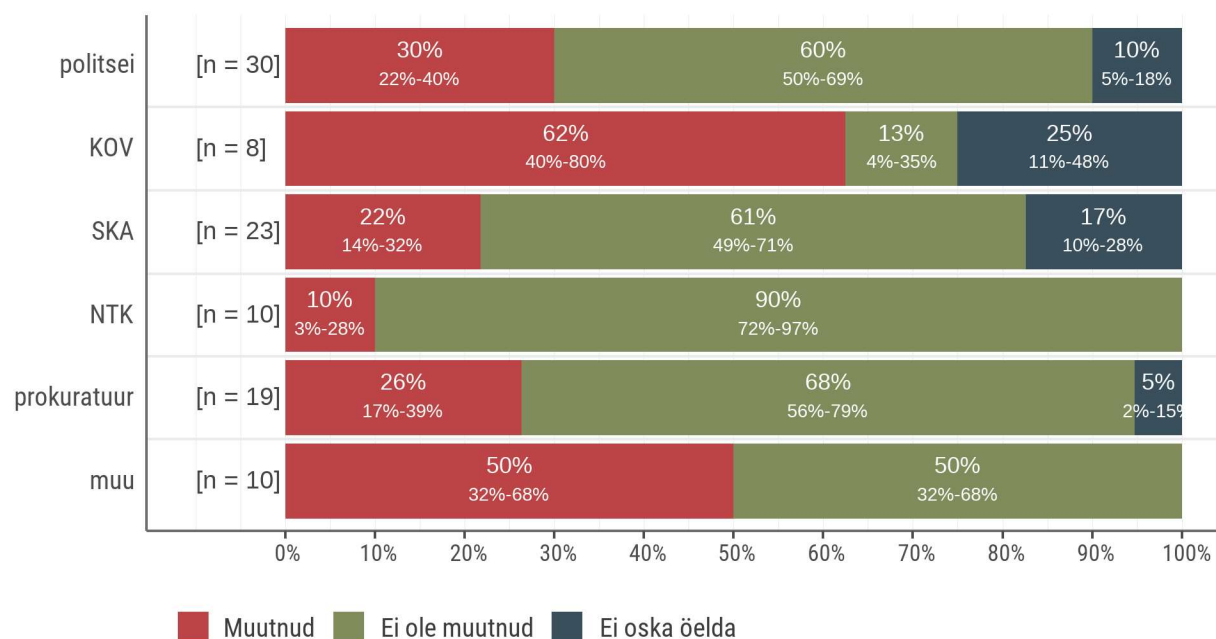
—(Prosecutor)

"Cooperation goes on all the time anyway, and our networks, even with the same people, work all the time anyway. ... it [MARAC] sometimes provides a greater opportunity to officially address and thus determine whether we have obtained a necessary cooperation partner or not."

—(Representative of the SIB)

Compared to other institutions, participation in MARAC has changed the working methods of the majority of local government officials (see Figure 57), who act as core members of MARAC and, to a lesser extent, WSC representatives.

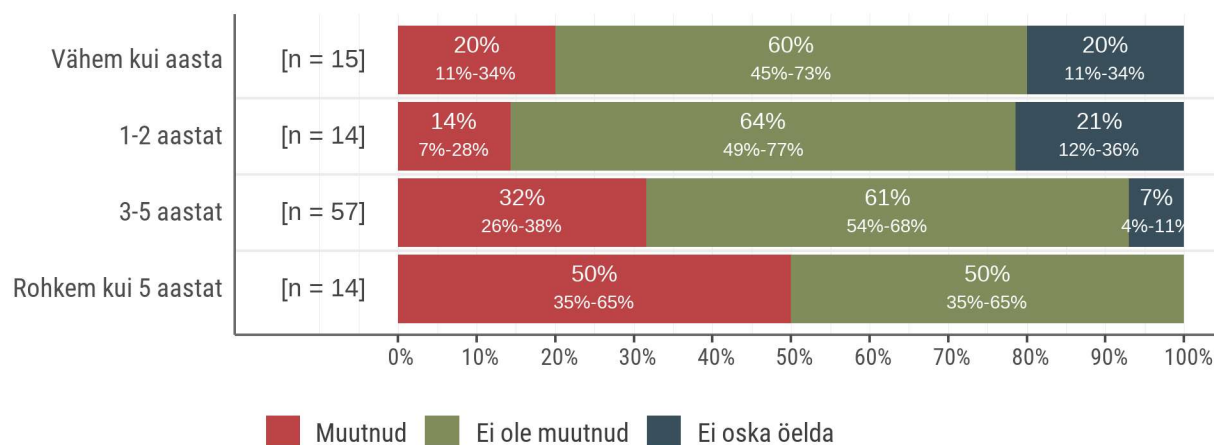
Figure 57. The proportion of members of the core group according to how the work in MARAC has changed the working methods of dealing with domestic violence - by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

The change in working methods is perceived by a larger proportion of those who have been active in MARAC for a longer period of time (see Figure (58)). Since MARAC was introduced some time ago, people who have previously operated in MARAC have compared operations with and without MARAC. For those who have recently started working as a member of MARAC, it comes with the position, and there is no comparison to the working methods of the position without MARAC. Therefore, several of the core group members with short-term experience are not able to assess the impact of MARAC on the work.

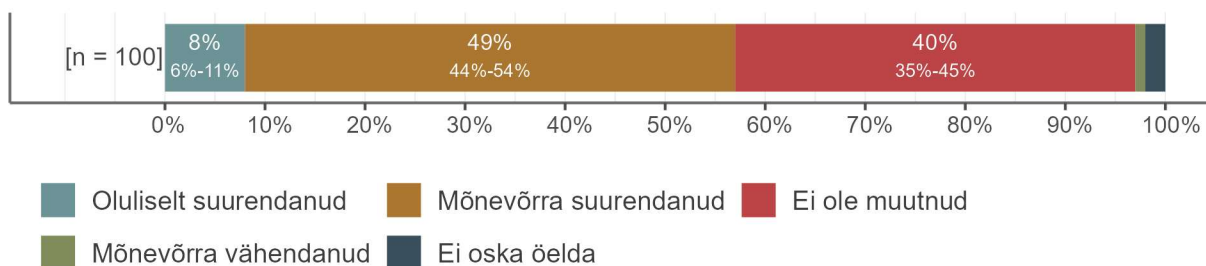
Figure 58. The proportion of members of the core group according to how the work in MARAC has changed the working methods of dealing with the issue of domestic violence - by duration of activity



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Working in MARAC increased the general workload of some members and not others: approx. 60% of the members of the core group increased their overall workload while operating in MARAC, and approx. 40% of the workload did not change (see Figure 59).

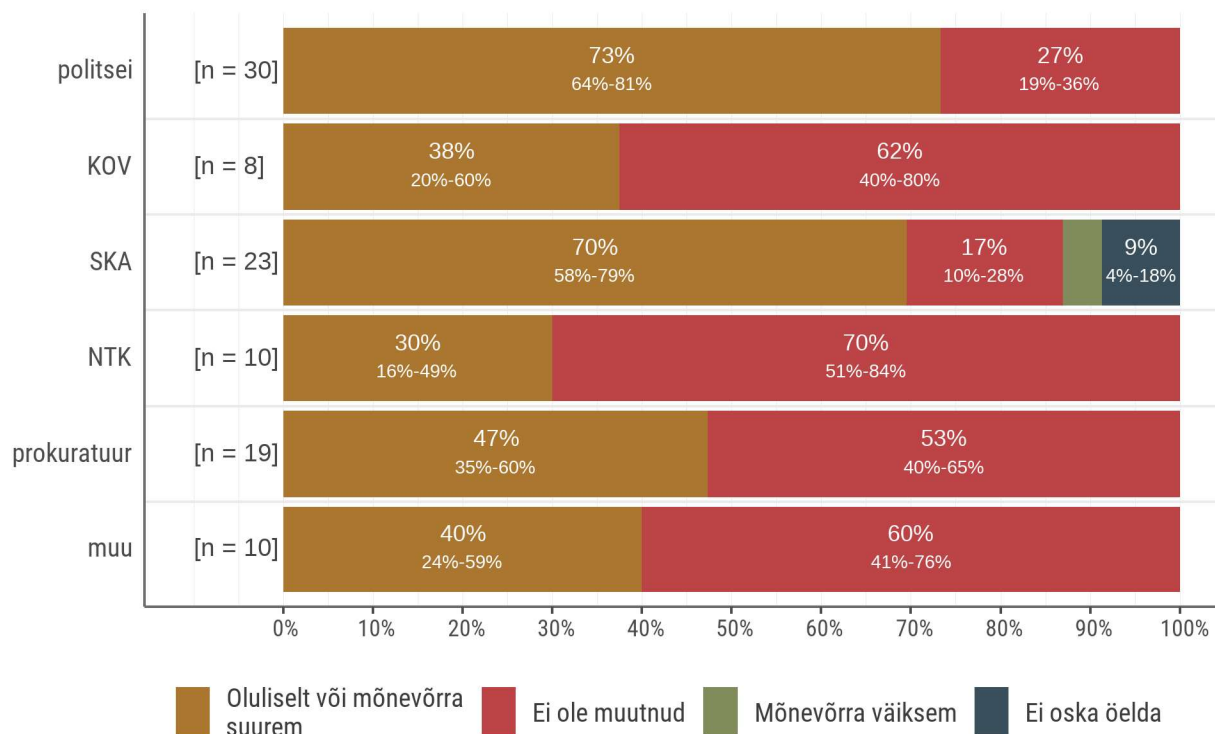
Figure 59. Distribution of core members based on how work at MARAC changed their overall workload



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

The increase in workload due to MARAC was pointed out more by the representatives of PBGB and SIB than the representatives of other institutions, who have the roles of MARAC coordinator, meeting leader, and mostly recorder.

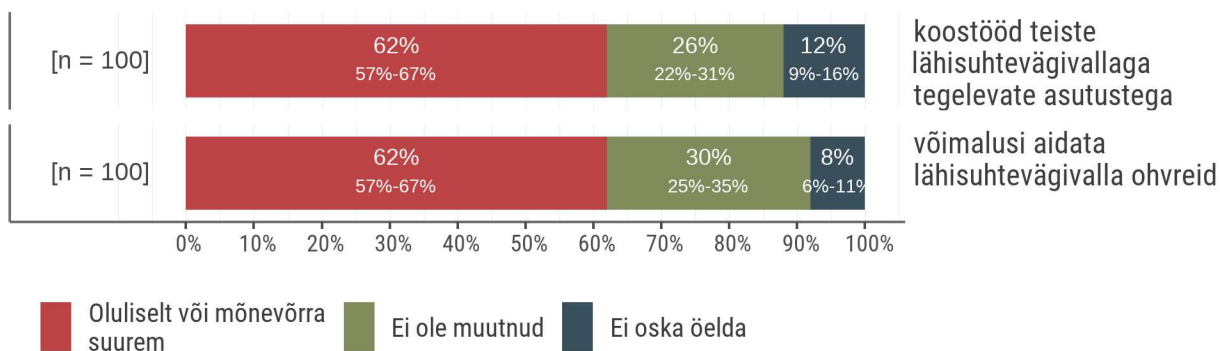
Figure 60. Distribution of core members according to how working at MARAC has changed their overall workload by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Although MARAC did not change the previously used working methods for a large number of core group members, many still believe that MARAC improved inter-agency cooperation. According to the results of the survey, slightly more than half of the MARAC members believe that working in MARAC improved both cooperation with other institutions dealing with sexual assault and the opportunities to help victims of sexual assault. Both improved by nearly 60%, according to core group members.

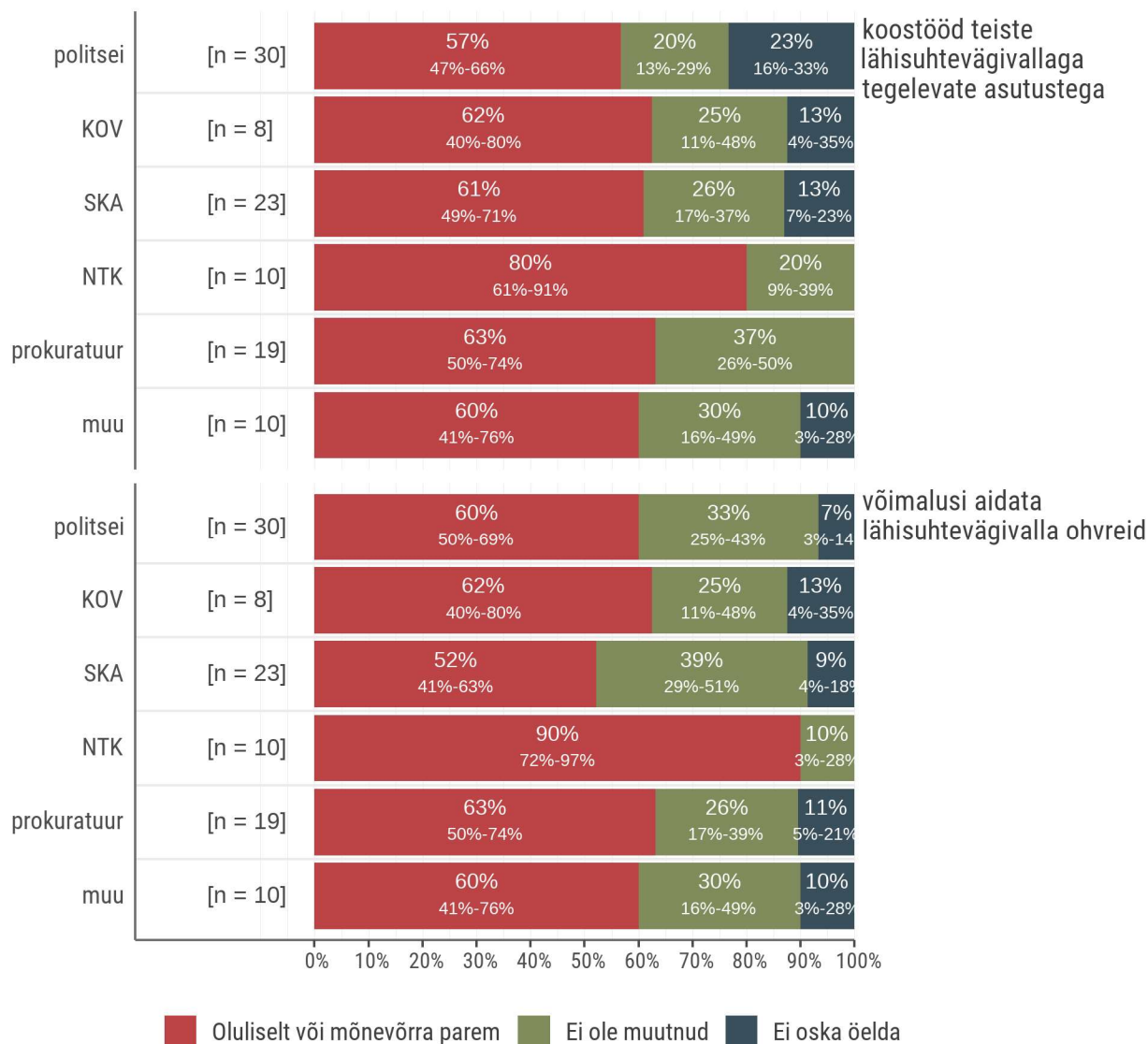
Figure 61. Breakdown of core group members according to how working at MARAC has changed their...



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Both, i.e., cooperation with other institutions and opportunities to help victims of DV, improved by 50-60%, according to the core group members, regardless of the institution that the core group member represents (see figure 62). Among WSC representatives, this share is even higher (80-90%). Based on this, it seems that among the WSC representatives, compared to the representatives of other institutions, the majority appreciates that the handling of DV cases is done in cooperation between different agencies as a result of MARAC.

Figure 62. Distribution of core group members according to how work in MARAC has changed cooperation with other agencies and opportunities to assist victims - by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

According to several members of the core group, the MARAC model has proven to be a valuable tool in enhancing cooperation between agencies and improving the possibilities of

helping the victim. Its impact and effectiveness have been highlighted by various parties in several interviews:

Creation and coordination of the information field: MARAC establishes a shared information platform among institutions and network members. This facilitates improved coordination of assistance and services, enables more prompt responses, and helps prevent duplication of efforts.

"The cooperation still works very well, and we agree on who would be the most appropriate specialist, with whom the victim could have, so to speak, the first contact for her, and I think that is very good."

—(Prosecutor)

"MARAC, this model provides an opportunity to break the barriers of information sharing... right there, I don't know, within half an hour a solution will be found, and it will be a working solution... which is effective, fast, efficient."

—(SIB)

Activation of parties: MARAC pressures all parties to contribute, thereby activating all institutions.

"Is it such a complicated case from the get-go... In this sense, I see MARAC as a very good opportunity... to influence weaker cooperation partners to act more actively."

—(PBGB)

"This common information space and quick exchange of information is probably the main thing that makes the... prosecutor move, all the time pushes the prosecutor forward."

—(PBGB)

Case tracking: Cases handled through MARAC remain actively in view and do not go away.

"If, for example, there really is this case in MARAC, it is certain that this case will be discussed and it will not disappear anywhere. This is perhaps the biggest plus in the case of MARAC."

—(WSC)

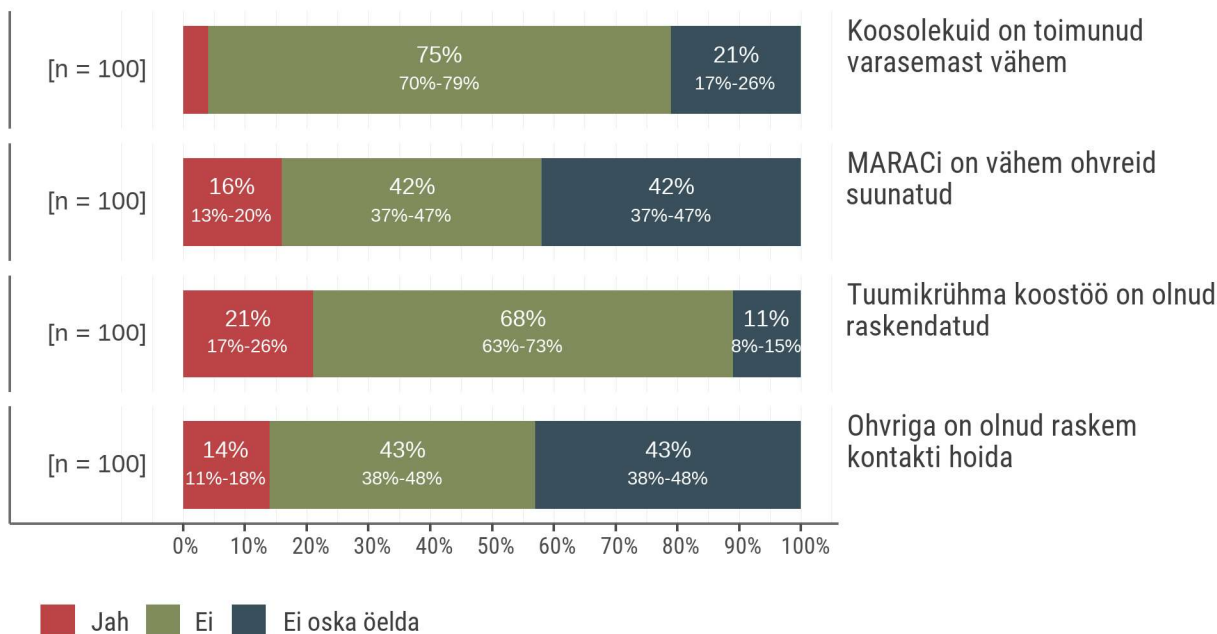
Thus, MARAC's positive impact on work organization is seen as coordinated action and information exchange between agencies in order to ensure the best possible help and support for victims.

In summary, MARAC did not change the working methods of dealing with DV of about 60% of core group members. At the same time, the general workload increased for many. The workload of many participants, especially the police and SIB representatives, increased due to the additional tasks at MARAC. MARAC improved the cooperation of core members with other institutions and the possibilities of helping victims of DV, especially according to WSC representatives.

2.4.3 Impact of crises on MARAC's work organization

The crises had little effect on the functioning of MARAC. A fifth or less of the members of the core groups indicated that the crises of the last years affected the functioning of MARAC. The largest part considers that the crises have not affected the activities of MARAC, or they cannot assess the impact of the crises on MARAC (see Figure 63).

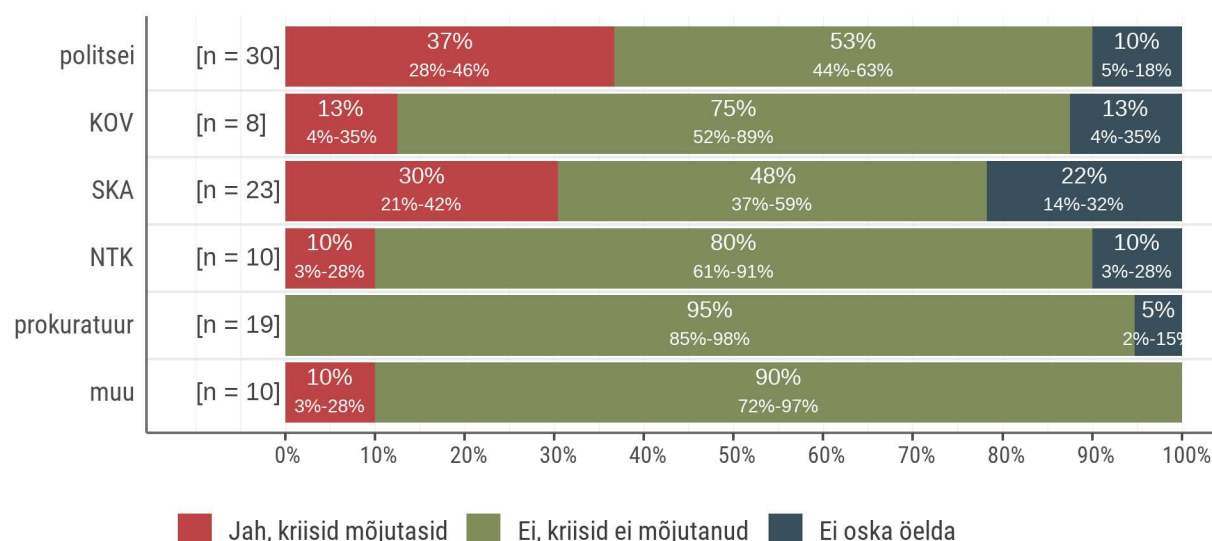
Figure 63. Distribution of core members according to the assessment of how the crises of recent years (corona crisis, war in Ukraine, etc.) affected the functioning of MARAC



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Since the MARAC-specific burden of the SIB and the police is greater than that of other members of the core groups, a larger proportion of them felt that the cooperation of the core group was more difficult due to crises (see Figure 64).

Figure 64. Distribution of core members according to the assessment of how the crises of recent years (corona crisis, war in Ukraine, etc.) affected the cooperation of the MARAC core group - by agency



The recent decline in the number of MARAC cases was felt more generally by several members of the interviewed core groups. Surveillance data also show a decline in the number of cases. The core group members cannot explain the reasons for the situation, and therefore, they are not sure whether it is due to the crises, there has been a general decline of DV in society, or it is more difficult to convince the victims to participate in MARAC.

"the diagram shows that the situation is more likely in a decline... Does it show that, well, I can't say - whether it really has decreased in families, has people's awareness increased? Or it is that these interventions are not effective enough; it will be seen that I reported it, but nothing changes and things continue to go on... so is it that people don't report anywhere anymore? They won't talk about it even if you ask them, they won't report it to the police, or are things really better? I can't tell."

—(Representative of the PBGB)

In interviews with core group members, the reasons for the drop in the number of cases are the difficulty of obtaining consent from victims and the decisions of core group members to leave cases with an initial score below the threshold assessed by DASH to be handled outside of MARAC. This is also indirectly confirmed by surveillance data, according to which the mean initial DASH score of MARAC cases increased in 2022. Rather, cases with an initial score above the threshold are included in MARAC, and cases with an initial score below the threshold are discarded. Thus, a clear link between the decline in the number of MARAC cases and recent crises cannot be established.

A clear effect of the coronavirus crisis was the move of meetings, including MARAC meetings, to virtual environments. As such a situation prevailed in society, it did not have a significant specific impact on MARAC. At the same time, the spread of the possibility of virtual meetings has changed the preferences of some people, including MARAC members. While there are

people who prefer to hold meetings physically in the same room, there are also people who prefer to use virtual meetings to save time.

"Of course, these on-site meetings are very important. When we do it online, it has happened that, for example, before the meeting takes place, they announce that the meeting will take place online. Then it's like a big surprise, you've prepared yourself for going. Of course, for some people, it is easier online, and for me, it may be like there might even be some kind of internet outage. I talk, talk, talk, and it gets stuck; this is like an obstacle. It has even happened that I have been in contact by phone. But I think that if you do it online, then the opportunity for the victim to participate in this meeting disappears, so then they have to join in, so it is also easier for the victim to actually participate on the spot, to see these people face to face. Online meetings are an alternative, but it should not be such a general tendency that we always do it online."

—(representative of the WSC)

"very often, it is also possible to virtually participate so that you switch to the meeting for the moment when your matter is being discussed."

—(Prosecutor)

"If there is more than one, I will go there, and if there is work and I see that there is not going to be a lot of discussion, it is not the first case, for example, and I have other tasks, I prefer to be online, driving also takes time about forty minutes there and back."

—(local government)

In summary, important changes have taken place in recent years, which are partly related to crises and other changes that cannot be related to crises. As a result of the crises, the format of virtual meetings and hybrid meetings have been introduced, and some people in specific roles in MARAC have increased workloads. However, the reasons for the decline in MARAC cases are not directly attributable to the crises, and the reasons may be different.

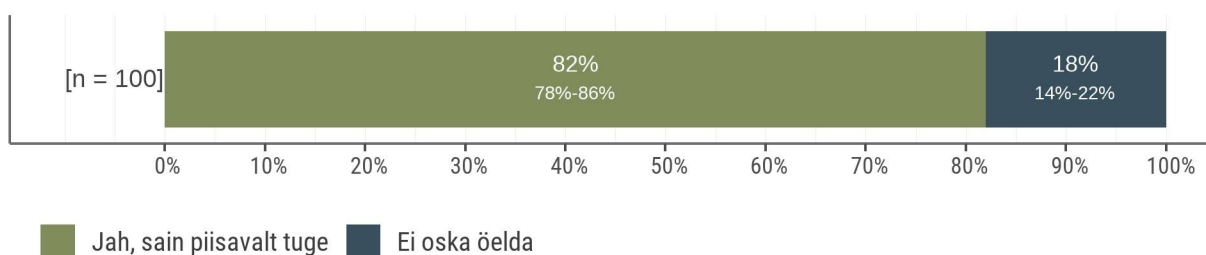
2.5 Support, self-care account, and DV e-course

DV is a complex issue that can affect both the safety and mental health of officers. In order to maintain health and the ability to work, it is important that specialists working with DV know how to manage their work consciously in a way that preserves their own and others' safety and health. To this end, MARAC has developed guidelines and organized training and currently offers DV e-training. It is possible to use self-care account options, and network members share experiences among themselves.

2.5.1 Assessment of adequacy of support

Most core group members feel that they have received enough support from core group members in their region over the past year to cope with their tasks in MARAC (see Figure 65). However, nearly a fifth of core group members cannot assess whether the support has been sufficient.

Figure 65. Distribution of core group members according to assessment of the adequacy of support to operate in MARAC from other core group members in the last 12 months



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

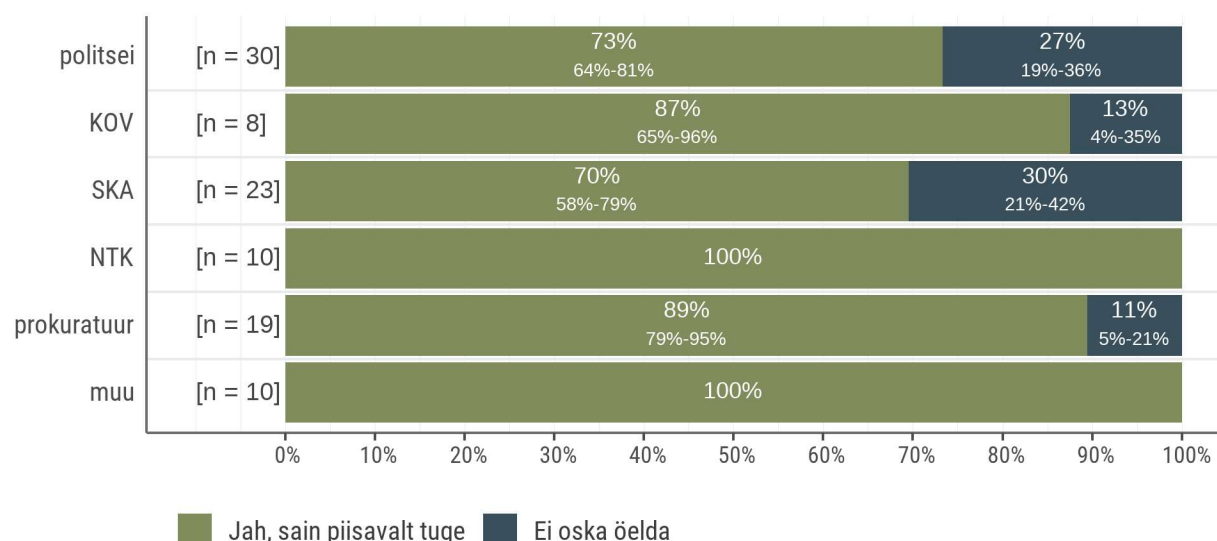
In the core groups of Lääne-Harju municipality, Tartu City, Hiiu County, Jõgeva County, and Lääne-Viru County, all members think that they have received enough support. In another core group, there is at least one member who cannot judge whether they received support. The survey data does not show everything, but one interviewee pointed out that in a small place, informal support of each other functions as a natural part of MARAC.

"If we take a big city or Tallinn or somewhere where the logic of MARAC structure is a little different than here, where we just get together sometimes to just talk, ventilate, so to speak, co-supervise each other. But there is probably no time and opportunity for that. We have the advantage that we can. We live here, we know each other, we can get together, maybe online, if necessary."

—(Representative of the SIB)

All interviewed representatives of the women's support centre and other agencies believe that they have received enough support (see Figure 66). Compared to other institutions, a smaller proportion of SIB and police representatives believe that they were supported sufficiently.

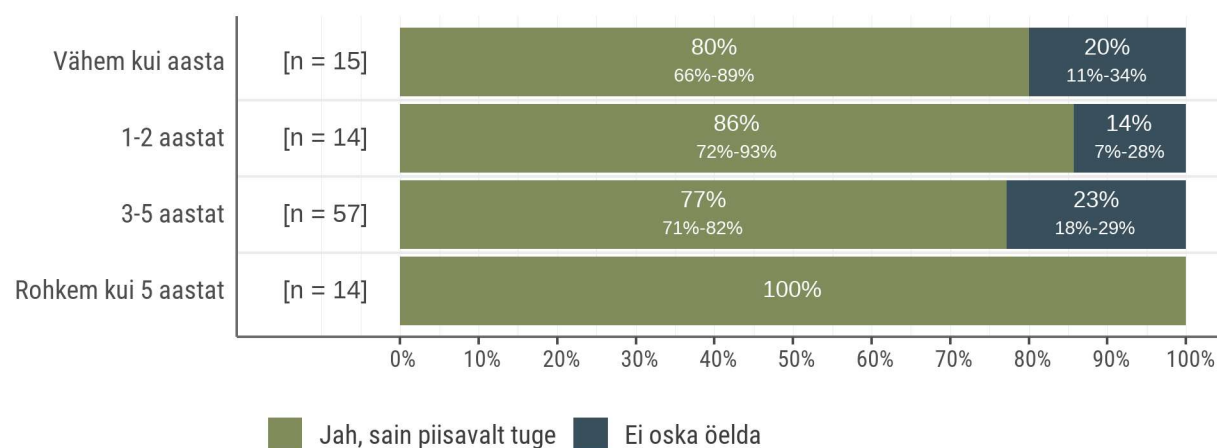
Figure 66. Distribution of members of the core group according to the assessment of the adequacy of support to operate in MARAC from other members of the core group during the last 12 months - by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

The assessment of the adequacy of the support depends on the length of service in MARAC. All of the members who have been active in MARAC for a long time (more than five years) stated that they received enough support. Among the members with less seniority, there are also those who cannot assess whether the support was sufficient (see Figure 67).

Figure 67. Distribution of members of the core group according to the assessment of the adequacy of support to operate in MARAC from other members of the core group during the last 12 months - by duration of operation



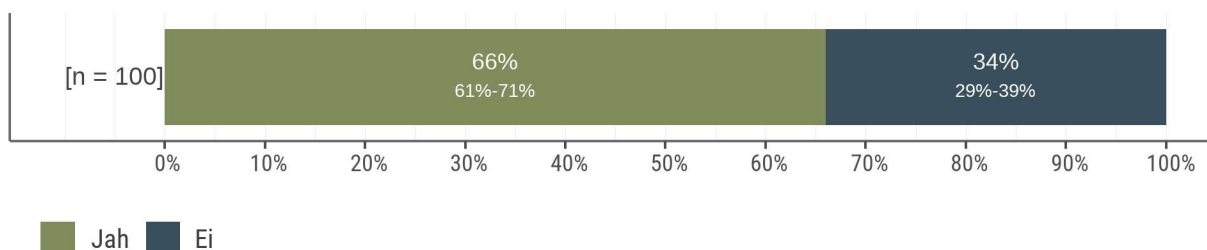
Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

2.5.2 Using a self-care account

The MARAC self-care account is a financial resource assigned to MARAC teams, which can be used for self-care activities such as core group supervision or co-vision, individual supervision, professional support, joint activities, etc.

Approximately two-thirds of the members of the core group have used the MARAC self-care account option during the last year (see Figure 68)

Figure 68. Breakdown of core group members according to whether they have used the MARAC self-care account option in the last 12 months (e.g., for group supervision, individual supervision, joint professional support activities)

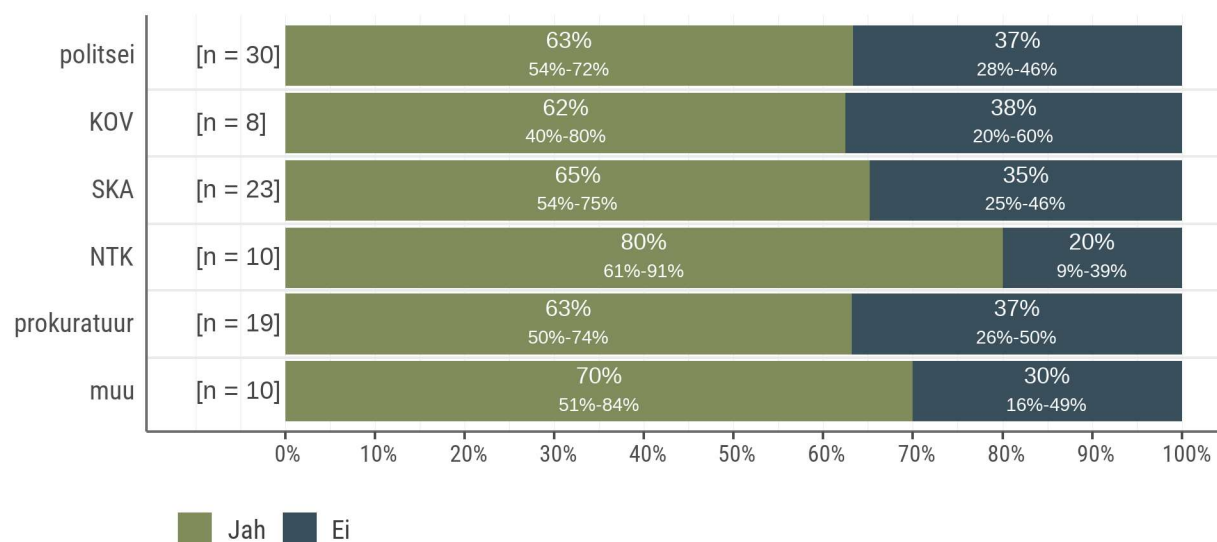


Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

In Tartu County and Järva County, all core group members have used the self-care account option. No one in Valga County has done this. In all other regions, some members of the core groups have used a self-care account.

Although, on average, a higher percentage of women's support centre employees have used a self-care account than representatives of other institutions (see Fig 69), the difference is not statistically significant (see confidence limits).

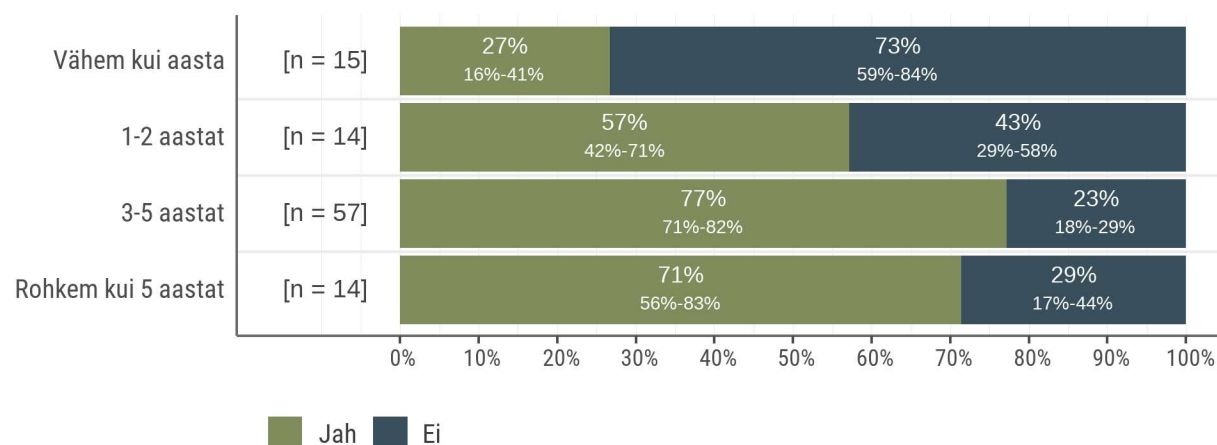
Figure 69. The proportion of core group members who have used the MARAC self-care account option in the last 12 months - by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Among those who have been active in MARAC for a longer time, there is a higher proportion of those who used a MARAC self-care account in the last 12 months compared to those who have been active in MARAC for a short time (see Fig. 70).

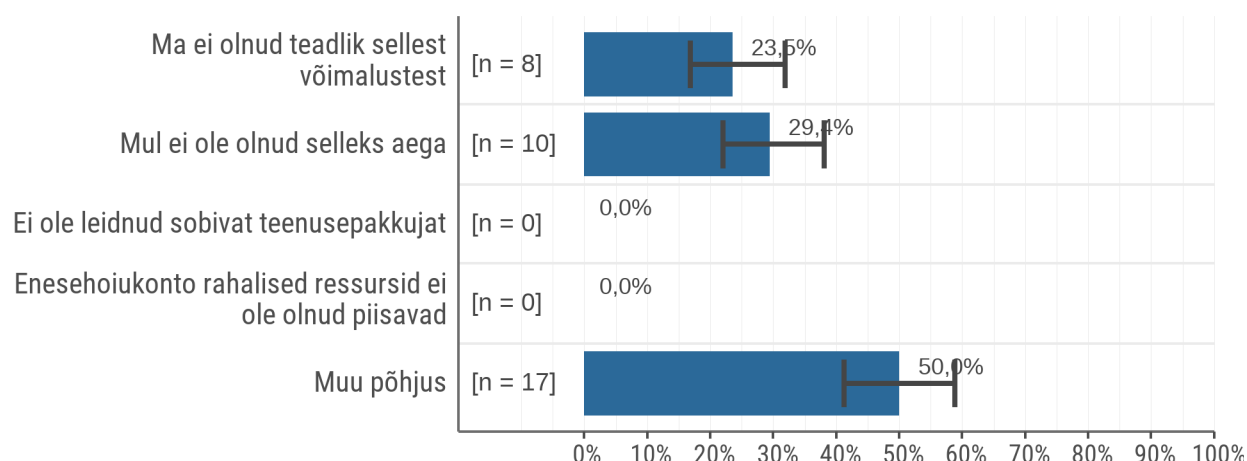
Figure 70. The proportion of core group members who have used the MARAC self-care account option in the last 12 months - by duration of operation



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

The reasons why the self-care account was not used are lack of time and ignorance of this possibility.

Figure 71. Share of members of the core group according to the reasons for which the MARAC self-care account has not been used (percentage of members who have not used the self-care account)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

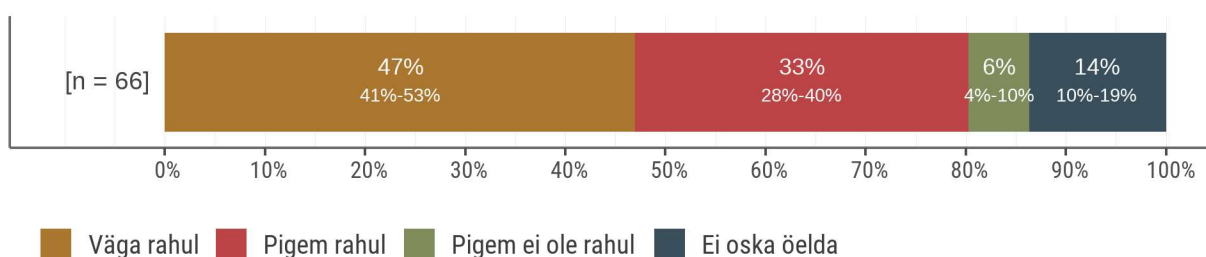
Other reasons cited for not using a self-care account were most often lack of need. Several respondents wrote that they have been with MARAC for a very short time and, therefore, have not yet used the self-care account options. In two cases, it was noted that the funding possibilities did not allow supervision to be organized. In the interviews, the lack of funding for organizing supervision was described both from the point of view that there was simply no funding and also from the point of view that not all costs are considered eligible.

"... for example, last year I planned ... supervision, and then it turned out that since it is project-based, it is financed from the project, then it turned out that it can't be done because there is no money to do this supervision. Now, I started planning again this year, and since it's a project-based story, it's not eligible; one activity is not eligible, and another is not. Third, if I want to do a two-day supervision, I can't because I have to do some kind of cooperation meeting or some kind of integration event. Well, I can't; it is not eligible... Maybe this has caused a little bit of indignation lately. Why would I do it if I'm told no? But it does not directly concern this method as such; the method is inherently good and cool, and intervention with it is efficient. ... The last information was even that there was catering, which is not eligible ... why set such strange frames? Well, then I wonder why I'm doing it if it's really my job to chew through this maze of projects, to go through this logomachy. This is perhaps the only small fly in the ointment."

—(Representative of the SIB)

The majority of self-care account users are very satisfied or rather satisfied with the possibilities of the self-care account.

Figure 72. Distribution of core group members who have used a self-care account according to satisfaction with MARAC's self-care account options (% of self-care account users)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Based on the interviews, everyone who participated in the supervision was satisfied with it. People who recently joined MARAC described the need to get to know other MARAC members better.

"Supervisor is very important. I remember one supervision in particular, where we actually had the topic of talking a little about what others don't know about you, and then we really got to know each other better. We got to know each other's backgrounds, who we are, and what we have done in life, and of course, I was able to surprise everyone the most with my background. It was a very cool supervision."

—(local government representative)

"with [name of Victim Support worker], that is, with Victim Support, communication has become way closer. But with other parties again, the thing is that I have no contact with them outside of MARAC. That I don't know them... Maybe it's not important at all, but I don't know them as people either. That, well, you get to know them there in the MARAC circle, you kind of pick up some information."

—(A person who has been active in MARAC for less than a year)

At the same time, it turned out that it did not suit at least one person who had participated in the co-vision.

"I don't remember the exact set of rules because I generally don't want to go to co-visions. And I've said many times during these co-visions, listen, what is the point of this co-vision? ... When I need a solution, I want to know the answers to all the questions, and I ask as many of those questions as I want. But if a case is taken in the process of co-vision, and I can't ask questions and get answers to them, and I can't express my opinion, then I'm not really solving the case. It's more of a joke for me. ... In short, yes, co-vision is not my cup of tea."

—(local government representative)

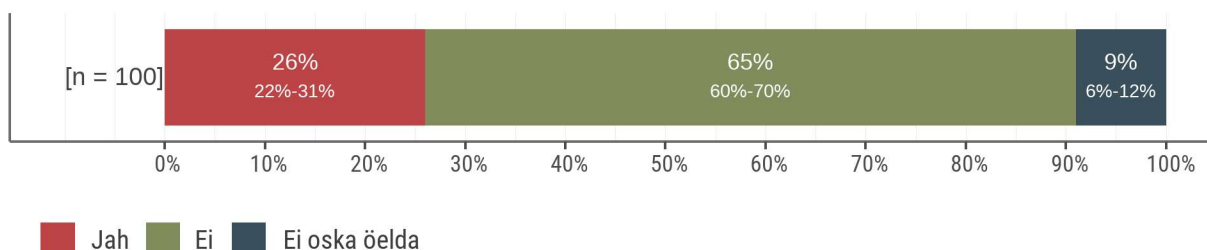
Overall, core members highly appreciate the supervision and support provided by other members at MARAC. A smaller percentage of new MARAC core group members have used a

self-care account than members who have been active in MARAC for a long time. Not all teamwork exercises are suitable for all professionals.

2.5.3 E-course on domestic violence

Less than a third of the members of the core group have completed the domestic violence e-course of Victim Support (see Figure (73)). None of the core group members from Järva County, Jõgeva County, and Võru County had completed the domestic violence e-course. At least one core group member from all other core groups has completed the DV e-course.

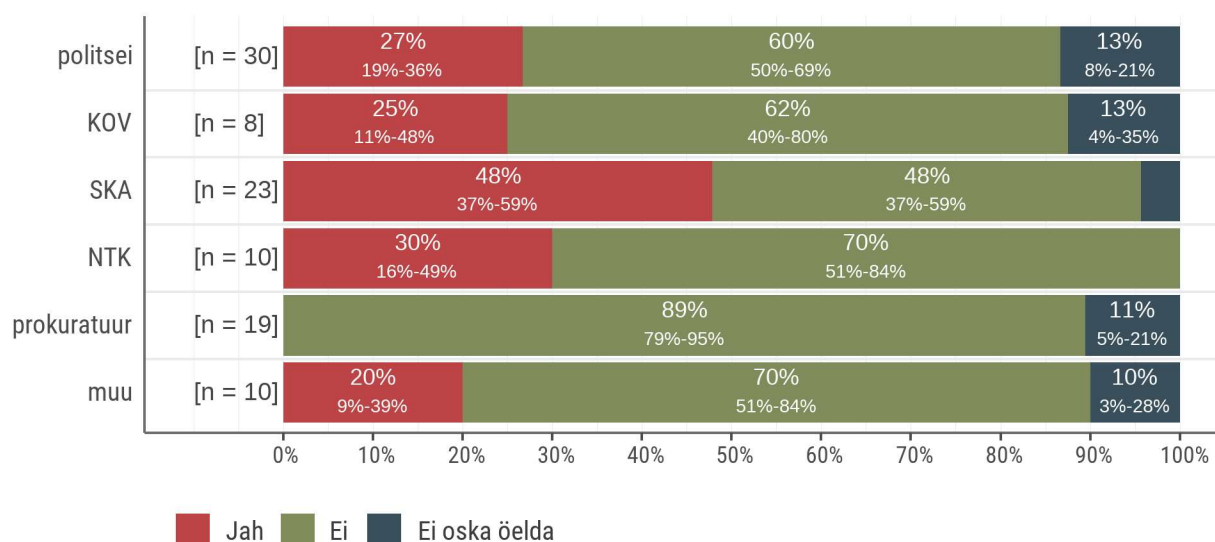
Figure 73. Distribution of members of the core group according to whether they have completed the e-course on domestic violence



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

According to the authorities, more SIB employees have completed the DV e-course, and not a single representative of the prosecutor's office has completed it. Some MARAC members from other agencies have completed the DV e-course, but there are more who have not completed the course.

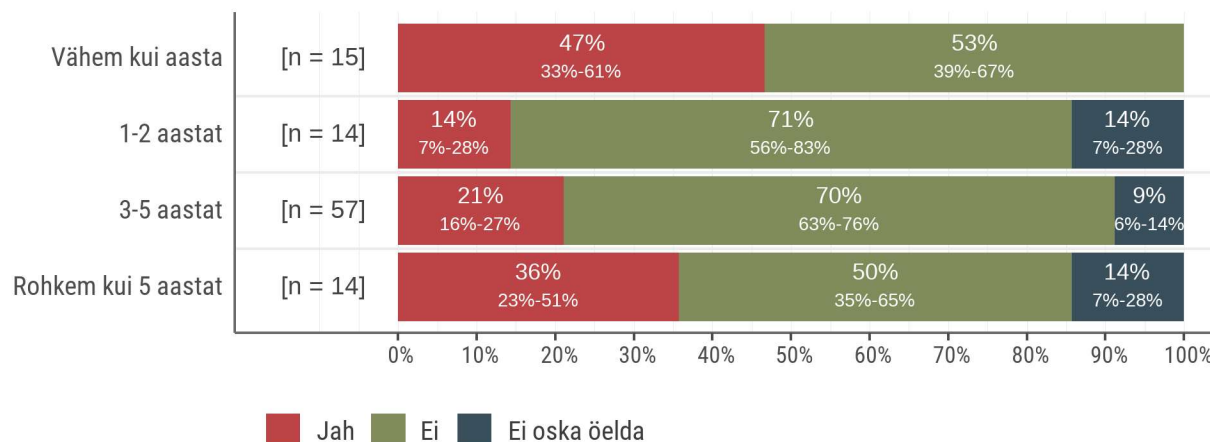
Figure 74. The proportion of members of the core group who have completed the e-course on domestic violence of Victim Assistance - by agency



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

More new MARAC members who have a short experience operating in MARAC have completed the DV e-course.

Figure 75. The proportion of members of the core group who have completed the e-course of Victim Support on Domestic Violence - by duration of activity in MARAC



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Overall, members of MARAC core groups have a variety of opportunities for support and knowledge, and for the most part, the support is highly valued. Particular emphasis should be placed on orienting new MARAC members who may initially be unfamiliar with the workings of MARAC, the type of support they require, and where to seek assistance.

2.6 Volunteers

2.6.1 Introduction

A volunteer is a person who provides victim support services in their time without any remuneration. The recruitment, training, and support of volunteers are managed by the SIB MARAC volunteer coordinator. However, volunteers are involved in MARAC cases by the regional SIB Victim Support worker in cooperation with the MARAC volunteer coordinator.

We collected data on the role and tasks of volunteers, work organization, and need for support and received support and satisfaction with surveys and interviews. In the following, we describe the volunteers and their role in MARAC, first summarizing the number of volunteers, their background, and the number of MARAC cases in which they are involved. We then describe the role of volunteers from the point of view of the MARAC manual, the members of the core group, and the volunteers themselves, and outline what problems are seen in the role of volunteers. We also describe more specifically the activities of the volunteers in the cases and the channels through which the volunteers communicate with the victim, how communication and information flow with the rest of the network is organized, how long it takes to deal with MARAC cases and how the volunteer succeeds in reconciling it with the rest of their life. Finally, we describe the volunteers' need for support while operating in MARAC and how they value the support they receive.

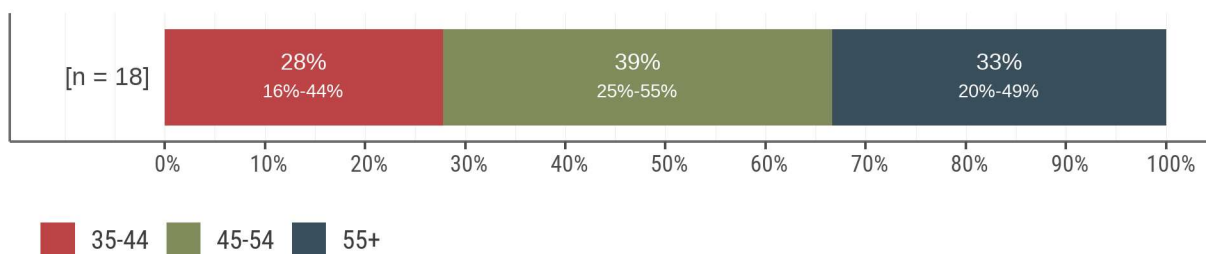
2.6.2 Number, background, and workload of volunteers at MARAC

Based on MARAC monitoring data, a volunteer was present in 112 cases, which is 23.2% of all cases (in the years 2019-2022) in which the volunteer's information was indicated with the case.

SIB has 64 trained contract volunteers, some of whom also act as WSC representatives in MARAC. Thirty-two volunteers have the experience of participating in the MARAC case. Three of them are WSC representatives. We included in the survey those volunteers who have MARAC experience and who are not simultaneously in the role of WSC representative. There were 29 people in total, and 18 volunteers answered the survey. The following analysis is based on the responses of the volunteers who answered the survey.

The average volunteer is a woman aged 50. There is one man among the volunteers. In the age distribution, there are quite equally people younger and older than the average (see Figure 76), but none of the volunteers who answered the survey were younger than 35 years old.

Figure 76. Distribution of volunteers by age groups



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

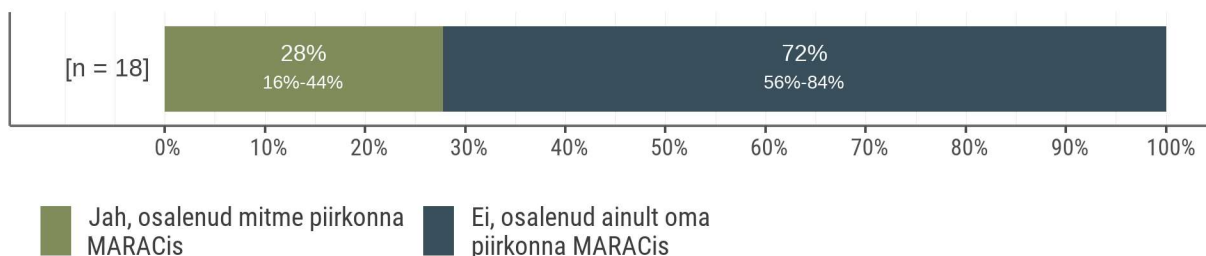
A large number of volunteers operate in Harju County, the region with the largest population in Estonia. Among the respondents to the survey, in addition to Harju County, there were at least a few volunteers who worked in the following regions:

- City of Tartu
- Jõgeva
- Lääne-Viru County
- Pärnu
- Põlva
- Valga
- Võru

No volunteers responded about other MARAC regions (i.e., Tartu County, Järva County, Lääne County, Rapla County, Saare County, Viljandi County, and Ida-Viru County), which may mean that there are no volunteers in these regions or volunteers of these regions simply did not respond to the survey.

The activity of several MARAC volunteers is not limited to the core group of their own region, i.e., several are ready to act and do act on MARAC cases in different regions.

Figure 77. The proportion of volunteers who have participated in the MARAC of several different regions



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

The volunteer's area in which they operate is formed according to the volunteer's own definition. Volunteers usually define the region based on their place of residence, but there are also volunteers who are ready to contribute in counties close to their place of residence or all over Estonia.

"My experience is that you usually meet face-to-face once or twice. The first meeting should be face-to-face, but nowadays, a lot of communication takes place either by phone or through other channels, so yes, this region is important in some sense; I really wouldn't go to South Estonia for a meeting from here."

—(A volunteer)

"I got my first client from a completely different region because there is none in my region [name of the region]. I have no contact with such cases, and they are not active. ... [region of the residence] is not far, so I got a client instead from [name of the area where the volunteer operates on a case]."

—(a volunteer)

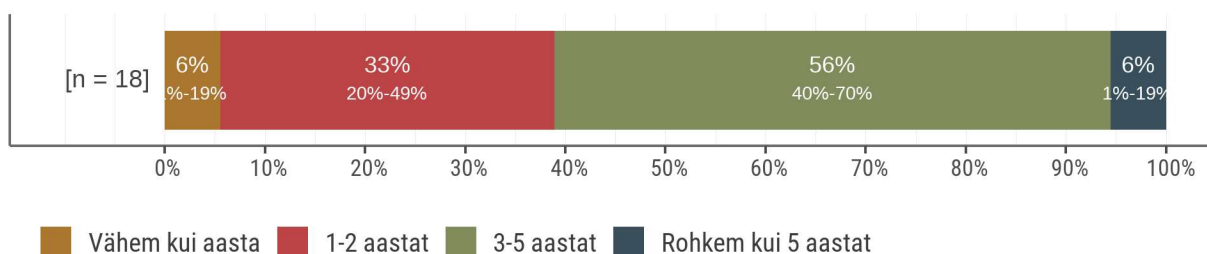
Thus, there are situations where no cases are offered to the volunteer in the area of their operation, and therefore, the volunteer operates in another area. However, there are areas where there are very few or no volunteers.

"as far as I know, in our region. There are probably two of them, maybe even three. In fact, the tendency in our region is that everyone rather thinks about themselves, and in order to contribute in some way, and it is completely voluntary, you don't get any kind of reward for it. Some kind of support and joint activities, yes, they are there to keep this team of volunteers. But there is nothing really tangible like that, which is what people in our area would want, I think. This is also the reason why we have so few volunteers."

—(representative of the WSC)

Most of the volunteers were recruited to MARAC many years ago, while some volunteers have joined MARAC recently (see Fig 78).

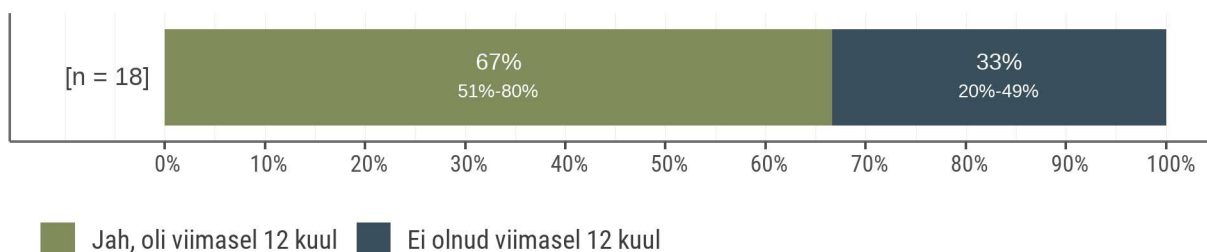
Figure 78. Distribution of volunteers by years of activity



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

All respondents to the survey have had a history of MARAC, as the survey sample was drawn from volunteers who had a history of MARAC cases. Almost two-thirds of the volunteers had at least one case of MARAC in the past year. The remaining volunteers were split in half, with the last incident in 2022 and 2021.

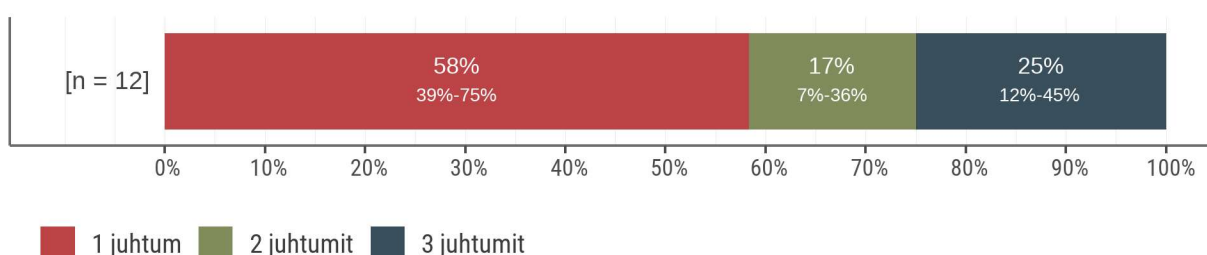
Figure 79. Distribution of volunteers according to whether they had a case of MARAC in the past 12 months



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

Volunteers have typically (in almost half of cases) been involved in one MARAC case in the past 12 months, but some volunteers had two or three cases.

Figure 80. Distribution of volunteers with cases by the number of MARAC cases in the last 12 months



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

The reasons why a volunteer had no cases in the past year are different. On the one hand, there are situations where there are no cases to offer to the volunteer, or the Victim Support worker does not know how to use the volunteer's help. On the other hand, the volunteer may not have the time and opportunity, or the chosen volunteer may not be suitable for the victim in a particular case. According to the survey, volunteers who had no cases were divided into two: half were not offered cases, and half did not have time to take a case. In the interviews, the volunteers and one of the core group members described situations where the victim or their need for help was not compatible with a particular volunteer. Incompatibility can result from the amount of time and opportunities the volunteer has, as well as from the (in)compatibility of the volunteer and the victim based on other characteristics.

"then they [the volunteer] didn't have the opportunity for physical meetings, but I needed the person to be there, not often, not every day, but more or less as a support, not only by phone."

—(SIB)

"if there were few volunteers, there were moments in the region where it was not possible to find the right support person, I emphasize, right in the sense that, as I said, not everything suits everyone."

—(SIB)

"there was a male victim, seventy years old, ... the woman was violent both mentally, mainly mentally, but also physically ... we also got to the point, can you imagine if I go to meet this man, right, as a woman. It would even kind of amplify it. ...there are probably not many Russian-speaking support persons, let alone a Russian-speaking man and ideally an older one as well."

—(A volunteer, female)

Overall, the average volunteer is a 50-year-old woman who has had one case of MARAC in the past year. Finding volunteers with a suitable profile for all MARAC cases is not easy with the current volunteer composition. The interviewees noted that there is especially a shortage of male volunteers who can speak Russian.

2.6.3 The role of volunteers

MARAC guidelines define a volunteer as part of the Victim Support service, and their role is described as follows: "If necessary, the victim is supported by a volunteer who is in constant contact with the victim of violence during the implementation of the security plan, advises and guides them and offers psychological support."

In the volunteer chapter of the MARAC manual, the volunteer's duties are listed as follows:

1. Supporting the victim in the implementation of the MARAC security plan
 - Encouraging and supporting the victim, including providing psychosocial support, to help cope with difficult situations; assistance in finding alternatives to facilitate coping; encouraging the victim to stick to a daily routine; support in seeking help (for example, of a professional counsellor); binding one's own support to an already existing support network; providing

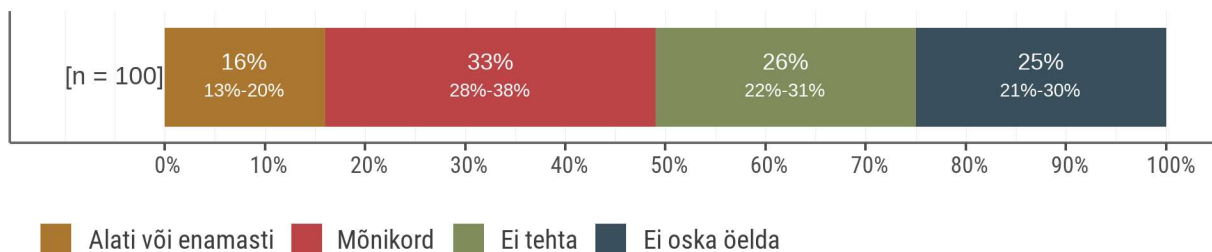
information so that the victim is aware of the options and can make fact-based decisions about the next steps.

- Attending network roundtables (including MARAC meetings) and agency meetings, representing the victim and the victim's needs.
2. Providing support in the procedural process
- preparing the victim for meetings with representatives of the authorities, a court hearing, or meeting an investigator (describing the procedure, explaining the roles of the officials, explaining what will be asked, for example, at the meeting with the investigator in the court or with the proceedings authority, what needs to be discussed, etc.);
 - assisting in communication with various institutions to help and protect the victim, if necessary, accompanying the victim in dealing with authorities.

In addition, the MARAC manual states that if necessary, the volunteer offers help and information to the victim's family members and/or other loved ones.

The core members had relatively little experience with volunteers and little awareness of the practical involvement of volunteers (see Fig 81). Almost half of the core group members indicated that volunteers are not involved in MARAC cases in their area, or they do not know if they are.

Figure 81. Distribution of core group members by assessment of the frequency of involvement of volunteers in MARAC cases over the past 12 months



Source: A survey of MARAC core group members.

At the same time, all the members of the core groups of Hiiu County, Järva County, Jõhvi, Narva, and Rapla were of the common opinion that volunteers are either not involved or they are not aware of the involvement of volunteers. On the other hand, in the core groups of Lääne-Harju municipality, Lääne-Viru County, and Saare County, all members found that volunteers are either always or mostly involved. In all other core groups (Ida-Harju, Tartu City and Tartu County, Jõgeva County, Lääne County, Pärnu County, Põlva County, Valga County, Viljandi County and Võru County), at least one core group member answered that volunteers are always, mostly or sometimes included and at least one did not know about the involvement of volunteers. Several interviewed core group members also did not recall cases where volunteers were involved, and the role of volunteers was discussed rather hypothetically. Also, some members of the core groups considered the volunteers to be SIB Victim Support services, which is why they also saw their role only through Victim Support and not as case-based specialists in the network.

"I am not so familiar with it that I could judge. I know a couple of people who they are, and for example, I went to child protection with one of my clients, I met a volunteer there, or I mean, really, there was a victim's assistant there, who took the volunteer with them and offered it to a woman."

—(WSC)

"I don't dare to say anything very specific right now. I don't remember, but I think it looks like a familiar word to me."

—(Prosecutor)

"We didn't have them [volunteers], and there haven't been... I haven't encountered them much, and somehow, I have no answer to this question."

—(SIB)

The members of the core groups described and understood the possible role of volunteers similarly to the tasks described in the MARAC guidelines:

1. Volunteers offer psychosocial support, primarily involving attentive listening and serving as an essential conduit for social communication.

"women most of the time, well, let's say the most difficult cases are that women are usually isolated, they don't have a social network to communicate with, and then maybe really the support person is the only one with whom she might be in constant contact, like instead of a girlfriend. They have no friends or family. Maybe they do, but they have been prohibited to communicate with them for years."

—(Prosecutor)

"the victim may not have, let's say, some kind of support network outside of their life, where they need this support or, well, not like encouraging learned helplessness, but, for example, to be a pusher there, such a pusher, and that, for example, in the case of one victim, I just had a volunteer next to them. That they would reach certain authorities."

—(SIB)

"it's some kind of peer support person, and I understand that those people who have gone through all this themselves or, as I understand it, these volunteers, they can also share their experience."

—(SIB)

"in some cases, the client simply needs support. Just knowing that the client has someone who they contact or who contacts them regularly, and maybe they can complain to that someone, that maybe there is nothing more to be done in this story, but that support is there, they support them."

—(SIB)

2. the volunteer helps the victim by advising on affairs and explaining situations

"not to do things for them, but to support them in every way, to help them do these things themselves, to make their own decisions, and in this, the support person has a

very big role, help, especially if these processes go on for a long time in connection with some kind of custody rights battles, and then it is completely reasonable that sometimes, I know, the victim knows, I have a support person, I can always call them, always meet them, talk, calm down and so on."

—(Prosecutor)

"if a person is in shock, they need someone to repeat some very simple things to them, ... maybe explain the situation, that, well, the situation as well, ... they explain what the person has said, that other official..."

—(local government)

3. The volunteer accompanies the victim to various agencies,

"Let's say riding together with a victim on the bus and going through the door of the court, and that maybe could be the role of a volunteer."

—(Prosecutor)

"Volunteers could perhaps help these relatively vulnerable victims in the sense that, if necessary, they could go to the authorities somewhere and fill out some papers and encourage them and give some information. For example, demanding child support is also a part of the fact that if it is still about divorce, these volunteers give advice, accompany, advise, enforce, encourage."

—(local government)

4. A volunteer is an assistant or substitute for a Victim Support worker

"After all, we have fixed working hours. And sometimes it is necessary for a [volunteer], for example, to support the victim outside of working hours because the victim cannot run between authorities alone. Well, this is also to reduce our burden."

—(SIB)

In the cases of the four interviewed volunteers, their main task in practice was to provide psychosocial support. The content of the work consisted of regularly talking to the person by phone, listening to the person, and advising or supporting them in completing practical matters.

"My role is to be a confidant, a support person or a confidant. Because during the time that she lived in such a violent family model, in a violent family, the abuser usually is a man, but there are exceptions. He cuts the woman off from her relatives and her friends, right, and in fact, she is only in her small home circle, maybe also in her work circle, but she doesn't communicate with anyone outside, which means she loses all contact with both friends and relatives. She has to start recreating them. I think that I will be her confidant until she restores these contacts, even at least one person." ... Psychosocial help - we have agreed on this: I will not solve all kinds of legal and other problems for her. I am the one who is taken along, who gives psychosocial first aid."

—(A volunteer)

"my specific support was going through the divorce process. At first, it seemed that the victim had decided that she was going to file for divorce, and then we looked into

how to do that. But then it turned out that this abuser in prison filed for divorce themselves. Since the victim, or my client, is a Russian person who does not speak Estonian, I also helped her translate the court documents and understand the matter, and in this process, the divorce took effect. After that, the victim has become a bit passive, so the next step should now be to apply for sole custody of the child."

—(A volunteer)

"I support, motivate or even inspire; I simply offer support and maybe sometimes also take some concrete steps like now do this or don't do this or try this and that ... maybe in some uncertain moment offer the certainty so that they would stick to their position or the principles given in MARAC. If to give specific examples here, if they have been advised not to communicate with their partner, then to support in that, like if sometimes they feel like sending a message or if they get messages from there again, so that they could stick to their decisions, sometimes they just need that kind of support."

—(A volunteer)

Broadly speaking, the above description of the role of both the core groups and the volunteers corresponds to that given in the MARAC guidelines. More specifically, the MARAC guidelines state that a volunteer may be assigned upon referral to MARAC, and the volunteer is identified as a possible actor in the following stages and roles:

- Background investigation - background information about violence is collected from the victim either by the specialist who performed the risk assessment (in case they remain the victim's main contact person), an employee of SIB Victim Support, or **a volunteer**.
- Meeting - the victim or their **representative (volunteer)** shares information from them or the victim's point of view.
- Monitoring and follow-up evaluation

None of the interviewed volunteers had contributed to the collection of the victim's background information when referring the victim to MARAC. All were assigned to support the victim either during or after the MARAC case. In the post-MARAC activities, the role of the volunteer was not to follow up or monitor the victim but rather to act as a psycho-social counsellor and encourage the completion of legal proceedings. Interviews with volunteers revealed that volunteers define their role as psychosocial supporters and try to draw a clear distinction between counselling, which requires specific knowledge and skills, and the general task of Victim Support.

" I personally see my role as more of an advisor or supporter. Although I also have a background in law, so to speak, I have studied it, and if really needed, I can be of support in this, but I am not. In that sense, anyway, I'm more like, as a support person, I feel that it's necessary to hold the victim's hand there in court, right? But I rather see myself, yes, as an advisory or enforcing person."

—(A volunteer)

"but a volunteer, the way we have been trained. After all, we have been trained only to provide psychosocial first aid, which means that it is the most important thing

when a person suffers psycho-trauma; there are some accidents... Actually, I have a medical education. We are not trained to do more than that, and the rest of the skills we have are the skills we have acquired over the course of our lives. Officially, we only have psychosocial first aid, right? There is no other training in this sense, and we are not therapists, we are not counsellors, we are only listeners, right?

—(A volunteer)

Based on the interviews given by volunteers, they feel differently about to what extent and how the volunteer's role in MARAC is to represent the victim, provide an overview of their situation, and inform the rest of the core group. There were volunteers who saw that their role was only to provide support to the victim, and since the victim chooses what information and to what extent to share with the volunteer, the volunteer cannot represent the victim in the MARAC network or provide an overview of the victim's situation to the rest of the network.

"I think rather not the introducer of the victim's point of view, because, well, ... the victim shares with me exactly what they want to share. ... I cannot say that I am the representative of the victim."

—(A volunteer)

"I can, and we can talk to the social worker with the client's consent. The client is allowed to say yes... But it all has to happen with the client's consent. No reports of any kind about the client's situation, we are not allowed to give them."

—(A volunteer)

On the other hand, there was a volunteer who saw differently from the others that representing the victim at the MARAC meeting is the volunteer's role because, for the victim herself, participation in the meeting, despite MARAC's victim-centred approach, can have a re-victimizing effect.

"a person is invited to a meeting at the table in MARAC, so to speak, that we talk and then we all bombard you, so to speak. Perhaps I myself would not want to be in this role, thinking that I am broken, so to speak, and then I go in front of strangers, yes,... it should be through a support person, that is, the support person is their voice, so to speak, who then sits there at the meeting, acts on behalf of them, so to speak."

—(A volunteer)

In practice, such a solution currently works in the development of the volunteer role, that the role and tasks of the volunteer, depending on the context and the case, are agreed upon in each specific case.

"We describe our need, our vision, so recently we have been trying to it this way, not just call that we have a volunteer, but also organize a meeting with the victim, where we introduce to her, where we discuss things, identify important moments and why this person is placed next to her."

—(SIB)

"The MARAC coordinator described it a bit, and then I probably kept in touch with this victim's support a few times to see what the goal is, what we want to achieve with this person, and what my role is."

—(A volunteer)

Direct examples of practice where the volunteer's role was unclear did not emerge in the interviews. However, as a more general trend, one volunteer pointed out that there has been a problem that volunteers do not always know exactly what their role is. Since 2023, a uniform practice has been implemented, where when a volunteer is involved, a meeting of three parties (Victim Support, volunteer, and victim) takes place, during which, among other things, the role of the volunteer and the needs of the victim are specified. The use of such a practice should eliminate the described role confusion of volunteers in the future.

"the fault is or where it seems to be missing... the support person does not know what to do, whether to go to the store with them or to enforce, or you have to listen to them. What is the purpose of the matter? They need to be supported, to be there for them. That's the goal, isn't it? Maybe it is to help with the divorce papers, for example. The tasks should be specific and clear to this support person."

—(A volunteer)

The practical examples of volunteer work presented in the interviews were all such that the role of the volunteer was agreed upon in each specific case, and the volunteer provided it mainly as psychosocial support to the victim. In terms of the help given in specific cases, the volunteers did not have a question as to what their role was. More generally, however, many feel that the boundaries between the roles of Victim Support, psychologist, and possibly other counsellors and volunteers are not quite clear. Therefore, it would be necessary to make it clearer where the role of the volunteer lies among all the other professionals dealing with the case.

"I myself don't quite understand that there is a Victim Support worker, then there is a volunteer, right, and the victim can, so to speak, call everyone and complain about their concerns, and then everyone has to support them ... I would try to clarify this role a bit more because sometimes it seems to me that this Victim Support worker has too much..., well, they have different topics and they could not or should not be in the role of a psychological counsellor or support person if the victim has a psychologist or the victim has a support person, right? Moreover, all other agencies that are dealing with her. Or, if it is important, that there is also a Victim Support worker, isn't there, who actually supports, that sometimes it is unclear to me, why am I here to begin with."

—(A volunteer)

"Often, I have understood that this Victim Support worker is a support person with whom they have already established contact. ... perhaps it also depends on the Victim Support worker as a person. That you can say stop, that this is where the role of the support person begins, that my topic ends here... roughly speaking, the limit seems to be here."

—(A volunteer)

Such a situation, where there are many advisers and counsellors, can cause confusion in the opinion of the volunteers and core group members as to who to turn to and with which question (see similar sense of role overlap among core group members in chapter Roles of core group members).

"Sometimes the victim doesn't even understand that they can just as well call the Victim Support worker; why should they call the support person, right? It's just that at what point should I call whom? About once a week, I report to the Victim Support worker, and once a week, I report to the support person."

—(A volunteer)

In several cases, it was pointed out that the volunteer's role in practice must be adjusted based on the presence of the Victim Support worker and other supporters and the help they provide.

"they went there once a week or once in two weeks, regular visits to a psychologist, right... I was there just for when it's really difficult, and they need to talk to someone, right, so they would just call."

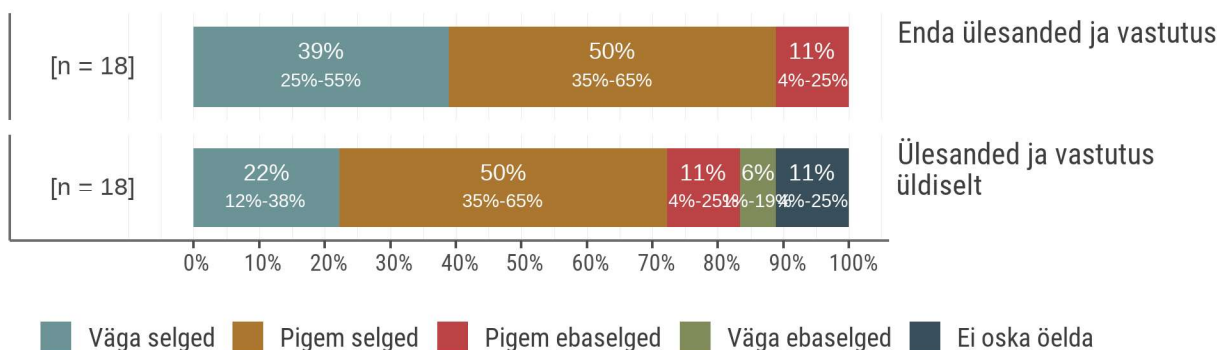
—(A volunteer)

"Perhaps this service should be designed in a way where when they come, for example, or call the Victim Support Service, they go to the Victim Support person, and from there, they receive counselling services. Then, they come to MARAC and are evaluated. Let this Victim Support worker remain like that to them, so to speak, because they have told them the whole story already. They don't want to talk to the support person anymore, and they don't need to talk to the support person. A support person would be there to listen to the story again, but we don't know what to do; rather, just be there."

—(A volunteer)

Despite some examples of role confusion, volunteers generally feel that their own roles and the roles and responsibilities of the regional MARAC members are clear. There are only a few people for whom tasks and responsibilities seem unclear (see Fig 82). The new procedure implemented in 2023, according to which all involvement of volunteers is preceded by a tripartite meeting between Victim Support, the volunteer, and the victim, could further increase role clarity.

Figure 82. Distribution of volunteers according to how clearly the volunteer assesses the tasks and responsibilities of the MARAC members to be in the region in general



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

Overall, the role of volunteers is broadly in line with the MARAC guidelines. In practice, the role of volunteers is limited to the provision of psychosocial support, but since counselling and psychological support are also offered through other agencies and members of the MARAC network, the line between the volunteer role and the roles of other counsellors is somewhat blurred. The majority of volunteers are clear about the roles of MARAC network members as well as their own role in solving a specific case. The placement of the role of volunteers within the wider MARAC system is somewhat confusing. Volunteers are not members of MARAC core groups (except in exceptional cases when a specialist who is a core group member also does volunteer work in MARAC) but represent their own institution in the network when planning resources and services. Therefore, the question arises whether volunteers can be treated as case-based specialists in the MARAC system, whether the volunteer is rather a representative of the victim in MARAC, or whether the volunteer's role is narrowly limited to providing psychosocial support services in SIB Victim Support.

2.6.4 Work organization and workload of volunteers at MARAC

2.6.4.1 Frequency and channels of communication between the volunteer and the victim

Interviewed volunteers described the organization of work in providing support to the victim mainly as one or two meetings at the beginning of the case, followed by (regular) telephone conversations. The initial physical meeting was considered important in order to establish a trusting relationship between the victim and the volunteer and to agree on what kind of help and in what form the volunteer would provide. Several volunteers noted that it is difficult for the victim to trust a stranger, and the first face-to-face meeting helps to overcome this. In some cases, the possibility of a physical meeting during the entire period is considered important, and it also determines the suitability of the volunteer and the victim, but not all volunteers can offer help in this way.

"Actually, this phone thing really bothers us, and it's not a very good option. My client would need face-to-face communication.... In fact, they would need, they are a person who needs another person, and sometimes, maybe we even say, a hand on the shoulder

or, say, a physical touch or knowing that someone has their back. They need it to see a person because the times we have met, I understand that they actually need it and that they have quite a significant lack of closeness or human contact."

—(A volunteer)

Regular phone conversations are a practice for all volunteers. The calls usually take place at an agreed time with an interval of one or two weeks.

"Well, this contact could be like once a week or something like that in the beginning, definitely for an hour or two or something, to understand what's going on."

—(A volunteer)

" with one, we had an agreement that on Tuesday at such and such time."

—(A volunteer)

If necessary, additional interview times are arranged, or depending on the agreement, the victim can also call a volunteer if they deem it necessary. However, one volunteer had an example of a situation where the victim called at a time when the volunteer was unable to answer. To avoid such a situation, it is always recommended to agree on the rules of contact for regular communication and crisis situations or for irregular communication.

"in the beginning, they also called me at night. And I don't remember if they texted or called. Sometimes, we have an agreement that if you call at any time that I can't answer, I'll call you back or send a message when I can call you. These agreements are usually made in the beginning. But in this first case, it was also a learning moment for me, and when they called at night, I did not hear the phone. And then, when I looked in the morning, there was a missed call, then there was a message that you see, you promised you would be there for me, but you're not, aren't you? I had to go through all these processes for myself, think it through, and, so to speak, be smarter in the future. So you agree that you can send a message, but sometimes I can also happen to be sleeping, for example. Or I'll be working, so you can let me know when I can call you."

—(A volunteer)

Whether the contact is made by the volunteer or the victim depends on the agreements and the situation. There are cases where the caller is usually a volunteer, and there are cases where the victim is the caller.

"one of these people doesn't call, even though they could, and we just have an agreement with the Victim Support worker that I won't call them myself because it's not such an extreme case; they have to deal with child protection, and all the things themselves."

—(A volunteer)

Since the volunteer's central job is communicating with the victim over the phone, it is important for it to be convenient. All volunteers pointed out the inconvenience of using the Nokia button phone given to them by the SIB Victim Support service as a work tool. In order

to communicate by phone, volunteers have introduced phones with two SIM cards or e-SIM, which allow them to dispense with a special phone used for volunteering and to carry two phones with them. However, not all volunteers have yet developed such a solution for themselves and are tied to an inconvenient button phone and two phones.

"Actually, I haven't solved it myself, but another volunteer told me that they put another SIM card in their phone. I haven't looked into it yet, and maybe I can do the same so that it would be easier for me otherwise carrying and charging with two phones separately, and it's a real headache that I have to somehow solve it myself."

(A volunteer)

One volunteer pointed out the need to create social media and electronic communication channels in order to be in contact with the victims. Since younger people call on the phone less and less often, and the usual communication has moved to social media channels, it would be important to create appropriate communication channels to support the younger target groups.

"But there could certainly be other communication channels these days. For example, one of my clients was a young person who wanted to communicate more via Messenger. And then I had this Nokia phone, but it was already very difficult to send messages from that number, right? You have to tap each key several times, and so on. She sent me a message very often and wrote everything down there, and then I typed back the message. I did feel that there was a need for a Messenger, especially for the younger generation. But I couldn't do it under my own name. Probably. But there could be a solution."

—(A volunteer)

All volunteers pointed out the need to keep their personal information secret and emphasized that they do not share their personal information with the victims. At the same time, they had negative examples from the experience of others, which in turn strengthened their sense of the need to protect personal data.

"As a volunteer, I don't share my messenger or my personal contacts for security reasons, right? So not so much for the victim, but for the perpetrator, that I know there has been at least one case in MARAC just like, where on social media and from social media, I don't know, I don't remember if even the account was taken over or whatever then by the abuser, right? In order to protect your children and yourself, you are more concerned about your children, right? So that I do not share."

—(A volunteer)

In summary, the volunteer usually communicates regularly with the victim by telephone. A physical meeting is arranged, if the situation allows, at the beginning of the case. As a modern means of communication, it would be important to create a safe way for the volunteer and the victim to communicate via social media and to introduce all volunteers to modern options to avoid the need to use two phones at the same time.

2.6.4.2 The volunteer's contact with Victim Support and the MARAC network

The volunteers' tasks and the cases they contribute come through the SIB Victim Support worker. SIB's Victim Support worker offers a case to a volunteer if they see that it might benefit the victim. The volunteer agrees or disagrees according to their own possibilities. During the case, contact with the Victim Support worker may become more frequent or less frequent, depending on the specific person and the case.

"Basically, I should communicate with the Victim Support worker when I have problems. But we have current information, and we get current information in such a way that the Victim Support worker herself asks me, writes how it is going, and what the situation is. And then I have written to her. About what the situation is. So I do not have this obligation; it has not been agreed that I should report on an ongoing basis."

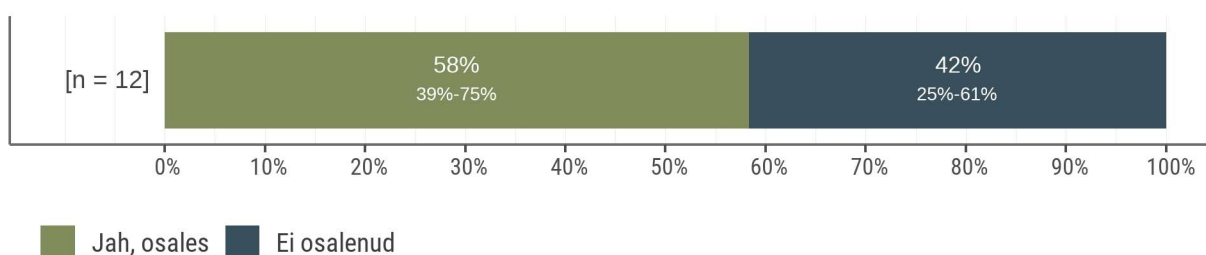
—(A volunteer)

"Actually, there is no regular contact [with the Victim Support worker]. In fact, it is that I am given this case, and then I get the case, so to speak, I get my phone or my number. And then, if I have any questions related to a specific case, I can turn to them."

—(A volunteer)

In general, the information related to the case goes to the volunteer through the Victim Support worker; the volunteer has no direct contact with other members of the core group. Information flows from them, if at all, either through a Victim Support worker or through MARAC meetings. About half of those volunteers who had a MARAC case in the last year have attended MARAC meetings (see Figure 83).

Figure 83. Breakdown of volunteers by whether they attended MARAC meetings in the last 12 months



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

The reasons why volunteers have not attended MARAC meetings are fairly evenly divided into the following categories: (1) the volunteer has not been invited to the meetings, (2) the volunteer has been unable to attend due to other daily life activities, and (3) other reasons. To elaborate on other reasons, MARAC volunteerism was mentioned after the active period of the MARAC case, when meetings no longer took place.

Volunteers' sense of whether their participation in the meeting is necessary varies. In the interviews, there was one clear example of a situation where the volunteer did not have

enough background information to support the victim, and in their opinion, participating in the meeting would have enabled them to get it.

"As a volunteer, perhaps participating in the meeting is necessary precisely because, for me, it has been the case that I have not received all the information before and when I sit there at the table, so to speak, or also online, while sitting at the table I even got most of the information. And also later there, I talked with the psychologist, who was, so to speak, a psychologist, wasn't he? So then I got some information from there, which was a surprise for me. And maybe I don't need to know everything. But for me, it also explained some of the attitudes of this victim towards, for example, a child protection worker or a psychologist. It was easier for me to understand the situation."

—(A volunteer)

In other cases, the interviewed volunteers had not participated in the meetings because the cases were at such a stage (ongoing support) that the meetings no longer took place or the volunteers were unable to participate due to their other obligations. According to the survey, the volunteers who participated in the meetings rated their role in the meeting as either very clear or rather clear. None of the volunteers rated their role in the meeting as completely unclear or rather unclear.

Volunteers had different views on what information they needed to support the victim. There was an interviewee who thought that the information that the victim shared with them was enough for them.

"as much as the client speaks, I don't get [more] information, which is good in itself because the less I know, the better. Yes, so that it doesn't leak anywhere, nobody can suspect me; if the client themselves speaks, that's their right."

—(A volunteer)

At the same time, there was an interviewee who believed that in order to provide efficient support, it is necessary to know the victim's background and their progress as a result of other measures determined through MARAC. At the same time, such information does not reach the volunteer sufficiently in practice, and therefore, the volunteer cannot act in the most effective way.

"I felt that this cooperation could be smoother and closer, that I could get information faster, precisely in the sense that if I want to be a support, but if there have been some kind of stories behind it, right, they have lied something or they don't spend the night where they actually have to spend the night and something is actually wrong with the kids or something like that, right, which they don't tell me themselves. I'm not saying that it would directly change my role, but maybe it would be easier for me, and maybe it would be easier for me to direct or support them in some places and maybe explain to them that maybe there is some child protection or there are so many of those officials there. I don't even know who they all are there, right? For example, in the case of this last person or this young person, the case was that they got this social housing, and then at some point, it turned out that they didn't actually stay there very much; their children were somewhere there in the children's centre, but in order for

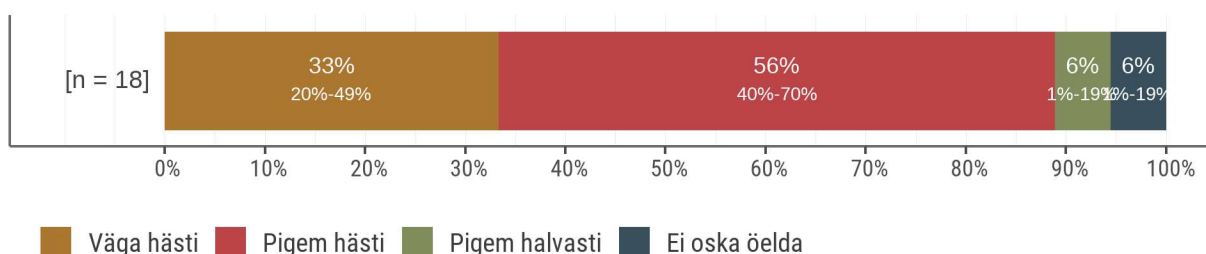
the client to keep this apartment, they have to spend the nights there, don't they; such nuances that I would definitely find out [about them]."

—(A volunteer)

2.6.4.3 Volunteer's working hours and combining activities with everyday life

Volunteers have chosen the volunteer work and workload themselves and have done so consciously. Therefore, there were no situations in the interviews where MARAC's activities interfered with a person's daily life. Generally, MARAC volunteers have flexible work schedules or other commitments that, with some planning, allow for a good combination of MARAC volunteer work. In instances where errors occurred, volunteers gained insights from these experiences and established clearer agreements for the future. According to the survey, the vast majority of volunteers find that they are able to reconcile MARAC activities and their daily lives well (see Figure 84).

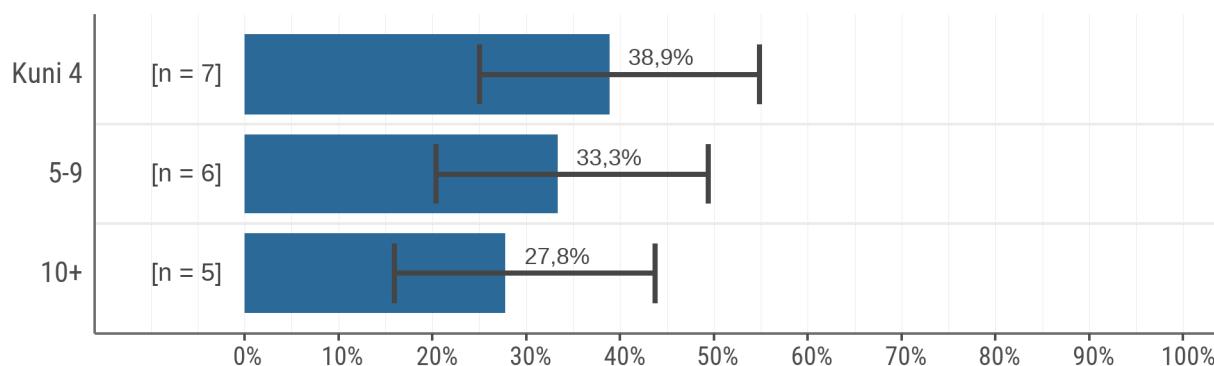
Figure 84. How well are you able to reconcile MARAC's activities with your daily life?



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

Volunteers estimate that they contribute varying hours of work time to cases in one month, from two hours to 50 hours. The average working time for different cases is 10.7 hours per month, but due to the high dispersion, it must be concluded that the cases of volunteers differ a lot from each other, and the estimated time spent on them also varies by dozens of times.

Figure 85. Breakdown of volunteers according to the average number of hours per month they spent working on the last MARAC case

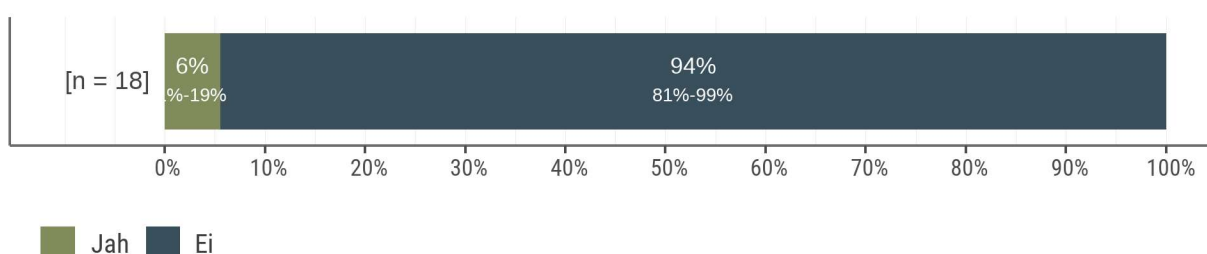


Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

2.6.4.4 Volunteers' assessment of MARAC work organization

In general, volunteers have not felt at risk when acting on MARAC cases. One of the volunteers who answered the survey had experienced a situation in which they felt threatened. In the interviews, the volunteers pointed out the importance of security and the principles they use to ensure their own security. Hiding personal contacts was mentioned as the main one. Ensuring security was considered important by all, and it has mostly been successful. At the same time, the occurrence of a dangerous situation shows that in order to ensure safety, the issue must be actively monitored and analyzed, as in what and how the situation arose, and the preparation of volunteers, the provision of support, and work processes must be improved.

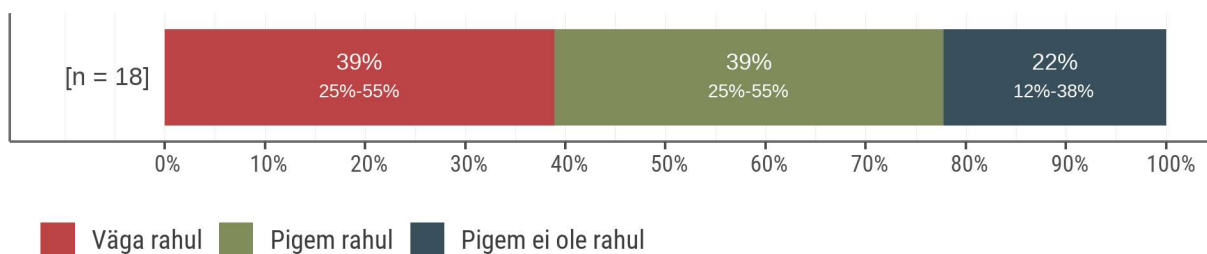
Figure 86. Distribution of volunteers according to whether they felt threatened by the perpetrator



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

The majority of volunteers are satisfied with the work organization of MARAC, but there are also some volunteers who are not satisfied (see Figure 87). Due to the small number of volunteers, it is difficult to find the relationship of dissatisfaction with other background characteristics. No clear correlations can be drawn with the workload in MARAC, participation in meetings, or clarity of tasks. Dissatisfaction is also not related to the intention to leave MARAC.

Figure 87. Distribution of volunteers according to satisfaction with the work organization of MARAC in their region



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

2.6.5 Volunteer development, support provided, training

All the volunteers working in MARAC have completed training before the start of volunteering, but several of them point out that during the activity, they gather important practical knowledge that cannot be acquired in training.

"Not everyone knows everything. A volunteer learns in the process. We can go through the training, but the real-life comes when you have to do something."

—(A volunteer)

Gaining practical experience is considered important, and several volunteers pointed out that the current workload and opportunity to contribute are too low. In addition to gaining practical experience and learning during volunteer work, it also helps to maintain motivation to volunteer. All volunteers want to contribute to the improvement of society, and if there is no application for this, the motivation also decreases. Also, what was learned in training is forgotten if it is not possible to apply it in practice.

"We have a lot of these volunteers; they are underutilized, but you can see. ... we get too little attention from those who enforce it. Maybe we use these volunteers too little because we have quite a lot of them who probably haven't received a single case."

—(A volunteer)

"That's why you have to keep these volunteers; how can you say... Really, that you can handle it and dare to take it on, that you've had, you've completed this training, and after all, volunteers should have some cases here and there. That's what people came there for. Otherwise, it's just that the momentum passes, so to speak, and you'll get scared that maybe you can't do it or what you do or say is wrong."

—(A volunteer)

"The volunteers of MARAC complain that they have come here to help but that they have not really succeeded."

—(A volunteer)

Only those volunteers who have MARAC experience, i.e., who have volunteered for support in at least one case, participated in the MARAC survey. It should be taken into account that there are also volunteers who have not had any cases. Among volunteers with MARAC experience who took part in the survey, the perceived workload in MARAC is low, and many volunteers have looked for other places to contribute as volunteers.

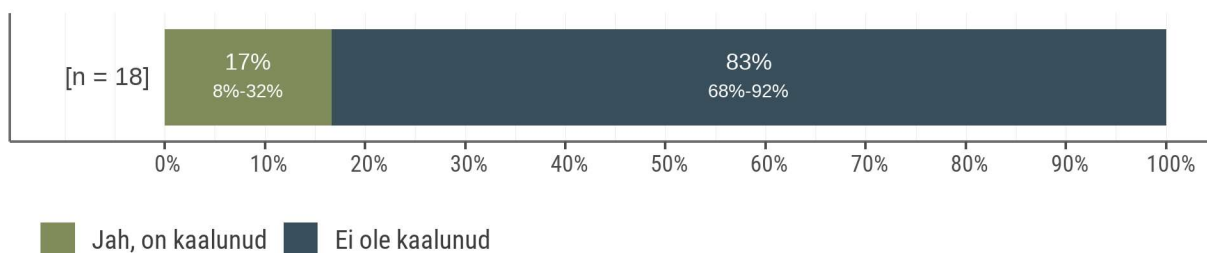
"I think even just one case a year is too little to keep up the momentum."

—(A volunteer)

Using the example of interviews, volunteers have found an application for themselves in other volunteer work. For example, volunteers have been offered the opportunity to contribute to the DV case as a Victim Support person after high-risk mitigation, as well as to help Ukrainian war refugees through SIB. However, the low workload at MARAC does not seem to cause a dropout in volunteering. According to the survey, only a few volunteers

considered quitting volunteering at MARAC, and their reasons for quitting were more related to their other workload. One volunteer justified their contemplation of discontinuing volunteering by citing the limited opportunities to assist the victim. This limitation is connected to the scarcity of practical services that can be provided to the victims.

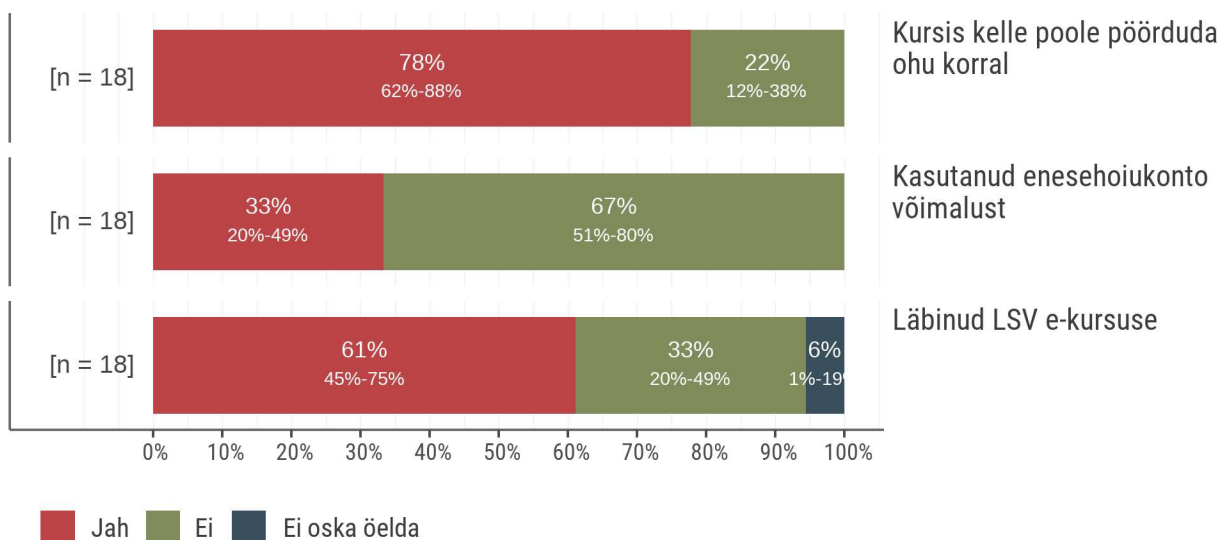
Figure 88. Breakdown of volunteers by whether they have considered quitting as a MARAC volunteer in the past 12 months



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

Volunteers consider it important that they practice and be able to find solutions to improve their functionality during practical activities, seek support and additional knowledge themselves, and share them with others. The majority of volunteers know where to get support and help in case of danger (see Figure 89). At the same time, in the last 12 months, about a third of the volunteers used the self-care account for supervision or professional support activities. Almost 2/3 of the volunteers have completed the domestic violence e-course of Victim Support. Therefore, in addition to practicing, a large number of volunteers are aware of where to get help and support, and many have also improved their knowledge and skills.

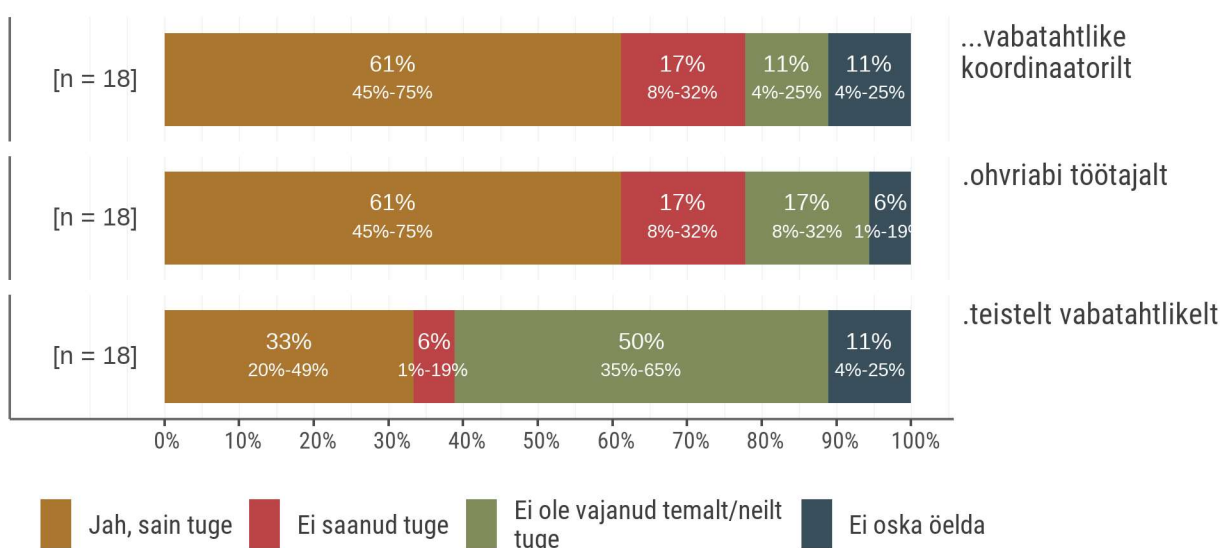
Figure 89. Are you familiar with who to turn to for help in case of danger in MARAC?



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

There are very few volunteers who did not need support to cope with their tasks in the last 12 months. Most needed support from either the volunteer coordinator or the SIB Victim Support worker, and they also received this support (see Figure 90). However, in both cases, there were also some volunteers who did not receive support from them even though they needed it.

Figure 90. Distribution of volunteers according to whether they needed and received support in the last 12 months to cope with tasks at MARAC



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

Although some volunteers in the survey indicated that they did not receive the support they wanted, none of the volunteers interviewed did receive support from the volunteer coordinator when they needed it. Several volunteers mentioned the current volunteer coordinator by name and referred to them as an important person who can be asked for help and who also seeks help from among volunteers for other volunteers.

"but the head of the volunteers [name] had always offered that if you need ... in the same way, [name] had called me when another volunteer needed support, and he wanted that maybe I could support her, right? In my opinion, it could go through [name] [offering support to volunteers] or through the leader of volunteers."

—(A volunteer)

Few seek help or support from other volunteers. At the same time, the solution of mutual support of volunteers emerged in the spring of 2023 on the volunteers' own initiative. Those who have sought help from other volunteers have mostly received this help. The provision of mutual support by volunteers takes place:

1. through the volunteer coordinator, who, if necessary, directs one or another volunteer to consult with a more experienced volunteer
2. through an informal Messenger group conversation between volunteers

"We have a so-called support group of women in our messenger, so that if you are in an uncomfortable or difficult situation, ... you feel bad, so we have this support group, where you can write down your whining. Then the other volunteers, there is a small group like that, who then help and support a little, let's say, they support the support person. But completely informal and completely created by ourselves."

—(A volunteer)

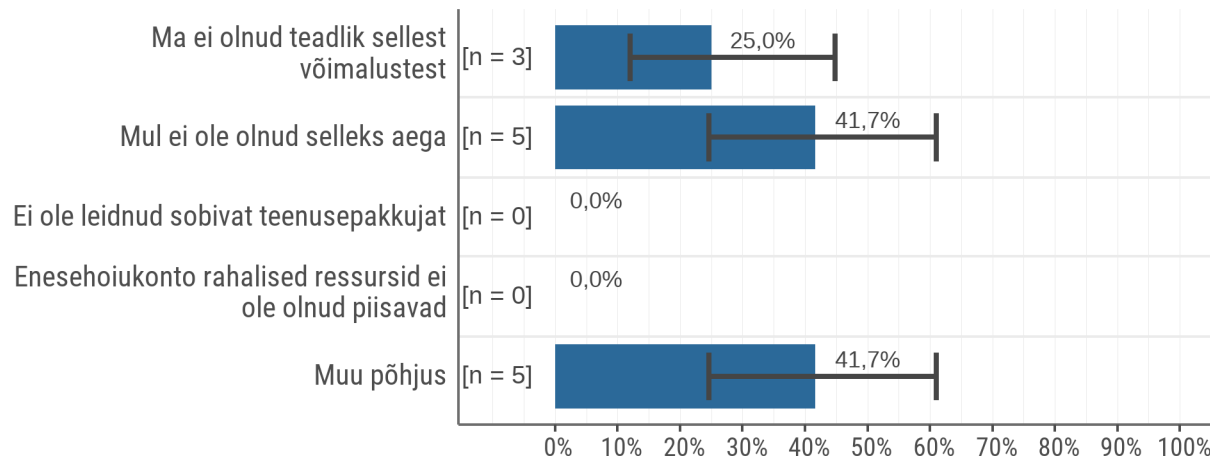
If the main support providers for core members are other core members through core networking, special supervision, and other development activities, volunteers have little contact with other core group members and generally do not seek support from them. Some volunteers act as WSC representatives at the same time, and their positions and roles are somewhat different from other volunteers. They also have partial support from other members of the core group.

"We are a small place, we communicate with each other so much, we know each other, so we immediately ask that we can't go on from here or that it's like this, yes."

—(A volunteer)

Low use of the self-care account (see Fig 89) is due to ignorance of this possibility and lack of time (see Fig 91).

Figure 91. For what reasons have you not used the MARAC self-care account (proportion of non-users)?



Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

Everyone who used a self-care account was very satisfied or rather satisfied with it, and there were no dissatisfied people. In the interviews, one of the users of co-vision described it as an interesting solution that allowed them to share their experiences and listen to other people's problems and solutions.

"Co-vision, I think that some have bigger problems than I do. That it was the place where you could unburden your heart and listen to what others recommend, face to face, that it was otherwise, yes, these coffee mornings are still online, and you can talk

there too. One co-vision and I went to the place. Well, I didn't have a direct need; I really went more out of curiosity, and it was definitely interesting. There were very different people, different cases, and different problems."

—(A volunteer)

In summary, the workload of volunteers in MARAC is considered low, and the overall opinion is that there should be more opportunities to practice in order to act competently. Despite this, only a few consider giving up volunteering. Volunteers look for and find alternative ways to contribute to society. Training support from the volunteer coordinator, Victim Support worker, and other volunteers is generally assessed as available. However, there are some volunteers who have not received support or do not know where to get support.

3 Effect of MARAC on the victim

3.1 Introduction

MARAC's effect on the victim is manifested on the one hand in its result, i.e., in mitigating high risk. However, it can be difficult to objectively assess the efficiency of MARAC as a whole since each case, its treatment and results are different, and it must also be taken into account that for the victim, solving the situation of domestic violence is a significantly broader and longer-term process than MARAC intervention within it. This means that once the high risk has been addressed, domestic violence has not necessarily disappeared from the victim's life. On the other hand, the impact of MARAC on the victim is manifested in how the victim has understood MARAC, how victims have been involved in MARAC processes, and what their experiences and contacts have been with the core group and its professionals.

In the following, we describe the awareness of the victims of the principles of MARAC's networking model and its purpose, as well as their evaluations of cooperation with members of the MARAC core group based on interviews with victims (we interviewed eight victims from different regions of Estonia). As the central working form of the MARAC core group is the MARAC meetings, we map the opinions of both professionals and victims and the experiences of victims' participation in the MARAC core group meetings. Finally, based on the survey data, we look at core group members' cognitive evaluations of MARAC's impact on increasing the victims' safety and discuss in more detail the factors that emerged from the interviews, which, according to core group members and victims, promote or reduce the efficiency of MARAC.

3.2 Victim perception of MARAC

When a victim's case is included in MARAC, it has previously been necessary to ask for the victim's consent. The victim's consent assumed that the victim was aware of the MARAC principles, and the consent form contained the sentence: "I have been explained the principles and use of MARAC case management, the involvement of the case management network in dealing with my case, agreements on further work arrangements." From April 1, 2023, in accordance with the Victim Support Act, instead of asking for consent, the victim will be informed that his/her case will be included in the MARAC core group work. Regardless of whether the victim is informed or consented procedurally, it is still important that the victim understands MARAC and its purpose in order to obtain cooperation from the victim.

The victims' understanding of MARAC is rather superficial, and the victims explained that MARAC is a group of professionals that tries to help them.

"Basically, this is how I understood that people from different social fields come to help and advise. I brought up this problem, and then everyone started giving advice on what I could do."

—(a victim)

"...everything was in the sense that it was quite clear that, in my opinion, the Victim Support brought out very well what we were going to do there, more or less. The main thing was that this was a safe place; no one would criticize me, and they all listened to my stories. And then they advised, it was very good for me, I felt completely safe, no one criticized anything, no one acted as if I had done something wrong."

—(a victim)

At the same time, there were victims who felt that the nature and purpose of MARAC remained unclear to them at times.

"Yes, to explain more exactly what it is and what opportunities I have, perhaps more explanation work because I really haven't exactly understood what it is during these two years. What is the point of this, but in the sense that at the end of the day, yes, there should be more explanation, communication, maybe, there should be more and better information."

—(a victim)

"it was said that this is the place where... well, the police, the centre worker, and others who want to help me gather. Somehow, that's how I understood... I don't know. I was told something, but I didn't understand everything. Honestly, I don't know."

—(a victim)

At the same time, there were also those victims who did not feel a great need to understand the nature of MARAC more precisely, as well as those who pointed out that they would have needed more explanations from the point of view of what MARAC enables and means to them.

"I understood from this that it is like a support network, which should be available to me in some way, as a support, who will discuss this topic. That much I learned about it before, or well, I still do not really know much more about it."

—(a victim)

In addition to gaps in understanding MARAC's purpose and work, there was confusion among some victims:

- whether their case is closed or still open at MARAC,
- whether they have received help from MARAC from separate professionals or from the local government.

Misunderstanding can be caused by victims not distinguishing the activities of MARAC from other measures aimed at helping them escape domestic violence. Once MARAC has achieved its goal and the high risk has been mitigated, for the victim, the resolution of the situation continues, and therefore, they do not feel that MARAC has ended. Although we only recruited victims for interviews whose cases had been closed at MARAC, some interviewees were still confused as to whether MARAC was still working on their case.

"I don't even know, to be honest; since we have these procedures, everything is still in progress; I'm crying in some random place with my own people. Yes, we have several

procedures, so I have the feeling that it is still going on somewhere; it seems that it was just that there was summer in between. I think it is still there because the procedure has already been completed, and the result is here; in the meantime, new things have happened. I believe that if it were over, someone would tell me it's over or that's it."

—(a victim)

One victim interviewed described a situation where they were not sure what documents they had signed and what they actually meant for them.

"I have to say I don't know, and I'll call now and ask; after all, I've signed the contract, I've given a number of signatures. You know, I have to look up the papers to see if they are two different things, so I was wondering if they were two different things. I will immediately talk to [person's name] about whether this [name of local government] is the MARAC system at all or what system is there that I have signed because I am often in a fog, let's put it this way."

—(a victim)

All in all, the most important thing for the victim is that they get help and support from MARAC to increase their safety. How comprehensive the victim's understanding of the MARAC core and its work should be is not defined in detail in the MARAC instructional materials. Since one of the factors affecting the operation of MARAC is the victim's willingness to cooperate, it is probably necessary for the victim to understand MARAC to the extent that it allows them to understand in general terms what the purpose of MARAC is and what their role, responsibility, and tasks are in it, and what opportunities MARAC offers them. There may also be a need for more clarification on the termination of MARAC processes. As processes related to domestic violence situations often continue even after MARAC ends, it can be difficult for a victim to know whether or not the core group is still working on their case.

3.3 Cooperation of the victim with specialists

If in MARAC's networking model, the primary concern lies in the collaborative efforts among the specialists within the core groups, which we previously addressed, then, from MARAC's effectiveness perspective, the victim's collaboration with the MARAC core group holds equal significance. MARAC operates for the victim's benefit, and it is incumbent upon the victim to embrace the solutions offered and undertake the necessary steps to extricate themselves from the situation of domestic violence. Thus, the needs and concerns of the victim must be central to MARAC operations (London et al., 2021). The victims' attitudes toward the work of the core group and their willingness to cooperate in MARAC are influenced by the victims' contact with the professionals belonging to the core group. In the following, we extract from the interviews with the victims their experiences with the members of the core group.

In the interviews with the victims, it is obvious that, in general, the victim communicates with the core group through a Victim Support worker, and mostly, this arrangement suits the victims.

"In general, I don't know these contacts or these people, no one. I still have no idea who is who. In other words, it's more like a Victim Support worker who should sort out that, okay, for you, these and these people are actually important for your case."

—(a victim)

Victims highly value the support they receive from Victim Support workers and their skillful communication. More trusting and freer communication is often achieved with the Victim Support worker than with representatives of other agencies.

"Ah, so there was a point, even until now, [the Victim Support worker] has called occasionally, asked how things have been, they have been very active... I had a very trusting relationship with them; I could call them at any time, and I could talk to them at any time. They were there for me a lot."

—(a victim)

Victims differ in the extent to which they want their interactions to be limited to the Victim Support worker and the extent to which they want to interact with MARAC core group members more broadly. Some victims indicated that they preferred to interact with the Victim Support worker individually rather than with the entire core group at the MARAC meeting.

"So I think this [information] came through [the Victim Support worker], it came later, and it is even better if it comes from just this one person. In that sense, it was better for me, procedurally, than to hear from behind the desk that we are not doing anything."

—(a victim)

However, among the victims interviewed, there were those who communicated closely with other professionals belonging to the core group. Which specialists the victim communicates with depends on the case, i.e., which processes take place during MARAC and in which field the specialist offers support to the victim. There were situations where, before referral to MARAC, the victim communicated with a number of professionals who are part of the core group in the area due to domestic violence and with whom communication continued during MARAC.

"Yes, with the Victim Support worker, the prosecutor, and then with the local constable and then with the support person. The most continuous communication took place with them. At the moment, I don't remember that there ever were more people. I'm also the kind of a person who doesn't want to talk much to complete strangers. I also knew them better."

—(a victim)

"but the women's support centre, they called me from there once a week even, I think really, once in two weeks, that they were there for me and then with the psychologist as well. And then, in fact, I did communicate with three people."

—(a victim)

Victims' broader assessments of cooperation with the core group differ and depend on both the victim and the experience of interacting with core group members. The interviewed victims were very satisfied with the communication of the Victim Support worker, but it should be taken into account that all the interviewed victims were included in the study through Victim Support workers.

However, the experiences and sense of cooperation with other members of the core group differed. **Some victims felt that they received a lot of support, encouragement, and advice from the core group specialists, and they identified specific specialists who helped and supported them.**

"there was a lot of encouragement from MARAC members. I was in constant communication with the family worker and the constable. The prosecutor and I met a few times when the criminal proceedings against the man were completed. The same prosecutor who was there at the trial was also a member of MARAC, and he gave me a lot of encouragement so that I could still go to the end. His words were running through my mind all the time. At first, the husband still wanted to get in touch by all means so as not to let go. But well, at the beginning, I gave in a few times, and we got together, but then they found out that I met him, and then they talked, talked, talked to me again."

—(a victim)

"In the end, it was like this culmination, and thanks to this MARAC and all this work, I finally got the self-confidence that people are there for me. Because they and the child protection worker were on my side, everything was fine..."

—(a victim)

At the same time, there were victims who felt that the cooperation with the core group did not go so well. At this point, the following **reasons for dissatisfaction in communication with specialists** were pointed out:

- In some cases, victims felt that specialists were too passive.

"That there I felt that child protection was like a very pointless organization, that they just sat, were silent, when I even asked them to help me in this situation, they were just silent and actually said nothing to me, that then I did feel that it was a pointless place to put my energy..."

—(a victim)

- Among the victims, there was a desire to receive more guidance and encouragement in going through various processes that turned out to be too difficult for the victim, such as preparing various documents/statements.

"There should have been probably more of something like: You know, come here, let's mark it down right away. You will come to the police station. Is next Thursday okay with you so we can help you put this thing together a little more like that kind? Not that you're going to be on your own at home, and then you don't dare to do anything. That there should be something like, like, that let's talk about it calmly, that they should have sent me to the investigator right away, for example."

—(a victim)

- At times, the victims felt that they were not believed and that they had to prove their situation further and justify themselves to the specialists belonging to the core group.

"Sometimes they believed you, and sometimes they didn't. I am a sensitive person, and I understand when I am not believed. Rather, I felt incompetent... In MARAC, however, in general, I felt that I had to justify myself and prove that I was right. If I hadn't had to focus on it, I would have been more specific."

—(a victim)

- One victim also highlighted a difficult situation where one member of the core group was a professional with whom the victim had had negative contact prior to MARAC, and in this case, the victim felt that they did not receive the help they needed prior to contacting MARAC.

"It was traumatic for me that I had previously appealed this decision in February, that they did not start [criminal proceedings]. I appealed to the prosecutor's office, and my prosecutor was [name of prosecutor] at the time. And [name of the same prosecutor] also sat at my round table at MARAC, in the sense that he himself failed to start. The way he spoke to me when I met him beforehand was extremely like... In short, he lacks the experience and competence to communicate with a person in such a situation. And it was extremely uncomfortable for me that he was sitting there at the table. He, in turn, gave me a blow; I mean, it should really be checked more carefully... That at least those who have somehow been involved in some decisions or things in the past, so that they were no longer there at the table."

—(a victim)

Overall, victims' experiences with members of core groups differ. Victims mostly communicate with a Victim Support worker from among the members of the core group, and all interviewed victims were satisfied with this communication. Victims' experiences with members of other core groups have varied. Some of the victims have felt support, advice, and encouragement from the members of the core group. Others, however, have pointed out problems related to the passivity of professionals, unwillingness to believe the victim, and the lack of guidance and counselling.

3.4 Attendance of the victim at the MARAC meeting

The participation of victims in the MARAC meeting depends on two factors: firstly, whether the victim is invited to the core group meeting, and secondly, whether the victim herself attends the meeting. Speaking of the first factor, inviting a victim, there are different opinions among the members of the core group and different practices in different regions. In some core groups, the victim is included in the meeting more often; in others, less often. There are also differences in whether the victim is included only in the first MARAC meeting or in subsequent ones as well.

"...that we like do not usually involve victims in our MARAC, they have been there very few times..."

—(an official of the PBGB)

"With us, it is like we offer an opportunity to victims, who want to come, will come. Sometimes, well, maybe once the victim comes, then the next time they don't, but they are always offered this opportunity. And then we, the core group, are also aware that, for example, this time the victim is present."

—(prosecutor)

Opinions of core group members about the usefulness and effectiveness of victim involvement vary. Some professionals consider that the victim should not be included in the meeting for various reasons. Sometimes, we feel that the meaning and effectiveness of the victim's participation in the meeting largely depends on the state of the victim. Thus, the general view is that involving the victim in the MARAC meeting presupposes that the victim is ready for change and ready to accept help.

"...if this person is very active, they want to make changes themselves anyway, they are capable of it. In other words, they are not in an acute phase, and they are a little more advanced; they are already oriented towards changes in their life, where they want to know what I can do to be better."

—(local government official)

According to the core group members, the reasons why the victim should not be included in the MARAC meeting are the following:

- Some members of the core group thought that it would be easier for the specialists of the core group to discuss the case if the victim is not present at the meeting because then it is possible to discuss it more objectively and in a freer atmosphere, which in turn allows more effective planning of measures to help the victim.

"And let's be honest, I think this option where there are no victims present is more suitable for me personally. Because, in my opinion, these emotions of theirs do not help us very much. We, especially as we have the minds of police officers, must be neutral. We clearly see that one is the victim, and the other is the perpetrator. Then, the victim always expects sympathy and thinks that their emotions should somehow affect us, but in fact, it cannot be so. And it is easier and freer for us to discuss with the specialists when there is no victim present."

—(an official of the PBGB)

- MARAC meetings have a predetermined limited time for discussion of each case. Therefore, the victim's participation in the meeting may create time pressure, so after listening to the victim's story and concerns and counselling them, there is not enough time for the core group to discuss solutions, divide tasks, and make decisions.

"...and since we have a limited time, whenever the victim comes to a meeting like this, the time is longer, but still the next case comes up, there is a limited time, so this matter must be resolved within such a time. And then, well, just one specific case was trapped in time; the victim was so sensitive that they were not even able to listen to what was offered to them."

—(representative of the WSC)

- It is also feared that if the victim participates in the meeting, there is a risk that the victim will not understand everything that the specialists are discussing, and therefore, it may happen that the victim will have a misconception or confusion about the plans, conclusions, and decisions of the core group. Hence, it is deemed more effective to communicate crucial information and decisions to the victim after the meeting rather than involving them in the actual proceedings.

"That I said like, there is no point in burdening the victims with the various topics that we discuss when establishing the security plan. We might go through twenty points, right, but in the end, only four points will go into the plan, and if she's there all the time listening to these things, it's just really confusing that, in this sense, we will find the solutions that we think are right, and then only the correct solutions are then communicated accordingly to the victim by the agreed person."

—(prosecutor)

- The victim may feel uncomfortable alone in front of all the officials, and the experience may have a re-victimizing effect. There have also been cases where the core group has not been able to ensure a completely safe atmosphere for the victim. Members of the core group point out situations when a specialist behaved inappropriately, for example, presented thoughts accusing the victim or questioning the victim excessively.

"Of course, we have had a case where the victim was questioned about what you wanted or why, for example. But, well, this situation found a solution in the sense that the person who participated in the core group realized that they were wrong with their behavior and that they shouldn't behave like that. And I've come to realize that our core group is maybe a little afraid of involving the victim. Maybe someone will start asking questions again, but it's more like you must not ask why you haven't done this or that. What we should ask is exactly what kind of help they need, how we can help, that these are the right questions that really need to be asked."

—(representative of the WSC)

However, there are equally opposite assessments, i.e., **specialists point out several beneficial factors for the victim's participation in the MARAC meeting:**

- Attending the meeting gives the victim the opportunity to be in direct contact with the specialists dealing with their case, ask questions and advice, and express their wishes and needs.

"If the victims themselves have specific questions to which they want to get an answer, I am not able to deliver and pass on this information to them, or if there is confusion about what they themselves seem to want or doubt whether it was the right decision at all to agree with MARAC. I think it would give the victim a sense of security."

—(representative of the WSC)

- In some cases, this opens up new details about the case that specialists were previously unaware of. In this way, it is possible for the core group to better understand the victim's situation.

"We talk quite openly. Sometimes, we get such information that the police say oh-oh, we don't have that information; in short, sometimes we receive new information."

—(local government official)

- The aspect of cooperation with the victim is also highlighted as important - if the victim is involved in the processes, it is easier for both them and the core group to find out what the solutions are that are realistically feasible for the victim.

"In this sense, on the one hand, I support it because, well, what the big concern of today's networks is is that everyone keeps discussing, worrying, and proposing plans among themselves, so the question is how this person, who actually has to implement these things, do they agree with them, are they even feasible? After all, they are the ones who actually have to do the work. It would be really good if they were there, and if they were not, we could simply suggest options. But we don't know whether and which of these options are suitable, what works, what doesn't work, and what the reasons are for that."

—(an official of the PBGB)

However, when victims are invited to meetings, it often happens that victims do not attend the meeting. The reason here is that the victim cannot participate due to other obligations and that they do not want to participate.

"Well, I guess participation in the meeting is also a matter of voluntariness. Whoever wants to come, we always accept them, we listen, but the number of participations, the percentage is really not very high."

—(prosecutor)

"others, well... we had this new one, maybe she could come, but she had a small child, she couldn't come with a small child, and it was quite uncomfortable. When new ones come, I see again, some go to work, so they can't just ask for time off."

—(Official of the SIB)

If a victim attends a MARAC meeting, it is primarily the first meeting or the opening meeting. There are victims who have attended several meetings, but this is less common. In the opening meeting, the victim is usually introduced to the members of the core group and asked to describe their situation, and the specialists ask clarifying questions to open up the victim's concerns more thoroughly.

"I took a deep breath behind the door and went in. This was basically it: tell your story. And I remember that it was relatively like the storytelling version. They may be asked clarifying questions if there were any topics related to children, but by and large, it was just storytelling."

—(a victim)

Interviewed victims have different experiences of attending MARAC meetings: some think it worked well, others think it didn't. **Several victims pointed out the circumstances why it was difficult for them to participate in the meeting:**

- Some victims indicated that they did not feel that their situation was understood and believed by members of the core group or that they feared that their words might later be turned against them.

"When I was sitting at the table, I didn't have the feeling that anyone really understood me, to be honest. However, most of the faces were relatively dull in the sense that there were people from the prosecutor's office, there were other people, there were a huge number of people at the table."

—(a victim)

- One victim felt the problem of telling their story repeatedly. Since the victim already had to tell their story during the risk assessment and, in many cases, also in other situations in contact with specialists, it seemed excessively burdensome, unnecessary, or somewhat re-victimizing to tell their story again at the meeting of the core group.

"Because I was more than fed up with the fact that I had to tell my story again and again at the table... in my opinion, if I remember correctly now, they had someone make an overview before; this person had told the history of the case, and then I didn't even understand why it was necessary. This victim has to come again to tell the story to the team, and the Victim Support specialist is more or less familiar with it. In my eyes, this information could be collected in a slightly different way. Like re-victimization. I understand that it is necessary, but it is certainly possible to escape it in a psychologically little less burdensome manner..."

—(a victim)

- Nearly all victims conveyed having experienced a sense of unease and anxiety during the meeting. One factor contributing to this discomfort was the feeling of being alone in the presence of a large number of individuals. Additionally, there was confusion and anxiety regarding what information to share with the core group and which aspects to focus on.

"how did I feel? That I am one, but there are many of them; that's how. In fact, I would have liked it more if we had met with the girls from Victim Support, even in their office, even online, because they understood me; we had a mutual understanding. Then, I would have answered the questions they asked. But now I was sitting alone, and I didn't know what to say to make them believe me because I realized that a lot depends on them."

—(a victim)

- Some victims felt that attending the meeting was unnecessary for them and did not provide additional information or support.

"I felt that it didn't give me anything, that I didn't directly benefit in any way from sitting there and talking. The same work is actually done by my lawyer; he is familiar with everything, in fact, with everything we have. That yes, I did not see any benefit to myself from being and sitting there at the meeting."

—(a victim)

On the other hand, I also had positive experiences from participating in meetings. At the MARAC meeting, some victims felt that the members of the core group understood them and tried to help them in the best way possible, and the victims felt more confident as a result.

"And like, I could also see from their faces that they were also disturbed by my whole situation, what was happening to me on a daily basis, that this empathy and such a thing came from all of them, that both the prosecutor and the investigator himself, who wrote down things in the meeting that, well, all of them were disturbed by the situation, understood and were understanding."

—(a victim)

"then the Victim Support, the prosecutor, that they were there emotionally and with as much advice and force and the law as they could possibly have."

—(a victim)

In summary, core group practices and members' views on victim involvement in MARAC meetings vary. Different opinions are caused by both personal preferences and previous experiences involving the victim. Core members have good and bad examples of participating in meetings with victims. In the case of good examples, the participation of the victim leads to receiving better information for making decisions, confidence for the victim, and cooperation with the victim in the implementation of measures. In cases of negative examples, the victim's participation leads to re-victimization and prolonged, inefficient use of the meeting. Members of the core groups, whose previous experiences in involving victims created difficult situations, doubt more and feel less desire and readiness to involve victims in the meetings in the future. Victims' experiences with attending the MARAC meeting also differ. In order to harmonize the practices and principles of involving victims in the meeting by a core group, to avoid discomfort and insecurity for the victim, and to ensure an effective discussion at the meetings, clearer instructions should be created on when and in what ways to involve victims in the meeting and how to solve the obstacles that arise.

3.5 Impact of MARAC on victim safety

Because all MARAC cases differ, it is difficult to assess the effectiveness of the MARAC model in increasing victim safety as a whole. The experiences presented in the survey and interviews concern both the effectiveness of the MARAC model and its bottlenecks. In the following, we provide an overview of the overall assessment of the increase in victim safety based on the most recently completed case of the core members, and then we map different attitudes, opinions, and experiences regarding the factors that reduce and promote the effectiveness of MARAC.

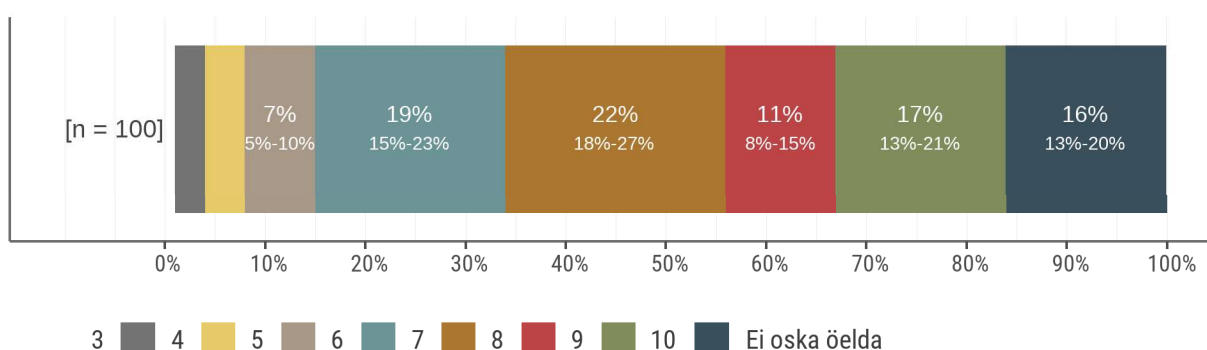
Core team members and volunteers rated how much they felt MARAC increased victim safety on a 10-point scale based on their most recently completed case. On average, MARAC's impact on increasing the victims' safety is rated quite high - the average rating of the core group members was 7.8 points, and the average rating of the volunteers was 7.6 points. The distribution of core group members' ratings is shown in Figure 92, and volunteers' ratings are shown in Figure 93. From the distributions, we can see that the assessments of the

increase in the victim's safety are evenly distributed; there are both lower and higher assessments. The high variability of the assessments is probably due to the fact that each case and the impact of MARAC on it is different. It should be taken into account that the increase in security is rather difficult to assess, as it depends on many different factors. Often, after MARAC intervenes and mitigates the high risk, the situation of domestic violence does not completely end for the victim, and many processes (for example, criminal proceedings, divorce, or custody and access rights disputes) continue after MARAC is completed.

"Well, in the sense that even this MARAC will not solve the situation completely. After all, MARAC is there to reduce this high risk. And this high risk can always come back, that at some point everything will be fine, that just like ups and downs, a person's life goes on and so do these situations."

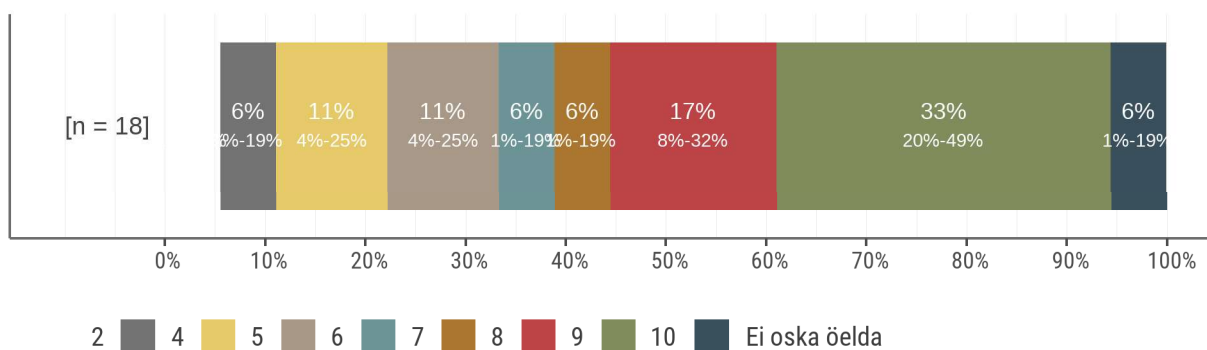
—(Official of the SIB)

Figure 92. Core group members' ratings of MARAC's impact on increasing victim safety based on the most recently completed case (on a scale of 1-10, where 1 - did not increase at all, 10 - increased very much)



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

Figure 93. Ratings of the volunteers of MARAC's impact on increasing victim safety based on the most recently completed case (on a scale of 1-10, where 1 - did not increase at all, 10 - increased very much)

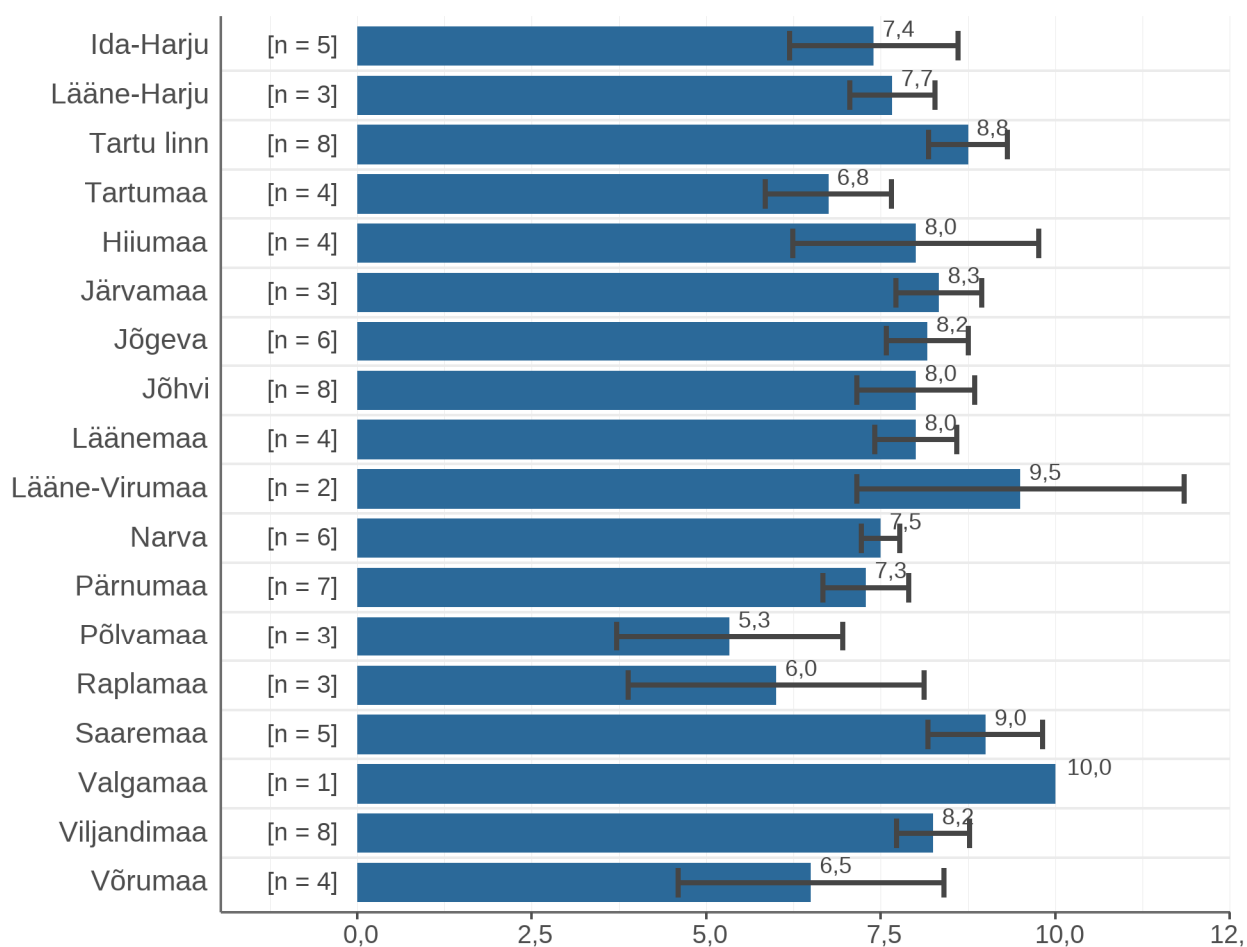


Source: MARAC volunteer survey.

Across regions, core group members' mean ratings of MARAC impact are similar (**94**). Põlva County stands out with a somewhat lower rating, and Saare County with a higher rating. Although the impact of MARAC is rated highest on average in Lääne-Viru County and Valga County, it must be taken into account that in these regions, it is based on the opinion of only 1-2 specialists, and there are no statistically significant differences between the regions.

Representatives of different agencies evaluate the impact of MARAC on the victim's safety in a similar way.

Figure 94. Average rating of the core group members of the impact of MARAC on increasing victim safety based on the most recently completed case (1 - did not increase at all, 10 - increased very much) - by region



Source: A survey of MARAC core groups.

3.5.1 Factors that reduce the effectiveness of MARAC

Both in the survey and in the interviews, members of the core groups pointed out a number of reasons that, in their opinion, could reduce MARAC's efficiency in increasing victim safety. Among them, the victim's traumatization and the resulting lack of cooperation are seen, as well as the lack of resources of the core institutions and factors external to MARAC, which

are due to the limited legal possibilities to help the victim. At times, victims also doubted how MARAC benefited them and felt the continued need for help. In the following, we reveal in more detail the factors that reduce the efficiency of MARAC, according to the members of the core groups and the victims.

3.5.1.1 Evaluations of core group members

The members of the core groups who gave lower evaluations of the impact of MARAC in increasing the safety of the victim most often attributed the small positive impact of MARAC on the safety of the victim to the fact that the victim is not willing or ready to accept help.

"Well, don't we also dream from time to time? Well, think how nice it would be if we could solve these things here like this right away. So that, like wizards, we would help a person there, but unfortunately, that person still must be ready to help themselves and, well, we can't do things for them that they have to do themselves. We can't make decisions for them, and we can't do those things on behalf of them."

—(local government official)

"Of course, we talk, and of course, we influence and try to explain by influencing, I mean how one or another thing could help further and whose advice might be needed the most, but we can't do everything for people, we simply do not have the legal right to do so. I can see that it is necessary to turn to a medical service somewhere, but if they themselves do not admit it. We can do everything within our power in MARAC and agree on something, but if they don't go there, it's that simple."

—(Official of the SIB)

In the interviews, the members of the core group pointed out various reasons and situations why, in their opinion, the victims do not cooperate with the MARAC core group. In several cases, the victim's traumatization and psychological/emotional reasons were highlighted. Often, victims are in such a vulnerable state that it can be difficult for them to seek and receive help. Victims may also feel ashamed and embarrassed or still be in denial about their situation, hoping that the situation will go away without making major changes.

"And it can be, of course, well, in that sense, it comes from the person because if they are very wounded, and this is what we talked about before, that they do not want to cooperate and do not want to talk about their concerns and does not know how to ask"

—(prosecutor)

"... we still have cases where the victims, women, just hope that, well, maybe the matter will somehow go away by itself and maybe something will change, and maybe there is no need to make the matter official at all, and usually these cases all come back to us anyway, I can't tell the number."

—(local government official)

Sometimes, core group members feel that the effectiveness of MARAC can be reduced by situations where the victim is ready for changes and cooperation with MARAC but does not want to adopt all the solutions offered by the core group. At the same time, it must be taken

into account that in the MARAC process, the victim must have the opportunity to decide which solutions are most suitable for her.

"We cannot force criminal proceedings on the victim if they do not really want it. If they want to look for other solutions, so be it. Of course, we always try to convince them that they could turn to the police, but in reality, I do not follow the procedure because we already know that the victim who does not cooperate with this matter, or in fact, in the end, it may happen that this matter does not go anywhere and it may on the contrary, it's like doing harm to the victim, that like I'm in favor of it, which is what our judicial practice has also reached, that let the victims be those who really want to, well, ... want to participate in this process and are ready to change this page in their life, turn a new page, if they are not ready, we can still help them through MARAC. But we can also do it without the procedure. I mean, this approach is more victim-friendly, but of course, we always try to convince the victim to consider other options as well."

—(prosecutor)

Apart from the victim's willingness to cooperate, according to the members of the core groups, several other factors influence the effectiveness of MARAC. On the one hand, according to them, MARAC's effectiveness may be reduced by a lack of resources. As MARAC is primarily a collaborative network, MARAC itself does not have additional resources to use to assist the victim. Similarly, interviews with professionals in a study that evaluated the effectiveness of MARAC in the Cardiff region of England revealed that one of the major concerns of MARAC professionals is the lack of resources to help victims, which poses significant obstacles to MARAC's effectiveness (Robinson, 2004).

"I don't know, maybe our expectations regarding MARAC are too high, but I started to think about it; if you look at the goal, that it is a place to exchange information, just yes, that's okay. We have a difficult case where, for example, a mother is in a shelter, and we all discuss what we can do quickly, but if you look at it as offering new sources of help, it is not there."

—(local government official)

At this point, it is pointed out that it is not possible to offer the necessary services to the victim in the amount that the victim actually needs, for example, changing the place of residence psychological help.

"or I mean lack of help, lack of psychologists. The services of a psychologist don't help once, right? Because in the big picture, if you have been broken for twenty years, one or two months of psychologist sessions won't fix it. In reality, the aid that the state should provide should be intensive aid. Through MARAC, it could be possible to get these victims faster and better. ... in the end, these things are done by psychologists, the same group of psychologists that we have, right. ... And the second thing I already said, right, is that we also don't have a psychologist in the core group; this is not directly a disadvantage of MARAC, but it is again our own problem in that we simply do not have such people in the county to be involved. I understand very well that the few we have are so busy."

—(prosecutor)

External factors such as legal regulations, procedural delays, and limited awareness of MARAC within the broader administrative and judicial system can significantly impact the situation. Consequently, core group members may, at times, perceive that MARAC hinders their ability to promptly assist victims and implement solutions.

"MARAC is necessary, but MARAC is definitely not a miracle cure. It could be faster, for sure. Solutions could come faster... But there are no quick solutions. That is the biggest concern, I think."

—(representative of the WSC)

"And what about the law? If the laws were more victim-friendly, it would be much better for MARAC to actually help. Well, actually, we have a victim protection directive for the victim's interests and protection, but at the same time, it is not particularly implemented, so the suspect has more rights, for example, to be released from custody. But it is not as easy for the victim to get a restraining order as, for example, for this suspect to get his rights, for example, to be released from custody earlier, to appeal, right, because the victim does not have such protection."

—(representative of the WSC)

In several cases, obstacles related to the speed of requesting and implementing a restraining order were specifically mentioned in terms of legal obstacles.

"I sometimes feel that, for example, by issuing this restraining order... For some reason, we take a lot of time with this kind of thing; if it could perhaps be implemented more quickly, I think it would contribute a little better to solving it. Sometimes, well, I'm not a prosecutor, but from the sidelines, I sometimes wonder why it's so difficult when all the indicators are there. In fact, its implementation could be a little easier."

—(an official of the PBGB)

The members of the core groups also see the lack of evidence as an obstacle to helping the victim more efficiently, which is why legal processes to increase the victim's safety are significantly more difficult.

"On the legal side, there is little evidence, and most things remain at the level of he said, she said, and the other side essentially laughs in the face of the victim. And they know that many things are he said, she said, which many years later are already very difficult to prove. We are trying to collect the means by which we can influence the other side as much as possible without crossing the lines. We keep the victim somewhere away for a while so that they can start to arrange their life. The perpetrator will always find some weaknesses, but they know where the limits are. They will not cross them... Our opportunities often end in this sense... We have done everything possible. But we cannot completely dismiss the perpetrator. We can only give suggestions on what the next move should be and what needs to be done next. We don't have any more chances because the law doesn't allow us to deal with the other any longer."

—(Official of the SIB)

As some members of the core groups feel that the law sets limits on their opportunities to help victims, they sometimes think that they do the same things in MARAC that they would do outside of MARAC, and in addition to more efficient information exchange, they do not feel any additional benefit in MARAC to help the victim, or they doubt there is any benefit.

"Yes, exactly the same that we can only do what the law allows us, what it prescribes, then we follow this law. We can just share our thoughts there, recommend something, just like other people who are involved, but we do exactly the same things."

—(prosecutor)

"But to say that now, you see, the victims who were in MARAC have received so much better help; there is no such comparison as far as I know, or I don't know it. They have received help; whether they would otherwise get the same or a different one, I can't say."

—(representative of the WSC)

3.5.1.2 Assessments of victims

Among the interviewed victims, there have also been doubts and misunderstandings about what MARAC offered them. In certain instances, this ambiguity could be attributed to the victims having a limited understanding of the nature of MARAC. Consequently, it becomes challenging to differentiate the support received through MARAC from a hypothetical scenario where MARAC did not exist and assistance was provided separately by various professionals and officials.

"MARAC was just a meeting for me after a certain period of time, where I could report how I was doing, what they could do, or whether there has been any news about the so-called perpetrator or something like that. I was able to talk about my concerns there, so to speak, but yes, for me, it was just a kind of meeting where I come to see how I'm doing, that maybe my lawyer did something more in the back somewhere, but for me, it was just one... a few meetings, either at home or on-site and clear as well, that's it. That's why it's also incomprehensible to me that I didn't get anything from there. Such an incomprehensible thing."

—(a victim)

"In this sense, I still didn't directly understand what its principle was, what it was for me, that I like to understand that it was for the investigators, for the lawyer, and well, all of them were able to communicate, but I sort of got nothing directly from it. That is like the feeling I have."

—(a victim)

Victims' doubts about MARAC can also be caused by the fact that often complex problems continue for the victim after the end of MARAC, and the need for additional help is felt.

"It would rather, ... that there should be something else, that I now actually need a lawyer to help resolve this situation so that I can live peacefully. For example, I can't move now. If I move, I still need the consent of [the child's] father to allow us to move... In my situation, I should actually get a recommendation from the child protection

workers and the police so that I could more easily apply for sole custody myself without any very large bureaucracy, and that's why I find this situation very difficult."

—(a victim)

In summary, the specialists involved in increasing the victim's safety at MARAC see various circumstances that affect the efficiency of resolving the situation of domestic violence. On the one hand, according to the members of the core groups, the efficiency of the MARAC processes can be affected by the fact that the victim has little readiness and capacity to take the necessary steps to change their situation due to trauma. Conversely, the core groups acknowledge that they may not consistently deliver services and support to victims at the level required, as the resources available for MARAC activities are contingent on the resources of the agencies within the core group. The legal limits for helping victims and the slowness of the processes can also create obstacles to helping the victim, according to the core groups. The interviewed victims themselves sometimes do not see the benefits of MARAC, which is due to a lack of understanding of MARAC and its goals, as well as the fact that even after MARAC, victims may still have a number of complex concerns that need to be resolved.

3.5.2 Benefits of MARAC to the victim

If we previously discussed the factors reducing the efficiency of MARAC, the members of the core groups pointed out several useful factors and advantages of the MARAC model compared to the situation if there was no MARAC. Among them, they mentioned versatile support and encouragement for the victim, the victim being better informed about possible solutions and the concentration of advice and information from different agencies in one channel, the trauma-aware communication method of the specialists belonging to the core, and faster coordination of services and support. However, the victims themselves mentioned various specific services, support measures, specialist advice, and assistance received from MARAC. In the following, we describe in more detail the benefits of MARAC from the perspective of both core group members and victims.

3.5.2.1 Evaluations of core group members

MARAC's support for the victim is perceived by core group members as one of the important benefits. The MARAC core group includes specialists from various fields, all of whom are oriented towards supporting and helping the victim. According to core group members, this makes the victim feel cared for; they feel that their concerns are important and they are being heard. The specialists also believe that the support they provide, in turn, encourages and increases the self-confidence of the victim to take the necessary steps to change their situation.

"they [the victim] said that I can certainly [call them], that they feel safer, that they know that different parties are working and are somewhere in sight. That someone stands up for them, that they are not alone, that is very important to them."

—(representative of the WSC)

"And this is what I have felt because in some cases, for example, to jointly explain to the victim that you have the right not to let them into your apartment, you have the right to evict them from your place of residence, to register your place of residence elsewhere, for example, so that they do not have the right to come to the apartment. If, for example, one official talks only about this, only Victim Support talks, it may not be enough for the victim. But just supporting them and saying that it's a brave move, do it; it will help you. I think maybe it will reach them better."

—(representative of the WSC)

The members of the core groups think that in MARAC, the information transfer to the victim is more thorough and more considerate of the victim's condition than it would be in the case of separate help from specialists, and thus, the victim is more aware and informed about their options. Since the opinions and assessments of all specialists are gathered in MARAC, it is possible for the victim to receive information significantly more efficiently, and it is also possible to advise and guide the victim in a way that takes into account the victim's vulnerable state and, consequently, the ability to receive information.

"in reality, the amount of information that is given to a person, what can be done and what rights the victim has and so on, it is actually quite voluminous, and certainly the victim in such an emotional moment cannot accept it in reality when the patrol person speaks to them at the scene. In this sense, the role of Victim Support is to calmly explain these options, including the option of MARAC, either by phone or in meetings. Thanks to this person getting MARAC, where they are actually dealt with, so to speak, let's say that we have had a person who holds the victim's hand, is like a support, which helps to find, among the many solutions, the solution that could work be the best solution specifically for this victim. MARAC has definitely brought this change. If there was no MARAC, it would be normal as always, whether the investigator tells you everything and whether the investigator conveys all this information, plus these outdated attitudes, problems that unfortunately still exist in the police, that they still talk about making some kind of statements and they don't know how to communicate with victims without re-victimization and so on. Victim support can do this, and MARAC helps these victims find the right help in this regard. Regardless of whether we have a criminal or not, I think that the situation has improved with MARAC, at least for the victims who have entered MARAC."

—(prosecutor)

MARAC also makes it possible to identify high-risk factors across agencies and to find solutions to mitigate them, which grow out of the cooperation of various specialists and are not the direct responsibility of any agency.

"Like we have given all kinds of help, including real estate help. We have also referred real estate agents to people and all that. There was one of those cases where we could collect information very quickly because I had all the municipal registers in my hands, such as the real estate register and the register of landowners. We were able to act very quickly, so by the end of the meeting, we already had a real estate agent, so that kind of collective quick action, so to speak. It was also successful in the sense that this

case ended with the fact that this joint dwelling was sold, and it was between the mother and the son; in fact, there was no husband. But this matter was resolved. And successfully."

—(local government official)

Vulnerable victims in high-risk domestic violence situations often do not know where to go and what steps to take to resolve the situation. Therefore, the core group members think that MARAC offers the victim possible solutions and activities, and the victim does not have to look for opportunities and contact different authorities separately.

"faster in the sense that maybe there, so to speak, those opportunities are there, that these people are sitting at the table, who immediately know that, well, let's say maybe, in a certain sense like connections or so, right, that kind of faster exchange of information, so that they don't have to go through the gauntlet, now I turn to somebody, now I look it up on the Internet, right, now I turn to the local government, the local government refers me to Victim Support, Victim Support refers... all this crap does not happen, I don't have to do this looking things up journey there on top of everything."

—(an official of the PBGB)

At the same time, one interviewed specialist pointed to the fact that a victim with MARAC experience will be more aware in the future, and if a similar situation arises, they can seek the necessary help earlier and know where and whom to turn to with their concerns.

"I rather think that someone who has been at high risk once and has received help for it then they go to look for that help earlier. I guess there was one somewhere, but I don't know for sure if anyone else has been here twice; I cannot recall, kind of. I would rather say that it hasn't happened yet, which doesn't mean that it won't happen. That it may happen, that they have received such support, they just know how to apply earlier and whether it has to go all the way to a MARAC case."

—(representative of the WSC)

3.5.2.2 Assessments of victims

Some victims also felt that MARAC allows them to get help from a single source, and therefore, they do not need to describe and explain their entire situation to several agencies and specialists. At the same time, it should be taken into account that not all victims perceived that MARAC made their lives easier.

"Everything is clear in MARAC that the case is serious, but if it goes outside MARAC, then you have to prove it again. Without MARAC, the victim has to repeat herself dozens and dozens of times over and over again, and it is not helpful in that sense. And people feel that they can speak directly, and that's also what I think has been most helpful in the case of MARAC, that I don't have to say everything myself, and people communicate."

—(a victim)

Since the victims do not have an overview of the systems and possibilities for solving cases of DV in Estonia, they cannot point out the beneficial factors in a broader way, as the members of the core groups did, comparing the possibilities with the situation if there was no MARAC. Victims' assessments mostly concern the specific services and support measures they were offered during MARAC that increased their sense of security and well-being. Similarly, in a study conducted in England (Robinson & Tregidga, 2005), where victims who participated in MARAC were interviewed, it was found that in addition to receiving emotional support, victims value and notice various practical assistance measures and services.

In this study, the interviewed victims pointed out the following support measures and services that increased their safety:

- In some cases, adding their number to the emergency response list of 112 service providers was cited as an important safety measure, which means that if a victim calls 112, the people working there can send help to the caller more quickly.

"It was an encouragement that I mostly got from there so that I wouldn't be afraid; soon after that meeting, I moved back home, and I also made a statement to the police that the man was not allowed to come to my yard. Well, if I had seen him, I would have been able to call for help after calling the rapid response. In other words, [advice was given] how to make this call to 112 so that a rapid response would arrive."

—(a victim)

- In several cases, services received through Victim Support services were linked to MARAC. For example, victims mentioned the psychologist service they received through MARAC, either for themselves or for their children.

"By the way, does it go under MARAC? But I also received funding through Victim Support to see a therapist, and this is what I used for the child. It was very important for me..."

—(a victim)

"Then, after that, it started. When Victim Support offered this opportunity, we went to MARAC. There, I was given a lot of advice in the women's support group, as well as got a lot of information. I also received psychological help. That after the attack it was so important and the child also received play therapy..."

—(a victim)

- Among other things, victims generally mentioned how they received various advice and answers to their questions from MARAC.

"well, there were questions related to divorce, for example, which I was helped with."

—(a victim)

"And then they said to go to ER, they gave advice, they were there, it was like very sweet. And I went to ER, and I had those injuries recorded."

—(a victim)

"Let's just say that in all questions, concerns, and advice, they answered and were there for it to go well."

—(a victim)

- Some victims cited the specific practical help and support they received from the core group specialist as a strength of MARAC.

"The child protection worker then ordered family reconciliation and also checked the home to make sure that everything was fine. They communicated with me, communicated with the child's father, and then advised, so they were more on my side. They understood I had been abused."

—(a victim)

"I got this [prosecutor's name] from MARAC at some point. They helped me out by drafting one of the responses I sent. I mean, because he harassed me tremendously through e-mails, phone messages, and phone calls, I sent a letter, and since I had sent that letter, from that letter, like, another legal clause began to run for him, that in this regard they helped me."

—(a victim)

Overall, core group members feel that MARAC has many advantages compared to the situation without MARAC. As the main advantages, the members of the core groups see that MARAC includes representatives of several fields, and thus, the victim gets a better overview of their options from a single source, and in the cooperation of different agencies, case resolution and service coordination are faster. In addition to increasing the victim's awareness, the members of the core group feel that support, encouragement, and communication that takes into account the victim's condition have an impact on the victim's well-being. At the same time, it has to be taken into account that although the members of the core groups see them as the benefits of MARAC, there have also been the opposite experiences among the victims, and at times, they have felt a lack of support and understanding. When discussing the benefits of MARAC, victims view MARAC from a narrower perspective and point to various services and support measures that increased their well-being and sense of security as benefits, such as the psychologist service, the 112 emergency response list, and advice, recommendations, and support from core group professionals.

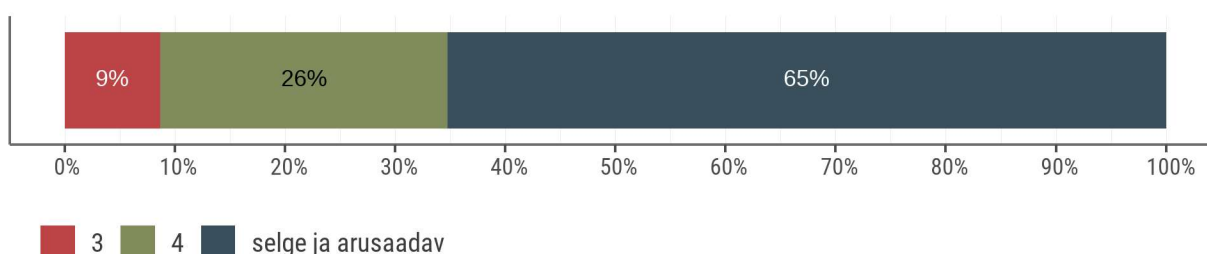
4 E-course on domestic violence

An e-course has been created for specialists dealing with domestic violence in the learning platform of the Digital State Academy, the aim of which is to raise the awareness of specialists about domestic violence. The course explains the nature of domestic violence and the principles of support and offers guidelines on how to behave in a situation that requires quick and decisive intervention. The e-course is divided into four modules: domestic violence, MARAC's networking model, trauma, and self-care.

As of the end of September 2023, 114 people had completed the domestic violence e-course. However, 23 people had filled out the course feedback form, and the following feedback analysis is based on their answers.

In the opinion of most, the content of the e-course on domestic violence was clear and understandable (see Figure 95). Among those who gave feedback, there were none who found the course confusing and incomprehensible.

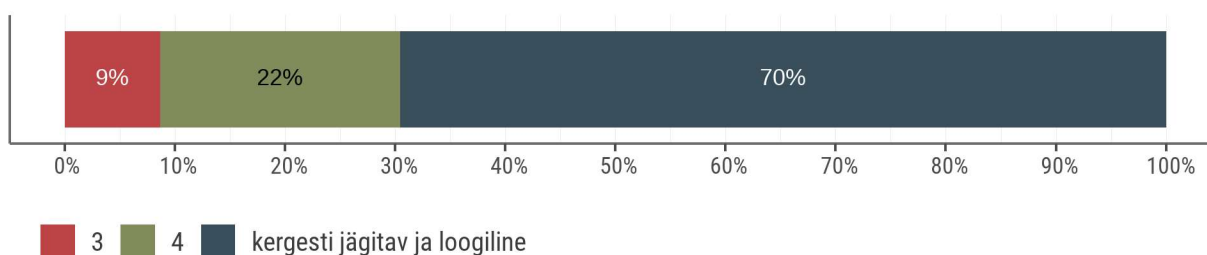
Figure 95. In your opinion, was the content of the course clear and understandable? Answers on a 5-point scale, where 1=confusing and incomprehensible and 5=clear and understandable



Source: DV course feedback

The majority considered the structure of the course easy to follow and logical (see Fig 96). Similar to the previous question, there were no negative evaluations of the course here either.

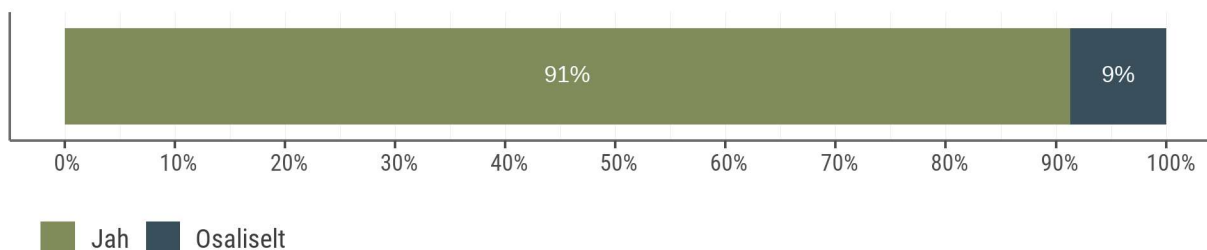
Figure 96. How do you rate the structure of the course? Answers on a 5-point scale, where 1=hard to follow and confusing and 5=easy to follow and logical



Source: DV course feedback

The majority felt that they had mastered the learning outcomes formulated at the beginning of the course. Partial acquisition of learning outcomes was noted by a few (see Fig 97).

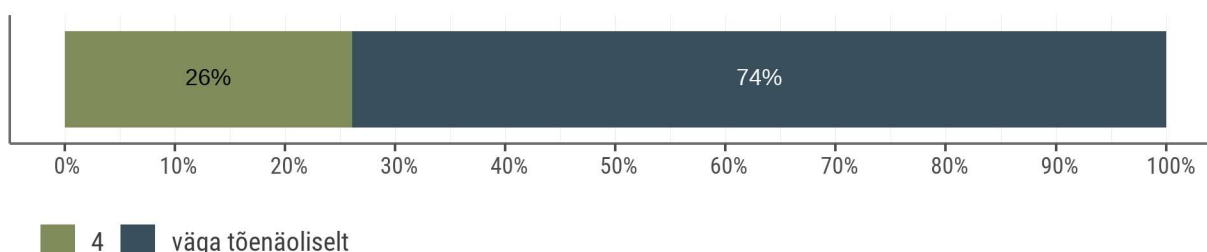
Figure 97. Do you feel that the learning outcomes formulated at the beginning of the course were acquired?



Source: DV course feedback

All those who gave feedback on the course would most likely recommend others, for example, their colleagues or partners, to take this course (see Figure 98).

Figure 98. Would you recommend the course to others (colleagues, cooperation partners, etc.)? Answers on a 5-point scale, where 1=a little likely and 5=very likely



Source: DV course feedback

The course feedback form also had a series of open questions where the respondents could evaluate and describe the course in their own words. The most positive aspect that was brought out was that the course was well-structured, understandable, thorough, and interesting. What was positive about the course structure was its diversity (videos and conversations, exercise tasks, revisions, tests, interactivity) and the use of different media (video and audio files, texts with videos). On the positive side, it was also noted that you could take part in the course at a time that suited you. Several feedback providers praised the practicality of the course (solving a sample case, examples of how to communicate with a client, and solutions to be implemented in your work immediately). The comprehensiveness of the trauma module was also emphasized separately.

The respondents gained new knowledge from the course, especially about the MARAC model and its operation. Some feedback providers also brought out new knowledge about legislation, brain activity, LGBT+ issues, self-care and prevention of burnout, risk assessment (how to assess high risk, how to use the DASH form), and talking to the victim.

In the opinion of the feedback givers who completed the course, the following topics could be covered more thoroughly in the course in the future:

- dealing with the victim (conducting a conversation with the victim and how to support the victim of IPV);
- matters related to children;
- matters related to the elderly;
- men as victims of DV (detail the specificity of the topic);
- the topic of non-violence;
- specific topics related to trauma (for example, trauma through life stages, talking about trauma with children);
- self-care;
- introduce more different cases;
- conducting a MARAC meeting;
- what services can be offered to the victim?

"I liked the different study materials that were used to give an overview of the topics. They were compact, understandable, and useful. I liked the connection of the course with practice throughout the course through the solution of a sample case. Other practice tasks were also good options for consolidating knowledge and memorizing the most important. It was also positive that several useful tools for working with domestic violence cases could be downloaded to the computer."

"It was good to be reminded of active listening techniques. The influence of brain processes on behavior was also an exciting part. The entire course aroused even more interest in the given topic. I would like to thank the authors and implementers of the idea of this course - an extremely interesting, compact, and concise overview of the topic."

However, the technical problems encountered during the course (environment freezing, recording problems, assignments not progressing, unexpected jumps back in the system, it is not possible to drag answers to the right place, all worksheets not opening on the phone, etc.) were noted as the bottlenecks of the course. The technical problems also affected the question of completing the course - some participants were not sure whether they had officially completed the course or not; for example, one who completed the course saw on the course website that their percentage of completion of the course was zero or they had not yet received the certificate of completion of the course. At this point, however, it must be taken into account that some technical problems may not be related to the online platform of the course and may instead arise from the device used to complete the course (computer, smartphone) and its settings (e.g., saving cookies).

Another major problem that emerged was the time pressure to complete the course. In the opinion of the feedback providers, there should be more time for completing the course, and there should also be information somewhere about the last possible completion date of the course and the approximate time required to complete a chapter. At this point, however, it must be taken into account that, technically, there is no time limit on the e-course, and the

learner can complete it at a pace that suits them, but time limits may be set for learners by their training providers, such as employers.

Some pointed out problems with language and spelling in the course. At times, frustration was felt due to the multi-interpretation of test questions and answers, so-called trick questions, where course participants did not understand whether it was their knowledge or something else that was being tested. Failure to pass the final test also caused feelings of disappointment. However, only a few people saw problems with the content of the courses. According to one respondent, the course has too many LGBT+ topics. One respondent wrote that their practical experiences in dealing with the subject of DV sometimes did not match the course materials, and for one respondent, completing the course was emotionally difficult, as they themselves have been a victim of DV.

"... the use of language (sentence, spelling, etc.) is not of uniform quality throughout the course. In the first half of the course (up to the MARAC part), the language quality is so bad that it hinders the learning process. You have to read the sentences several times to understand the content. In the tasks, there are questions that are posed in a way that can be understood in many ways, and in the answer options, there are variants that can also be interpreted in many ways. This caused slight frustration when doing tests. the environment visually lost my progress in the course when I reached 80%. It startled me, and although it didn't prevent me from moving forward technically, it confused me for a moment..."

"In terms of content, I didn't really miss anything, and I wouldn't change it. However, there were occasional technical errors, and it took a lot of time for a new activity to load. Sometimes, I didn't save the completed "journey" properly in the course, so I had to redo something that I had actually already done when continuing the course. This could be taken into account in the future because it is obviously not a course that can be completed in one go, and it is important that the progress is correctly recorded so that when you return to your studies again, you can continue from the right place. The last possible completion date for the course could also be provided somewhere because, to be honest, I couldn't find it anywhere, and it made me a little nervous while I was studying to see if I could complete the entire course before it closed."

In summary, the feedback of the DV course participants is positive. According to the respondents, the course was content-rich, understandable, and well-structured. The bottlenecks in completing the course are mainly technical errors and time pressure. Therefore, in order to develop the course, it is necessary to deal with solving the problem of technical obstacles and the time required to complete the course. Since the volume of the course is large according to those who have completed it, when considering the possibilities to deal more thoroughly with the topics that the feedback brought up, care must be taken that they do not significantly increase the volume of the course.

Conclusions and recommendations

We present the main conclusions and recommendations of the study by report topic.

MARAC core groups and the role of core group members

There are 18 MARAC core groups in Estonia, with a total of 137 people working in them. 13 people participate in the work of more than one core. The MARAC network operates on the assumption that the most important regional institutions for ensuring the safety of the victim are represented in each core group: the Social Insurance Board, the Police and Border Guard Board, the Prosecutor's Office, the Women's Support Centre, and the local government. The list of members of the core groups operating in Estonia includes representatives of the Social Insurance Board, the Police and Border Guard Board, and the Prosecutor's Office in all regions. There is no representative of the Women's Support Centre in the two regions. A representative of local governments is a member of those individual core groups whose area of activity overlaps with the territory of one municipality. In others, local government representatives participate as specialists on a case-by-case basis. According to the members of the core groups, the core groups in all regions include the necessary key institutions whose work and service coordination are MARAC's goals. In the interviews of the core group members and in the answers to the survey, individual specialists whose addition to the network would enable the MARAC core group to assist the victim more efficiently were named.

Recommendation: the composition of the agencies of the core group members (PBGB, SIB, prosecutor's office, WSC, and LG) is suitable, and for the networks to function, the representation of these agencies must continue to be ensured.

MARAC's mission is to identify victims at high risk of domestic violence⁴ and ensure their safety in cooperation with the specialists of the institutions. From both the survey and the interviews, it is evident that the collaboration among institutions functioning within core groups in Estonia is generally effective. The members of the core group value the clarity of their role in the meetings and in MARAC in general, and the role clarity of all parties quite highly, and the majority are satisfied with the work organization of the regional MARAC. According to the survey, operating in the core group of MARAC improved both cooperation with other agencies dealing with DV and the opportunities to help victims of DV, according to the opinion of slightly more than half of MARAC core group members. About a third of core group members feel that MARAC changed their work methods. The change in working methods is perceived more by those who have been active as a member of MARAC for more than five years. A common field of information and closer cooperation between institutions is highlighted as an important advantage of MARAC, which enables better coordination of the support and services offered to the victim. Although there are several aspects to improve

⁴ MARAC is intended for victims of legal age, but also accepts victims under the age of 18 if they are victims of high-risk domestic violence by a partner or ex-partner.

and adjust MARAC, core group members see MARAC as an important and necessary framework for collaboration between agencies.

Recommendation: MARAC is a relevant and necessary collaborative framework for bringing together professionals dealing with high-risk domestic violence cases, and we recommend continuing to develop MARAC.

The main form of cooperation between MARAC core group members is meetings. MARAC core group meetings are held regularly, mostly once a month. Special meetings will be convened if necessary and if resources are available. This is done when the case needs urgent attention, and there is no time to wait until the next regular meeting. Meetings are skipped during the summer months or when there are no cases. Core group members mostly feel that meetings are held with sufficient frequency, and individual members want to increase or decrease the number of meetings. According to the survey and interviews, specific rules are set for conducting MARAC meetings. Most mandatory elements of MARAC meetings always or mostly work well, according to a survey of core group members. The core group members describe the organization of the MARAC meetings and the use of time as efficient and bring MARAC's organization as an example to other round tables. MARAC meetings, as the central form of cooperation in the network, mostly function well, and the rules and format of the meetings are generally appropriate. Specific parts of MARAC meetings need improvement, such as the process of preparation and sharing of documentation and involvement of victims.

Recommendation: To continue to conduct MARAC meetings with the current time management rules and structure.

More narrowly, the survey revealed a number of issues and recommendations regarding the number of core group members, their roles, and the involvement of case-based specialists in MARAC.

MARAC meetings are sometimes overcrowded, especially in larger regional core groups where one agency is represented by multiple people. This situation makes it difficult for victims to participate in meetings, nor does it follow the principle of data protection, according to which the number of people who are familiar with each victim's case must be as small as possible, and the use of resources on implementing MARAC is not optimal.

Recommendation: keep the number of members of the core group (especially in meetings) to a minimum, avoiding, if possible, the representation of one agency by several people.

A member of the core group may be in a role conflict if they are simultaneously a representative of the agency in the MARAC core group and also a provider of a service or support directly to the victim. Such role conflict has led to excessive and inappropriate questioning of the victim at the MARAC meeting in some cases, which made the victim feel unsafe. Also, role conflict, where the victim had negative contact with a core group member before MARAC, to whom they turned for help, led to a situation where the victim felt that the core group members did not support them.

Recommendation: Add clear guidelines to the MARAC manual on how the core group and its members should handle a situation where a core group member is in a role conflict situation at a MARAC meeting.

Several members of the core groups feel that in order to operate efficiently, additional specialists who are not currently in the core groups are needed. More specifically, the need for a health specialist was identified and described in two different roles: (1) for members of the advisory core group to implement more efficient measures that take into account the health condition of the victim or the perpetrator; (2) a representative of an institution providing health care services, who, similarly to other members of the core group, represents the institution within the limits of resources and services. Although the members of some of the core groups already include representatives of hospitals, some of them also felt that it was necessary to involve an additional specialist in the field of health. It should be taken into account that the involvement of an additional specialist increases the number of core group members and is not necessary in all cases. Also, it may not be appropriate to involve a specialist in the field of health on a basis similar to that of other members of the MARAC core group, whose daily work is to help victims of DV. Therefore, different bases must be developed for the involvement of a specialist in the field of health.

Recommendation: Consider what the possibilities are and in what role to involve specialists in the field of health in MARAC and give instructions to the core groups to involve additional specialists.

The members of MARAC core groups have, on average, quite a lot of MARAC work experience - according to the survey, nearly 70% of the members had participated in MARAC for three years or more. In MARAC, nearly 15% of members have short-term experience, i.e., experience of less than one year. A new person joining MARAC takes time to understand MARAC, comprehend what the roles and responsibilities of core group members are, how MARAC's work organization works, which victims are taken into MARAC, and how. The longer time required for new members to settle in is shown by the core members' assessment of role clarity. In addition to the fact that members with shorter experience rate their role clarity worse than those with longer experience, the survey revealed that a smaller percentage of them used the self-care account option and felt that they received enough support from other MARAC members. At the same time, the majority of members with shorter MARAC experience have participated in the DV e-course compared to members with longer experience.

Recommendation: to make it easier for new MARAC core members to settle in, we recommend directing them to the DV e-course, preparing short and specific instructions for them that explain the roles, responsibilities, and tasks of the core group members, and additionally acquaint the new member with how the regional MARAC works and what the possibilities are to get help and support for self-care.

The role and tasks of local governments in the core group and at MARAC meetings are not always clearly defined, and problems are felt by representatives of local governments as well as representatives of other agencies in MARAC core groups. Local government representatives themselves sometimes see ambiguity in their role as core group members in

general and in participation in MARAC meetings, and also that other parties in MARAC core groups have too high expectations and wishes for local governments. The representatives of other agencies in the core groups are critical of the contribution and participation of the local governments and feel that there are shortcomings in the cooperation readiness of the local governments and in the performance of their tasks. The variations in understanding and experiences may arise from the fact that other members of the core group may not have a comprehensive understanding of the resources and services that local governments can provide. Additionally, there may be a lack of clarity among local government officials about their role in resolving the case and the opportunities available to support the victim. The problem is with some local governments in some core groups because there are also local governments who positively evaluate the functioning of MARAC and their role in it. There are also core groups where the role of local governments is highly valued.

Recommendation: the core group works effectively if the roles of the parties are clear and they work cooperatively. Therefore, we recommend describing in more detail the possibilities and role of local governments in supporting victims and explaining it more precisely to all parties.

In addition to the role of representing one's agency in the MARAC core group, the MARAC manual defines the following roles at the meeting: Head, Coordinator, and Secretary of MARAC. Although MARAC's guidance material does not specify which agency's representatives fulfill these roles, in Estonia, the role of the head of MARAC is exclusively performed by a PBGB representative, the coordinator's role is performed by a representative of the SIB, i.e., a Victim Support worker, and the secretary is mostly a representative of the PBGB, but in some cases a representative of the local government, the prosecutor's office or the SIB. Based on the survey, mandatory roles in MARAC meetings are generally fulfilled. The survey and interviews showed that the role of the MARAC leader is causing confusion. It remains confusing why the PBGB representative fulfills the role of the head of MARAC, which is a technical and non-substantive job, and the core group work is essentially coordinated by the SIB representative.

Recommendation: clarify the role of the MARAC leader and further clarify the content of this role and the basis for its appointment to the members of the core groups.

MARAC victim profile and risk assessment

MARAC was created to prevent the consequences of high-risk violent incidents. The DASH risk assessment is used to assess the risk level of incidents. Mostly, the members of the core groups consider the DASH risk assessment to be a necessary and appropriate method to objectively assess the risk level of the cases on the basis of a single principle and thereby select the high-risk cases only to be handled in MARAC.

Based on follow-up data, the mean initial DASH risk assessment score is 14.9 points. However, approximately 30% of MARAC cases have an initial DASH score below the high-risk threshold or less than 14 points. In Estonia, victims with an initial score lower than the DASH threshold of MARAC are accepted if, in the specialist's opinion, there is still a high risk or danger of escalation in the case, and in such a case, the increasing benefit of MARAC is

always considered to resolve the situation. The round of discussions and the format for making such decisions varies from region to region.

More women than men are victims of high-risk domestic violence. The victims involved in MARAC are mostly women aged 35-50 with minor children in their households. However, there are also victims with a different profile (significantly younger or older, without minor children, male). In most cases, the perpetrator of violence is the victim's current or former life partner, with both occurring in relatively equal proportions. About one in ten MARAC cases are perpetrated by the victim's son or daughter, and it is most common among victims aged 65+. Thus, high-risk domestic violence does not only affect women of childbearing age, in whose relationship a man is the perpetrator of violence. MARAC must work equally well to identify and mitigate the risk of high-risk domestic violence situations for victims with diverse profiles.

Members of the core groups see the DASH questionnaire as an important bottleneck that is not suitable for all target groups. For example, the DASH questionnaire does not adequately assess the risk of elder partner or parent-child violence or a male victim. At the same time, the monitoring data of MARAC revealed that the incidence of initial DASH scores below 14 points is significantly higher among those aged 65 and older than in other age groups and in situations where the perpetrator is the victim's son or daughter, only 48% of cases have an initial score above the threshold. This is because some DASH questions are not applicable to these target groups, so the initial risk assessment score underestimates the actual risk. In addition, asking inappropriate questions in a vulnerable situation makes the victim uncomfortable. Since the DASH questionnaire cannot be modified, as it is a comprehensive risk assessment instrument, the possibility of developing risk assessment metrics suitable for the aforementioned target groups should be considered. This would allow for an objective and standardized assessment of risks, as it works in the risk assessment of victims in the target group of women of childbearing age with the DASH questionnaire.

Recommendation: to create risk assessment instruments suitable for target groups in order to assess risks in a standardized and objective manner in target groups to whom the DASH questionnaire does not fully apply.

Although the risk assessment of DASH can be done by representatives of various institutions, it has emerged that it is mainly done by SIB Victim Support staff and WSC representatives and less often by PBGB representatives. Several members of the core group from other agencies refer the risk assessment to the SIB if they feel that an assessment is necessary. The practice of filling out the DASH depends on the preferences of the person conducting the assessment and the instructions of the authority - some fill out the DASH questionnaire without the presence of the victim based on the information they got in a free-form conversation with the victim, others see that the questionnaire must be filled out by asking the victim the questions in the questionnaire directly.

Recommendation: since the methodology of filling out the DASH form depends on the person filling it in, we recommend considering whether it is necessary to define the ways of filling out the DASH more precisely and to harmonize practices.

The MARAC guidance material specifies, among the MARAC closure activities, that a new risk assessment (using the DASH questionnaire) is performed on the victim when the case is closed. According to the survey, approximately half of MARAC core group members do not know how often risk assessments are conducted. However, since the risk assessment is mostly carried out by the Victim Support worker, other core group members may not know whether an assessment was carried out at completion. The results of the MARAC completion risk assessment as monitoring data are also very patchy. The interviewed victims did not know if an evaluation was performed when their case was closed. Thus, it appears that risk assessments for MARAC completion are not conducted regularly. On the one hand, the final assessment is necessary to be sure that the case can be closed in MARAC and the risk is mitigated; on the other hand, the final score of the risk assessment at the end of MARAC is an important indicator for monitoring and evaluating MARAC more broadly.

Recommendation: Perform a risk assessment and compile mandatory documentation of results at the closure of the case.

Work and administrative burden and data protection

Working in MARAC has increased the workload by approximately 60%, according to core group members. The increase in workload due to MARAC is perceived more strongly by the representatives of PBGB and SIB than the representatives of other institutions, who are responsible for the roles of MARAC coordinator, chairman of the meeting, and, in most cases, the secretary, and bear the administrative burden associated with these roles. The survey revealed that as for the activities related to MARAC meetings, the requirement to prepare a security plan as a separate document is fulfilled a little less frequently, and in some core groups, the confidentiality agreement is not read out before the discussion of each case. Although the interviews revealed that it is generally considered necessary to conclude and read a confidentiality agreement and prepare a security plan for the victim, the increase in bureaucracy and workload associated with the currently established procedural requirements is seen as a significant problem. The respondents doubt whether it is necessary to sign a confidentiality agreement for each case and to read it out loud every time. Since essentially all core group members are aware of the confidentiality requirement when attending the meeting, they feel it is unnecessary to repeat this procedure before each case discussion. The solutions proposed by the members of the core groups for changing the confidentiality agreement are as follows:

- conclusion of one confidentiality agreement per meeting;
- conclusion of one confidentiality agreement per case;
- entering into a confidentiality agreement with a member of the core group (valid for all meetings/events in which they participate);
- reading the confidentiality agreement only when there are new people in the meeting.

Recommendation: consider changing the procedure related to the confidentiality agreement to reduce bureaucracy, taking into account that mandatory data protection requirements are met.

Strict compliance with the confidentiality agreement sometimes creates obstacles to the efficient sharing of information with the necessary officials. Several members of the core groups pointed out in the interviews that according to the confidentiality agreement concluded at the meeting, they should not share information outside the meeting, but at the same time, it may be necessary for work processes to convey information to their colleagues within the agency. For example, the representative of the social department in the core group has to inform the social worker in order to organize the provision of services to the victim, or the representative of the PBGB in the core group has to inform the regional police officer who handles the victim's case.

Recommendation: Adjust the text of the confidentiality agreement and create a regulatory-compliant solution for core group members to forward information shared at meetings to other employees of their organization who need it to perform their duties.

Creating a security plan creates conflicting opinions. Although in all MARACs, the content of the security plan is written down, i.e., the activities agreed upon at the meeting to increase the victim's security are recorded, there are differences in the formalization of this plan. According to the survey and interviews, in some MARACs, the security plan is not drawn up as a separate document. In several cases, it was pointed out that the security plan is reflected only in the minutes of the meeting. It was also revealed in the interviews that sometimes, the members of the core groups do not distinguish the security plan from the minutes of the meeting, thinking that it is the same document. The MARAC guidance material outlines the content of the security plan and its importance but does not clearly define the obligation to formalize it as a separate document. At the same time, in the description of the role of the MARAC coordinator in the guidance material, it is stated: "The minutes contain, among other things, the tasks, i.e., the security plan and its additions, agreed between the authorities." According to the principles of case management, the MARAC development team considers it necessary that the security plan be formalized as a separate document. Since the protocol is drawn up separately for each meeting and contains a lot of other information in addition to security enhancement activities, the security plan may not be easy to find and may not provide a clear overview of all activities planned for the protection of the victim and the results of these activities. However, since the preparation and filing of various documents is an additional administrative burden for the Victim Support worker, and sometimes the need for separate preparation of this document was not clear to the core groups, it is necessary to clearly define and communicate the requirements for formalizing the security plan. Efforts should also be made to find solutions to minimize the administrative burden on Victim Support workers.

Recommendation: to clearly outline the purpose of the security plan, the principles, and requirements of formalization to the core groups and explain their need. At the same time, consider ways to reduce the administrative burden of documentation for Victim Support workers.

Volunteers

There were 64 MARAC volunteers on the SIB list as of the summer of 2023, of which 32 volunteers have MARAC experience; that is, they have currently or previously been involved in a MARAC case as a volunteer. The recruitment, training, and support of volunteers is managed by the MARAC volunteer coordinator. The SIB Victim Support worker, who is part of the core volunteer area, is involved in MARAC cases in cooperation with the volunteer coordinator. The interviewed members of the core groups conceptualized and described the role of volunteers in a similar way to the one presented in the MARAC guidance material. Also, the interviewed volunteers' own vision of their role matches the opinion of the core members and the instructional material, and in most cases, the volunteers understand their role clearly. The involvement of volunteers in MARAC cases varies from region to region, and the survey and interviews revealed that there are regions where volunteers are not involved or are rarely involved. If a volunteer is involved, the role and tasks of the volunteer, depending on the context and the case, will be agreed upon on a case-by-case basis. According to the interviewed volunteers, their main role was to provide psychosocial support. Although, in general terms, the role of volunteers is understandable to different parties, there have been ambiguities in specific situations or details. Support for the victim can be provided by a Victim Support worker, a psychologist, and a volunteer, and this raises doubts in the volunteer about their role and its scope. It is also not unequivocally clear whether the volunteer is a representative of the victim in the network, a case-based specialist, or simply a provider of one part of the SIB victim support coordinated service to the victim. It is necessary to define more precisely what information about the case the volunteer needs for their work and to whom and in what way they must convey the information. Since Victim Support workers determine the volunteer's role and provide instructions, Victim Support workers must have a good understanding of the principles of involvement, the role of volunteers, and the various possibilities thereof.

Recommendation: to increase and simplify the involvement of volunteers, gather examples of positive practices of volunteer involvement for Victim Support workers, which clearly state the tasks of the volunteers and what the volunteers need to perform these tasks.

In order for the communication and cooperation between the volunteer and the victim to function well, it was pointed out that the volunteer must be suitable for the victim and their situation. The suitability of the victim and the volunteer can be influenced by, for example, age and mother tongue, but also gender, etc. Finding volunteers with a suitable profile for all MARAC cases is not easy with the current volunteer composition. In several cases, it was expressed that there is a lack of volunteers who speak Russian as their mother tongue, and there was also a situation where a female volunteer was not suitable for a male victim.

Recommendation: increase the diversity of volunteers so that it is possible to find a volunteer with a suitable profile for specific cases.

Volunteers' communication with the victim mostly takes place either by phone or in face-to-face meetings. Although, in general, a method and means of communication appropriate to the situation have been found, volunteers point out some circumstances that make

communication with the victim uncomfortable and should be modernized. Currently, SIB provides push-button phones for volunteers to communicate with victims, which are primarily suitable for making phone calls but are inconvenient for sending messages. Inconvenience is also caused by the fact that the volunteers have to carry several phones with them, i.e., both the phone provided by SIB and their personal phone. Some volunteers have solved the problem by using a dual SIM card or eSim solution on a personal smartphone, but not all volunteers are aware of these options, and this may not be technically possible on all volunteers' personal smartphones.

Recommendation: find out what the possibilities are to make the means of communication by phone more convenient for volunteers and introduce them to different possibilities.

Although the interviewees did not have experiences where the victim did not want to communicate with a volunteer by phone, the need to make communication channels more modern was brought up as an idea. It is increasingly common for social media and other virtual channels to become the main communication channel. Currently, however, there is no system or opportunity for volunteers to communicate with the victim via social media because it is not advisable to use personal accounts for volunteer work, and they are also not secure enough.

Recommendation: develop a system for volunteers to communicate with victims through virtual communication channels as an alternative to phone calls.

Increasing victim safety

The number of police calls before and after the MARAC intervention shows that the number of police calls decreases on average, which may indicate that there is less need for police intervention as a result of MARAC. At the same time, the number of challenges remained the same in one-fifth of the cases.

According to core group members and volunteers, the impact of MARAC on increasing victims' safety is, on average, quite high, but the variability of the estimates is large. On a 10-point scale, the members of the core groups rated the increase in the victim's safety with an average of 7.8 and the volunteers with an average of 7.6. Different core group members and volunteers assess MARAC's impact on victims differently, as each case and MARAC's impact on it is different. It should also be taken into account that the increase in security is rather difficult to assess because it depends on many factors, which is why different people may have different aspects of security in mind. Often, the situation of domestic violence for the victim does not end with MARAC intervention and high-risk mitigation; several processes (for example, criminal proceedings) may continue after MARAC intervention, so different evaluators may have a different moment in mind when talking about the completion of MARAC.

According to the members of the core groups, MARAC provides important support to the victim, as it brings together different specialists who are all oriented toward helping the victim. The core group members also believe that this increases the victim's sense of security and the confidence to take the necessary steps to ensure safety. According to the core group

members, in MARAC, the victim is significantly more informed about their options, and information is generally shared more in a way that takes into account the vulnerable state of the victim as the core groups have an awareness of how to communicate with the victim. In part, core group members see MARAC as an opportunity to coordinate support and services for the victim faster than if it were done outside of MARAC. Both the members of the core groups and some of the victims themselves felt positively that in MARAC, the victim does not have to turn to various institutions separately for help, but it must be taken into account that there were also victims whose experience with MARAC did not make things easier. As the main benefits, victims pointed out specific services and support measures (for example, a psychologist/therapist for the victim or the child, adding their phone number to the 112 emergency list), as well as specific advice and answers to questions that they received from MARAC specialists according to their field (for example, family mediation service with child protection, prosecutor's help in the proceedings, etc.).

According to some core members, the factor that reduces the efficiency of MARAC is the victim's lack of cooperation with the MARAC network. Some core group members feel that MARAC as a network model does not provide additional resources to help the victim, and there is also the problem of slowness of processes and obstacles related to legal regulation, which limit the possibilities of helping the victim. Core group members sometimes think that they are doing the same thing in MARAC as they would outside of MARAC, and apart from more efficient information exchange, they do not perceive the additional benefit of MARAC in helping the victim or doubt the benefit. At the same time, there have been situations where members of the core groups have felt that their opportunities to help the victim through MARAC have been exhausted. Often, core group members feel this in situations where there are addiction problems or mutual violence, when the victim is unable to cooperate due to trauma, or when there are other complicated circumstances in the case. Sometimes, there are doubts among core group members whether the case referred to MARAC is still high-risk, and in one interview with a core group member and a volunteer, doubts were expressed as to whether victims always tell the truth. Some of the interviewed victims also felt that they were not believed or understood by all the core group members of MARAC. From the above, it appears that core group members sometimes have difficulties in solving complex cases and, to some extent, tend to re-victimize the victim or are not able to use all the possibilities of networking (e.g., looking for services necessary for victims' needs or creating special solutions together). As MARAC aims to mitigate high risk with complex circumstances, MARAC core groups need more support and training.

Recommendation: to ensure that the new members of the MARAC core groups pass the (basic) e-course on DV and to find out whether the members of the MARAC core groups still need more specific training (e.g., networking, supporting a victim with addiction disorders, etc.). In cooperation with core groups, find out more precisely the main problem areas and situations where members of core groups feel that MARAC's possibilities are exhausted in helping victims with specific needs. With the support of the MARAC development team and/or within the agency, to provide support and opportunities for specialists to improve their knowledge and skills as well as to develop suitable solution ideas.

The interviewed victims expressed uncertainties and a lack of clarity regarding the specific benefits they derived from MARAC. These doubts may stem from the victims' limited comprehension of MARAC. MARAC was mainly understood as a team of different professionals trying to help the victim. However, there were victims who did not understand what MARAC was in general, what were MARAC meetings and their goals, and whether MARAC had ended or was still going on for them. At times, MARAC was indistinguishable from stand-alone support outside MARAC from other networks or specialists. Since MARAC is primarily a cooperation network for different authorities, it is not clearly defined what and how thorough the victim's understanding of the nature of MARAC and its functioning must be. However, since one of the factors affecting the operation of MARAC is the victim's cooperation with the core group of MARAC, it is still necessary for the victim to understand MARAC to the extent that it allows them to understand in general terms what the purpose of MARAC is and what the victim's role, responsibility, and tasks are in MARAC, what opportunities MARAC offers them, and to be clearly aware when the MARAC core group is no longer handling the victim's case.

Recommendation: communicate more clearly to the victim The content and objectives of MARAC from the perspective of victims, the victim's opportunity to participate in the MARAC meeting, and the role of the victim in the meeting, closing the victim's case in MARAC.

Victims communicate mainly with the Victim Support worker from MARAC's core groups, and victims are satisfied with this arrangement and communication. Victims' experiences with members of other core groups have varied. Some of the victims felt that they received a lot of support, advice, and encouragement from the members of the core group. Others, on the other hand, felt that the specialist was passive, did not believe the victim, and did not provide any guidance and counselling.

Opinions of MARAC core group members on victim involvement in meetings and the practices of core groups in victim involvement vary. There are core group members who see a number of benefits for victims in attending the meetings, as well as those who believe that victims should not attend meetings. Different attitudes are caused by personal preferences as well as by previous experiences involving the victim and the difficult situations that have arisen. Also, among the victims themselves, there are both positive and negative experiences of participating in the MARAC meeting. Since the participation or non-participation of victims in the MARAC meeting is an important factor in MARAC processes, the principles of victim involvement should be more clearly defined in order to harmonize MARAC practices.

Recommendation: identify good practices for involving victims in MARAC meetings and create common principles for deciding whether to involve victims in MARAC meetings. In addition, develop guidelines for resolving situations arising from the involvement of victims.

Domestic Violence E-course

An e-course has been created for specialists dealing with domestic violence, with the aim of opening up the nature of domestic violence, introducing the principles of support, and

offering guidelines on how to behave in a situation that requires quick and decisive intervention, thereby raising the awareness of specialists. As of the end of September 2023, 114 people had completed the domestic violence e-course. Twenty-three people had filled out the course feedback form. Specialists who completed the course and filled out the feedback form evaluated the course mostly positively. In the opinion of most of the specialists who gave feedback, the content of the course is clear and understandable, the structure is easy to follow and logical, and the learning outcomes formulated at the beginning of the course were achieved. The positive aspects of the course that were highlighted were the functionality, variety (videos and conversations, exercise tasks, repetitions, tests, interactivity), and the use of different media (video and audio files, texts accompanying the videos). Several technical issues in the online environment were perceived as bottlenecks, disrupting the learning process and its recording. However, it must be taken into account here that sometimes problems can be caused by the device used by the course participant. The second main problem was the high time consumption of the course and, as a result, the lack of clarity as to how long it actually takes to complete the course. Problems with the use of language and spelling in the course materials were also expressed as an area of concern. By the time the study was conducted, few of those who completed the course had given feedback, and therefore, the variability of problem areas and desired additional topics may be wider than revealed in this study.

Recommendation: Identify and resolve technical issues, distinguishing between those related to the online course platform and those that may be due to the device the course participant is using. In the case of the latter, to point out possible solutions to the learners to avoid technical obstacles. We also recommend considering the possibility of clearly indicating the approximate time required for the course, both in the study guide and, if possible, indicating the average time required for this module at the beginning of the curriculum modules. Problems with spelling and language use in the course materials also need to be resolved.

Terminology

The roles, processes, etc., related to MARAC are formulated and defined differently in the documents, and the use of terms and their meaning among the members of the core groups differ as well. At the same time, it is not unequivocally clear when they are synonyms and when different terms express different phenomena. Volunteers involved in MARAC cases are referred to as volunteers, volunteer support persons, or support persons. MARAC's guidance material uses MARAC working group members, core group members, and specialists. Also, the following distinctive terms are also used: core group and case-based specialist. In addition, the security plan is understood both as a separate document and as a plan that is part of the minutes of the meeting. Members of core groups with long MARAC experience are likely to have established the use and clarity of terms and are able to identify which are synonymous and which are distinctive terms. New members, as well as officials outside of MARAC but exposed to the process, may experience confusion in terminology.

Recommendation: harmonize the terminology used in the MARAC guidance materials.

Methodology

Analysis of MARAC monitoring data

The target group of the analysis is victims who have participated in MARAC since 2019. In the analysis of monitoring data, we used the SIB monitoring database as the main database, which contains various information about MARAC cases in 2019-2022. In order to supplement the MARAC monitoring data collected at the Social Insurance Board, we combined data from the Police and Border Guard Board (PBGB) database and the Prosecutor's Office database. We received permission from the Data Protection Inspectorate and the Tallinn Medical Research Ethics Committee of the National Institute for Health Development to combine the data. SIB informed all potential participants about the use of monitoring data via the SIB website of the study.

The PBGB and the prosecutor's office sent additional data to the SIB, where both data sets were pseudonymized and sent to the researcher. In the SIB database, each case has an identifier, on the basis of which we connected the datasets of the Police and Border Guard Board and the Prosecutor's Office.

Additional data from the PBGB included the number of calls to the police related to domestic violence 12 months before the MARAC intervention and six months and twelve months after participation in MARAC. The Prosecutor's Office added data on the criminal proceedings initiated and the application for and enforcement of restraining orders. After combining the SIB monitoring data and additional data from the PBGB and the Prosecutor's Office, the database was pseudonymized by the SIB and then forwarded to the researcher.

Cases with the same victim are noted in the database. The Police and Border Guard Board database contained the number of police calls for each MARAC case 12 months before the MARAC start date, six months after the MARAC, and 6-12 months after the MARAC, respectively. The database of the Prosecutor's Office contained data on cases where criminal proceedings have been initiated for the protection of the victim. The database contained information on the time of initiation of the criminal case and the necessary components (sections of the Penal Code) of domestic violence, as well as the time of requesting a temporary and long-term restraining order and whether the court granted the request. For the purpose of data analysis, we recorded the characteristics contained in the dataset if necessary (e.g., grouping regions into counties and coding the information contained in the text fields into new characteristics). In the SIB database, the data is not always entered in a complete form - in some cases, some fields were not filled in, so the summaries of the data presented in the study report are made only on the basis of the available data.

We analyzed the aggregated data set based on the research questions, i.e., we used only those features contained in the data set that were relevant to answering the questions. As a method, we used descriptive statistics, i.e., calculation of frequency distributions and averages. In the SIB database, the data is not always entered in a complete form - in some cases, some fields were not filled in, so the summaries of the data presented in the study report are made only on the basis of the available data. Therefore, although a descriptive

regression analysis was originally planned to find out which background characteristics are related to outcome indicators, such as the change in the number of incidents of violence or the change in the initial and final DASH scores, this was not possible, as the information used as an outcome indicator is not systematically reflected in the monitoring data.

Interviews

With the interviews, we discussed in more depth the evaluations of the different parties involved in the resolution of MARAC cases on the functioning of the MARAC networks and their impact. We conducted the interviews with four target groups: the MARAC development team, members of MARAC regional core groups, volunteers, and victims whose cases have been resolved in MARAC.

We conducted all interviews during the period based on a semi-structured interview schedule, and each target group's schedule differed depending on their role in MARAC. Most of the interviews took place via online call, while some were conducted by telephone. We recorded the interviews and prepared transcriptions that we used in the analysis of the interviews.

The methodology of interviews by target groups is described below.

MARAC development team

In the MARAC development team, we conducted a focus group interview via video call to get an overview of MARAC's current status and developments, as well as input for further data collection among other target groups. Seven people participated in the focus group interview, including members of the development team as well as representatives of the prosecutor's office and PBGB, who have more experience with MARAC.

Members of the MARAC regional core groups

In MARAC core groups we carried out case studies within the MARAC core groups from June 13 to July 3, 2023. For this purpose, we selected four core groups from among all MARAC regional core groups: The core groups of Ida-Harju, Jõhvi, Saare County, and Tartu. In all of them, we interviewed key members and ensured that representatives of various agencies - PBGB, SIB, Prosecutor's Office, WSC, and local governments- were present. If there were several representatives of one agency in the core group, we randomly selected one interviewee from each agency. Therefore, we interviewed five people in each core group, or a total of 20 core group members.

The names and e-mail addresses of the specialists belonging to the selected core groups were provided by the MARAC development team. We sent an e-mail to all members of the core group selected for the sample, in which we introduced the purpose of the study and suggested times for conducting the interviews. Since it was not possible to contact all the specialists by e-mail, if necessary, we searched for the phone numbers of the specialists from public sources and additionally contacted them by phone. In the event that the specialist selected for the initial selection could not participate in the interview, we replaced them in the same core group with another person who represents the same agency.

Volunteers

We conducted case studies among volunteers in the period June 15 and June 30, 2023. We defined the target group of volunteers as those who have been in the role of a volunteer in at least one MARAC case, i.e., have experience in a MARAC case. We selected the volunteers to be interviewed according to the sample of the core groups, i.e., from the same region, so that it would be possible to compare the volunteers' experiences with the assessments of the members of the core group. Since there was no volunteer in the Jõhvi region who would have participated in MARAC in that region, we interviewed two volunteers from the largest, i.e., Ida-Harju MARAC region. Therefore, the initial sample included four volunteers: two of them from Ida-Harju, one from Saare County, and one from Tartu. Those selected for the sample were first contacted by e-mail, and those who could not be contacted by e-mail were additionally called on the phone. One volunteer selected for the initial sample refused and was therefore replaced by another volunteer from the same region. However, the four volunteers interviewed had participated in MARAC as volunteers in a very narrow role, and therefore, the need for an additional interview to cover the volunteer role in MARAC more broadly emerged. Therefore, we conducted an interview with another volunteer whose region is Tallinn/Lääne-Harju. Therefore, we interviewed five volunteers in total.

Victims who have participated in MARAC

We conducted interviews with the victims between August 17 and August 28, 2023. The target group is limited to those whose MARAC case has been completed but no more than two years have passed since the case. As an additional criterion, we took into account that the victims would be from different regions of Estonia and that two Russian-speaking victims would be represented. In order to interview the victims, we previously requested permission from the Data Protection Inspectorate (DPI). After obtaining permission from DPI to conduct interviews with victims, Victim Support workers belonging to the core groups of different regions contacted the victims whose cases were handled in their core groups in order to create a sample. If the victim agreed to participate in the study, the Victim Support worker forwarded their contact to the MARAC project manager. In this way, the contact details of 12 victims were collected in order to be able to make replacements in case some victims refused to give an interview. From the sample, we randomly selected eight victims whom we contacted by e-mail or phone to introduce the purpose of the study, the principles of data collection and management, and to arrange a time for an interview. We contacted all the victims selected for the sample and agreed on an interview time. In addition, before the interview, we asked everyone to sign a consent form to participate in the study and to process the data collected during the interview, and we informed them about the possibility of receiving support after the interview, if necessary, from the Victim Support worker who first contacted them. In total, we interviewed eight victims, and 2 of the interviews were conducted in Russian. The majority of the interviews took place via online calls; two interviews were conducted by telephone.

Survey

Target groups and preparation of the questionnaire

In order to evaluate the impact of implementing the MARAC model on those involved in the MARAC networking model and possible solutions for improving the effectiveness of networking, we conducted a survey among **MARAC regional core groups** and **volunteers**.

In the target groups, the survey was conducted on the basis of somewhat different questionnaires because the role of volunteers in the work of MARAC networks is significantly different from the work of core group members. In the questionnaire for both target groups, we touched on MARAC's weaknesses and strengths in general, suggestions for changes, assessments of increased victim safety, adequacy of support, and use of a self-care account. In the questionnaire of the core groups, we discussed in more detail the working area of the members, their roles and their clarity, the structure and functioning of MARAC meetings, conducting risk assessments, changes in work methods and cooperation with other institutions, the impact of crises on the functioning of the MARAC network. Questions to the volunteers included their involvement, role, and time spent in handling MARAC cases, as well as general assessments of the performance of the MARAC core group. When preparing the questionnaires, we took into account which problem areas have previously reached the MARAC development team on these topics and the wider spread of which practices to investigate in all core groups.

Sampling

As of April 2023, there were a total of 137 members of MARAC core groups. In the survey, we included core groups from all sides, i.e., all members of MARAC regional core groups operating in Estonia were included in the sample. With the survey, we did not include specialists who have been exceptionally involved in the work of MARAC in some specific cases, as their exposure may be too little to assess the impact of the implementation of the model on their work practices and to make assessments for improving efficiency.

We included all those MARAC volunteers on the SIB list who have had the experience of a volunteer role in solving at least one case. Since the purpose of the questionnaire was to identify experiences and assessments of the functioning of MARAC, only those volunteers who have encountered MARAC in practice can provide answers. There were a total of 29 volunteers with case-solving experience, and we covered them with the survey in all respects.

Comparing the two samples revealed that there were two people who were simultaneously active as a member of the core group and as a volunteer. We left them in the sample of the core group, as the questionnaire for this target group is more comprehensive.

Conducting a survey

We conducted the surveys using the online platform Limesurvey. In order to conduct the survey, we received the names and e-mail addresses of everyone in the sample from the MARAC development team. On May 13, we sent both target groups an invitation to

participate in the survey, which included a general introduction to the study and an individual link to the questionnaire. We set a deadline of 2 weeks for the response. After the first week, we sent a reminder to those who had not yet completed the survey. After the second week, however, it became clear that not enough responses had been collected (12 volunteers and 87 core members had responded). As there were only a few respondents in some regions, we decided to extend the survey period and sent a notification via e-mail to those who had not completed the survey. We set July 5 as the new deadline for the survey. The final number of respondents was 100 among core groups and 18 among volunteers.

Descriptions of the final samples of surveys of core group members and volunteers

The following figures show the descriptions of the core groups and those who participated in the volunteer survey by main background characteristics. The numbers at the ends of the bars in the figure represent the number of observations, and the length of the bar represents the size of the share of the group.

Figure 99. Distribution of members of the core groups who answered the survey by main background characteristics

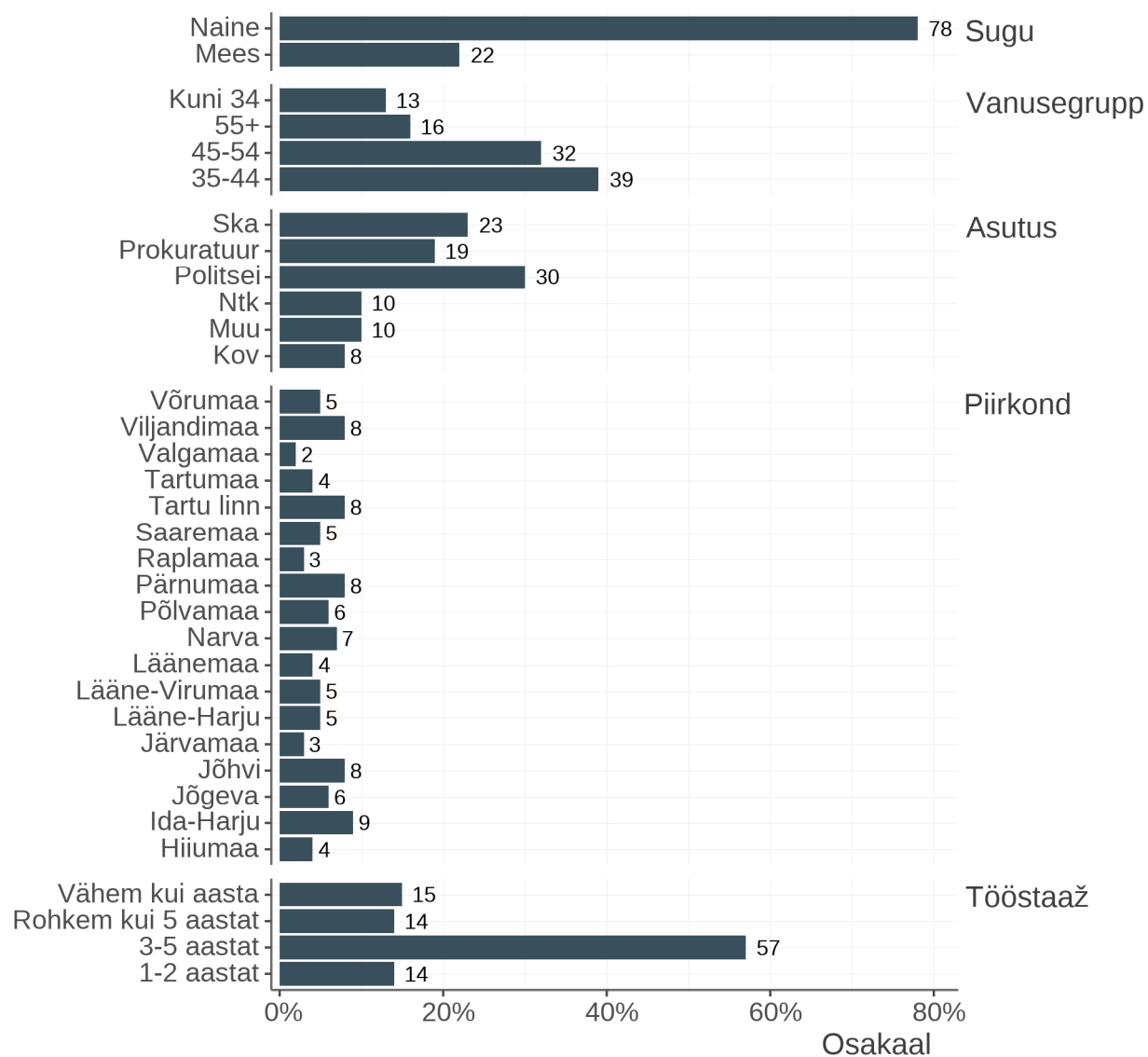
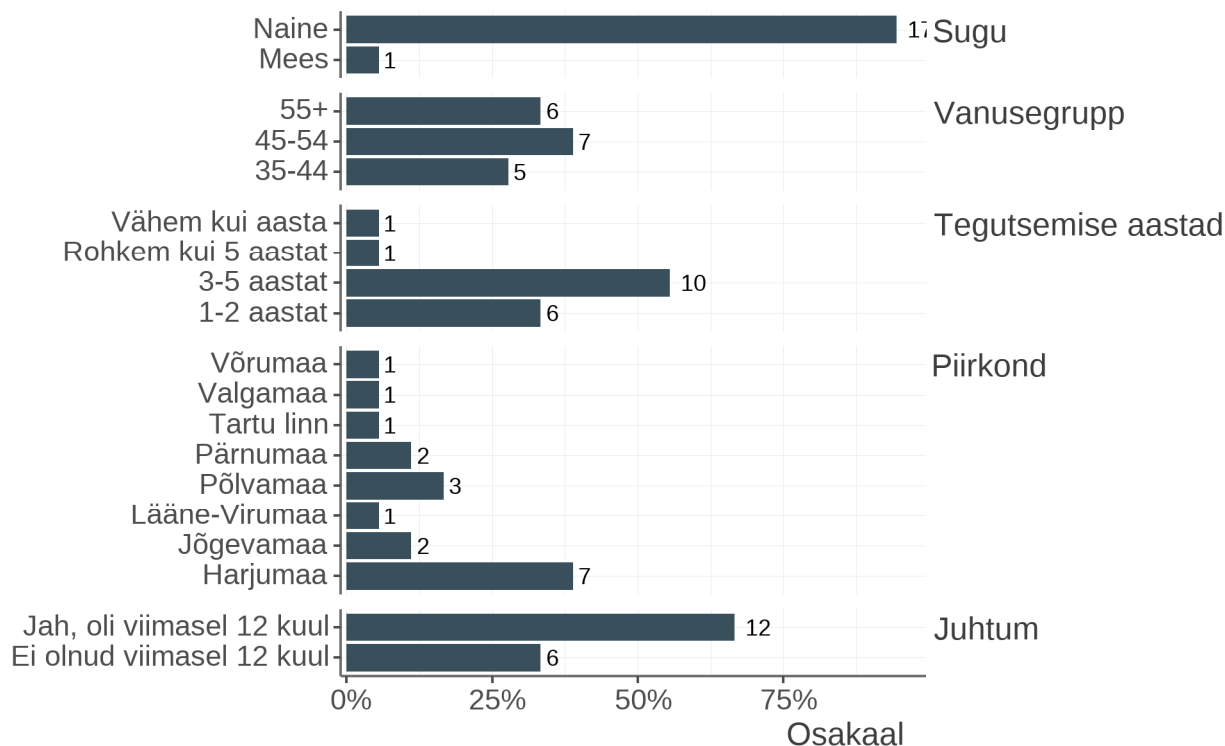


Figure 100. Distribution of volunteers who responded to the survey by main background characteristics



Feedback analysis of the domestic violence e-course

An e-course was opened in January 2023 to raise awareness of domestic violence among specialists working with victims. The study of the domestic violence e-course and feedback of the course after the study takes place on the learning platform of the Digital State Academy. The feedback analysis sample included all people who had completed the course and filled out the feedback questionnaire on the learning platform by the time the analysis took place.

Since it is a time-consuming course, it takes a long time to complete, and therefore, we started the feedback analysis at the final stage of the study. However, at the moment of the analysis, the number of those who provided feedback on the course turned out to be relatively low. As of September 28, SIB sent us an extract from the responses of those who gave feedback on the course through the learning platform, and 23 people had filled out the questionnaire. From the dataset of the feedback given to the course, we highlighted the general frequency distributions and, in summary, the observations made in the free answers.

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